

ROUTLEDGE STUDIES IN CULTURE AND DEVELOPMENT

Contemporary Perspectives on Art and International Development

Edited by
Polly Stupples and Katerina Teaiwa



Contemporary Perspectives on Art and International Development

Visual artists, craftspeople, musicians and performers have been supported by the development community for at least twenty years, yet there has been little grounded and critical research into the practices and politics of that support. This new Routledge book remedies that omission and brings together varied perspectives from artists, policy-makers and researchers working in the Pacific, Africa, Latin America and Europe to explore the challenges and opportunities of supporting the arts in the development context. The book offers a series of grounded analyses which covers: strategies for the sustainability of arts enterprises; innovative evaluation methods; theoretical engagements with questions of art, agency and social change; artists' entanglements with legal and structural frameworks; processes of cultural mapping; and the artist/donor interface.

The creative economy is increasingly recognised as a potential driver of development, and this book investigates the varied contributions that the arts and the creative economy can make to development processes, and how development agencies might best support such initiatives. *Contemporary Perspectives on Art and International Development* gives scholars of development studies, social and cultural geography, anthropology, cultural policy, cultural studies and global studies a contextually and thematically diverse range of insights into this emerging research field.

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Routledge Studies in Culture and Development

Paul Basu, Wayne Modest and Tim Winter, Series Editors

There is a burgeoning interest among academics, practitioners and policy-makers in the relationships between ‘culture’ and ‘development.’ This embraces the now well-recognized need to adopt culturally sensitive approaches *in* development practice, the necessity of understanding the cultural dimensions *of* development and more specifically, the role of culture *for* development. Culture, in all its dimensions, is a fundamental component of sustainable development, and throughout the world, we are seeing an increasing number of governmental and non-governmental agencies turning to culture as a vehicle for economic growth, for promoting social cohesion, stability and human well-being and for tackling environmental issues. At the same time, there has been remarkably little critical debate around this relationship and even less concerned with the interventions of cultural institutions or creative industries in development agendas. The objective of the Routledge Studies in Culture and Development series is to fill this lacuna and provide a forum for reaching across academic, practitioner and policy-maker audiences.

The series editors welcome submissions for single and jointly authored books and edited collections concerning issues such as the contribution of museums, heritage and cultural tourism to sustainable development; the politics of cultural diplomacy; cultural pluralism and human rights; traditional systems of environmental management; cultural industries and traditional livelihoods; and culturally appropriate forms of conflict resolution and post-conflict recovery.

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This book has its roots in a collaboration between a doctoral candidate (Polly Stupples) and one of her doctoral examiners (Katerina Teaiwa) who share a passion for research that explores creative practice as social action, although those explorations have taken them to different parts of the world: Central America and the Pacific. We are both cognisant of the way in which this field crosses disciplinary, geographic and applied/theoretical domains, and this book is a gesture towards expanding that cross-disciplinary engagement—about what art is and does, and where and how it does it—in productive ways.

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Introduction

On Art and International Development

Polly Stupples and Katerina Teaiwa

The 'earth' without 'art' is just 'eh.'

Anonymous

From art, literature, music and dance, I have learnt that there is a sensory experience of our lives that encompasses innumerable unnamed and unnameable shapes, hues and textures that 'objective knowledge' has failed to capture. The language of these genres communicates how ordinary people laugh and weep, work, play, pray, bless, love and curse, make a space to stand forth and walk, fall and die.

(Mbembe 2015)

While understandings about art and its value vary across time, space, culture and sub-culture, most accept the premise that a world without art would be a much lesser world indeed. Yet, there is far less agreement on whether it is possible to systematically harness art's often ephemeral qualities for tangible social or economic benefit and, indeed, whether such pragmatic goals are relevant to the practice of art. Philosopher and cultural critic Achille Mbembe's words remind us that art and the world of quantifiable 'objective knowledge' are often incommensurable. Yet, an increasing number of donors and partners in the development field are supporting art in the Global South with the intention of effecting change. The projects and processes that emerge with their support generate a new cultural space that inflects some old questions about the social value of art (see Belfiore and Bennett 2008; Carey 2006) with the politics of transnational funding in a context of unequal power relations. In this context, tying the value of the arts to processes of social change is highly

charged. Who decides what kind of art matters (and to whom and in what ways), and how do those questions intersect with local and global striations of power? Is it possible to predict ‘outcomes’ from the artistic processes with the certainty desired by project managers focused on accountability, and what are the implications of the unpredictability of art for donors who have to report back to their own funders? What forms of social change are valued by different actors in this space, and what assumptions about art, artists and social change are revealed through different policy approaches? These are some of the questions that development support for the arts raises and with which this book engages.

Development funding for the arts began in the mid-1990s and reflects the more holistic approach to development that emerged with development’s cultural turn. (Clammer 2014) However, support for the arts among the traditional donor community remains varied (it is common in Europe, for example, but far less so in the U.S., Australia and New Zealand), and how to plan for, monitor and measure art ‘projects’ in the context of development remains an area of contention as well as occasional innovation. In many cases, arts projects are simply not evaluated (Dunphy and Ware, this volume; Marsh and Gould 2003); in others, evaluation poorly reflects the processes involved (Stupples 2015); yet in some instances evaluation offers a vital opportunity to explore the complexities of what art practice means to people in specific places (Fontes this volume).

It is no surprise, therefore, that the different approaches of international development organizations to arts funding reflect the diversity of approaches to development itself. Liberal approaches to development (prioritizing economic growth as the primary tool to improve living conditions) may support aspects of the creative economy linked to employment, economic growth and exports, or connecting local producers to global markets (see De Beukelaer and O’Connor, this volume). Those with a more human-centered development approach might emphasize the potential for creative engagement to address issues of exclusion and marginalization, to contribute to post-conflict peace-building or to serve as vernacular forms for the culturally appropriate communication of development messages. More radical development organisations (more likely to be NGOs than bilateral agencies) might see the arts as contributors to a critical public space, where taboos and stereotypes are questioned, resistance voiced, regimes satirized and where the means and ends of

development are up for debate. Post-colonial and post-development critics might see the arts, as Achille Mbembe (2009) has suggested, even as an oppositional force to ‘development’—a space for the articulation of an alternative cultural imagining that lies well beyond the tropes of crisis and deficiency associated with the development discourse (see Stupples, this volume). Thus, support for the arts echoes the complexities and paradoxes long associated with development’s cultural turn, which Nederveen Pieterse has aptly described as both ‘a renegade notion at odds with established practices and a new brick in the wall of clichés’ (2010, p. 64).

The sheer range of art’s apparent ‘contributions’ to processes of social change is one of the compelling reasons for supporting them: artistic goods can be bought and sold through local and global markets; their symbolic content can support conservative or radical forms of social organisation and thought, and participation in processes of art-making can have a range of cognitive, psychological and social effects (McCarthy et al. 2004). The most recent *Creative Economy Report* (UNESCO and UNDP 2013) brings together multiple possibilities for the contributions of the creative sector to different development objectives, suggesting its capacity to provide employment and grow exports, but also to ‘generat[e] social energy, confidence and engagement, enable[e] both individuals and groups to aspire to and imagine alternative futures,’ therein supporting ‘inclusive growth.’ These multiple possibilities associated with creative practice are similarly advocated by international cultural organizations lobbying for the inclusion of ‘culture’ in the post-2015 Sustainable Development Goals (UNESCO and Hangzhou International Congress 2013). While such diversity and complexity may indeed be reflective of art’s varied manifestations, it can lead to confusion for those implementing development projects (see Zambrano and Bulloven 2007, for example), it contributes to challenges of monitoring and evaluation, and it can lead to impossible and contradictory demands being made of artists, as the following attests:

In order to get their support, international cooperation agencies demand us to become self-sustainable and market our artwork as profitable products in a context which is oblivious to art in the first place, and where art is hardly a commodity... On the top of that, and at the same time, they remind us to be innovative, risky, socially sensitive, left-wing oriented, and stand for political issues which undermine the establishment.

(Nicaraguan artist cited in Fontes 2008, paragraph 7)

It is in response to the many hopes for art's transformative power in multiple and diverse social contexts and with an awareness of the need to critically engage with the political and pragmatic complexities of supporting creative practice within the frameworks of 'development' that we have brought together this edited volume. While there has been considerable academic focus directed towards the broader question of culture in relation to development (Nederveen Pieterse 2010; Radcliffe (ed.) 2006b; Schech and Haggis 2000, plus other volumes in this Routledge Series), far less attention has been paid to the arts specifically. This volume focuses specifically on the arts, while many chapters also draw attention to the ways in which art influences, and is influenced by, broader cultural processes.

This book also intentionally involves both academic critique and critical reflections from practitioners. Grounded case studies, theoretical arguments and provocations, successfully applied project and policy models, critiques, evaluation techniques and NGO strategies are brought together to explore and critically examine the politics and pragmatics of supporting the arts through international cooperation. In doing so, the book draws attention to the mechanisms through which change and transformation actually occur, engages with artists' perspectives, explores the forms of agency that lie both within and outside of mainstream development agendas and confronts the challenge of sustainability for artists' initiatives. Examples of practice are drawn from Africa, Latin America, the Pacific and Europe, and the voices of donors, researchers, evaluators, artists, cultural activists and development workers are brought into dialogue.

A Note on Terms

In this book, the term 'art' includes all forms and traditions of dance, music, visual and digital arts, crafts, design, fashion, literature, film and theatre that serve as means for individual and collective creative agency and expression. In many cultures, 'the arts' have not historically been a separate field of activity, but are deeply integrated into political, economic and social life. This is reflected in the lack of terms for 'art' in many languages where art and everyday culture, or social life, are deeply integrated. This, however,

has led to differing notions and valuations of art where, for example, indigenous and traditional products become labeled separately as ‘craft,’ referencing the decorative arts and defined by their relationship to functional or utilitarian needs, such as costumes, pots, bags or mats (Teaiwa 2012). Given the sheer diversity of products and practices that require artistic imagination, craftsmanship or sensibility, we take an inclusive approach in this volume, incorporating the creative industries, ‘the arts,’ ‘craft’ and other creative expressions of culture into our discussions of ‘art’ in this collection. Our focus is on the potential multi-scalar social, political and economic effects of artistic processes and products (and their relationship to international cooperation).

Our approach to ‘development’ is similarly inclusive. We understand the meaning of development to be both varied and contested. While we accept that the broad premise of development is an improvement in living conditions (including material conditions but also issues of dignity, agency, freedom, choice and political participation, drawing on Goulet 1975; Sen 1999), we acknowledge that what needs to be improved and which strategies might best achieve an improvement (as well as which actors should undertake any ‘intervention’) are ultimately political questions. We acknowledge the critiques of development (as discussed below), but also the desire for social justice, for redistribution and for rebalancing global (and local) power dynamics that lie behind much development practice. It is hoped that thinking about ‘art’ in relation to ‘development’ will challenge and inform development thinking, as well as expanding our thinking about art’s contributions to processes of social change across a range of contexts.

Art and the Cultural Turn in Development

Development support for the arts emerged in the mid-1990s through development’s cultural turn. Over the last 20 years, culture has become central to development discourse, although skepticism remains about whether or not development’s engagement with culture has been transformative or has simply pasted new labels on old bottles (see Apthorpe 2005; Clammer 2005; Da Costa 2010; Nederveen Pieterse 2010). Development’s cultural turn has been explained and debated extensively

elsewhere (see Nederveen Pieterse 2010; Radcliffe (ed.) 2006b; Schech and Haggis 2000), and here we review its trajectory only briefly, and specifically in relation to the emergence of development support for the arts.

Radcliffe (2006a, p. 3) lists five key reasons for culture's rise in prominence within development since the 1980s, although—as she points out—each one encompasses a number of divergent perspectives: ‘the failure of previous development paradigms; perceptions of globalization's threat to cultural diversity; activism around social difference (gender, ethnicity, anti-racism); the development success stories of East Asia; and the need for social cohesion.’ The growing polycentrism associated with accelerated globalization was a further impulse behind development's cultural turn (Nederveen Pieterse 2010).

The 1980s saw an ‘impasse’ (Booth 1985; Schuurman 1993) in development thinking which was precipitated by a reversal in human development indicators, and a crisis of faith in previous development paradigms, both liberal (e.g., modernization, structural adjustment) and critical (e.g., dependency theory, world systems theory, modes of production). No single development model appeared to be globally applicable, and the desire to impose one particular model was implicated in processes of cultural homogenization, furthering the loss of distinctive cultural traditions. If the development project was failing, it appeared to be at least in part because it didn't take into account different cultural contexts, both in the formulation of development objectives and in the implementation of projects. Thus, the emphasis on culture in development emerged at the same time as a ‘retreat from structural and macro approaches in favour of micro and actor-oriented approaches’ (Nederveen Pieterse 2010, p. 64).

While development appeared to be failing to achieve its practical and measurable objectives, critical input from feminist and post-colonial writers ¹ influenced post-development writers such as Arturo Escobar (1995), who highlighted the cultural embeddedness of development theory and practice in ‘Western capitalist political economies and the cultural histories of European colonialism’ (Radcliffe 2006a, p. 3). Meanwhile, the relative success of the East Asian economies and their improvement of human development indicators provoked debate about the contribution of cultural factors (in particular, the Confucian tradition) to these outcomes. Furthermore, increasingly rapid processes of globalization prompted a more

polycentric geopolitics at the same time as it saw a rise in the number of (at least nominally) culturally motivated conflicts (Arizpe 2004, p. 164). These factors drew attention to ‘culture’ as both a threat and as a site for hybridity as a positive engagement with difference.

In response, a deep and wide-ranging debate about culture in relation to development was galvanized at the international level (see De Beukelaer and O’Connor, and Vlassis, this volume), spearheaded initially by UNESCO, and culminating in the UN Decade for Cultural Development (1988–1997). Throughout this period, a series of high-level international initiatives debated the possibilities of ‘culture’ to radically democratize and diversify development thinking, to make it more holistic and to question the cultural assumptions that underpinned it. While the radical challenge that development’s cultural turn seemed to constitute has not been fulfilled, it did result in a more positive and enabling view of culture than that articulated by the modernization theorists of the 1950s and 1960s, who saw ‘societies steeped in traditional cultures’ as an impediment to the process of ‘market-oriented development’ (Rao and Walton 2004a, p. 10; also see Schech and Haggis 2000, pp. 9–11). Furthermore, and importantly for our discussion here, this more humanistic approach to development included—within the far broader framework of culture—recognition of the value of creative expression in relation to nation-building, self-determination, intercultural exchange and cultural diversity.

If it seems somewhat surprising that it took so long (over 30 years) for culture to be recognized as significant to mainstream development, this may be due both to a ‘flight from culture’ and to the way in which the international development and financial institutions were established following the Second World War. Arizpe argues that the 1970s saw an intellectual ‘flight from culture’ due in part to ‘white man’s guilt,’ but also due to a reluctance on the part of Southern intellectuals to be characterized by cultural stereotypes (2004, p. 171). She also points out that culture was splintered off from ‘development actions among different UN agencies, national ministries, and international and nongovernmental development organizations.’ Development was ‘constructed exclusively in terms of economic growth’ and seen as the responsibility of the Bretton-Woods institutions (the World Bank Group and the International Monetary Fund), whereas cultural and political concerns were to be addressed by the UN and UNESCO (2004, pp. 164–67).

Since its inception, UNESCO has remained a key driver in developing, promoting and legitimizing a discourse that supports cultural diversity and prompting the development community to reflect on the importance of culture in relation to its practices. In the post-war era in which it was founded, UNESCO was charged with promoting understanding between cultures as a means of averting ‘wars that begin in the minds of men’ (cited in Arizpe 2004, p. 166) and valuing ‘unity-in-diversity’ as a prerequisite for peace. Its work is informed by the right to cultural expression that was enshrined in the UN Universal Declaration of Human Rights in 1948.² In the 1980s, the organization began to develop a number of high-level international initiatives (noted below) that debated the relationship between development and culture and are cited as foundational by almost every international donor that has an arts and cultural policy.³ It is worth noting, however, that this international debate on culture and development was not limited to UNESCO. In the 1990s, the World Bank, the Inter-American Development Bank and the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)⁴ began to focus on ‘culturally appropriate development’ (Arizpe 2004, pp. 174–75; Radcliffe 2006a; Rao and Walton 2004b; UNDP 2004; UNESCO 1999), but within these organizations, the approach to culture was largely instrumental and there was little explicit focus (at this time) on the arts.

The UN Decade for Cultural Development (1988–1997)

In 1982, UNESCO held the first World Conference on Cultural Policies (known as Mondiacult) in Mexico City.⁵ This was a seminal event in promoting international debate on culture and development. Mondiacult adopted what, for UNESCO, would become a foundational definition of culture as ‘the whole complex of distinctive spiritual, material, intellectual and emotional features that characterize a society or social group,’ including ‘not only the arts and letters, but also modes of life, the fundamental rights of the human being, value systems, traditions and beliefs’ (UNESCO 1982, paragraph 6). The conference also took pains to move away from what had been regarded as elitist conceptions of ‘high art’ and to recognize ‘intangible cultural heritage,’ including dance, rituals, orally transmitted

stories and festivals, knowledge practices and craftsmanship, and emphasizing the living social context in which cultural goods are produced and reproduced. ⁶ The conference also described the role of culture as the matrix through which people are enabled to reflect critically, identify values, gain self-awareness, generate new meanings and aspire beyond their limitations (UNESCO 1982, paragraph 7), and many of these ideas resonate within the various chapters of this volume:

It is culture that gives man the ability to reflect upon himself. It is culture that makes us specifically human, rational beings, endowed with a critical judgement and a sense of moral commitment. It is through culture that we discern values and make choices. It is through culture that man expresses himself, becomes aware of himself, recognizes his incompleteness, questions his own achievement, seeks untiringly for new meanings and creates works through which he transcends his limitations.

(UNESCO 1982, paragraph 7)

The Mondiacult conference broadened UNESCO's framework for culture and radically challenged narrow, economistic conceptions of development. It argued for 'humanis[ing] development,' focusing on its qualitative aspects, including 'the satisfaction of man's spiritual and cultural aspirations' (UNESCO 1982, point 10). As part of this broader platform, the Mondiacult Declaration supported arts education, conditions of independence for artists and stronger social recognition of the value of the arts.

The impetus behind Mondiacult was taken up in the UN Decade for Cultural Development, proposed by the Group of 77 that represented the interests of a majority of Southern countries at the UN and a handful of European allies (Arizpe 2004, p. 175). The decade continued to promote greater awareness of the cultural dimensions of development and to promote a more holistic and human-centered approach to development itself. It affirmed the importance of cultural identities, supported cultural participation and promoted international cultural cooperation (Stenou 2007, p. 108; UNESCO 1999). The UN Decade generated numerous international meetings, as well as publications and normative standards, some in relation to a broad conception of culture and others pertaining specifically to the arts. Examples of normative standards emerging from the UN Decade's discussions include: ⁷ the Recommendation on the Safeguarding of Traditional Culture and Folklore (1989), the Universal Declaration on

Cultural Diversity (2001), the Convention on the Protection of Underwater Cultural Heritage (2001), the Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage (2003), the UNESCO Declaration concerning the Intentional Destruction of Cultural Heritage (2003) and the Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions (2005).

Critical within the decade was the work of an independent World Commission on Culture and Development established by UNESCO and the UN in 1992. Chaired by former UN Secretary-General Javier Pérez de Cuéllar, the commission produced what is still regarded as a significant contribution to the debate, the report *Our Creative Diversity*. This report continued to challenge mainstream conceptions of development, stressing the embeddedness of development *within* culture and pointing out the cultural assumptions of development thinking and practice. At the same time, it argued for mainstreaming the concept of culture in development in the same way that ‘the environment’ had been mainstreamed through the concept of sustainable development (for example, in the Brundtland report ⁸ and subsequent Earth Summits). The report again stressed an expansive conception of creative expression and heritage, including intangible cultural heritage.

The commission initiated the first *World Culture Reports* to ‘survey trends in culture and development, monitor events affecting the state of cultures worldwide, construct quantitative cultural indicators, highlight good cultural practices and policies and analyse specific themes of general importance accompanied by policy suggestions’ (UNESCO 1998, p. 5). Although these reports have not been published biannually as originally envisaged, significant international reports on cultural themes continue to be published by UNESCO (such as 2009’s *Investing in Cultural Diversity and Intercultural Dialogue* and the *Creative Economy Reports* of 2008, 2010 and 2013). These reports continue to inform donor policy in relation to the arts as well as supporting those advocating for further arts funding within development.

The culmination of the UN Decade for Cultural Development was the Intergovernmental Conference on Cultural Policies for Development (held in Stockholm 1998), which was charged with transforming the ideas raised in *Our Creative Diversity* into policy and practice. ⁹ The main outcome of the Stockholm Conference was the publication of an *Action*

Plan on Cultural Policies for Development (UNESCO 1998), which focused on a range of issues similar to those raised by the World Commission: mainstreaming cultural considerations within development practice, promoting creativity and participation in cultural life, the potential for cultural exchange to support peace by enhancing mutual understanding, the need to democratize understandings of culture, freedom of expression as a human right and the protection of cultural heritage (tangible and intangible). It placed an increased focus on the economic potential (enhanced through professionalization, active management and expanded educational opportunities) of the cultural industries so long as the trade rules for the sector could be made fairer. ¹⁰ The *Action Plan* also outlined a particular role for ‘creators’ as making an ‘essential contribution’ to ‘improving quality of life, to promoting identity and to the cultural development of a society’ (UNESCO 1998, Point 13), and it strongly advocated providing more resources, both human and financial, for cultural development, including support for the arts.

The Emergence of Dedicated Arts Funding in Development

The initiatives associated with the UN Decade for Cultural Development mention the arts, in passing, as manifestations of, and contributing to, broader cultural processes, but they did not isolate them or explore them in depth. This lacuna was noted by a handful of donors, individuals and other lobbyists who subsequently began to focus on arts-centered projects, while at the same time drawing on those culture and development initiatives to support their work. The lack of direct attention to artists in the World Commission’s 1995 report *Our Creative Diversity*, for example, was noted by Dr. Ingrid Eide, president of the Norwegian National Commission for UNESCO. In response, NORAD (in partnership with UNESCO) developed and funded a project called Artists in Development, which offered professional workshops in the South to groups of artists and artisans in the late 1990s and early 2000s. The project had multiple objectives, as is often the case with arts funding in development: it set out to strengthen cultural diversity by supporting local artists—countering ‘asymmetries in the

cultural processes of globalisation' while at the same time improving technical capabilities to help them become 'income-generating,' and 'interface with the international market' (UNESCO 2003).

The late 1990s and early 2000s saw the establishment of a number of pilot projects like this and, more importantly, the establishment of dedicated 'culture funds' in some bilateral aid agencies and independent NGOs. These include Norway's development agency NORAD, Sweden's development agency SIDA and the Dutch NGOs Prince Claus Fund and Hivos. Although often referred to as 'culture' funds, these funds tend to primarily support artists while including support for institutions of public culture like museums, libraries and the media.

At the same time, a number of other factors associated with globalization in the post-Cold War era brought greater public interest and scrutiny to the values of the arts in the global context. Intensifying processes of globalization were seen both as a challenge (increasing cultural conflict, [11](#) the threat of cultural homogenization) and as an opportunity (increased contact with diverse cultural manifestations and hybridity [12](#) as a positive engagement with diversity). With increasingly diverse communities within nation states (partly through economic migration), intercultural understanding was seen as vital to social cohesion. In this context, 'supporting new, emerging and experimental arts forms and expressions' was, according to the World Commission on Culture and Development (1996, p. 41) 'an investment in human development.' The arts were seen as a valuable for increasing empathy with and understanding of culturally distinct 'others' as well as offering a public site for the abstracted discussion of contentious issues (Gould 2003; Malloy 2005), and artistic experimentation was seen to contribute to the negotiation of new identities.

The second factor that contributed to the increased visibility of the arts as a contributor to social change, was the rapid increase in the volume and value of cultural goods and services traded globally as part of the shift towards a post-industrial 'knowledge' economy and a strengthened focus on creativity and innovation as forces of entrepreneurial activity. Between 1980 and 1991, world trade in 'printed matter; literature; music; the visual arts, both cinema and photographic; and radio and television equipment' almost tripled, 'from \$67 billion to \$200 billion' (Jolly et al. 2004, p. 215).

At the same time, the proliferation of free trade agreements generated alarm about the possibility of cultural homogenization if cultural goods and

services were not excluded from these agreements. The film industry is the most often cited genre in this debate. Under a subheading entitled 'Diversity Destroyed in Less than a Decade,' Joost Smiers (2003) gives numerous examples of dramatic falls in national film production (in Turkey, Brazil, Mexico, Egypt, Indonesia, Algeria) following free trade agreements, liberalizing policies and the resulting influx of films from Hollywood. ¹³ The UNESCO Universal Declaration on Cultural Diversity (ratified in early November 2001), which was a response, in part, to these tensions, confirmed the distinctive nature of cultural goods and services as 'vectors of identity, values and meaning,' which must not, therefore, be treated as 'mere commodities or consumer goods' (Article 8).

Together, the initiatives associated with the UN Decade for Cultural Development have provided a frame of reference for integrating cultural policies into development and legal instruments with which to lobby for greater support for culture within development and for the arts as a vital aspect of culture. The rising economic importance of cultural goods and services and the political importance of the arts as contributors to social cohesion have intensified interest in the possibilities of the arts to contribute to a range of development processes. It is perhaps not surprising that support for the arts embodies some of the tension evident in development's relationship with the broader conceptual terrain of culture. Thus, the arts are variously seen as: expressions of cultural diversity—a bulwark against the homogenizing effects of globalization (and development); contributors to social cohesion through enhanced intercultural understanding; enablers of economic growth through trade and cultural tourism; more effective means (through community theatre for example) of transmitting development messages at the local level; or activist markers of cultural difference through which to make political claims (including contesting development).

Resulting Platforms for Supporting Artists

Today artists, arts organizations and cultural administrators are supported by development agencies and NGOs across the South and across a range of genres, including visual and performing arts, craft, music, film and television, writing and publishing and digital media. Processes supported

include arts education, cultural policy development, marketing and distribution, capacity-building in production technologies, festivals and networking, among many others. Some arts projects are small-scale and localized, whereas others have significance at national, regional and international levels. In many cases, exchange is a vital element of practice.

This does not mean, however, that artists can rely on steady support for their processes and infrastructure development: donor support for the arts is almost always short-term, in the (rather utopian) hope that arts organizations become self-financing or find ongoing financial support from another source within a typical project period of two to three years. Although this may happen occasionally (see Allardice; and Stevens and Munro, this volume), particularly when economic development and employment are core intentions behind the project, in most cases, it does not. This means that development funding mostly supports the emergence of multiple short-term projects but is less likely to support the building of physical infrastructure or a successful (but not profit-making) organization over time. On the other hand, as you will see throughout the chapters in this volume, artist-led projects do continue despite the unreliability of donor support, and in many cases, necessity really is proved to be ‘the mother of invention.’ Artist-led projects often show extraordinary resilience and entrepreneurial drive in maintaining the processes that they value in their particular context, although the vagaries of funding do affect the capacity of organizations to plan over the long-term. In many cases, a dynamic individual, trained professionally in the arts, is primarily responsible for developing and managing an arts project, either with occasional donor support (see Stupples, this volume) or entirely without it (see Stevens and Munro, this volume). There are examples in this volume where national-level state support for the arts is significant (see Lewis and Qwabe, this volume), but in many other cases, state support is completely absent or even unwanted, due to the conditions attached to it. Whether or not the entrepreneurial creative ‘industries’ should receive government subsidies remains open to debate. The sustainability of arts projects and processes over time remains one of the key challenges for artists in the global South, as it does for artists anywhere.

Development Actors Who Support the Arts

The presence of development organizations as arts funders suggests that existing state institutions in ‘target’ countries do not have the desire or capacity to support arts practices. In some cases, development organizations actively work with the state to develop cultural policy (see Teaiwa and Huffer, this volume); yet in other cases, cultural bureaucracies are regarded (by local artists) as conservative and anachronistic, and international donors support an independent cultural sector that is largely artist-led. As the approach of different supporting bodies is infinitely varied, here we give just a brief overview of the various actors involved and the general characteristics of funding mechanisms.

The range of donors in the art and development field is evolving and likely to expand with the current UN focus on the creative economy matching the current liberal turn in development. A number of bilateral aid agencies, mostly located in Northern and Western Europe, run targeted arts programs, although the ways in which these are administered varies. Some countries have a targeted ‘culture fund’ as part of their bilateral development assistance program. Denmark, for example, has a distinct Danish Centre for Culture and Development, which is part of the Danish Ministry of Foreign Affairs. In other countries, funding for the arts within development is split between the Ministry for Development and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, often with no common approach.

There are also variations in approach and focus. The French government’s support, for example, is oriented towards film, cultural policy and intellectual property. Some bilateral agencies, such as the Swedish development agency (SIDA), support governments in the South to draft national cultural policy. Others support independent arts networks that have, as part of their policy, an intention to influence state cultural policy. Many bilateral development agencies (like those of Australia and New Zealand) do not have dedicated arts and culture programs but will fund clearly development-focused groups like educational theater troupes. ¹⁴

Bilateral funds for the arts are often administered through embassy representatives in recipient nations. Former colonial powers tend to be particularly active in their former colonies, such as the Spanish embassies throughout Hispano-America, or France in the Pacific. Beyond the

administration of arts funds, embassies may also offer in-kind support, such as providing temporary venues for arts activities or sponsoring a visiting artist. In addition to embassies, national cultural associations such as the Goethe Institute, the Alliance Française, the Swedish Institute and the British Council all support the arts in the South in a framework of cultural exchange.

Equally as important as bilateral support is that which comes from a range of multilateral organizations. UNESCO is the most visible and the most wide-ranging in its support for the arts. It is highly active in advocacy at the international level, drives debate, informs policy development, invests in the drafting of international conventions and agreements which others can use as advocacy instruments, provides direct support to artists and arts organizations through specific funding mechanisms and has regional offices that support the development of cultural policies, research on the local cultural sector, the development of projects that enhance cultural diversity, the certification of works of tangible and intangible cultural heritage and capacity building in the sector in order to stimulate its economic potential. In Central America, for example, the UNESCO regional office in San José researches and drafts documents on cultural policy in the region, administers claims for heritage sites and supports a range of cultural tourism initiatives, such as *Mundo Maya* (formerly *La Ruta Maya*), which connects natural and cultural heritage sites in Belize, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras and Mexico. To what extent the efforts of UNESCO's regional offices are met with enthusiasm and cooperation by governments within the region varies.

UNESCO frequently partners with other multilateral organizations and foundations to extend their capacities. They have partnered, for example, with the African Union and the Ford Foundation to support the Observatory of Cultural Policies in Africa, and again with the French Embassy and the Chilean Society for the Rights of the Author to support a Chilean-based Cultural Observatory. In the Pacific, UNESCO has worked with the International Council for Monuments and Sites Pasifika, the Pacific Islands Museum Association and the Secretariat of the Pacific Community on a range of projects focused on cultural industries, cultural statistics, traditional knowledge, intangible and tangible cultural heritage, including the Pacific World Heritage Programme.

Other UN organizations are also active in supporting the arts, but to a lesser extent. The United Nations Conference on Trade and Development has been influential in articulating the value of the creative economy to development, with two major reports published in cooperation with the UNDP in 2008 and 2010. Those reports argued that the creative economy, having been successful in stimulating economic growth in ‘advanced economies,’ should now be considered ‘a feasible option for developing countries’ (UNCTAD 2008, p. iii), allowing poor countries to ‘leapfrog into emerging high-growth areas of the world economy.’ The creative economy is argued to have been more resilient to the recent financial crisis than other sectors, and cultural tourism is touted as an under-utilized tool for generating economic growth in the South. These reports argue that the creative economy can ‘foster income generation, job creation and export earnings while promoting social inclusion, cultural diversity and human development’ (UNCTAD 2008, p. 4) and therefore contribute to an ideal of ‘equitable, sustainable and inclusive growth’ (UNCTAD 2010, p. xx).

In 2013, UNESCO partnered with the UNDP to publish the *Creative Economy Report Special Edition*, which aimed to broaden the creative economy discourse away from too singular a focus on economic benefits (De Beukelaer 2014). The UNDP also financed (with the Spanish government) the MDG Achievement Fund, which included a ‘culture and development’ theme. The fund supported a number of large-scale capacity-building projects between 2007 and 2013 that contributed to intercultural dialogue, cultural diversity and expressions, cultural heritage and the cultural industries.

The European Union (EU) has also become far more active in recent years in promoting ‘culture and development’ and supporting the arts within that framework. ¹⁵ In 2007, the EU drafted its first significant policy on culture and development, *A European Agenda for Culture in a Globalising World* (Commission of the European Communities 2007), which was inspired by UNESCO’s work on cultural diversity. As well as strengthening intercultural dialogue within EU member states, it proposed increased cultural exchange with, and support for, the cultural sector in countries of the South. In 2009, the EU sponsored a major international colloquium on ‘Culture and Creativity as Vectors for Development’ that brought together artists, arts administrators and development professionals from Europe and from ACP countries (Asia, Caribbean, Pacific) to discuss connections

between culture and development and to review EU policy in this area. This meeting was followed by another in 2010, sponsored by the Spanish government, which was focused on the relationship between culture and the Millennium Development Goals in the lead up to the MDG Summit in New York later that year. The EU also supports the wide-ranging and influential ACP Cultures+ Programme, which promotes the development of the cultural industries and cultural sectors in Asia, the Caribbean and the Pacific, and which is based on the Cotonou Agreement (European Community 2000).

The Commonwealth Foundation, a long-time supporter of literature in Commonwealth territories, has also weighed in on the development debate, with a major report entitled *Putting Culture First: Commonwealth Perspectives on Culture and Development* (Commonwealth Foundation 2008), which noted the Commonwealth community's previous neglect of the cultural sector and analysed the possibilities of artistic and cultural contributions to development processes. More recently, IFACCA, the International Federation of Arts Councils and Culture Agencies, has begun to engage with the international development context, being particularly active in 2013 and 2014 in lobbying for culture to be part of the post-2015 development goals set to replace the Millennium Development Goals (see UNESCO 2013).

Some of these multilateral organizations, such as ACP Cultures+, actively support the emergence and consolidation of South-South networks (such as networks for the marketing and distribution of Caribbean audio-visual material both locally and globally). South-South networks are also supported by a number of NGOs. The European Commission and the Dutch lottery's DOEN Foundation and the Nordic NGO Mimeta support the ARTerial network, for example, which connects cultural producers across the African continent.

Non-governmental organizations are another important segment of donor support for the arts in the context of development. The range of NGOs involved is broad and idiosyncratic. As a consequence, their quality and influence vary widely. They range from large-scale, highly visible funders like the Dutch NGOs Hivos, Arts Collaboratory, the Prince Claus Fund and the DOEN Foundation, through to organizations established by individuals for personal motives. Some are principally development organizations with a cultural arm (Hivos is an example). Others, and these are far fewer, work

solely in the arts and public culture (the Prince Claus Fund, Arts Collaboratory and Mimeta are examples).

Mainstream development NGOs such as Action Aid, Save the Children and the Tearfund use the arts from time to time to assist with their work in other sectors, but their approach values culture *for* development, rather than the development of the cultural sector. They do not have dedicated culture funds, and the approach taken appears to be largely instrumental (see Marsh and Gould 2003).

Well-known artists also, at times, establish NGOs to support the arts in the South. Swedish author Henning Mankell, for example, founded Maputo's Teatro Avenida in Mozambique and also supports the Memory Books project that helps HIV-positive parents produce books for their children about their lives. In Mexico, visual artist Francisco Toledo has established a number of ventures around his native Oaxaca to support cultural patrimony and the arts: the Instituto de Artes Gráficas de Oaxaca, the Museo de Arte Contemporáneo de Oaxaca and an ambitious arts center in an abandoned textile factory at San Agustín Etla. In Oceania, renowned scholar and writer, the late Professor Epeli Hau'ofa, established the Oceania Centre for Arts and Culture at the University of the South Pacific that has grown over 18 years from a poorly funded informal collective of visual artists and dancers to become a focal point of the university's regional identity, outreach and education strategy (Hau'ofa 2008). Now named the Oceania Centre for Arts, Culture and Pacific Studies, it offers a foundation course that all university students from across the 12 member countries are required to take on Pacific culture and the arts, with a performing arts option for assessment. Wherever the connections are personal, support tends to be maintained over the long-term, and may be more sustainable because of the private funding attached.

Overview of the Book

This book is organized across four key themes: structuring culture and the arts for development; the interface of art, agency and activism; the practical dynamics of art and development; and evaluation practices in the arts and culture sector. There is, of course, considerable overlap between thematic

sections: the interplay between structure and agency influence the practical dynamics of grounded processes.

I: Structuring Culture and the Arts for Development

The chapters in this section focus on the frameworks through which the relationship between art and development is imagined and enacted. These include cultural policy formations, discursive frameworks, structuring institutions (such as UNESCO and its legal instruments) and regional approaches to policy-making.

Christiaan De Beukelaer and Justin O'Connor's chapter sets up many of the themes in the book with a productive critique of the relationship between the (currently ascendant) creative economy agenda and the broader (and older) field of culture and development. They describe the creative economy as an example of 'fast policy' embedded within a global agenda for development and economic growth, while highlighting the need for equitable and diverse access to the consumption and production of culture. The authors explore some of the problems of conflating creative industry initiatives with 'culture and development' efforts that have historically challenged teleological notions of development and the technocratic expectations of modernist development, and they draw attention to the specificities of 'art' within both fields. De Beukelaer and O'Connor propose a 'cultural economy' approach that engages issues of sustainability and social justice and does not reduce culture to economic utilitarianism, but rather attends to the non-economic values of culture.

Antonios Vlassis discusses UNESCO's role in advancing the cultural industries/development nexus and explores the interests and strategies of involved actors, as well as their political asymmetries. This chapter focuses on the international historical pathways of cultural development within UNESCO and the place of cultural industries in these debates. It explores why the cultural industries, despite their economic and symbolic importance, are still somewhat of a 'Cinderella' within international public aid for development. To this end, Vlassis identifies three contributing factors: the dispersed and fragmented strategies of UNESCO, the reluctance

and the indifference of developed countries and the weak transnational mobilization of arts NGOs.

Katerina Teaiwa and Elise Huffer's chapter explores regional cultural policy and program initiatives in the Pacific Islands through the work of the Human Development Programme of the Secretariat of the Pacific Community. It reflects on the process to identify and structure aspects of the cultural sector across diverse island states and territories between 2010 and 2014 with the support of a European Union grant. In particular, they describe the regional cultural mapping, planning and policy process, evaluation of the Festival of Pacific Arts and programs to enhance cultural industries in Fiji, the Solomon Islands and Samoa. While outcomes of these programs are too early to analyse, the chapter reflects on the complexity of this process in an indigenous context where funding is limited, government support is minimal and art and culture are seen predominantly as aspects of heritage, sociality, spirituality, tourism and entertainment.

Daniel Gad's chapter considers the importance of arts organizations and networks as civil society actors and teases out some of the potential contradictions and complexities in thinking of artists as agents of social change. The chapter then outlines implications for international cultural policy in framing artists as 'change agents' and discusses new possible alliances between the state, the private sector and civil society.

II: The Interface of Art, Agency and Activism

This section focuses on agency and activism—that is, on differing approaches to conceptualizing the relationship between art practices and various forms of social action. Each chapter examines a particular case, project or organization, but moves from there to explore the forms of change that emerge from it.

The section starts with a chapter by Polly Stupples, in which she explores the value of art's liminal relationship to development. It is often difficult for development practitioners to understand the value of the arts to development processes beyond their instrumental use to achieve predetermined development outcomes. Yet, those who support the arts often do so in the belief that art's value lies elsewhere. Based on extended

research with independent, artist-led projects in Central America, Stupples demonstrates the diverse forms of agency that arts practices can generate—at multiple scales, in relation to development goals and beyond them. Based on this analysis, the chapter theorizes the value of art's liminal relationship to development.

Iolanda Pensa addresses the value of 'contemporary' arts practices to development processes and conceptualizes this value in the idea of 'system error,' denying any easy cause-and-effect relationship between the two, yet still arguing for some development effects in relation to contemporary arts projects. The chapter is based on a grounded analysis of the multidisciplinary project Mobile A2K: Culture and Safety in Africa (2011–2013).

Megan Allardice discusses the perceptions of a group of contemporary dancers in Suva, Fiji on the role of the arts in multiple processes of development. She combines theoretical conceptions, such as Amartya Sen's notions of 'development as freedom' and 'lives of value,' with interviews with the dancers and the results of a dance-based research process, set against the socio-political context of Fiji. The two methods used are found to be complementary and jointly suggest both inherent and economic contributions of the arts to development.

Todd Lanier Lester discusses the strategies behind his development of a long-term artistic residency/urban and food justice project, called Lanchonete.org, currently being rolled out in São Paulo, Brazil. The project builds on intersections between the activism of social movements in contemporary urban spaces and the possibilities of artistic platforms to amplify voice, to bring groups together in novel configurations and to speak across socio-economic strata. Named after the ubiquitous *lanchonete* (lunch counter) and its porous, open-front or open-corner design, the project brings people together around a series of artists' residencies to discuss issues of forced evictions, food justice, access to resources, urban mobility and human resilience—in the hope of informing policy-making processes in the city.

III: The Practical Dynamics of Art and Development

This section examines, through a diverse series of examples, the practical dynamics of art and development. It focuses on examples of good practice, on strategies that have been tested over time and on innovative methods that show promise. It shares reflections from practitioners as well as academic researchers.

The chapter by social scientist Cheryl McEwan and artist Lillian Nabulime provides an account of an exploratory project to use soap sculptures to facilitate dialogue between women and men about HIV/AIDS in rural communities in Uganda. Art, here, is explored as an instrument of education, dialogue, and social and cultural change. The chapter provides a particularly nuanced account of the ways in which the tactile and porous nature of the works themselves prompt discussion and understanding and the value of using art to generate dialogue in contexts where literacy rates are low or in communities where modes of communication and information sharing are predominantly oral.

Ingrid Stevens and Allan Munro discuss the important contributions of craft development to South Africa for the creation of jobs and poverty alleviation, yet they note that many initiatives in this domain fail. In an attempt to counter this tendency, their research interrogated the methods of a major figure in successful craft development, namely, the Victorian William Morris. Drawing on his approach to design, labor and marketing, they developed and tested a theoretical model to benchmark successful South African craft initiatives. The results confirm the efficacy of the benchmarking process, offering strategies for sustainable craft development.

Vanessa Eden reflects on her work as an international volunteer in the Fijian arts sector and the ways in which artistic projects wove together multiple threads that generated diverse economic and social outcomes.

Janine Lewis and Thabiso Qwabe discuss the South African Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme, a collaboration between the South African State Theatre and the Tshwane University of Technology Drama Programme. This program offers community theatre groups development in dramatic arts education, as well as an opportunity to showcase their work in a professional theatre environment. This chapter details how the program has evolved over the years, affirming the development of new and intuitive ways of addressing the artistic training needs identified to empower communities in and around Tshwane

metropolitan area, Gauteng. These objectives include: developing the arts, developing the artists, developing audiences.

FreeDimensional is an NGO that supports artists around the world who are in danger. In this chapter, Sidd Joag and Todd Lanier Lester provide an overview of freeDimensional's integrated tools and services, from their conceptual underpinnings at the intersection of art, culture and human rights to their direct impact on the livelihoods of artists and culture workers who find themselves in difficult and dangerous situations as a result of their activism. Drawing on the organization's 'Creative Safe Haven Advo-kit,' this chapter outlines their DIY methodology for understanding conflict in the various forms, anticipating persecution and proactively accessing or providing critical support to individuals at risk for using creativity to fight injustice.

IV: The Question of Evaluation

In the final section, we turn our attention to the politically and pragmatically important field of evaluation. Evaluation of arts projects in the development field is frequently lacking (or poorly carried out), is often resisted by artists themselves, yet offers the possibility to deepen our insight into creative practices in particular contexts, as well as to improve donor policy.

Kim Dunphy and Vicki-Ann Ware explore evaluation practices employed in participatory arts initiatives that aim to effect social change, drawing from a systematic review of 151 articles on arts in development. Their findings indicate that evaluation is undertaken infrequently and methods were generally weak, although claims about outcomes are ubiquitous. The chapter concludes with recommendations for more effective arts in development work through stronger evaluation practice.

In the final chapter, artist, researcher and evaluator Claudia Fontes discusses how the methodologies used to evaluate the impact of the arts and the definition of the arts themselves as implemented by donors in the international cooperation scene can be analysed and deconstructed to introduce the possibility of an alternative evaluative culture. This new approach to evaluation is explained through examples from Central America and Africa, and it is hoped that this approach may lead to a deeper

and more holistic understanding of the value of the arts in development, while proposing a more democratic concept of ‘cooperation.’

An Emerging Field

The field of art and international development is broad and idiosyncratic. Arts processes can be supported as part of an economic development approach, a human development approach and even a post-development approach, as the chapters in this book demonstrate. Creative practices can fold seamlessly into mainstream development processes, and they can create spaces for critique of those same processes. They can contribute to agency and voice and contribute to sustainable livelihoods and community resilience, just as they can be volatile sites for political contestation and activism. Artists can be persecuted for speaking out in the public space, and sites of cultural heritage can be symbolic targets in armed conflicts. Artists who receive funding from the international community navigate multiple roles at multiple scales across the two distinct spheres of art and development, and they are constantly redefining the way in which the two co-exist.

Questions remain about how best to support and evaluate artistic practices in ways that are not reductionist and that sustain, rather than diminish, the very inventiveness, uncertainty and challenge that the arts are so often valued for. Questions of cause and effect, when it comes to creative processes, are often difficult to clarify and certainly to predetermine. Artistic processes (as part of broader cultural processes) outlast the standard development project cycle, and the vital processes that are part of creative practice may be less visible than the finished object that can be measured as an ‘outcome.’ Furthermore, there is a need to include examples of poor or even ‘failed’ practice in order to engage productively and critically with the possibilities of this field. Yet, the development community is increasingly paying attention to the complexity of the cultural sector itself, and some are experimenting with expansive evaluation frameworks that allow donors to also learn from the expertise of artists. The recent enthusiasm for the creative economy puts great emphasis on the creative industries as sites for inclusive growth, but it is important to recognize ongoing issues of power in

trade negotiations that involve cultural goods and services, just as it is important not to reduce the value, once again, of artistic outputs to their economic value. This book draws attention to the complexities of this vibrant and evolving field. It seeks to broaden the discussion about what values the arts have in relation to development, and it urges us to consider the many forms of agency embodied in the complex entanglements of art and international development.

Notes

- 1 For a discussion of the impact of critical post-colonial feminist perspectives on development thinking, see Radcliffe 2006a, pp. 12–3. For a discussion of post-colonial theory and its impact on development thinking, see McEwan 2009, [Chapter 3](#).
- 2 The UDHR defines everyone's entitlement to 'the economic, social and cultural rights indispensable for his [sic] dignity and the free development of his personality.' Article 27 specifically details the right 'freely to participate in the cultural life of the community, to enjoy the arts and to share in scientific advancement and its benefits' and to have 'the protection of the moral and material interests' as an author of literary or artistic or scientific works.
- 3 See, for example, AECID 2007; Hivos 2002; Ministry of Education of Finland 2007; SDC 2003.
- 4 In 2004, the UNDP based its annual *Human Development Report* around the theme of *Cultural Liberty in Today's Diverse World* (UNDP 2004), promoting multiculturalism, diversity and cultural freedom. See Nederveen Pieterse 2010, pp. 77–82 for a critique.
- 5 The conference itself was the culmination of a growing interest in cultural policies in the 1960s and 1970s. Antecedents included the Intergovernmental Conference on Institutional, Administrative and Financial Aspects of Cultural Policy held in Venice in 1970; the Intergovernmental Conference on Cultural Policies in Latin America and the Caribbean, held in Bogotá, in 1978 and the regional conferences in Helsinki in 1972, in Yogyakarta in 1973 and in Accra in 1975 (Stenou 2007, pp. 101–05).
- 6 Article 2 of UNESCO's 2003 *Convention for the Safeguarding of Intangible Cultural Heritage* (UNESCO 2003) defines it as 'the practices, representations, expressions, knowledge, skills—as well as the instruments, objects, artefacts and cultural spaces associated therewith—that communities, groups and, in some cases, individuals recognize as part of their cultural heritage.' See Kurin 2004 for a useful discussion on this somewhat elusive term.
- 7 For a full list of UNESCO's Legal Instruments in relation to Culture, including these, see portal.unesco.org/en/ev.php-URL_ID=13649&URL_DO=DO_TOPIC&URL_SECTION=-471.html.
- 8 See World Commission on Environment and Development 1987.
- 9 The Stockholm Conference also built on parallel work undertaken by regional actors, such as the Pan-African Conference on Cultural Policies for Development in 1998 and the European Task Force on Culture and Development's report *In From the Margins* (1997), which examined the potential for cultural policy to empower cultural minorities and disadvantaged social sectors.

- 10 The conference was not only celebratory, but issued a number of cautionary warnings, including the need to balance the economic imperative with respect for culture, and the imbalance in access to technological innovations such as the Internet.
- 11 The post-Cold War era saw a marked increase in the rise of intra-state conflicts frequently characterized as culturally driven, as Arizpe notes: '[o]f the approximately one hundred sixty wars that have occurred since 1945, most have taken place within nations, and especially since the end of the cold war, a very great number have been driven by ethnic, religious, or cultural discourses' (2004, p. 164). Debate about the accuracy of such 'culturalist explanations' (Radcliffe 2006a, p. 7) has not impeded a discourse around the potential of enhanced cultural understanding to promote peace and stability.
- 12 Hybridity has been seen as the counter to essentialism—a creative engagement with difference that 'liberat[es] the subject from notions of fixity and purity of origins' (Werbner and Modood 1997, p. 21). For an extensive discussion of the notion of hybridity in both celebratory and more ambivalent terms, see Werbner and Modood 1997.
- 13 Turkish cinema, for example, had been flourishing until a free trade deal signed in 1988 allowed major U.S. distributors to flood the market. By 1992, 'it had become impossible to find a Turkish film—or a film from any other European country—being screened in any cinema in Turkey' (Smiers 2003, p. 103).
- 14 The New Zealand and Australian aid agencies' support of the Vanuatu-based educational community-theatre group, Wan Smol-Bag, is an example.
- 15 Between 1990 and 2007, the EU allocated €155 million to ACP countries in the field of culture in development. That increased to €200 million for the period 2007–2013 (Africa-EU Partnership 2010).

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Part One

Structuring the Cultural Sector for Development

1

The Creative Economy and the Development Agenda

The Use and Abuse of ‘Fast Policy’

Christiaan De Beukelaer and Justin O’Connor

Fast and Slow Policy: Introductory Remarks

Cultural policy—like all public policy—travels at different rates. Preparation for United Nations (UN) or other intergovernmental resolutions —on culture’s multiple links with the sustainability agenda, for example— can be painstaking, lumbering, exhausting and above all, slow. On the other hand, we have seen ‘fast policy’ (Peck 2002), where ideas such as the ‘creative city’ and the ‘creative economy’ gain immediate traction in their zone of origin and rapidly circulate through what has become a global circuit of such ‘fast’ cultural policy. ‘Fast policy’ is often dismissed as a superficial fad, a quick fix adopted without scrutiny, easily available to politicians and policy makers who do not have to risk much but stand to make highly visible gains (Peck 2011). This is usually so; however, it does not necessarily follow that slow policy is always deeper, more rooted in real developments, more long term in focus. Fast policy often has the virtue of touching the *zeitgeist*, no matter how fleeting and insubstantial; slow policy may simply become out of touch, irrelevant, as it makes its way through the opaque circles of intergovernmental negotiation and bureaucratic-diplomatic processing.

The ‘creative economy’ is a quintessential ‘fast policy’ phenomenon. Initially popularized by ‘New Labour’ in Britain (DCMS 1998; Hewison 2014; Smith 1998), it was intended to promote the economic contribution of arts and culture to Britain as a forward-looking, post-industrial nation. However, it was rapidly taken up by those East Asian economies it sought to keep ahead of and by many developing countries who saw a new route to economic growth. From 2008, the creative economy agenda was promoted through a series of *United Nations Creative Economy Reports* (UNCTAD and UNDP 2008, 2010, 2013). As global debates are both crystallized in and driven by these reports, we will take them as the most tangible instance of what we call the ‘creative economy debate.’

In this trajectory, the creative economy exemplifies the phenomenon of fast policy slowing down, congealing into a discourse able to frame the real across multiple locations. This is not simply a question of ideology—the reduction of the discourse of the value of culture to that of economic benefit. As actor–network theory has helped demonstrate, this framing involves very real processes of measurement, of the creation and (re)calibration of instruments, of new sets of agents and institutions vested with the power to establish the boundaries and legitimate rules involved in a determinate set of practices—implicitly and explicitly set against other, competing ways of framing (Callon 1998, pp. 1–56). The creative economy is, in Michel Callon’s sense, performative. Of course, (cultural) policy is meant to be performative, and what the creative economy discourse performs is a transformation of the debates around cultural value into debates around the economic value of that cultural value. It grounds the value of culture in the language of economic efficiency (O’Connor 2015). We invest in culture insofar as it delivers new forms of economic growth, ones that perhaps are more cost effective (low barriers to entry for individuals and cash-strapped states), more sustainable (they do not rely on resources other than the human) and point away from the past (old industry, subsidized culture) towards the rising economic model of the future, where culture has become creativity (Garnham 2005), a resource transferable and productive across all sectors of the economy.

However, if the creative economy was fast policy, it could be so because it fed off—and helped rework—a wider ‘economic imaginary’ (Jessop and Oosterlynck 2008) of the ‘new’ or ‘knowledge’ economy (Jessop 2005). The creative economy was part of the next step in an economic evolution

away from industrial production and the mass provision of public sector services towards a new kind of economy and state. ‘Creative’ may be dismissed as an ‘empty signifier’ (what, now, is not creative?), but it was also a semiotic condensation of multiple narratives articulating a reinvented future which was within our—everybody’s—grasp. Creativity articulated the kind of human resources needed for a move to an innovation driven economy, but it did so in a way that drew on one of the oldest, most available reservoirs of human inventiveness and self-fulfillment: artistic creation.

The creative economy as fast policy contrasts sharply with the ‘culture and development’ moment in development studies in the 1990s. Throughout this period, much attention was given to a rich, diverse and theoretically substantiated debate on the role of culture in processes of development (Hermet 2000; Nederveen Pieterse 1995; Radcliffe 2006; Schech and Haggis 2000; Yousfi 2007). These arguments and ideas, which culminated in the UN Decade for Cultural Development (1988–1997), certainly gained policy traction, but nowhere near as quickly as the creative economy, nor did they move out of a well-defined cultural policy field.

In this chapter, we explore the creative economy agenda as a complex, unfolding set of discourses, tools, actors and imaginaries. We examine what happens when fast policy encounters other, older policy formations, in this case, that of ‘culture and development.’ This is clearly a rather large subject, so we focus our attention on the ‘creative economy debate,’ which attempts to combine elements of an older ‘culture and development’ approach (UNESCO 1998a, 1998b, 2000; WCCD 1996) with that of the creative economy. The challenge, we argue, is to connect the fast creative economy debate that has grown out of cultural (policy) studies (O’Brien 2014), geography (Pratt 2008), media and communications (Hesmondhalgh 2013) and economics (Throsby 2010; Towse 2003) to ‘culture and development’ thinking that is rooted in critical development studies through anthropology (Apthorpe 2005; Clammer 2012; Mosse 2005), development studies (Da Costa 2010; Nederveen Pieterse 1995) and post-colonial studies (De Beukelaer 2012).

From Cultural to Creative (and Back?)

The rise of the creative economy agenda in the ‘developed world’ has been extensively discussed (Hesmondhalgh 2013; O’Connor 2010, 2011). Less attention, at least until recently, has been paid to its extension outside its ‘heartlands,’ even though there are emerging exceptions (e.g., Barrowclough and Kozul-Wright 2012; De Beukelaer 2015; Fonseca Reis 2008). Though, while ‘the West’ has long shifted its economic policies towards services and ideas, the ‘Global South’ is now increasingly following suit (Miller 2009, p. 93). It is quite clear how this creative economy imaginary, its particular language, new econometrics and new kinds of actors/agencies from outside the traditional cultural policy field, quickly became a global agenda. It was picked up by those East Asian countries (Keane 2013; O’Connor and Gu 2006) trying to push their way into the ‘developed countries’ club, seeking to go beyond their established manufacturing success and promote the kind of high value-added economic sector that advanced services and innovation systems could provide. This happened in the first decade of the 21st century. More surprisingly, perhaps, has been the increasing take-up of this agenda in so-called ‘developing’ countries—including some of the poorest (De Beukelaer 2014a, 2015). This began in earnest in 2008 with the first United Nations Council for Trade and Development (UNCTAD) report, and was followed up with a second in 2010. Other international agencies such as the World Bank and World Intellectual Property Organisation have embraced the creative economy discourse as a key area for copyright exploitation, as have many national cultural diplomatic agencies, most especially the British Council and the International Organisation of the Francophonie, which have enthusiastically promoted the agenda throughout Africa and beyond.

No matter how fast the policy, it eventually runs into older discourses, older imaginaries, often embedded in long-standing networks of policy institutions, universities and think tanks, governmental departments and networks of cultural practitioners, activists and consultants. At the level of international agencies, it is UNESCO that has taken the lead in cultural policy and its relationship to the development agenda. UNESCO, in collaboration with other agencies, had across the 1990s developed a sophisticated understanding and critique of ‘development’ (WCCD 1996). It generally asserted the values and practices associated with ‘culture’ over against what they saw as reductive and destructively one-sided approaches to development, as expressed in GDP. Yet mainstream development

thinking remains reluctant (or unwilling) to incorporate this critique (Clammer 2012). In spite of this, the ‘culture and development’ approach influenced parts of UNESCO’s (2005) Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions. In explicitly rejecting the World Trade Organisation’s reduction of cultural goods and services to commodities like any other, it also sought more positively to assert the need to provide the social and economic preconditions for equitable and diverse access to the consumption and production of culture.

There is no space here to discuss in detail the provenance of the three UN *Creative Economy Reports*. What is clear is that the creative economy debate attempts to raise some more critical issues around the creative economy agenda, drawing on the perspective of the ‘culture and development’ approach discussed. In particular, it asserts the importance of local development pathways and highlights some of the problematic aspects of global cultural economies as well as the opportunities they provide. As such, it is entirely compatible with the aims of the 2005 Convention—arguing the need to provide social and economic policy frameworks and support structures for local cultural production and consumption. Such local cultural economies should be about equity and diversity and should maximize the opportunities for local cultural producers to make a living from their activities.

However, as De Beukelaer (2015) has argued, although the ‘culture and development’ agenda tried to challenge single-minded economic developmentalism by taking the cultural context into consideration, the celebratory accounts now associated with the creative economy agenda, often uncritically adopt the teleological sense of progress, economic growth and technocratic change associated with the kind of modernist development that ‘culture and development’ aimed to challenge. Yet the conflation of ‘culture and development’ and ‘creative economy’ might be interpreted as tactics or diplomacy. The creative economy is a real fast policy ‘brand’; it gets ‘culture’ to the negotiating table with the powerful economics, technology and development ministries in a way that the ‘culture and development’ debate never managed to do. The creative economy debate certainly performs some of this tactical work. More pointedly, the 2013 *Creative Economy Report* (UNESCO and UNDP 2013) uses the specific brand of a recurrent report established by UNCTAD in its 2008 and 2010 *Creative Economy Reports*—whatever reservations UNESCO may have

about the term ‘creative economy’ that term must be used and some of its key economic imaginary kept intact as part of this brand.

Contradictions of the Creative Economy

To an extent, the creative economy debate illustrates the ways in which fast policy runs into the complex messiness of the real. What started off as an easy rhetoric has to deal with the realities of the object it tries to designate and form. How does this encounter change the local details of its ‘rollout’ and at the same time alter the basic terms of the discourse itself? Part of this messiness relates to the way fast policy creates its own success, in that many constituencies use it as a way to further an already existing agenda. In the broadest terms, the cultural sector saw the creative economy as just another way of making the argument for culture: in emphasizing the economic benefits of culture, it sought increased resources which would in turn be beneficial to culture (Hewison 2014). Pragmatism, tactics, ‘rendering unto Caesar’ in the name of getting culture to the top decision-making tables—these all provided the circuits for the rapid dissemination of the creative economy agenda, alongside economic agencies and other new entrants that were brought in (design, tech firms, SMEs etc.). This new approach towards government often brought in new sectoral actors who welcomed the change of emphasis towards entrepreneurialism or commercial markets, and new sources of funding, such as from economic and trade departments. However, such new strategies have real consequences for the detailed implementation of creative economy policies, as well as provoking new conflicts of voice (or exit) around the agenda.

Such tactics might be effective in the short term, but they lack the robustness required to negotiate difficult strategic choices, when a policy narrative is tested against the competing interests and dynamics of the real. This is reflected in the creative economy debate that favors positive outcomes over critical engagement with challenges. The focus on positives reveals not only a desire to be upbeat, but also to hold together a complex and flimsy coalition. This conceals both the limited social inclusion that can be attained through arts, culture and creative industries (Belfiore 2002; Oakley 2006) and the negative spillovers of creative industries policies

(Peck 2005). Moreover, it fails to consider the full extent to which creativity is rooted in uncertainty and thus is prone to failure (Bilton 2010; Menger 2009). Beyond these general points of critique on the creative economy, we will highlight three ways in which the 2013 *Creative Economy Report* (CER) (UNESCO and UNDP 2013), as the most explicit exponent of the ‘global’ creative economy debate, has not quite connected to the messy context it operates in.

First, there are no bad examples in the 2013 CER. By this, we mean a focus on failed or outright problematic projects that highlight the difficulty to attain the success of the ‘best practices’ on display. Yet our call for ‘bad examples’ does not signify a cynical stance towards success: there is increasing debate on the necessity to recognize, acknowledge and understand failure and its underlying reasons in development practice. ¹ This does not mean that the 2013 CER, or any policy document, should be turned into a naming-and-shaming show of (un)known failed projects. Rather, it should invite all stakeholders involved to be more open about what does not work, and why certain elements, processes or relations posed problems in their practice. Surely, we can learn from best practices, but we can also learn from (our own) mistakes by confronting them more explicitly and perhaps more publicly.

The 2013 CER in fact mentions one ‘bad’ example, but presents it as a ‘best practice’: a micro-finance project has been set up in Ghana between the Institute for Music and Development (IMD), ARB Apex Bank and the Danish Centre for Culture and Development (UNESCO and UNDP 2013, p. 117). To date, this has, however, not yielded the expected result, and the project is currently dormant. Why not try to convey details about the encountered difficulties in the 2013 CER or on the IMD website in order to avoid future obstacles—or even failure—in other countries or cultural industries? This is merely one of many examples where failure should not be seen as the end of a project, but merely as one step in a long road to better practices. This is the way the IMD actually looks at the project (De Beukelaer 2014b, p. 95); yet, the 2013 CER falls short in conveying this.

Second, mobility remains a significant issue among artists and creatives. This occurs at three levels: emotional, legal and practical. It is no coincidence that we mention emotional first. The shaming of any visa applicant wanting to travel to Europe or the U.S. is emotionally taxing. Disclosing your life story and financial status to a stranger is no pleasure,

especially since this in no way guarantees that you will be granted temporary access to the country of destination. Yet, legally speaking, according to Article 14 of the UNESCO (2005) Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions, parties ² engaged to ‘provid[e] support for creative work and facilitating the mobility, to the extent possible, of artists from the developing world’ (UNESCO 2005). This remains, to considerable extent, a dead letter. Many artists are still refused entry to countries that are party to the convention. While lip service is paid to the importance of cultural and creative industries, many countries remain rather closed to artists looking to engage with their audiences.

Granted, some artists in the past have blatantly abused the rather lax regulations on artists’ visas to disappear upon disembarkation. It would thus be unfair to blame the countries of destination alone, even though travel regulations to countries like the UK and Australia have become highly restrictive. While these measures are part of a larger reactionary tendency in migration politics, this does not make the situation any easier for many *bona fide* artists, upcoming and established. ³ Culture and creativity are indeed mostly actively concentrated in cities, as the 2013 CER highlights, but artists and entrepreneurs thrive by local and global connections. The severe imbalance that exists, no matter its origins or politics, in the possibility of mobility for people with different passports does not do the creative economy any good.

Third, the 2013 CER maintains the divide between ‘developed’ and ‘developing’ countries and focuses on the latter explicitly. The engagement with examples, practices and ideas from ‘developing’ countries is a much-needed addition to the debate on the role of cultural and creative industries in societies. It is important because most attention in academia has been on so-called developed countries, largely ignoring the particularities in practices and strategies that exist around the world.

While we understand and applaud the explicit engagement of the report with the conditions and contexts in ‘developing’ countries, we equally regret the near-absence ⁴ of meaningful interaction with cities and regions in ‘developed’ countries. ⁵ Is a rigid divide between two groups of countries the best way to flag that there is some degree of difference? How does the difference between ‘developed’ countries that are in ‘crisis,’ between ‘developing’ countries that are ‘emerging’ and an Africa that is ‘rising’ pan

out in the old-fashioned divide between the ‘haves’ and the ‘have-nots’? After all, this division is not a mere reflection of a neutral reality, but the result of politicized discursive choices (Escobar 1995).

There are indeed differences, yet we propose an end to the rigid demarcation of ‘developed’ and ‘developing’ countries. By building on the examples and theories of ‘developed’ countries as inspiration for ‘developing countries’ while saying that the situation in the latter is *different*, little justice is done to the actual challenges that exist in diverse contexts. More crucially, employing this binary foregoes the not-so-simple discussion concerning the actual differences between places around the world. Perhaps we need to recognize more explicitly that Detroit can actually learn from Johannesburg.

While these challenges are known and acknowledged by virtually all stakeholders in the creative economy, there is an aspect of being unwilling to draw attention to them for fear of introducing dissent and problems into the agenda. There are deeper issues, as fast policy hits longer standing agendas and actors. In a certain sense, there is a deliberate avoidance of depth, or a rewriting of one history over another. The palimpsest of policy and practices remain un(der)explored (De Beukelaer 2015).

In this context, history matters. UNESCO—or anyone, for that matter—is unlikely to disagree with us on this point, yet little attention is paid to the importance of history in the context of the creative economy—or rather its displacement of other histories. Chapter Five of the 2013 CER opens with a section on path dependency, illustrating how history matters for the emergence of particular cultural industries in Japan and Mexico (UNESCO and UNDP 2013, p. 90). Further engagement with evolutionary economics, where path dependency forms an important part, is, however, relegated to a footnote (UNESCO and UNDP 2013, p. 26).

Underlying questions about the history of cultural politics and policies remain insufficiently explored. What discourse existed previously? How was culture previously linked to development, or why wasn’t it? What initiatives existed to support the cultural sector? What kind of policies have proven (in)effective in specific places, and why? What local politics helped or obstructed the consolidation of a cultural sector? What are the remnants of colonial rule in cultural policies (of public policy in general)? What general traces of (post-)colonial influences prevail when thinking about identity, class and ideology? ⁶ These tensions illustrate the difficulty of the

‘fast and catchy’ policy to connect to the complex realities it is meant to deal with. While the 2013 CER makes a necessary and important step to bridge this gap, it is unclear if the creative economy is equipped to internalize the contradictions of ‘development.’

Limits of the Creative Economy as Development Policy

As we noted above, though a piece of ‘fast policy,’ the creative economy condensed a number of themes. The release of the concept of the ‘creative economy’ into the policy ecosystem in the early 2000s introduced a new dynamic. Culture, and the particular kind of creativity associated with it, was to be promoted not as a supplement to, or modification of, GDP-led economic growth, but as a deepening of it. Culture, in the form of the creative industries, became available to local development strategies as a range of potentially profitable products and services. In addition, the growing importance of intellectual property rights within the large cultural corporations suggested a close affinity, if not a merger, of the creative industries with the wider mobilization of capacities required for a ‘knowledge economy.’ However, part of the success of the creative industries in mobilizing support was not just its narrative of cultural and economic ‘win-win.’ Its focus on contemporary and emergent kinds of cultural production, appealing to youth, new technologies and cultural practices outside the staid and elitist hierarchies of ‘high art’ and heritage, suggested a force of democratization. Finally, ‘creativity’ invoked the anthropological resource of culture in a new way. Creativity would, it was frequently argued, no longer be locked up in the elitist or at least specialized arts; now an ‘everyday’ democratic creativity would be linked to the necessarily (they were not subsidized) entrepreneurial energy of independent creative businesses that would galvanize local economies (e.g., Hartley 2005).

In addition, however, we need to look at some of the limitations of the culture and development agenda of the 1990s. The terms ‘creative industries’ and ‘cultural industries’ are, we would argue, not interchangeable (Garnham 2005; Hesmondhalgh 2013). The cultural (including media) industries—the mass production and distribution of

symbolic goods and services—have long been seen as an essential part of national identity in ‘developed’ countries and crucial to nation-building in ‘developing’ countries. The support and regulation of the broadcast and print media especially were seen as essential to processes of modernization, and only latterly linked to possible economic spin-offs. They were usually subsidized. The deregulation and globalization of (Northern-dominated) media industries in the 1980s and 1990s—linked to the new digital technologies of satellite and the Internet, as well as new legal and logistical technologies—undermined this nation-building model. Here, the theme of cultural diversity crossed with an older debate within UNESCO—that of the New World Information and Communication Order.⁷ This movement attempted to redress the one-way flow of information and communication from developed to developing countries. Complex in its geopolitics, it was more or less defeated by the early 1980s—a period which marked the rise of neo-liberalism in the U.S. and UK and a new phase of media deregulation and globalization.

In this sense, protecting national cultural industries—asserting the rights of states to make an exception of cultural goods and services within GATT and then WTO agreements—seemed a legitimate aspect of the cultural diversity agenda and was acknowledged as such in the 2005 Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions (De Beukelaer, Pyykkönen and Singh 2015). However, there are some problems with this. First, though its demise has been greatly overstated (Calhoun 1994), the nation-state is no longer seen to be the unique source, or guarantor, of local cultural identity in the face of a Western-dominated global modernity. New digital and logistical infrastructures of global exchange have opened new possibilities for diverse local production even as they have brought the dominant global media players to the front doorstep, merely changing the *context* but not the nature of the ‘cultural exception’ (Guèvremont 2015).

For many critics, all this suggested—and continues to do so—a folding together of the ‘culture and development’ agenda with commodification and the forces of neoliberalism (McGuigan 2004). At the moment—as exemplified in the creative economy debate—they exist in juxtaposition, or the creative economy agenda shunts ‘culture and development’ to the margins, or the latter simply exits from the debate.

Yet, perhaps this suggests a new challenge, in which these two agendas need to learn to talk to one another (De Beukelaer 2015; Oakley and O'Connor 2015; Pratt 2014). It demands recognition of the limitations of both 'culture and development' and of the creative economy. There is then a radical uncertainty or ambiguity at the heart of the creative economy debate, and this in turn articulates a wider sense of uncertainty or conflict of imaginaries. This can provide a space to bend or shift or reframe, or it might lead to confusion and incoherence or even a kind of double-speak, emphasizing culture to one audience and economic development to another.

Art, Culture or Creativity?

What is the position of art in relation to the creative economy and the 'culture and development' agendas? Throughout the three *Creative Economy Reports*, there is much focus on both 'culture' and 'creativity,' but the position of 'art' in this debate is somewhat uncertain. Some supporters of the creative economy agenda would explicitly exclude 'art' or 'the arts' from the creative industries (Potts et al. 2008). This position is echoed by its critics, who suggest that art has been completely sidelined in favor of 'innovation' (Oakley 2009; Oakley and O'Connor 2015). However, in the original DCMS (1998) formulation,⁸ and with most accounts of the cultural and creative industries/economy, 'the arts' are included as part of the sector. We might add that the whole creative cities agenda, whether linked to Richard Florida (2002) or Charles Landry (2000), had the arts as central to the cultural offer of the city (Grodach and Silver 2013).

The arts have been present in other ways, too. As noted above (and elsewhere, cf. Oakley and O'Connor 2015), the notion of creativity being put into play in the creative economy has been explicitly linked to the kind of imagination, experimentation and unorthodox 'method in the madness' working practices associated with figure of the artist. This particular concept of the artist is associated with Enlightenment and Romantic notions of 'genius' and was deeply ingrained in the humanist aspirations behind the establishment of UNESCO after World War Two. On the other hand, the rise of the culture and development strand within UNESCO was also associated with a longer tradition in which 'art' was to be seen as one part—

perhaps only a minor one—of a wider anthropological view of culture. Indeed, one of the key resources for challenging the uni-linear, Western-centric model of development was this anthropological notion of ‘everyday’ culture, in all its diversity. This emphasis on the anthropological not only asserted the validity and the human necessity of what were often dismissed or patronized as ‘traditional’ cultures as part of any concept of development, but it also rejected the implicit hierarchy contained in the Western emphasis on art as the pinnacle of human civilization.

This distinction can be traced back to two foundational works of cultural policy and anthropology that were published almost simultaneously: Mathew Arnold’s *Culture and Anarchy* (1869) and Edward Tyler’s *Primitive Culture* (1871). Arnold framed culture more narrowly as art and literature—‘the best that has been thought and said,’ and the idea of its uplifting role has its roots in the French and German Enlightenments. Additionally, through the movements of Romanticism and Modernism, art (as defined in Western aesthetics) was given a privileged role as an expression of pure human creativity often denied in other parts of society, notably ‘the economy.’ Tyler, on the other hand, took an anthropological approach. He defined culture as ‘that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society.’ Culture was defined broadly as all that which is not determined by nature. Though claiming general validity as an account of human society, this approach was mostly directed towards ‘primitive’ or ‘traditional’ societies.

Arnold’s approach deeply informed much of Western cultural policy up to 1945 and beyond. Critics such as Raymond Williams and Richard Hoggart (the former Assistant Director-General at UNESCO from 1971 to 1975) stressed its elitism and its denigrating of ‘ordinary culture.’ Anthropologists also took issue with Tyler’s notion of ‘primitive culture’ for having an implicit hierarchy whereby these primitive cultures are positioned on a (potential) teleological trajectory towards the ‘civilized’ as indexed against their ability to produce ‘art.’ Later anthropologists—such as Franz Boas and Margaret Meade—asserted the validity of traditional cultures as human meaning systems and thus actively informed the later agendas of cultural diversity (Bennett 2013).

The anthropological critique of Arnoldian ‘high culture’—that culture is part of a wider society and not the preserve of an educated and

Western(ized) elite—is now part of the language of contemporary democratic cultural politics. But where does that leave the notion of ‘art’? Though it is common to use the term ‘art’ to describe artifacts, stories, literatures, music, performances and so on coming from all times and all places, historians tell us that the term and the concept of ‘art’ comes from Europe in the middle of the eighteenth century. As Jacques Rancière (2013, p. ix) wrote recently:

[E]ven if histories of art begin their narratives with cave paintings at the dawn of time, Art as a notion designating a specific form of experience has only existed in the West since the end of the 18th century.

It is here that a distinct realm of practice, ‘creative’ in a way that was different from mere artisan handicraft, and knowing the world differently from science or morality, came into being. For many critics, of course, this was tied up with elitism, class society and the separation of the cultivated from the ignorant masses—the ‘rise of the bourgeoisie.’ This is undeniable in large part, but with it came two other elements. First, ‘art’ became a new site or set of tools for governments to work on populations in new ways, as a distinct realm separate from the ‘everyday’ (Bennett 1998, 2013; Hunter 1988). It was used to civilize them, to make them into citizens, to make them into self-governing liberal subjects, to actualize their potential. Second, the distinct realm of ‘art’ came to hold up certain ideals—of freedom, or self-fulfillment, of a harmonious society—against the world of economy and administration. These notions of culture-as-art are still with us and inform cultural policy in recognizable ways. Third, the tension between ‘art’ and ‘culture’ has also built on the paradoxical opposition between inherited and shared customs and traditions, on the one hand, and a striving for new forms of individuality, on the other. As William Ray (2001, p. 16) puts it, culture,

tells us to think of ourselves as being who we are because of what we have in common with all the other members of our society and community, but it also says we develop a distinctive particular identity by virtue of our efforts to know and fashion ourselves as individuals.

Such issues all raise large philosophical and historical questions, ones we are unable to address here. The key point is that in any attempt to understand global creative economy policy, the couplet—so slippery and all embracing—of ‘art and culture’ needs much closer scrutiny.

First, the (hierarchical) distinction between ‘art’ and (anthropological) culture no longer ideologically maps onto the Global North and South, or perhaps there is now greater recognition that this simplistic distinction (should have) never quite covered the complexity of global relations. It is not only that the cultures of the South have now gained their recognition and legitimacy, even if the ‘culture game’ of the art trade remains an unequal affair (Oguibe 2004). The tensions between art and culture that emerged in eighteenth-century Europe—individual/communal, disruptive/constructive, future-oriented/traditional, innovative/preservative and so on—now pervade the globe.

Second, asserting the anthropological notion of culture (everyday or ordinary culture, or as a ‘way of life’) can no longer automatically define a democratic cultural policy either against the Global North or against ‘the arts,’ wherever they are. We can see this very clearly in the creative industries. These gained a strong democratic charge by claiming to open up avenues of ‘everyday’ creativity outside of the established arts. Yet, at the same time, this notion of creativity drew (explicitly and implicitly) on that classic artistic creativity of disruption, innovation, individual drive and restlessness. In this case, of course, artistic creativity was to be used as a resource for economic innovation and growth rather than a residual value to be set against ‘the economic’. Artistic creativity is therefore very ambiguous (Pang 2012). On the one hand, it can be branded as elitism, despising the unsophisticated pleasures of the masses and/or cozying up to the wealthy and powerful. On the other, it becomes a new human resource to be exploited for innovation economies or the symbolic capital of aspiring global cities. Might there be a need to be more explicit about the role of ‘art’ as a particular form of culture within cultural policy?

Art has been part of the critique as well as the celebration of power; free circulation of ‘artistic’ goods part of civil society as well as the market; a distinct realm of citizenship and human empathy as well as a site of liberal governmentality and state building. Art has been part of establishing colonial superiority over ‘backwards’ countries; it has also been a way of claiming global citizenship against local states, of embracing the future against the oppressive past. Despite being frequently relegated to heritage, to pre-industrial or analogue culture, to a neo-feudal accompaniment to early capitalism, might not art’s disruptive, individualizing and empowering

aspects in many ways mark contemporary world *not less, but more* than ever before?

From Culture and Development to Cultural Economy

There is certainly a need to make more explicit the inherent uncertainty and contradiction at the core of artistic practice. We need to be clearer about the value being claimed for art working within arguments in support of culture. That is, alongside culture as anthropological ‘fact’ (see, e.g., Appadurai 2013)—people act in certain ways with certain world views and customs and so we have to work with these for development initiatives to work—is culture as ‘value’—these meaning systems are part of what it is to be human, to have human dignity. These two aspects are intertwined in the ‘culture and development’ approach that sees culture as both means and end of development.

These ideas perhaps found their most coherent policy expression through the World Commission on Culture and Development, set up by the UN and UNESCO in 1993, and in its report *Our Creative Diversity* (WCCD 1996). Its opening statement was: ‘Development divorced from its human or cultural context is growth without a soul.’ Culture can be, in the words of two World Bank economists, ‘harnessed for positive social and economic transformation through [its] influence on aspirations, the co-ordination of collective action, and the ways in which power and agency work within a society’ (Rao and Walton 2004, p. 4). But culture is an end as well as a means. Development, according to Amartya Sen (2004) and others, is an entitlement to a dignified way of life, and culture is absolutely central to this. It is for these reasons that Lourdes Arizpe—who supervised the 1998 *World Culture Report*—could write: ‘Culture is not embedded in development but development embedded in culture’ (Arizpe 2004, p. 181).

The emphasis on culture as both anthropological fact and human value needs to be understood in relation to the great ‘other’ of culture: the economy. ‘Culture and development’ was a rejection of neo-classical economic models and *homo economicus* (De Beukelaer 2012). In asserting the need to take other forms of meanings into account beyond that of abstract economic rationality, it asserted both the fact of culture—people

actually see and act upon the world in ways that neo-classical economics cannot understand—and introduced the possibility of extra-economic meanings and values as grounds for judging the success of any process of *actual* human development.

Culture and development engaged in a process of ‘re-embedding’ the economy in anthropological culture. However, first, this tended to give culture a normatively positive value—breaking with abstract economic man—and introducing a kind of ‘embedded culture good/disembedded economy bad’ binary. Second, this generated a highly ambivalent value for ‘art,’ which could be seen as specific ‘organic’ expressions of this culture or as a second-order disembedding, or separating out of culture from everyday life towards professional and elite practice. This ambiguity is at play in cultural policy formulations of ‘art and culture,’ where argumentation slides between the terms but cannot bring itself to elide them. Third, as noted above, culture and development was unable to deal adequately with the creative economy agenda. Here was a form of cultural production that was, in part, structured around global ‘disembedded’ markets and whose developmental ‘pay-off’ was couched in economic metrics of jobs and money. In addition, it was presented as a liberation of everyday democratic creativity and assertion of popular cultures against the state-heavy worlds of art and heritage. In this context, culture and development’s positioning of art as some disembedded form of culture merely played into the hands of the creative economy.

In this context, it is ‘art’ as much as anthropological culture that continues to provide its traditional historical opposition to ‘pure’ economic or governmental rationality (cf., O’Connor 2015). One of the key sources of opposition to the creative economy agenda has been from those who reject the reduction of art to economic logics (cf., Hewison 2014). This can be seen in the work of both Bourdieu (1996) and Rancière (2010), who see the historical specificity of art (with all its complex bourgeois, governmental and Eurocentric aspects) as nevertheless a space of autonomy and dissent that we lose at our peril.

Nevertheless, the new forms of intersection between art, culture and economy articulated in the creative economy agenda—however distorted—are not to be avoided, nor is the proliferation of ‘artistic’ energies and aspirations beyond the established art world which that agenda also proclaimed. In order to capture this, we prefer the term ‘cultural economy.’

This is not cultural economics—where the ‘economic’ is the business dimension of the cultural product, to be discussed in relative isolation by (sympathetic) economists. Nor it is that form of cultural anthropology that sees culture as a distinct ontological realm of meaning opposed to, and threatened by, disem-bedded markets driven by abstract economic logics.

Cultural economy recognizes that contemporary cultural production is an economy—it has contracts, markets, jobs, copyright and so on—but refuses to accept that economy as an external given which culture must either oppose or accommodate. The values produced, distributed and consumed in the cultural economy cannot be separated from the practices and institutional arrangements through which they are produced.

This, of course, is a political economy of culture approach (cf., Hesmondhalgh 2013), which strongly marked media and cultural industries policy thinking in the 1980s and early 1990s, and which had a significant impact on UNESCO and the 2005 Convention. Cultural economy, by extension, is a way of registering the proliferation of cultural production outside of the large cultural industry systems which political economy tended to address—a proliferation of aspiration towards cultural work and a proliferation of connections between the sphere of ‘culture’ and the rest of the ‘economy.’ However, cultural economy is much more explicit than political economy in asserting that the values expressed in ‘art’ and in ‘culture’ should have a greater say in how its forms of work, markets, regulation, subsidy and policy infrastructure should be organized.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we have explored some of problematic aspects of the creative economy agenda. More particularly, we have tried to show how the ambiguities and evasions reflect an historical conjuncture in the creative economy debate through which the frictions between the ‘culture and development’ and ‘creative economy’ agendas may open up new spaces for thinking cultural policy, or result in incoherence or the discursive violence of a market-driven innovation program. We looked in some detail at the ambiguities of art and/or culture: do we see art as a residual category confined to the heritage sector of the creative economy, or are its values in

fact coming to be more dispersed, more global than ever before? We ended by evoking a reconsideration of the term ‘cultural economy’ in which the different strands of political economy, culture and development and creative economy thinking might be productively brought together (Gibson and Kong 2005).

We began by contrasting fast and slow policy. We suggested that the ‘culture and development’ agenda had come out of a long process of practical and critical work across different national and international bodies. In contrast, we see the creative economy as an ad hoc neologism, which nevertheless has captured the policy imagination of countries and cities around the globe. We are witnessing fast policy turning into slow policy.

This might not mean a deepening of our understanding of the concept and its accommodation and alterations of previous policy settings. Slow policy may simply adopt the flimsiness of fast policy and embed this in the diplomatic-bureaucratic world of cultural policy. Thus, the well-rehearsed ambiguity of the term ‘creative industries’ in terms of statistics (does it include ICT or design, should this be cultural and creative etc.) (Tremblay 2011) and indeed, as to what its economic impact consists of through employment (e.g., Markusen et al. 2008; Ross 2007) or innovation (e.g., Pratt and Jeffcutt 2009) or tourism (e.g., Richards 2011) etc. have persisted alongside more ideological oppositions to its agenda (e.g., Lovink and Rossiter 2007; McGuigan 2009). Does anyone really have a clear idea of what a creative economy policy agenda might actually consist of? Are there really grounds for modification, adaptation, feedback and redirection—or is it simply the dead hand of policy formulations to be trotted out but not really taken seriously?

In its attempt to get culture into the Millennium Development Goals and the post-2015 Sustainable Development Goals, the senior leadership of UNESCO has asserted the role of culture as a driver for development (see, e.g., the 2013 Hangzhou Declaration; the 2013 CER; and the 2014 Florence Declaration). ⁹ Yet this form of ‘development’ linked to culture is no longer in some sort of opposition to economically oriented development, as the ‘post-development’ literature claimed (Rahnema and Bawtree 1997), but is merely a supplement to it. ‘Culture’ is to be used to attain an array of (human) development goals, none of which appear to in be in any kind of tension with any other, and are all equally attainable:

Adequately nurtured, creativity fuels culture, infuses a human-centred development and constitutes the key ingredient for job creation, innovation and trade while contributing to social inclusion, cultural diversity and environmental sustainability.

(UNCTAD and UNDP 2010, p. xix)

The data presented to systematically explore this influence focuses on economic trade to fit into the crudest and most problematic measure of development: the growth of the GDP. The declaration manages to reconcile this multifunctional positive contribution of culture by inserting it into a kind of superficial historical narrative of a progression from agriculture, to industry, to services, to a ‘creative economy’ that no economic historian or sociologist would take seriously.

Cultural policy globally faces a moment of crisis and opportunity. The post-1945 development paradigm outlined a singular path in which developing countries were to move from ‘traditional’ to ‘modern’ societies (Escobar 1995). Cultural policy has been deeply implicated in this paradigm in the past, as a way to legitimize the nation state as a driver of this development process. Nevertheless, cultural agencies like UNESCO did seek to challenge or modify this paradigm, asserting the centrality of culture and cultural diversity to individuals and societies. This challenge was strengthened by the anti-colonial movement (and later world system theorists), which argued that the geopolitical ‘game’ was rigged in favor of developed countries (Chang 2002). This was also joined by a growing anthropological argument for the equal validity and continued relevance of ‘traditional’ cultures, themselves no longer seen as static. Both challenged the implicit hierarchy whereby the ‘art’ and civilization of the West represented a higher form of spiritual achievement, and both promoted local, non-Western cultures as vital resources for development and nation-building. These tendencies converged in the ‘cultural and development’ agenda that animated much of UNESCO’s work, culminating in the 2005 Convention.

Underlying much of this discourse was an attempt to assert the centrality to any social development of a set of values and meanings over and above those allowed by neo-classical economics. We have tried to show how in different contexts and in different ways, both ‘art’ and ‘culture’ have articulated values opposed to economy and administration. The creative economy disrupted these settings. Fast policy can crystalize the zeitgeist, or

at any rate, its speed relates to the paucity of existing policies and/or the presence of forces that seize on such policies as immediately desirable. In a very schematic way, we could characterize the creative economy agenda as the move of neo-liberalism into the heart of cultural policy. No longer dismissing it as unproductive, wasteful and left-wing, culture now becomes productive of new jobs, new wealth and new subjectivities.

We have seen in this chapter that there are grounds to suggest that the ‘culture and development’ approach failed to deal adequately with the economic and cultural dynamics of the cultural and creative industries or with the changing status of the nation-state under globalization. As a consequence, the fast policy agenda of the creative economy was able to make enormous headway in global cultural policy circuits. We have suggested that the creative economy agenda in turn fails to engage the range of issues and problems with which ‘culture and development’ was concerned and which have not disappeared even if they have changed. Core to this failure are an avoidance of sustainability and social justice issues and a refusal to deal with the questions of non-economic value which culture articulates. It is to these that any progressive cultural policy must address itself.

This moment of cultural policy crisis offers both challenge and opportunity. Two paradigms are found wanting. We have suggested the need for a more direct engagement with the economy of culture, one we have called ‘cultural economy.’ This extends the work of the political economy of culture—where that economy is seen as constructed within specific historical socio-political agencies—into a new context in which ‘culture’ can no longer be seen as opposed to ‘economy,’ nor reduced to it. It asserts the right to judge the arrangement of the cultural economy in the light of the cultural values which produce, and are produced by, that cultural economy.

Notes

1 See, for example, the website <http://www.admittingfailure.com/>.

2 Most EU countries are party to the convention; however, the U.S. is not.

3 For a detailed discussion and examples, see the special issue on Art and Mobility of *Interartive*: <http://artmobility.interartive.org/>

4 Memphis (p. 37) and Rotterdam (p. 117) are mentioned in the report.

- 5 Elsewhere, De Beukelaer (2014a) has paid greater attention to the contentious role the dualistic divide plays in the reading of creative economy trade data.
- 6 Colonial legacies are mentioned in passing in the 2013 CER (on pp. 38, 59 and 87). They should, however, receive far greater attention when looking into (cultural) policy issues.
- 7 The NWICO was a movement of developing countries organized around UNESCO in the late 1960s and early 1970s. It sought to challenge the dominance of the developed world over flows of information and communication. As such, it was part of a wider mobilization of developing countries against what they saw as the barriers to development placed in their path by the already existing developed countries. It was defeated in the 1980s by a U.S.-led coalition of developed countries. Cf. *Media, Culture and Society*, special issue on 'Farewell to NWICO?' (Sparks and Roach 1990).
- 8 The Department of Culture Media and Sports was the body under New Labour in the UK from 1997 to 2010 that popularized the use of 'creative industries' and proposed a sector classification system (DCMS 1998).
- 9 This is also reflected in the personal messages of UNESCO Director General Irina Bokova and UNDP Administrator Helen Clark, 'Let's put culture on the agenda now!' <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mWS3UPqm9iU>

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2

UNESCO, Cultural Industries and the International Development Agenda

Between Modest Recognition and Reluctance

Antonios Vlassis

Introduction

Between 2010 and 2015, the United Nations (UN) political arena was dominated by the international debate on the culmination of the Millennium Development Goals and on what would follow them: the post-2015 agenda. During the Rio+20 Summit held in 2012, participants launched a process to determine a set of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) that would frame the future development agenda. UNESCO (the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization), along with many international actors, sought to influence the post-2015 policy agenda, arguing that culture has an essential role in sustainable development and must be integrated into the SDGs. ¹

Since the 1970s, UNESCO—the only UN agency with a legitimate and clearly recognized interest in culture—has worked to feed the international debate on the links between culture and development and, in doing so, it has become the main multilateral arena for the creation of international frameworks that bridge culture and development. A great number of UNESCO's initiatives and legal tools demonstrate this effort to embed the relationship at the international level and to raise awareness within the

international community of the importance of implementing cultural policies in relation to development. The section that follows examines the historical emergence of UNESCO's policy agenda on culture and development, and then focuses more specifically on the place of the cultural industries within this agenda. The term 'cultural industries' refers to the economic organization of inputs and outputs for creativity, production, distribution and exhibition, as well as the preservation of cultural expressions. The cultural industries include visual and performing arts, publishing, film and audiovisual arts, music as well as crafts and design, which are not, strictly speaking, industries, but which are similar in their management and advertising (Singh 2011). According to the UN Creative Economy Report (UNESCO-UNDP, 2013, p. 9), world trade of cultural goods and services totalled a record U.S. \$624 billion in 2011 and more than doubled from 2002 to 2011. As this indicates, a fundamental challenge for the cultural industries/development nexus comes from its multifaceted nature: the cultural industries make and circulate artistic expressions and are, at the same time, bearers of identity, values and meaning, and agents of economic, social and cultural change and development (Hesmondhalgh 2007).

Recent research emphasizes the legal, institutional and sociological features of the culture and development agenda (Clammer 2005; Da Costa 2010; Le Duc 2010; Nurse 2006) as well as associated policy outcomes. Further research has assessed the overall impact of the agenda on national and regional policies (Barrowclough and Kozul-Wright 2008; De Beukelaer 2015; Troussard et al. 2012). This chapter analyzes the policy process through which the international agenda regarding the cultural industries/development nexus was formulated and explores the context in which that agenda evolved, as well as exploring why and how UNESCO includes the cultural industries/development nexus within its priorities. In this respect, this chapter fills a gap in the literature by focusing firstly on the political pathways through which the cultural industries/development nexus travels within UNESCO's agenda-setting, and secondly, by highlighting why the nexus is still a 'Cinderella' within international cooperation for development.

International Political Pathways of ‘Culture and Development’ and the Place of the Cultural Industries

UNESCO depends on its Member States to provide the necessary resources that give the organization its mandate. However, the organization (as an international arena for socialization and political lobbying) is also capable of mobilizing a collective imaginary and of producing new principles and concepts (Barnett and Finnemore 2004; Oestreich 2012). Since the 1970s, UNESCO has been the central site for the diffusion of ideas about culture and development and, within that, has sought to influence the connections between the cultural industries and development.

From Venice to Stockholm: Cultural Industries Without a Concrete Place

In the 1970s, in the wake of decolonization, UNESCO was faced with the needs of a number of newly independent states with an approach that saw culture as ‘a marker of identity’ (UNESCO 2007, p. 76). The organization took the initiative to organize an Intergovernmental Conference on the Institutional, Administrative and Financial Aspects of Culture in Venice, from 24 August to 2 September 1970. This was the first intergovernmental conference on issues related to culture. The conference acknowledged the responsibilities of national governments with respect to the cultural life of the nation (UNESCO 1970, pp. 7–11). Following this, UNESCO organized the World Conference on Cultural Policies (Mondiacult), held in Mexico from 26 July to 6 August 1982 and attended by delegations of nearly 130 Member States. The Mondiacult Declaration argued for the importance of strengthening the links between development and culture in the broadest sense, and it called for ‘humanizing development’ (UNESCO 1982). The Mondiacult Declaration contained 181 recommendations for national governments and international organizations, addressing various issues such as cultural identity, the cultural dimension of development, culture and democracy, cultural heritage, artistic and intellectual creation and arts

education, as well as the planning, administration and financing of cultural activities.

Despite financial and symbolic challenges during the 1980s and 1990s,² UNESCO launched the World Decade for Cultural Development (1988–1997), the most tangible result of the Mondiacult conference, which aimed to place culture at the heart of development.³ As part of that Decade, in 1991, UNESCO established the World Commission on Culture and Development, chaired by former UN Secretary-General Javier Pérez de Cuéllar. In 1996, the commission presented the report *Our Creative Diversity* (World Commission on Culture and Diversity, 1996), which became a landmark document and has been highly influential in debates on culture and development (Aylett 2010, p. 357). Based on the concept of holistic human development, the report considers the overall dynamics of creative diversity, its powerful effect on development policies, as well as the effects of globalization processes that extend beyond the economic sphere. Finally, at the end of the World Decade for Cultural Development and following the conclusions of the World Commission, the Stockholm Intergovernmental Conference on Cultural Policies for Development was held in 1998, again aiming to embed cultural policy as a key element of development strategy.

These debates, however, did not push the normative work of the organization towards more prescriptive action. UNESCO's multiple initiatives, somewhat 'fragmented and dispersed' (Maurel 2009, p. 134), were limited to general moral commitments, without establishing institutional mechanisms. In addition, 'cultural development' itself (the subject of the UNESCO Decade) suffered from a muddled definition of culture and a confusing delimitation of its scope. As Gifford Philipps (1975, p. 238) has suggested, 'the problem today may be that too much is expected of culture: it is expected to restore humanism, counter industrial alienation, prevent war. This may be asking too much—especially since there is no firm consensus on what is meant by "culture."' In his 1994–1995 report on UNESCO's activities, the Director-General of the organization, Federico Mayor, regretted that 'while great strides have been made in advancing the conceptual case for linking culture and development, much still remains to be done to demonstrate how this approach can actually be applied practically in the field' (UNESCO 1997, p. 50).

At this time, the debates invoked a broad concept of culture and the value of the cultural industries did not find a concrete place in the renewal of development thinking. Indeed, the link between the cultural industries and development has not yet been systematically explored, even though the term ‘cultural industries’ no longer carries pejorative connotations, but has begun to be ‘used in academia and policy-making circles as a positive label’ (UNESCO-UNDP 2013, p. 20).

The Convention on the Diversity of Cultural Expressions: The Recognition of Cultural Industries for Sustainable Development and Poverty Reduction

During the 1990s, rapid economic globalization and integration and the liberalization of trade exchanges raised major concerns for many national governments and cultural organizations over the effects on cultural diversity. Given the dual nature of the cultural industries, including both symbolic and material production (Caves 2000), their treatment within international economic agreements became the subject of growing political interest. By the end of the 1990s, an alliance of actors including international organizations, national governments and non-governmental organizations had mobilized in favor of ‘the diversity of cultural expressions’ and the establishment of an international legal tool on this principle (Vlassis 2015a). As Jean Musitelli explains (2005, p. 515), the diversity of cultural expressions is built both on the impetus around the ‘cultural exception’ from trade negotiations and on the concept of creative diversity, ⁴ conceptualized by UNESCO. Following hard negotiations on several issues, such as the link between trade and culture and the scope of the legal tool, the Convention on the Protection and the Promotion of Diversity of Cultural Expressions (CDCE) was adopted by UNESCO in 2005, and as of July 2015, it has received the support of 138 Member States and of the European Union (EU). For the purposes of the convention, ‘cultural expressions’ refers to the ‘various ways in which the creativity of individuals and social groups takes shape and manifests itself. These manifestations include expressions transmitted by words (literature, tales...), sound (music...) images (photos, films...)—in any format

(printed, audiovisual, digital, etc.)—or by activities (dance, theater...) or objects (sculptures, paintings...)' (UNESCO 2005). In this sense, the object of the CDCE is particular vis-à-vis other legal texts of UNESCO and does not refer to cultural diversity in the broadest sense of the term, but to a specific aspect of the latter regarding the cultural goods and services created, produced and distributed by cultural industries. The CDCE also stipulates the integration of cultural industries into sustainable development (Article 13), and it aims to strengthen international cultural cooperation through many tools, such as the expert and information exchange among the Parties, the preferential treatment for developing countries, as well as the setting up of an International Fund for Cultural Diversity (hereafter the IFCD), a multi-donor voluntary fund established under Article 18.

The IFCD is one of the concrete initiatives and one of the main tools of the CDCE for promoting sustainable development and poverty reduction in developing and least-developed countries through the development of cultural industries (Vlassis 2011, 2014). Many countries have minimal cultural policies, and their implementation remains problematic due to a lack of political will, of expertise and of financial resources. The IFCD became operational in 2010, and its implementation is based on the good faith and loyalty of state parties to the CDCE. As of April 2015, the IFCD supports 78 projects in 48 developing countries with U.S. \$5.2 million in funding. Forty-eight per cent of its projects are in Africa (five each in South Africa and in Kenya, four in Cameroon) and 28 per cent in Latin America and the Caribbean (three each in Uruguay and in Mexico). Sixty-one per cent of the beneficiaries are non-governmental organizations (NGOs), and most of the projects focus on capacity development (see also Toggler, Sediakina-Riviere and Ruotsalainen 2012). In addition, 30 per cent of the projects deal with music or cinema/audiovisual arts, and more than half of the projects deal with gender equality or youth. The eighth session of the Intergovernmental Committee of the CDCE, held in December 2014, approved seven projects for funding through the IFCD. Four of those projects were allocated funds of approximately U.S. \$100,000. ⁵

Within the institutional frame of the CDCE, UNESCO and the EU also created an expert facility program (with a value of one million euros and funded by the EU) that sought to strengthen the system of governance for cultural industries through technical assistance missions, which took place between December 2011 and December 2012. Following three calls for

applications, Barbados, the City of Buenos Aires, Burkina Faso, Cambodia, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Haiti, Honduras, Kenya, Malawi, Mauritius, Niger, the Seychelles and Vietnam were chosen to benefit from technical assistance missions. The 13 selected projects dealt with many domains of governance of the cultural industries, such as the promotion of cultural management and artistic entrepreneurship (Niger, Barbados, Mauritius, Malawi), the improvement of the legal and regulatory framework for the promotion of cultural industries (Vietnam, Democratic Republic of the Congo), the inclusion of cultural modules in education (Burkina Faso), as well as the development of cultural industries such as music (Democratic Republic of Congo, Kenya, Seychelles), visual arts (Kenya), performing arts (Honduras, Cambodia), sculpture (Honduras), handcrafts (Cambodia) and the broadcasting sector (Buenos Aires, Honduras).

More recently, UNESCO and many other international actors have advocated for the inclusion of culture within the post-2015 UN agenda (Vlassis 2015b). Numerous political actions, based largely on the normative framework of the CDCE, have been part of this advocacy strategy: the Hangzhou Congress organized by UNESCO and China in 2013 and entitled ‘Culture: key to sustainable development’; the Special Thematic Debate of the UN General Assembly, held in May 2014 entitled ‘Culture and sustainable development in the post 2015 development agenda’; UNESCO’s ‘Third World Forum on Culture and Cultural Industries,’ held in Florence in October 2014 and the adoption of the Florence Declaration; the establishment of the ‘Culture for Development Indicators’ Tool—supported by the Spanish government—to assist in measuring the role of culture in development processes; and the publication of the third and Special Edition of the *Creative Economy Report* in 2013.

Cultural Industries as the Cinderella of the International Development Cooperation

Despite these initiatives, the cultural sector—including the cultural industries—remains weak in comparison to other contributors to sustainable development and other motives for giving international development assistance, such as economic, environmental, humanitarian, educational or

those related to national security (Degnbol-Martinussen and Engberg-Pedersen 2003, p. 17). For instance, in the synthesis report of the UN Secretary-General (United Nations 2014) on the post-2015 agenda, there is only one mention of culture in the broadest sense and no mention at all of the cultural industries or the creative economy. I argue that three factors help to explain why the cultural industries/development nexus remains marginal within the international development policy agenda: the fragmented strategies of UNESCO, the reluctance of developed countries to recognize and support the cultural industries/development nexus and a top-down approach to policy that lacks a strong transnational mobilization of art and culture organizations.

UNESCO: Fragmented Strategies

To illustrate some of the structural problems of UNESCO and its fragmented strategies, we can look at the example of the pathways through which the International Fund for the Promotion of Culture (IFPC) has traveled since its establishment in 1974 by the 18th UNESCO General Conference. As a 2010 report on the IFPC explains, recalling the recommendations of the 1970 Venice conference, ‘the General Conference was convinced of the urgent necessity of giving greater prominence to culture in the development of individuals and societies and strengthening international cultural cooperation’ (UNESCO 2010, p. 5). Alfred Davidson (1975, p. 223) claimed that ‘the term *culture* for the Fund is undefined but includes painting, sculpture, music, dance, writing and other kinds of fine art, their propagation by the mass media and research, training and education in the arts.’ Unlike other UNESCO funds, such as the IFCD, the IFPC is not linked to any UNESCO cultural convention.

Bearing these points in mind, the operations of the IFPC should, it seems, contribute to: strategies for culture and development; the establishment or reinforcement of institutions, structures and facilities whose purpose is cultural or artistic; the training of specialists in cultural action, as well as supporting artistic and cultural production and circulation. In the first session of the IFPC’s Council in February 1976, the Director-General of UNESCO welcomed ‘the first international mechanism for the financing of

cultural development seen as a vital factor in development' (UNESCO 2010, p. 5). To achieve these aims, the fund holds financial resources from voluntary contributions made by governments, other institutions, associations and private individuals.

However, the IFPC has functioned largely in a top-down manner (Sabatier 1986): its priorities have been expressed by a central authority largely disconnected from the specific needs of developing countries. Thus, there has been a gap between the intentions of the council and the political will of the actors on the ground to implement policies for cultural development. The historian Chloé Maurel has argued that a large number of projects supported by the IFPC have not been successful. The IFPC, for example, had supported the creation of a Pan-African Cultural Fund, but UNESCO noted in 1981 that 'the projects have lagged [...] no project has really been achieved' (Maurel 2011). Moreover, in the early 1990s, the Director of the IFPC noted that the fund was little known and its activities were dispersed. Its financial situation also gave cause for concern because the funding sources had not been tapped and administrative costs were too high in relation to project funding (UNESCO 2010, p. 7). At the end of 1990s, the Director-General of UNESCO regretted 'the Fund's decline since the early 1990s, on account of problems encountered in increasing its financial resources in order to implement all of the programs' (UNESCO 2010, p. 7). Most of IFPC's capital (almost U.S. \$6 million since it was established) was paid in its early years in the form of voluntary government contributions, with three main countries (Venezuela, Iran and Saudi Arabia) providing nearly 80 per cent of public contributions to the fund. Since 1999 the fund has not drawn any more public funds; however, private financing has not taken off either. From 1999 to 2006, only three partnerships were established (and for relatively small sums), namely with the Ford Foundation (U.S. \$50,000), the Inter-American Development Bank (U.S. \$26,000) and the French bank group Crédit Agri-cole (U.S. \$300,000).

Thirty years after the fund's creation, the IFPC has accumulated a plethora of structural problems: a crisis of governance and management, limited financial resources, a lack of visibility, dispersed activities and isolated impact. In 2006, UNESCO decided to suspend the fund's operation. At that time, its resources reached U.S. \$4 million. Among the last projects co-funded by IFPC were projects to train 35 young private cultural promoters in management (Burkina Faso), to support an art school in Dan-

dora (Kenya), to bring children's literature into the classroom (Rwanda), to train young people in theatre and television (Palestine), to support an urban arts festival in 2006 (Croatia) and to support residencies in media arts for women (Canada). It is worth noting that between 1993 and 2006, the IFPC also administered the UNESCO-Aschberg Bursaries for Artists Programme in the fields of music, visual arts and creative writing, established by the sale of property constituting the Aschberg donation in 1994. The IFPC has, on several occasions, financed shortfalls in the program amounting to U.S. \$240,065 (UNESCO 2010, p. 14) The suspension of the IFPC's activities seems to reflect several structural problems within UNESCO, such as a lack of strategic planning, a lack of proper assessment and monitoring of activities, as well as inadequate criteria for choosing projects (Courrier 2005; Imber 1989; Maurel 2009; Singh 2010).

Following the request of four Member States (Algeria, Cuba, Egypt and Venezuela) in 2011, the 36th General Conference of UNESCO took the initiative to restore the IFPC. Although the initiative could potentially play an important role in the cultural industries/development nexus, there are some issues regarding the usefulness of its restoration, the political and institutional implications of this action and also about the link between the IFPC and the IFCD in relation to the CDCE. The re-establishment of the IFPC would seem to create competition for scarce financial and symbolic resources.

Added to this picture is the fact that UNESCO is, today, in an extremely difficult financial situation owing to the suspension, in late 2011, of its U.S. contribution. ⁶ Moreover, a recent audit report on UNESCO's management, published in April 2013, has pointed out that the reforms launched by the organization before 2010 were 'of limited efficiency' and have been undertaken 'too slowly and inconsistently owing to a lack of strict governance' (UNESCO 2013).

Developed Countries: Between Reluctance and Indifference

The second factor that contributes to the weakness of the cultural industries in relationship to the development agenda focuses on the lack of a group of

political entrepreneurs (Finnemore and Sikkink 1998; Ingebritsen 2002) with sufficient financial, social and symbolic resources to contribute to the dynamic inclusion of the cultural industries/development nexus within the international development policy sphere. Here, the adoption of the CDCE and the establishment of the IFCD provide illustrative examples.

During the negotiations for the adoption of the CDCE, a small number of developing countries, including Senegal, Burkina Faso, Morocco and Andorra, underlined the unequal structure of global cultural exchange, and they favored the establishment of an international fund to support weaker cultural industries. This initiated a debate about the mandatory or voluntary contributions of Parties to the IFCD. The major concern of the main promoters of the diversity of cultural expressions—such as France, Canada, Germany and China—was the international regulation of trade and culture rather than the strengthening of cultural cooperation. Other developed countries, such as the U.S., Japan, New Zealand and Australia, reluctant to support a binding international tool on the diversity of cultural expressions, were also reluctant to support a fund based on mandatory contributions (UNESCO 2004). The debate was finally resolved in favor of voluntary contributions but with the addition of a provision found in paragraph 7 of the CDCE's Article 18: 'Parties shall endeavour to provide voluntary contributions on a regular basis towards the implementation of this Convention.'

As of July 2015, only 47 of the 138 Parties of the CDCE have contributed to the fund, and the total contributions received had reached U.S. \$7.4 million. The combined contributions of France, Norway and Finland reached over U.S. \$3.4 million. In the context of the international debt crisis and major budget cuts, the voluntary nature of contributions generates uncertainty about the financing and the visibility of the fund and suggests serious difficulties for the elaboration of a structured and coherent approach to strengthening cultural industries in least developed countries. Canada, for example, which was very involved in the creation of the CDCE, has not contributed to the fund since 2008. ⁷ Neither have Greece, Austria, Denmark and South Africa since 2009, and Spain and India since 2010. On the other hand, the Netherlands, Italy and the UK—all very developed countries in terms of their own cultural industries and major donors in terms of aid to developing countries (Perroulaz, Fioroni and Carbonnier 2010)—have not yet contributed to the IFCD resources, and the contributions of

other countries such as Germany, Australia, Austria, Denmark, Switzerland and Sweden remain very low today (below U.S. \$270,000).

It is obvious that many developed countries are reluctant to explicitly include the cultural industries within international development cooperation. This position was reflected in the UN Special Thematic Debate on ‘Culture and Sustainable Development in the Post-2015 Development Agenda’ that gathered a multitude of high-level representatives of developing countries and of regional and international organizations but was marked by the absence of representatives of developed countries (EU member states, Japan, the U.S., Canada, Australia, New Zealand) and of the European Commission. Likewise, very few representatives of developed countries participated in the Hangzhou Congress in 2013 that advocated for culture’s inclusion in the SDGs.

The exception worth mentioning is Spain, which has been very dynamic regarding international development cooperation for the cultural industries.⁸ In relation to the Millennium Development Goals, the Spanish Agency of International Cooperation for Development has supported 18 joint programs linked to the theme of ‘Culture and Development’ with a financial allocation of U.S. \$95.6 million.⁹ However, since 2011, the new conservative government, in the context of a public debt and deficit crisis, has radically changed the Spanish agenda on development policies and the place of culture within it.

Grassroots Mobilization

The third factor that weakens the implementation of concerted cultural industries/development policies is the lack of a transnational movement of culture and art organizations seeking to lobby national governments and multilateral organizations for a more dynamic inclusion of the cultural industries within international development.

Two points can be made regarding the international behavior of arts-based NGOs to date: on the one hand, during the CDCE development and implementation, the majority of NGOs were focused on the interface between trade and the cultural industries, leaving out of their major priorities the broader importance of cultural industries for sustainable

development. For instance, numerous Coalitions for Cultural Diversity were established by the end of the 1990s in order to promote the establishment of an international legal tool on the diversity of cultural expressions. ¹⁰ The French and Canadian associations of cultural professionals had a leading role in the creation of this international cultural network. The question of the treatment of cultural goods and services within free trade agreements (FTAs) and the threat of FTAs to cultural policies ranked high on their policy agenda, whereas the relationship between the cultural industries and development was a lesser priority. The Canadian and French Coalitions, for example, organized two international meetings (in 2001 and 2003) of cultural professional associations to address ‘cultural diversity, cultural policies and international trade agreements.’ ¹¹ On the other hand, most arts-based NGOs and cultural associations in Africa, South America and Asia lack the financial resources necessary to lobby national governments and international organizations (Pouligny 2001). ¹²

I argue that a large transnational coalition of art and culture NGOs could serve to legitimate the cultural industries/development nexus. However, without the approval of and the contributions from NGOs, the global dissemination of the importance of cultural industries for sustainable development remains incomplete.

The desire to help shape the post-2015 development agenda has, however, resulted in a greater level of international integration and promotion of the value of the cultural industries in recent years. In 2013, international NGOs developed a common declaration in favor of the international integration of the cultural sector—including the cultural industries—within the SDGs. The statement entitled ‘Culture as a Goal in the Post-2015 Development Agenda’ was prepared by influential NGOs in the cultural sector such as the International Federation of Arts Councils and Culture Agencies, a worldwide network of national arts funding agencies in 80 countries; the Committee on Culture of United Cities and Local Governments, which fosters the relation between local cultural policies and sustainable development; the International Federation of Coalitions for Cultural Diversity as well as Culture Action Europe, the major European voice of the cultural sector linking over 110 national and European networks. However, compared to the level of mobilization that surrounded the CDCE, advocacy for the inclusion of culture in the post-2015 UN agenda seems to only echo the actions of UNESCO and of some developing

countries rather than emerging from a genuine and widespread grassroots movement. Furthermore, a lack of financial resources and of support from developed countries means that the action taken by these cultural NGOs remains largely declaratory and is not accompanied by other advocacy activities, such as international meetings to share ideas, or the production of specific expertise on the issue.

Conclusion

UNESCO remains the main international arena for the debate about the links between culture and development and the significance of cultural industries in this field. The CDCE (led by UNESCO) was an important step for the slow but genuine recognition of the cultural industries in national and regional development policies. Today, a coalition of actors—including developing countries, international organizations and NGOs—is emerging in favor of a more dynamic inclusion of the cultural sector within international development cooperation. Partnering with this coalition of actors, UNESCO continues to be a leading actor in advocating for the inclusion of culture in the post-2015 UN development agenda (Vlassis 2015b).

However, there are major challenges to the possibility of this actually happening. I have drawn attention to three major factors that explain why the cultural sector still remains somewhat of a Cinderella within the international development agenda: the fragmented actions of UNESCO, the reluctance and indifference of many developed countries towards the integration of cultural industries within international development policy agenda and the lack of a broad-based, bottom-up transnational movements of art associations to give broader multilateral legitimacy to the cultural industries/development nexus. To these challenges can be added two others: UNESCO has not yet persuaded the increasingly influential ‘new’ development donors (the big private foundations and philanthropists) of the importance of cultural industries for sustainable development and poverty reduction, and the international pathways of the cultural industries/development nexus reflect national contexts in which the

resources allocated to the cultural industries remain very low compared to those for environmental, security or social issues.

Nevertheless, the international debate continues on a more explicit inclusion of culture—and of the cultural industries—among the frameworks of international development. Although many challenges still exist, it may be the case that the components of the debate and the configuration of actors are facing a turning point that could lead to a broader international institutional recognition of the potential of the cultural industries for job creation, economic growth and poverty reduction, as well as for the inclusion of minorities in social, political and cultural life.

Notes

- 1 Within its work on culture and development, UNESCO highlights three areas of particular interest: the cultural and creative industries, cultural heritage and cultural tourism.
- 2 Following the political controversy on the discussions about the New World Information and Communication Order, UNESCO went through an unprecedented political crisis that led to the U.S. and UK withdrawing from the organization in 1984. The reasons for the withdrawal focused mainly on a harsh critique of the politicization of the organization and on a lack of efficiency, relevance and pragmatism on the part of UNESCO (Senarclens 1988, pp. 169–99).
- 3 Since World War II, the dominant view of development has seen it as synonymous with economic growth within the context of an international market. The World Bank, for example, categorizes countries' 'development' according to their per capita income. Similarly, since the 1980s and the end of the Cold War, the Washington Consensus has gained ascension in development policies. The consensus asserts that global welfare would be maximized by the liberalization of trade, finance and investment, and by restructuring national economies to provide an enabling environment for capital (Rist 2007). However, the last two decades of the 20th century also saw the flourishing of alternative conceptions of development: the adoption of the Declaration on the Right to Development in 1986, the publication of the Brundtland Report *Our Common Future* prepared by the United Nations Commission on Environment and Development in 1987, as well as the first publication of the *Human Development Report* in 1990. The Preface of the 1990 report explained that 'if the growth in gross national product is important for achieving all essential human objectives, it is also important to analyze how this growth is reflected—or not—in human development in different societies.' The Brundtland Report, dedicated to sustainable development, defined development as that which 'meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.' Such initiatives paid attention to the non-economic aspects of development. Growth is not an end in itself, but needs to also have a positive impact on well-being. In addition, it was argued that development should be measured by a broad spectrum of data, including political rights, economic and social freedoms, the health system, environmental and educational policies (Rist 2007, pp. 345–416).
- 4 In the 1990s, a coalition of actors, driven by France and Canada, defended the term 'cultural exception' (*exception culturelle*) in order to exclude cultural goods and services from the agenda

of international trade negotiations, such as the last period of negotiations on the General Agreement on Trade in Services of the World Trade Organization in 1993, the negotiations on the Multilateral Agreement on Investment within the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development, as well as the negotiations around FTAs between the United States and Canada in 1989 and on the North American Free Trade Agreement in 1994. By the late 1990s, however, the term ‘cultural exception’ was abandoned, and a more inclusive term, ‘cultural diversity,’ was gradually substituted (Vlassis and Richieri Hanania 2014).

- 5 These include: empowering African youth to harness the potential of the music sector in Cameroon, the Congo, Côte d’Ivoire, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Kenya, Malawi, Mozambique and the United Republic of Tanzania; promoting young people’s participation in the book and music industries in Mexico; developing an efficient policy for the promotion of cultural industries in Morocco; fostering an active participation of vulnerable groups in the creative sector in Uruguay.
- 6 Since late 2011, the U.S. has put their contribution to UNESCO on hold following the majority vote on making Palestine a full member of the organization.
- 7 In Canada, since 2006 and the voting in of a new conservative government, the latter has displayed reluctance towards supporting the cultural industries with a clear effect on CDCE implementation. In 2012, the conservative government announced major budget cuts affecting public radio in Canada, the Canadian Conference of the Arts (CCA), the National Film Board, the Library and Archives of Canada, as well as the Coalition for Cultural Diversity. In late 2012, the CCA, Canada’s largest arts advocacy agency, wound down operations after 67 years (CBC 2010). Within a context of profound debt crisis in Europe, the cultural industries are being affected by budget cuts in many places, and particularly in countries with conservative governments. For instance, in 2010, the UK government announced the abolition of the UK Film Council, and the Spanish government, in 2013, dramatically reduced public support for the national film industry.
- 8 For the majority of national governments, their share of ODA allocated to culture ranged from 0.21% to 1.3% between 2009 and 2012. In marked contrast, Spain’s allocation was 14.41% in 2010 thanks to its contribution to the UN Millennium Development Goals Achievement Fund (UNESCO 2012).
- 9 The Millennium Development Goals Achievement Fund was set up with a generous contribution of U.S. \$710 million from the Government of Spain. Among its priorities, it’s worth mentioning the strengthening of creative industries and the protection of natural and cultural heritage as effective instruments of economic development. The beneficiary countries of this fund linked to the theme ‘Culture and development’ have been Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Cambodia, China, Costa Rica, Ecuador, Egypt, Ethiopia, Honduras, Mauritania, Morocco, Mozambique, Namibia, Nicaragua, Occupied Palestinian Territory, Senegal, Turkey and Uruguay. Projects that specifically support the creative and cultural industries were funded in Cambodia, Honduras, Mozambique, Senegal and Uruguay (MDGIF).
- 10 In September 2007, the International Federation of the Coalitions for Cultural Diversity (IFCCD) was created by 42 national coalitions for cultural diversity grouping in the aggregate more than 600 cultural professional organizations representing creators, artists, independent producers, distributors, broadcasters and editors in the publishing, motion picture, television, music, performing arts and visual art fields. The federation is incorporated in Canada and has its Secretariat in Montreal. The French Coalition ensures the representation of the IFCCD at UNESCO in Paris.
- 11 From 10–13 September 2001 in Montreal, the Canadian Coalition organized the first international meeting of cultural professional associations, which brought together 40 culture organizations

from 10 countries. The French Coalition organized the second international meeting in Paris, from 2 to 4 February 2003. The meeting brought together nearly 100 associations from 32 countries.

- 12 For instance, in mid-2013, among the 43 National Coalitions for Cultural Diversity, only 12 have a website (South Africa, France, Canada, Chile, Togo, Paraguay, Peru, Austria, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, United Kingdom). Moreover, only the websites of the French and the Canadian Coalitions—translated into three languages (English, French and Spanish)—contain reports, studies and specific publications, as well as archives of the movement and information on past and upcoming activities.

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3

Structuring the Culture Sector in the Pacific Islands

Katerina Teaiwa and Elise Huffer

This chapter explores recent regional cultural policy and program initiatives in Pacific Islands Countries and Territories (PICTs) through the work of the Human Development Programme of the Secretariat of the Pacific Community (SPC)¹, the Council for Pacific Arts and Culture and a range of non-governmental, educational, intergovernmental and government partners. It reflects on the process to identify and structure the culture sector across diverse island states and territories between 2009 and 2014 with the support of a major European Union grant. In particular, we describe the regional cultural mapping, planning and policy process, evaluation of the Festival of Pacific Arts (FOPA)² and a program to enhance cultural industries in Fiji, the Solomon Islands and Samoa. While the outcomes of these programs are too early to evaluate, the chapter describes the initiatives and reflects on the complexity of this process in a regional context where funding for arts and culture is limited, national government support is insufficient and art and culture are seen predominantly as aspects of heritage, sociality, spirituality, tourism and entertainment. This is in contrast to the much larger funding available for mainstream development programs focused on governance, security, health, education and gender issues.

The Pacific is widely known to have the largest aid per capita globally (Too Many Aid Agencies 2014), but very little of it supports arts and culture. While Pacific scholars have explored and critiqued the relationship between culture and development (e.g., Hooper 2005), very little work

exists on the relationship between the arts and development in Oceania. While our chapter is primarily descriptive of activities in Oceania, analytically, it argues that culture and the arts are inseparable for the Pacific Islands. While traditional scholars of Oceania are not always attentive to this, Pacific arts practitioners are. Those who wear multiple hats across education, heritage sectors and cultural or arts practice are coming to realize that supporting well-designed and widely consultative cultural policy processes, for example, also supports development in arts education. Educator, artist and scholar Cresantiya Frances Koya from the University of the South Pacific writes: ‘Community awareness about the potential contribution of the arts to economic development through stimulation of the creative and cultural industries as well as for human and social growth is essential’ (Koya 2011, p. 20).

We also discuss here how values of indigeneity and place-based heritage within national contexts articulate with regional identities and initiatives which are as culturally and politically powerful. Historical kinships between Pacific cultures that extend back over 2,000 years, while currently altered by 20th-century state boundaries, still allow for Pacific identities, activism and development initiatives to have multi-scalar resonance and effects that also extend across time (Spriggs 2009; Teaiwa 2014b). Essentially, Oceania is a space where real kinship extends across hundreds of miles of sea and is alive in the oral traditions of contemporary Pacific peoples. This shapes the nature of international relations in this region, allowing for cultural initiatives to resonate beyond basic economic and political priorities. The regional Festival of Pacific Arts which brings together arts and culture delegates from up to 25 nations, states and territories across Oceania, is one such forum in which these multi-dimensional practices and values play out. Regional development policies such as those discussed here similarly attempt to harness and balance both local and regional concerns and aspirations to support culture and art for development while protecting customary rights and values. Though they are ‘indigenous’ in rather different structural ways (cf., Merlan 2009), the concerns of Pacific Islanders are similar to indigenous minorities across the globe where long-term relations to place, genealogy and kinship shape contemporary life. With the exceptions of Hawai‘i and New Zealand, Pacific Islanders are the majority populations in their home countries, with

many groups retaining or fighting effectively to maintain rights over their customary lands and waterways (Hooper 2005).

Art, Culture and Development in Oceania

Until relatively recently in global history terms, Pacific Islands peoples have archived, transmitted and transformed their knowledge systems, materials and practices through oral, embodied, material and visual forms. There were no textual or writing cultures as such in Oceania. What is described today as ‘art’ was an integral part of sociality, kinship, personhood and political and economic values and activities. It was an integral component of communication and livelihoods, and a central mode of knowledge and cultural production (Brunt et al. 2012). Today, Pacific ways of knowing, being and doing continue to be coded into visual forms, choreographies, rhythms and harmonies. The Pacific arts express not just aesthetic forms but are often seen, as Brunt and his colleagues argue, as valuables, or treasures which are designed to elicit sensory, moral, political and intellectual reactions (Brunt et al. 2012). Our main point here is that to speak of ‘culture’ in the Pacific Islands always means to speak of ‘art,’ not as a high practice divorced from everyday lives, but as one integral to it.

With the arrival of Europeans, and especially missionaries who created orthographies of Pacific languages during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, Pacific knowledge began to take parallel textual forms, some of which fixed otherwise fluid systems, and some of which were discarded for new forms of spirituality and governance (Teaiwa 2012a). Under colonialism and missionary-run education systems, Pacific music, dance, architecture, canoeing, tattooing and other design and communication practices were seen as primitive and imagined as outside the realm of civilization and modernity, including when in the service of tourism or entertainment. The dominance of mainstream capitalist and neo-liberal approaches to economic development as a framework and rationale for shaping public policy, infrastructure, planning and investment has meant that indigenous knowledge, products and practices are increasingly seen as irrelevant to Pacific futures. The arts thrive in Pacific communities, but in a

world often parallel and rarely integrated with the well-funded sphere of 'development' (Teaiwa 2007; cf., Throsby 2015).

With the growing awareness of this gap, in recent years, Pacific Island countries, as expressed in Objective 11 of the regional Pacific Plan, have made significant moves to develop policy, programs and institutions that support cultural safeguarding along with development (see Huffer 2006 and the Pacific Plan 2013). Institutions such as the Vanuatu Cultural Centre and the Tjibaou Cultural Centre in New Caledonia have become models for those across the region committed to supporting art and culture in a more systematic or structured fashion, even where funding is regularly scarce. Staff in the Human Development Programme of the SPC, conscious of the better support for indigenous arts and culture in their neighbouring countries of New Zealand and Australia, and, drawing on the work of Colin Mercer (2002) and cultural economist, Professor David Throsby (1994, 2001, 2008, 2010, 2015), actively sought international funding from the European Union, and partnerships with UNESCO, the Pacific Islands Forum Secretariat and government culture departments to realize their goals of naming, shaping and boosting a Pacific 'culture sector.' The idea, led by SPC culture advisor Elise Huffer, was to formalize what had previously been viewed, economically, as informal practices and activities only visible (and not always measured) under, for example, the umbrella of another sector such as tourism. The successful five-year project was called 'Structuring the Culture Sector for Improved Human Development' (Selling Culture 2012).

SPC highlighted how cultural policy was becoming increasingly important in government policy formulation, nationally and internationally. Throsby (2010, p. ix), for example, suggests that the aspects increasingly considered by governments include: the prospects for the creative industries as dynamic sources of innovation, growth and change; the role of the arts and culture in employment creation and income generation; the appropriate means by which governments can support the creative and performing arts; the possibilities for public/private partnerships to preserve cultural heritage; and legal and economic questions concerning the regulation of intellectual property in cultural goods and services. This is an issue of particular concern to Pacific Islanders, who often hold the rights to knowledge, designs and other forms of knowledge communally.

While the benefits listed are increasingly acknowledged as necessary for convincing policymakers and leaders to better define and support the culture sector, Throsby's point on cultural heritage has the most salience for many in the Pacific and is a key motivation for cultural development focused on safeguarding and fostering Pacific cultural ideas, practices and products, some of which are rooted in pre-colonial values and beliefs, and others which are the results of introduced ideas and materials. Together, these are seen to fuel cultural industries while helping safeguard tangible and intangible heritage. While anthropologists and many artists understand culture to be fluid and transforming, it is still the case in Oceania that people often understand 'culture' to signal what they view as 'traditional,' pre-colonial or customary values and practices, as distinct from post-colonial, global and introduced ideas and forms. Teaiwa has argued that the impetus for the commercialization of culture in the Pacific thus always needs to be balanced by this heritage aspect and, furthermore, requires a third element of bringing Pacific epistemological and ontological principles and values into dialogue with commercialization and preservation for a more effective and sustainable development outcome (2007, p. 146).

The extensive work of cultural practitioners and various programs initiated by SPC, UNESCO, the Pacific Islands Forum Secretariat (PIFS), the Council for Pacific Arts and Culture, the European Commission, the World Intellectual Property Organisation and the University of the South Pacific (USP), among others, means that culture is increasingly viewed as a resource and asset for human development in the islands. Legal scholars, including Forsyth and Farran (2013), have undertaken research on the legal and intellectual property implications of commercializing Pacific culture, but there is still much more work to be done and dialogue to foster, both nationally and regionally. These were the aims of two key policy initiatives: the creation of a Regional Culture Strategy (2010–2020) and a Pacific Culture and Education Strategy (2010–2015). In the preface to the Regional Culture Strategy (2010, p. 1), the Honorable Faustina K. Rehurer-Marugg Minister for Community and Cultural Affairs, Republic of Palau, stated:

The Pacific Regional Culture Strategy takes the region a step further by setting standards and aspirations for Pacific cultures, regionally and nationally. It acknowledges and celebrates the rich, varied and diversified cultural repertoire of the Pacific region. The fact is Pacific peoples are not a monolithic group. Their views and backgrounds are diverse, and understanding the differences of the rich cultural nuances is everyone's responsibility. However, our countries all share the need to

better safeguard and promote their cultures, through a range of measures that are outlined in this Strategy.

Culture is the mirror of a nation and endows it with a set of norms that sharply point out the standard of a society. It is the dynamic force of our development with respect to economic growth, but also it is the breath that blows the conch shell of a nation's identity and its intellectual, moral and spiritual life. Cultures of the region do indeed connect and uplift us and those we meet along the way.

At national levels, the cultural policy work being encouraged regionally has allowed ministries and departments of culture, many for the first time, to set clear directions and engage with a range of stakeholders. It has also allowed for a cross-sectoral approach more explicitly connecting culture and the arts to education, agriculture, tourism, trade and many other sectors. Structuring and supporting heritage through policy work has also been boosted by UNESCO's Centre for Pacific States' initiative to promote the 2005 Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions following intense efforts by the region to ratify and implement the 2003 Convention on the Safeguarding of Intangible Heritage, and to increase the number of Pacific World Heritage Sites which were both Pacific state parties' priorities.

In international cultural policy, the 'contemporary arts,' those with clear external origins or sources, such as the ubiquitous reggae music, hip hop and modern dance, are usually present and recognized in policies and programs in support of culture. However, many Pacific countries still tend to focus primarily on traditional or heritage art forms, knowledge and content when considering the potential of cultural industries or tourism. This focus on heritage is featured most prominently at the FOPA, a veritable Olympics of Pacific art and culture, which is rotated through a Melanesian, Micronesian and Polynesian host country every four years.

This focus on heritage, however, is changing in places like Fiji, with increased attention on the cultural industries, which incorporate expressions of culture ranging from heritage to contemporary arts. The approach of regional bodies such as SPC and PIFS to the cultural industries increasingly aims to avoid separating heritage and contemporary arts, but rather, to create joint spaces for their expression.

Under the guidance of the late Professor Epeli Hau'ofa, the Oceanian Centre for Arts and Culture (the OCAC, now known as the Oceania Centre for Arts, Culture and Pacific Studies) at USP, based in Fiji, took a different

approach early on and successfully focused on contemporary and fusion forms of visual arts, music and dance. Importantly, what they supported, compared with initiatives in Australia and New Zealand and with what is still the main concern in the islands, was the creation of regional, intra-Pacific or Pan-Pacific, and specifically ‘Oceanian,’ styles and forms (see Hau‘ofa 2008). The broader agenda of the OCAC-USP work was growing regionalism and regionally grounded, rather than tribal, local or national, identities and expressions of cultures. Hau‘ofa had an explicit goal in promoting creative expressions of Oceania to challenge what he perceived as belittling views of the Pacific as backwards or under-developed (Hau‘ofa 1994; Teaiwa 2014a & b; Oceania Centre for Arts, Culture and Pacific Studies). The work of the Oceania Centre (see [Figure 3.1](#)) inspired other similar collectives such as dance company and academy VOU (see [Figure 3.2](#)), which has now become internationally recognized for its unique approach



[Source: Photo by Jeremy Dusebury, used with permission.](#)



Figure 3.2 Navitalai Waqavotuwale, Edward Soro, Ratu Rusiate Rokilibau and Jiuta Tigarea of VOU dance company, Fiji performing *Matavali Drift*. Source: Photograph by Fotofusion and used with permission from Sachiko Soro, VOU company director.

to contemporary Fijian performing arts (VOU: Bringing Pacific dance back to the world).

While specific groups and organizations across the region have figured out strategies to support their work through a combination of educational, phil-anthropic, corporate and small government sources of funding, there is as yet no major, systematic culture or arts funding body anywhere in Pacific Islands countries and territories. New Zealand, for example, has ‘Creative New Zealand’ (see Ngā Toi Māori) and Australia has ‘the Australia Council’ to support development in the arts. Regionally active international aid and development agencies such as the United Nations Development Programme and Australian AID seldom directly fund arts and culture but will, in some instances, support creative modes of delivering development messages and outcomes. The French Embassies and Alliance Française, on the other hand, have always been engaged with local art and artists and regularly support arts initiatives, especially ones engaged with French collaborators. The French Embassy in Fiji, for example, funded the staging of the Pacific Island’s first opera, *Domo ni Karmen*, in 2009, produced again in 2014, with playwright Larry Thomas and musical director Igelese Ete (see Domo

ni Karmen). These represent oneoff opportunities, and developing sustainable national or regional funding structures to support arts and culture remains a challenge.

Enhancing the Cultural Sector in the Pacific

A primary goal of the SPC's regional initiative to structure culture has been to create national cultural policies and thus frameworks for cultural development through the European Union grant of 713,474 EUR. From 2010 to 2013, six countries were supported to undertake a mapping, planning and policy development process that would allow governments, institutions and communities to work together to formalize their cultural sectors (Teaiwa and Mercer 2010). Culture and arts activities had mostly been seen as part of the informal economy and were not systematically counted as contributing towards the national economy, social capital and national well-being. Targeted areas included: traditional knowledge such as indigenous knowledge of fishing, composition, weaving, healing and dance, which can be seen as a subset of intangible cultural heritage (ICH); other forms of ICH, including oral, musical and performing arts, based on indigenous and non-indigenous sources; tangible cultural heritage, including physical sites in the land and sea, and the material arts, such as houses, canoes and cultural objects; cultural industries, including visual arts, crafts, film, television, literature, theatre, fashion and digital music production; and cultural intellectual property regimes covering copyright issues and other matters of proprietary rights and protection across all these areas.

The mapping process was also designed to understand structural and systemic gaps and assets of the sector such as existing cultural or arts institutions, bodies and support systems, legislative and other incentives such as budgetary assistance, fiscal incentives, focused investment, branding or the use of soft diplomacy for the promotion of arts and culture. A national cultural policy was presented as an ideal instrument for the realization of cultural development goals and plans and imagined as systematically formulated through regular consultation and dialogue with all interested parties. In the Pacific, given the ubiquitous nature of

indigenous and migrant expressions of culture, ‘stakeholder’ generally means everyone.

The SPC project consisted of a program of workshops, dialogues, information exchange and production of materials, including a Cultural Mapping, Planning and Policy (CMPP) Workshop conducted for members of the Council for Pacific Arts and Culture in March 2010 in Nouméa and the Pacific Consultation on Cultural Industries in December 2010. This was followed by a sub-regional CMPP monitoring and evaluation meeting in May 2011 in Suva, workshops for cultural producers, enablers and promoters in 2012 in Suva and in Guam and a series of focused tool kits on policy. The CMPP implementation, monitoring and evaluation workshop was immediately followed by the inaugural Cultural Statistics workshop (see [Figure 3.3](#)) hosted by the SPC and the UNESCO Institute of Statistics in collaboration with UNESCO and the Pacific Islands Forum Secretariat, which brought together cultural officers and representatives from National Statistics Offices for the first time (Teaiwa 2012a).



Figure 3.3 Regional participants in the first Pacific Community (SPC) cultural statistics meeting, 2012.

The overall project, led by Elise Huffer, targeted four specific but complementary and mutually supporting areas: developing cultural policy; promoting cultural industries; preserving cultural heritage; and building cultural relations in the African, Caribbean and Pacific group of states (ACP) through museum exchanges. A program of activities under each area was then organised to bring together what has been viewed in many PICTs as a mostly informal or non-integrated (and often ad hoc) array of cultural activities, products and events. This process included capacity building in inclusive cultural mapping and information gathering exercises, as well as developing systematic approaches to gathering cultural statistics in order to create an evidence base and integrate culture into national policy making, particularly economic and social planning. For decades since independence, many Pacific countries have not prioritized such work for a number of reasons, including the fact that culture permeates everyday social, economic, religious and political life and is regularly ‘taken for granted.’ During the inaugural cultural statistics meeting in Suva, we observed statisticians regularly asking, ‘What are you trying to measure?’ with cultural officers asking, ‘Why are we trying to measure this?’ Objectifying, institutionalizing and ‘measuring’ culture does not always make sense to bureaucrats or artists, and can also have unintended consequences that always need to be considered. Countries such as New Zealand with a large indigenous population have relatively strong cultural statistics models for ensuring the maintenance of the special links between indigenous arts practice, community values, spirituality and the environment, things that are rarely easy to measure (see Ngā Toi Māori).

An evaluation of the Pacific-Caribbean exchange initiative between museum staff, students and researchers under the SPC-EU program led to a proposal yet to be discussed in detail between Caribbean and Pacific culture leaders to expand collaboration between the two regions. It was hoped that this could be effected through the Small Islands Developing States (SIDS) mechanism, and the project was presented at the SIDS conference that took place in Samoa in September 2014. This project is designed to increase exchanges of information, ideas, arts and culture professionals, workers, artists and performers around four areas: cultural policy, heritage and museums, cultural industries and culture and conservation of nature. The Pacific and Caribbean regions are clearly distinct, but they also have many commonalities: dynamic and ambitious but under-resourced culture sectors;

a will but insufficient means to foster the cultural industries in a way that both protects and promotes local artists, producers and communities; a desire to preserve heritage and to ensure that accomplishments and hardships of past generations are transmitted and not forgotten; a tradition of regional festivals such as Carifesta (the Caribbean Arts Festival) and FOPA; and strong regional identities and architectures in spite of the diversity of local and introduced (colonial) languages, and cultures (cf., Teaiwa 2012b; Teaiwa, Figueroa and Finin 2007). Both regions may have much to gain by working more closely on development in culture and the arts.

Evaluating the Festival of Pacific Arts

In 2009 a team was put together by SPC, with significant financial assistance from UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage section, to evaluate the impact of and propose recommendations for improving the region's quadrennial, premier cultural event: the Festival of Pacific Arts. The festival can be described as one of the main catalysts for cultural policy work, as indicated in its founding principle to protect and promote traditional expressions of culture, and particularly the arts, across the region since 1972. The Council of Pacific Arts, which brings together government heads of arts and culture of all Pacific Islands and was renamed Council of Pacific Arts and Culture in 2010 to reflect its widening policy role, was established in 1975 to oversee the festival. The year 2012 marked the fortieth anniversary of the festival, and in total, 11 international gatherings have now been held in different parts of Oceania, including in New Zealand and Australia. Significantly, the festival has not changed from being mounted for Pacific Islanders by and for each other, rather than foreign audiences and tourists in particular (see Teaiwa 2014a). Economic profit has never been the goal of the festival. While each event has underscored the potency of the arts for the maintenance of Pacific cultures and identities, this hasn't always translated into regional systems, structures or sustainable funding related to the festival. Each national organizing committee had to come up with its own approaches and strategies to hosting the event in the absence of a shared guide until the late 1990s.

The SPC has been the custodian of the festival since its inception; however, it lacked a culture program until 1996, when at the initiative of the Council of Pacific Arts, a cultural affairs bureau was established, funded by France. Six years later, it became fully integrated into SPC programming, but capacity in its culture division (now part of the Human Development Programme) has always been thin or under-resourced until receiving initial funding through UNESCO and then through a European Union global grant (Investing in People) in 2010. These funding sources allowed Huffer and her team to adopt a more structured approach to cultural development including evaluating the region's premier arts event.

The festival evaluation consultants included Joycelin Leahy, Joyce Yeap and Bill Pennington. Their main goals entailed evaluating the specific contribution that FOPA makes to safeguarding intangible cultural heritage regionally and nationally, especially through the media; to building regional and international cooperation and cultural networks; and to passing on a sense of the importance of intangible cultural heritage to younger generations. Furthermore, they explored the extent to which FOPA contributes to the full inclusion of women in Pacific cultures; the economic, social and cultural benefits devolving from FOPA nationally and regionally; as well as how it contributes to greater awareness of the links between culture, sustainable development and poverty reduction, especially through the creation of cultural goods for the elite and village sectors of the market. Finally, they looked at the efficiency of the organizational set up of FOPA and the incidence of sponsorship, state and private support, while acknowledging that each festival was to be examined within its own merit and context (Leahy, Yeap-Holliday and Pennington 2010).

After extensive consultations with key stakeholders in many of the participating PICTs, the team made some key recommendations. The regular format of the festival involves highly programmed and staged performances, fashion shows and exchange of gifts, but much of the festival experience is off-stage in the temporarily constructed 'festival village.' The team thus made a series of recommendations that were both artist/delegate and host centered. These included: the importance of securing long-term funding for and cost-effective transport to the festival; revisiting the stated objectives of the festival to better include issues of sustainable development; fostering the agency and participation of women and youth; including other key regional agencies and the private sector in supporting,

funding and planning for the festival (especially Pacific Trade and Investment and the South Pacific Tourism Organisation); the need for delegates to better address the carefully chosen theme of each quadrennial festival; better facilitation during the festival of opportunities for artists to exchange ideas amongst themselves via symposia, professional development workshops, master classes and the inclusion of a 'jam house' or informal space where anyone could gather and make art, jam or dance together (Leahy, Yeap-Holliday and Pennington 2010).

Furthermore, their recommendation called for: the establishment of Pacific Arts Awards for participants that truly promoted the 'spirit' of the festival; better explanation during the festival of sacred or taboo aspects, costuming and performance; better regulatory systems and measures for the protection of intellectual property, including a robust media accreditation system; the creation of a guide for participating delegations; the sharing of technical expertise and advice between host countries; and, most controversially, the opening up of the festival to any interested participant, and not just official PICTs delegations (Leahy, Yeap-Holliday and Pennington 2010). This would mean the opening up of the festival, historically very tightly focused on the participation of official political and territorial entities, to independent and contemporary artists, those from the large Pacific diaspora, non-official collectives and a whole range of other interested artists or cultural practitioners. It will be interesting to see whether such diversity of participants will be seen at the next FOPA in Guam in 2016.



Figure 3.1 Solomon Islands Tapa at the Festival of Pacific Arts, 2012.
Source: Photo by Katherine Teawa

Enhancing Pacific Cultural Industries

A new EU-ACP Cultures + funded project beginning in 2014, building on the previous EU project, involves establishing a conducive national and regional environment for the cultural industries in the Pacific. The specific objectives include structuring cultural industries in Fiji, Samoa and the Solomon Islands; strengthening the national regulatory framework for the promotion of the cultural industries; and fostering sustainable economic opportunities for cultural producers and entrepreneurs. The action targets artisans and producers of cultural expressions in the ‘informal sector’; arts bodies, councils, associations and networks; and public and private sector industry players. The final beneficiaries are perceived to include communities with emphasis on young people, women and men whose livelihoods are dependent on the cultural and related industries; custodians of traditional knowledge and cultural expressions; the private and public sectors and wider society. The goals include the establishment of structured

cultural industries with government and development partner support, a regulatory framework for the promotion of cultural industries in the three countries and improved domestic and international market access for Pacific cultural producers. The latter element aspires to up-skilling cultural producers and essentially bringing them into the ‘formal sector’ with increased market opportunities.

Project activities involve a structured series of capacity-building activities across the three countries. These include national strategic development workshops, recruitment of a cultural officer and in-country consultants, development of associations and networks, copyright management and awareness campaign and enforcement workshops, cultural industries human resources needs scoping, technical assistance missions, national entrepreneurial workshops and trade promotion events. The project will conclude with an external evaluation allowing participants and the arts and culture communities to voice their views of the work and further needs.

The culture and arts environments in each of the three targeted countries are particularly ripe for cultural industries development. In spite of the Solomon Islands suffering national devastation in 2014 from an intense flood that displaced thousands of people in Guadalcanal and the capital, Honiara, they are continuing to develop artist-in-residence programs through a new Art Haus initiative, they have launched a fashion association and are implementing their national cultural policy, which was launched in 2013 while still riding the wave of a resoundingly successful hosting of the 11th Festival of Pacific Arts in 2012. Infrastructure and networks of culture and arts stakeholders had been well set up for FOPA, stimulating nationwide participation, renewal and interest in the cultural industries. Similarly, in 2013, a Samoan Arts Council was established with former artistic director and choreographer with USP’s Oceania Dance Theatre Tuilagi Seiuli Allan Alo as the inaugural president. Regular arts symposia, exhibitions, arts-related media and other activities were quickly stimulated across the island of Upolu. These are now regularly captured in an arts column edited by Vanya Taulea’alo (Vice-President of SAC and arts gallery owner) for the *Samoa Observer* newspaper. A recent development has been the assistance of Australia to enable the Arts Council to establish a secretariat and hire permanent staff.

Fiji has a relatively well-established higher education sector, a Fiji Museum, National Trust, Fijj Arts Council and an active department of

national heritage, culture and arts and an Institute of I-Taukei (indigenous Fijian) Language and Culture, while being the regional hub of international development. It has thus been a regional center for incubating and growing arts and cultural initiatives, many of which have proved sustainable, even while regularly struggling for real funding. Two interesting recent developments in Fiji include the establishment of Fiji Fashion Week as the premier regional fashion event engaging designers at all career levels. Local audiences and consumers who are interested in home-grown fashion and creative content have been growing steadily in this island nation and boutique and cottage industries are currently flourishing around local-made or 'Fiji-made' brands.

There has also been a marked increase in active support from the U.S. government via their Embassy in Suva for creative industries development. In 2013–14, for example, the U.S. Embassy, usually led by Ambassador Frankie Reed, supported U.S.-based visual artists, slam poets, musicians and rap artists to work with communities across Fiji. Importantly, Reed is both female and African American and this fact, and the significance of bringing African American artists to the Pacific as part of these initiatives, is not lost on Pacific Islanders. Drawing musical and choreographic inspiration from other black people, whether from the U.S., the Caribbean or Africa, has always been important in the Pacific Islands (see Teaiwa 2012b; Webb 2014). The success of the U.S. Embassy's American Music Abroad exchange program, which brought reggae-hop band Audiopharmacy to Fiji in 2013, for example, underscored this long history of exchange and inspiration between Pacific Islanders and black Americans (Nasiko 2013).

In spite of all these developments, a key component that is still missing in all these countries, and the region as a whole, is the statistical measurement or capturing (both qualitatively and quantitatively) of all this arts and culture activity with a real sense of how it contributes to national and regional economics, individual and communal efficacy, vitality and wellbeing. Vanuatu is so far the only country to carry out a related exercise (to be extended to other Melanesian countries) involving the systematic measuring of the relationship between the 'kastom economy' (or traditional, indigenous economic and social ways of life and governance) and national well-being through an 'alternative indicators' project (Makin 2012). The alternative indicators project has led Vanuatu to rethink its national

sustainable development framework resulting in a greater focus on environmental, social and cultural well-being. As a result, consultations have been much more inclusive and grounded, with strong input from chiefs, women's groups, young people and rural and urban communities. Nonetheless, for culture to thrive as a sector, related to but independent from other sectors, measuring the specific contribution of the arts and cultural activities, goods and services remains necessary.

Conclusion

For thousands of years, Pacific Islanders have adapted and developed their cultures to thrive in a sea of islands spread across one-third of the surface of the planet. In this challenging and inspiring oceanic environment, Pacific people have integrated their social, cultural, political, spiritual and environmental practices so that the people, the ocean and landscapes form inter-related and complex systems of mutual relations. Over time, and especially since the arrival of Christianity, capitalism and colonialism, aspects of this world have changed. In the contemporary Pacific, culture, of which the arts are a primary expression, is often separated from formal governance structures, norms and regulatory systems, even as it continues to shape the lives and decision-making practices of leaders and everyday islanders alike (see Teaiwa 2014b).

In this context, recent international and regional developments supporting the 'structuring of the culture sector' in PICTs need to agree on national and local understandings of culture and the arts as key aspects of everyday life, as well as assets that can, to an extent, be shaped, supported, measured and evaluated in terms of their contribution to national social and economic well-being. Traditional knowledge, for example, may not be created for economic growth, but it can contribute to activities with positive economic benefits. The increasing numbers of Pacific Island scholars, cultural practitioners, artists and policy makers involved in the field of cultural development allows for an approach that balances pressing social and economic needs with cultural values and concerns. Incorporating local and indigenous values throughout the cultural development process is essential for ensuring that initiatives and outcomes are owned by local or indigenous

communities and that any objectification or commodification of culture is done in accordance with cultural norms and based on regular consultation and dialogue between cultural stakeholders, which, as mentioned earlier for the Pacific, is everyone (Teaiwa 2007). The Regional Culture Strategy (2010, p. 3) argues that the cultural sector across the Pacific is ‘integral to the lives of all Pacific people, has great potential to both drive and support sustainable development and economic growth within the region, and yet receives little attention or recognition as a formal sector requiring astute management to maximise its economic and social contributions.’ In response, the Regional Culture Strategy ‘sets out steps to earn the cultural sector this recognition of its full, multi-faceted contributions to the region’ (Teaiwa 2007).

Notes

1 As of 2016 the ‘SPC’ is known as the ‘Pacific Community’ and its former ‘Human Development Programme’ is now the ‘Social Development Programme’.

2 As of 2016, known as the Festival of Pacific Arts and Culture (FestPAC).

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4

Artists as Change Agents

Structural and Policy Implications

Daniel Gad

Introduction: Development, Civil Society and Transformation

This chapter explores the role and relevance of artists as social change agents within the context of international development. For over sixty years now, the field of international development has sought concepts and strategic frameworks that set a standard of comparison for the basic conditions for a fulfilled life. The existence of international agreements like the Universal Declaration of Human Rights 1948 ¹ suggests the ability of ‘humanity,’ despite its diversity, to find common ground in the design of social goals and the amelioration of social grievances. Such agreements, however, only fulfil their aim when they effect actual change in the concrete circumstances of people.

One of the most important actors in ensuring accountability to such globally agreed agendas is civil society. The free activity of civil society requires institutionalized human rights in order to flourish, yet, at the same time, it often emerges through protest and resistance in precisely those areas where such rights are missing. Civil society (and this includes independent arts organizations) can act as a watchdog, a check on the powers and actions of the state and, in this sense, non-governmental organizations (NGOs) are an important part of any process of democratic transformation.

Processes of transformation involve, by necessity, an openness to other perspectives, a readiness to change and the skill and will to communicate. New knowledge often emerges as the symbiosis of traditional, contemporary, local and foreign perspectives. If transformation implies a willingness to deal with change, it is striking how low the relevance of education and artistic practice is within the policy agendas of many societies. Education and artistic practice are central means of developing openness, dealing with change and developing the capacity to communicate, as will be discussed below. Despite this relevance, cultural policies that support artistic development have a hard time prevailing in the economic context of the struggle for limited resources, and this is reinforced by the way in which the social effects of creative practice often cannot be measured in a linear or predictable way, as other chapters in this volume attest.

Valuing the Arts

Within the assessment criteria for development policies, which are aligned strongly with efficiency, the impact of art and of culture may seem frustratingly intangible. While the economic value of the arts can indeed be calculated—in countries as diverse as Brazil and Mali, the creative economy accounts for up to six per cent of the GDP (Jeretic 2009)—it is more difficult to account for art that is *socially* relevant but not necessarily economically successful. Where development projects and cooperation must justify their use of funds, an anxiety emerges over the setting of clear, achievable objectives.

It is not surprising, therefore, that mainstream development agencies often support, for example, educational theatre that communicates the dangers of HIV/AIDS (as in the case of Theatre for Development). Yet, the theatre sector specifically, and the arts sector in general, is not necessarily promoted through such funding, even if it already deals with socially relevant issues through the language of the arts—which is far less direct and concrete, but is not necessarily less effective. As art is often a reflection of what happens in society, a form of criticizing things that need to be changed, or a forum for debating where this change needs to be located,

support of the arts ‘for their own sake’ is rare among most actors in the field.

The experiences of arts projects all around the world (for example, the Casa de los Tres Mundos ² in Nicaragua or the Music Crossroads Programme ³ in Southern Africa) demonstrate that art can facilitate the ability to question social situations at the same time as articulating an imaginative sense (even utopia) in the context of politically repressive situations. Although, precisely because they stimulate critique, cultural workers are often prevented from acting as free artists.

Art is always a contributor to broader social discourses, including those that seek solutions to societal ills. In its final report in 2007, the Enquete Commission ‘Culture in Germany’ described the arts and culture as critical sites for social reflection:

The self-reflection of society on values and standards takes place in the sphere of culture. Therefore, it is important, not only for individuals and their quality of life, but also for the development of society, that as many people as possible are involved in the cultural discourse that takes place through the medium of the arts.

(Deutscher Bundestag 2007, p. 49)

With much praise directed towards the subversive and critical potential of art, it is important to clarify precisely where and how art can work within development and to critically question some common assumptions, particularly around art’s ‘positive’ contributions.

Not Only Subversive

A common assumption is that art is the expression of the freedom of the artist: he or she chooses its content, regardless of external conditions, for artists only obey the ‘rules’ of art. Therein, it is argued, lies art’s subversive potential. However, this assumption is not universally valid, for it emerged from a particular historical and cultural context. With the emergence of western European aesthetics in the eighteenth century, an earlier Renaissance idea of artistic ‘genius’ was reconceptualized. At this time, the artist became the antithesis of courtly society and was declared a rebel element, almost representing a new social order of his own. In the

nineteenth century, the concept of the artist as an individualist, an outsider, marginal and a dissenter, validated by his recognized ‘genius,’ became highly influential if not normative in the Western world. It became generally understood that the artist did not follow standard, socially prescribed rules of order or morality: art was only obligated to itself (Gad 2014, p. 31).

And yet, the generalization of this model of art and artistry conveniently ignores the extent to which the artist (in Western Europe as elsewhere) has always depended on patrons and markets. Even in the economy of art in the west, the artist was never entirely free to express his or her own thoughts. He or she always acted in the service of a client or patron, market or movement. The myth of artistic autonomy is fraught with historical assumptions. It also overlooks how this model may not be valid for many non-European cultures.

Similarly, a common assumption that art is ‘critical’ or subversive ignores the historical reality of art’s significant role in the stabilization of existing social systems, glorifying their rulers or ideologies or providing a symbolic language for the perpetuation of national identity. This is as much a modern, as pre-modern, phenomena. Art can, of course, be subversive, but also conservative, restorative or reactionary, depending on the context, both social and political. Art can be a medium for creating and perpetuating stereotypes and representations of the ‘enemy’; it can deepen or even create rifts between its own reference group and others. It can stir up conflicts and contribute to the outbreak of violence. ⁴ Art is as diverse, ambivalent and partisan as any other cultural or communication system, and its effects can be positive or destructive. It can engage with the emotions or human rationality, it can communicate on different levels, and it can use its aesthetic impact to influence its audience in one direction or another.

Mediation and Change

In thinking about the arts as a site for social change, we should also consider the role of cultural mediators, whose job it is to connect art and audience. Cultural mediators (who may or may not be artists) promote communication and cultural exchange between people of different social backgrounds, locally and internationally. Hans-Dieter Lehmann, current

president of the German Goethe-Institut, has called artists and cultural mediators ‘seismographs of society,’ for they ‘observe, analyze and assess the condition of a society’ (Lehmann 2006). Hilmar Hoffmann, one of Lehmann’s predecessors, further developed the idea:

If we transfer the image of the seismograph to the artistic and cultural sphere, then it is about pluri-causal processes and interpretations rather than the mere displaying of changes... The seismograph becomes a subject, he [or she] can and must choose what seems to be important and what he [or she] wants to show... Inalienable characteristics of artistic work as a seismograph of change are to generate symbolic forms of interpretative, evaluative and cognitive appropriation of the world from the experience of our changing life. By playing through and setting an example of culturally specific ways of interpreting the world and human beings, the arts open opportunities of change and development within a society. They open up “spaces of possibility” for overcoming mental blocks and socio-political dead ends.

(Hoffmann 2002, pp. 14–8)

The possibility of artists and cultural mediators to stimulate change enables us to conceptualize him or her as a ‘change agent.’ This is not to suggest that a single artist or work can steer society to a new course, rather, that the sum of artistic statements and the diversity of creative expressions, whether they are direct in their intention or experimental, have a cumulative effect. Artists and cultural mediators, in facilitating artistic and cultural processes, become subtle activists for social change.

Some artists and cultural mediators do use the power of art to directly address social issues, generating a more immediate expanded awareness. The list of possible examples includes the Russian music and performance group Pussy Riot, which acts as a collective of activists, using artistic expression as a direct form of intervention into political discourse. ⁵ The events in the context of the so-called Arab Spring show the possibility that some activists use artistic means to expand existing communication channels and also to make them more urgent and effective. ⁶ Over a longer period, they may contribute (albeit partially) to the transformation of a political system and of social behavior. The impact or success of such a form of direct artistic action cannot be predicted: only in retrospect can clear reference points be identified.

In recent years, the term ‘artist’ has become widespread to define socially engaged practice within and through the arts. Yet, those actions which might be named ‘artivism’ seldom follow a single, strategic direction. In parallel, many artists are suspicious of the possible instrumentalization of

art. They suspect the inherent freedom of art will be threatened if art is transformed into an explicit and purposive action addressing an equally explicit social problem or issue. Predictably, one can expect many artists not to want a 'role' in society as a perceived 'seismograph' or 'change agent' of any kind.

Arts Education, Arts Audiences and Subjectivity

If the arts have value in processes of social transformation, then arts education becomes an important site of agency. The 'Roadmap for Arts Education,' formulated after the first UNESCO World Conference on Arts Education in 2006, argues for arts education as a human right:

Culture and the arts are essential components of a comprehensive education leading to the full development of the individual. Therefore, Arts Education is a universal human right, for all learners, including those who are often excluded from education... Arts Education is also a means of enabling nations to develop the human resources necessary to tap their valuable cultural capital.

(UNESCO 2006, p. 3)

The arts are also, themselves, sites of public education and critical reflection, as discussed by Scheytt (2003, p. 6). Scheytt argues for arts education as enabling 'a capacity for ethical reflection and the transmission of values' (2003, p. 6). This concept of an extended education includes the idea of people developing their own subjectivity. Audiences and participants gain capacity in making their own perceptions and judgements; they learn to communicate, and to think more freely about human behavior. Literacy should be understood more broadly as including artistic literacy.

Tasks for Policy

How, then, can cultural policy support these potential contributions of the arts to processes of social transformation? Cultural policy should support and promote an environment in which cultural workers can create the

conditions for the experience of, participation in, mediation of and education in arts and culture. Cultural policy is not only defined by financial support, it also ensures freedoms and provides legitimacy, which constitute important conditions for artistic-social practice. This may be particularly significant in some countries where cultural workers struggle with enormous challenges, including a lack of state budget support, little interest from the private sector and when their role is treated with suspicion—as if cultural workers represent a subversive and/or disruptive force. Not infrequently, the right to freedom of expression is severely curtailed by governments precisely because of the artist's perceived political or social responsibilities. Even without censorship, of course, a lack of resources can have a detrimental impact on the development of artistic freedom (UNESCO 1979b). It is important, therefore, to move the national and international cultural policy focus to the support of artistic creation and arts education, and to ensure that this policy is strongly informed by artists and their associations.

Within the parameters of global cultural policy (embedded within the multiple declarations and recommendations of UNESCO), the status of the artist is currently defined firstly in terms of social responsibility, and secondly in terms of rights. Governments are obliged to create a social environment that encourages 'freedom of artistic expression but also the material conditions facilitating the release of this creative talent' (UNESCO 1980). The 1997 World Congress on the Implementation of the Recommendation Concerning the Status of the Artist was convened by UNESCO to address a number of issues faced by cultural workers, including limited freedoms to express themselves, a disregard for copyright and the lack of social security. Congress participants argued for the cultural sector to participate in the design and implementation of cultural policies, wherein independent professional associations could be formed and play a role. Within this scheme, cultural workers would fully promote the use of arts and culture in the development of society, leaving a question about the instrumentalization of the arts in such discourses (UNESCO 1979a).

The development of the cultural sector itself, however, should also be a priority in cultural policy. It is important to include artistic criteria as well as 'human development' criteria in funding guidelines: '[t]he cultural sector will never bloom and eventually benefit broader human and social ends unless it is allowed to build its own infrastructure (support systems of

education, production, distribution, communication, etc.), and there is sufficient room in which independent artists can operate' (Gerlach-Hansen 2006, p. 118). It is not enough to construct the conditions for the effective mediation and use of arts and culture in development. This must be accomplished hand in hand with the development of an independent cultural sector itself.

Cultural workers are important in mediating and facilitating the potential relations between the independent cultural sector and society and the use of the arts in diverse social processes. Their capacities and visibility can be strengthened through engaging with professional networks. In recent years, more and more networks have been established, including the African ARTerial Network,⁷ the Arab Cultural Policy Group, the NGO Freemuse (supporting freedom of expression in music)⁸ and the NGO freeDimensional (supporting artists in danger worldwide; see Joag and Lester, this volume). Even though these networks do not necessarily exist in comparable settings, they all have been assembled to foster change and the transformation of both political discourse and practical approaches to supporting cultural workers. Networks, as rhizomic civil society actors, are often motivated by an observed inactivity or incapacity in the public institutions of their region. Over the years, these initiatives have identified a crucial need for advocacy groups and for better access to professional training in their specific thematic area. ARTerial Network's 'Arts Advocacy and Networking Toolkit,' which offers training for socially and politically active artists and cultural mediators, is one example out of many.

These examples are significant, but they represent small steps in promoting supportive conditions for artists globally, including within development contexts. Governments and public institutions, and also private sector stakeholders, could play a greater role in creating the conditions that allow for the necessary freedoms of artistic creation as well as access to art and arts education. Corporate social responsibility is one area in which commercial enterprise presents opportunities. In the Federal Republic of Germany, 'der aktivierende Kulturstaat' has emerged as a new term, translated with difficulty as 'activating culture state.' It indicates a synthesis of state action, market actors and civil society. Knoblich and Scheytt describe the concept as 'aimed at a new, holistic understanding of cultural policy.' In the 'activating culture state,' support for creative cultural practices involves diverse actors from all three sectors working together.

This form of cultural governance is ‘an attempt to solve problems of ownership, financing and social development, using arts and culture through different sectorial and cross-sectorial alliances.’ It attempts to move away from a top-down model and ‘to lead cultural policy into the heart of society, and to make it stronger than before—as a common concern of different actors’ (Knoblich and Scheytt 2009, p. 1).

This framework offers a model of integration, alliance and partnership that moves beyond older models of ‘using’ arts and culture instrumentally for development. It invokes an alliance between independent sectors, offering multiple and diverse pathways towards social development. There remain major issues with regard to the way many governments are virtually incapacitated by corruption, mismanagement and a lack of know-how, and where civil society or the private sector is no solution, as they suffer the same problems. Worldwide social ills demand new strategies and solutions, and one such is to activate the enormous potential for arts and culture in development.

Notes

- 1 Influential in the drafting of further agreements, such as: the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (1966); the Action Plan on Cultural Policies for Development (UNESCO, 1998); and the UNESCO Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions (2005).
- 2 See Casa de los Tres Mundos, Nicaragua. Online: www.c3mundos.org/ (accessed 20 November 2015).
- 3 See Music Crossroads International. Online: www.jmi.net/page.php?n=3&ID=6#.VdukZNYUdrE (accessed 20 November 2015).
- 4 Two recent examples include the caricatures of Muhammad published in the Danish *Jyllands-Posten* in 2005, or the violent attack on the office of the satirical paper *Charlie Hebdo* in Paris in 2015. Many other, less highly publicized, examples exist.
- 5 See the following YouTube clip of various public ‘performances’ of Pussy Riot as an example. Девчонки из PUSSY RIOT захватывают транспорт. Online: www.youtube.com/watch?v=qEiB1RYuYXw&list=PL596119EEA8603CA5 (accessed 20 November 2015).
- 6 See, for example, the work presented on the blog *SuzeeintheCity* (2014), which documents street art in Egypt: Online: suzeeinthecity.wordpress.com (accessed 17 November 2015).
- 7 See Arterial Network (a civil society network that supports the cultural sector across Africa). Online: www.arterialnetwork.org/ (accessed 20 November 2015).

8 See Freemuse (an organization that advocates for free musical expression). Online: freemuse.org/ (accessed 20 November 2015).

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Part Two

The Interface of Art, Agency and Activism

5

Breaking the Frame

The Agency of Art's Liminal Relationship to Development

Polly Stupples

Introduction

There is a call for the arts to exert a transformative role in the context of development—to bring about positive change. Indeed, many advocates, eager to claim a place for art within the (somewhat indifferent) field of development, make significant claims about the arts' capacity to contribute to core development objectives, such as economic development, peace building and social inclusion. Insufficient attention has been paid, however, as to exactly how—in which ways and through which mechanisms—artistic practices might actually achieve these things, and even less attention has been devoted to exploring other forms of agency that artistic practice may embody. This chapter aims to expand our understanding of the possible sites for, and forms of, agency that may be generated through arts projects beyond those articulated by mainstream development frameworks: possibilities associated with art's aesthetic properties, with its capacity to travel beyond the local and beyond the issues of underdevelopment and with its unpredictability and ambiguity—that is, with its liminal relationship to development.

These questions are explored in this chapter through analysis of the workings of an independent artist-led education initiative in Nicaragua with whom I worked, over a number of years, as a doctoral student. La ESPORA is a school for contemporary visual arts ¹ that runs workshops, residencies and exhibitions for emerging artists from throughout Central America, with a specific focus on developing a more plural and critical approach to visual arts in the isthmus. The school's critical motivation, shared with other artist-led initiatives in the region, ² constructs the context for a more dynamic and responsible artistic production, while resisting a range of marginalizing political practices in the cultural field. These include complacent attitudes and hierarchies within the local art establishment, ³ the demand from the global art establishment for Central American visual art to conform to exoticist expectations, ⁴ a dominant regional pictorial imaginary that perpetuates a limited number of marginalizing stereotypes while conforming to a conservative market (such as the female nude which privileges the male gaze and bucolic landscapes that reflect the colonial gaze of America as cornucopia) and the skewed demand by international donors for creative work that deals with development 'issues' over a broader palette of themes. La ESPORA's practices (funded largely through development cooperation) cannot be said to contribute directly to peace building, social inclusion or economic growth, yet they are certainly 'socially engaged.' The organization therefore provides an ideal site to explore a wider understanding of art's agency, particularly in regard to its liminal relationship to development.

Development Frames Art's Social Productivity

Before exploring the specifics of La ESPORA's practices, it is useful to consider how art's social productivity and agency is conceptualized within development. This is a complex task: development spans a heterogeneous and contested terrain and the way in which the arts are attended to, or not, by development actors, speaks in part to broader political questions. Some general remarks, however, can be made.

Art's liminal relationship to development has meant that many arts advocates have sought to demonstrate art's relevance to mainstream

development frameworks in order to secure both legitimacy and funding—a form of what Eleanora Belfiore (2006) calls ‘policy attachment.’ Thus, Hivos initiated a discussion around the idea of ‘culture’ being added as the ninth Millennium Development Goal (MDG) (Hivos 2005). ⁵ This kind of lobbying effort was repeated most recently through the Hangzhou Declaration on Culture and Sustainable Development (2013), which seeks to have culture (including the arts) embedded within the suite of Sustainable Development Goals, which replace the MDGs post-2015. One implication of such policy attachment is that art’s agency tends to be defined in instrumental terms—that is, in terms of what it can contribute to these pre-defined development frameworks. Thus, the arts are commonly valued as contributors to economic growth, employment and exports (in the creative economy) and as contributors (via therapeutic intervention or culturally embedded communication) to more human-centered development outcomes, such as social inclusion (see UNCTAD 2008, 2010; UNESCO and UNDP 2013). While research has shown that the arts can be used effectively as tools to address various social development issues, ⁶ it is reductive and politically problematic to see them only in this light, as the example of La ESPORA will demonstrate.

Indeed, development policy is increasingly recognizing less overtly instrumentalized values for the arts. The Spanish Agency of International Cooperation for Development (AECID), for example, in 2007, articulated the value of ‘safeguard[ing] the specificities of the cultural life of countries as a value in and of itself *and* an indispensable prerequisite for the economic, social and political development of societies [emphasis added]’ (AECID 2007, p. 9). The UNESCO/UNDP Special Report on the Creative Economy (2013) emphasised the ‘non-monetised benefits of culture’ which can lead to ‘empowerment, capacity-building, enhancing local image and prestige’ (2013, p. 17), and validated the way in which ‘cultural energy’ might contribute to catalysing various forms of collective action (2013, pp. 39–40). A very few independent NGOs, like the Prince Claus Fund, Hivos, DOEN Foundation and Arts Collaboratory (all Dutch-based), prioritize aesthetic quality and innovation ahead of social objectives (themselves viewed in expansive terms) as funding criteria, but this approach remains rare (see Fontes, this volume; Hivos 2002; Prince Claus Fund 2012).

One of the challenges of supporting the arts through development assistance is how to articulate, value and evaluate less clearly

instrumentalized forms of agency. Development outcomes are required to be predictable and measurable in the short term, partly for valid reasons of accountability and transparency. Yet this demand for predictability and measurability, for broad social change that can demonstrate a quick and clear return on investment, supports instrumentalization and reduces the visibility of other ways in which artists intentionally act.

The arts, however, were brought into the development field as part of a cultural turn that aimed precisely to counteract development's managerialist approach, to recognize other aspects of human experience and aspiration beyond that of material survival and to diversify development thinking beyond economic growth as the primary indicator of well-being (Nederveen Pieterse 2010; Rao and Walton 2004). How, then, might we explore the value of artistic practices in the development context in more expansive ways that may still speak to 'development' but in different ways than those imagined by the majority of development actors? One strategy for exploring such alternative forms of agency is to talk with artists themselves, as experts on their own practices, including the social nature of those practices. Another is to examine the relationships between different processes and outcomes, between different sites and scales of agency in a way that helps to move beyond such dichotomies as personal response vs. broad social engagement.

Why Agency?

An emphasis on agency emerged as part of development's cultural turn to counter the discursive violence in framing development subjects as powerless victims, characterized by the negative terms of 'underdevelopment.' Such reductive framing has been roundly critiqued for homogenizing diverse experience, reproducing powerful binaries (lack as opposed to abundance, traditional as opposed to modern, developed as opposed to underdeveloped and so on) ⁷ and denying the agency of those on the receiving end of development assistance. ⁸ Thus, the cultural turn impelled a 'retreat from structural and macro approaches in favor of micro and actor-oriented approaches' (Nederveen Pieterse 2010, p. 64) and the actions of grassroots initiatives gained greater recognition. Furthermore,

with the emergence of post-development theory in the mid-1990s,² many researchers sought to validate agentic practices in the South away from the focus on ‘development as both the problem and solution of the predicament of postcolonial subjects’ (de Vries 2007, p. 35).

Focusing on agency does not assume that actions are the ‘discrete expressions of individual will’ (Thomas 1998, p. ix), separated from the relations of power that animate all social contexts. As William H. Sewell (1992, p. 20) has pointed out, the intentions people are able to form and the ‘creative transpositions’ they are able to undertake vary greatly both within and between societies. Sociologist Norman Long sees agency in the development context as exerted within ‘contested arenas in which actors’ understandings, interests and values are pitched against each other’ (2004, p. 15). In relation to such ‘contested arenas,’ Sherry Ortner has fruitfully distinguished two modes of agency that co-exist and are interrelated: a mode of *resistance* that responds to dominant structures, and a mode of *projects* constructed ‘within a framework of [one’s] own terms, [one’s] own categories of value’ (2006, p. 145). Investigating the ways in which artists conceptualize their own agency (in ways that both resist dominant structures and construct independent projects) supports a process by which development subjects articulate their own agendas for change (see Nederveen Pieterse 2010, pp. 1–18) and reveals the full range of agency both in relation to, and beyond, development frameworks.

Anthropologist Alfred Gell emphasizes the agentic nature of all artistic practice (whether the agency is that of the artist or of the patron), arguing that art is ‘a system of action intended to change the world rather than encode symbolic representations about it’ (1998, p. 6). Art generates change through mediating social processes, motivating significant ‘inferences, responses or interpretations’ (Thomas 1998, p. ix). In the example that follows, I pinpoint the ways in which thinking about, talking about, making and showing art mediates various forms of social agency both within and beyond the context of ‘development.’

Mapping Agency in the Practices of La ESPORA

La ESPORA is an independent, artist-led education initiative promoting critically engaged visual arts practice in Central America. It runs an ongoing program (limited at times by the vagaries of development funding) of critical workshops (TACon), ¹⁰ residencies (RAPACES) ¹¹ and touring exhibitions (EX-IT). ¹² The organization seeks to institutionalize these educational services in a purpose-built facility, but development support for the arts does not extend to such long-term interventions, or to the construction of physical infrastructure. La ESPORA's core practices sit alongside a range of other projects (regional conferences, art workshops for talented but disadvantaged children, a television program that bridges contemporary and popular art forms, a series of podcast interviews with artist-led spaces throughout Latin America) under the umbrella organization EspIRA ¹³ that all contribute to the same overall objective of developing a more plural and critical context for visual arts. In this chapter, I will focus solely on La ESPORA's core educational practices.

TACon: Workshops in Contemporary Art

Throughout the year, La ESPORA runs critical workshops for emerging artists in Managua based around students' works in progress. The format of these workshops involves peer-to-peer dialogue, critical questioning and collective reflection. They are open to anyone, whatever their artistic educational background, and some young artists have now been involved in these processes since La ESPORA's inception in 2006. In a presentation to Dutch donor Arts Collaboratory, La ESPORA's founder, Patricia Belli explained the method as follows:

[S]omeone shows an artwork: one by one, everyone else gives an opinion about the following: what the artist attempts to express, what means he [/she] uses to do that, and how well he [/she] succeeds. All three opinions are, of course, subjective interpretations; therefore a discussion arises about how every participant reached those conclusions. The most important tool of the discussion is to question how you know what you know: what are the elements that make you think, feel that? How do these elements do that? Through their conventionalized role in culture? And if so, what's the power mechanism behind this convention? Or do they affect you through a biological mechanism?

Then the facilitator will question the political implications of the piece: what stereotypes are present in the ideas the piece supports? And then, after everyone has spoken, the [artist] is

allowed to tell his [/her] story, addressing the same issues: intention, means, success, ideology, elements of surprise.

Finally we discuss everything again, based on the new light the [artist] has shed.

Through this methodology, the encounter becomes exchange.

(Belli 2007, Part A)

The workshop method promotes a self-conscious critical awareness on the part of young artists regarding the mechanisms through which their work generates a particular effect or gains meaning and the ideological implications of form and content. In other words, it heightens the agentic potential of the work (in Gell's terms) through clarifying the relationships between intention, medium, form, reception and social and political context. This process of critical dialogue and exchange is transformative in a number of ways.

To begin with, the individual is encouraged to create work that stems from personal experience—the work is a ‘project’ in Sherry Ortner’s sense, constructed on one’s own categories of value—rather than conforming to dominant modes. The student’s own experience is validated, as it becomes central to their creative work. At the same time, the broader social context is brought into play and understood not as something static or external, or necessarily limited to the local, but as part of the individual’s encounter with the world. In this way, the work becomes an active response to, and intervention in, contemporary lived experience, rather than a passive reproduction. The mode of critical questioning (reminiscent of a dialogic Freirian approach) raises the critical consciousness of emerging artists about the politics of representation and what it means to be making art in contemporary Central America (about the agency of art). Students’ voices are strengthened through having to articulate and discuss their own intentions, processes and perceptions, and their perspective is broadened through engagement with others. Their own artistic criteria are explored, debated and strengthened through collective reflection and through inevitable processes of trial and error.

Students are, furthermore, encouraged to research the work of other artists whose work may speak to their own and to draw on a range of theoretical trajectories, historical and contemporary sources. In this way, their own practice is seen as part of a global dialogue, in which students have the right to engage. This strengthens voice and counters the

marginalization of artists from the ‘periphery’ in global circuits (see Araeen, Cubitt and Sardar 2002).

Residencies: RAPACES, Residencia Artística Para Artistas Centroamericanos Emergentes (Artists’ Residency for Emerging Central American Artists)

At the end of each year La ESPORA runs a four to six-week residency for young visual artists from throughout Central America. Local and international teachers (from Brazil, Mexico, Panama, Argentina, Cuba, Japan, Denmark as well as Nicaragua) who are known for the quality of their art work as well as their flair for teaching, facilitate workshops based around a central theme such as art and power, or the influence of the social, geographic and temporal contexts on the creative process.

Critically engaged dialogue is again the principal mechanism of exchange: between participants, between teachers and participants, through the formal workshops, but also through the experience of living under the same roof. Discussions, triggered by workshops during the day, continue deep into the night. These residencies differ from the TACon workshops by bringing together emerging artists from throughout the Spanish-speaking countries of the region (from Guatemala, Honduras, El Salvador, Costa Rica, Panama and Nicaragua). This intra-regional dialogue has particular significance in light of the relative isolation of many parts of the region stemming from a complex history of colonial divisions, foreign interventions, dictatorships and civil war. A common strategy among artist-led initiatives in the region is simply getting to know one another, to explore points of convergence and divergence, common challenges and opportunities. This, in turn, contributes to the exploration of identity and the critical construction of place.

One of La ESPORA’s catalogues explains the value of intra-regional dialogue in the residencies:

Due to the plural nature of the group, the discussion ranged between the local and the international, the generational, the political, questions of race and gender. It also moved between the most conceptual proposals about the role of the Central American artist in the global panorama, for example, to the most intimate expressions of psychological foundations.

Through these residencies, emerging artists develop technical skills but are also made aware of a range of theoretical approaches which help them to gain further understanding of, and confidence in, their own creative process in relation to artistic production in the region and beyond it. Identity is explored, articulated and affirmed.

Ex-It: Exposición Itinerante Centroamericana (Itinerant Central American Exhibition)

Following each residency, the work produced by participating students is shown in a travelling exhibition that spends a few weeks at each of the region's capital cities (and sometimes in smaller centers) over a period of six months. ¹⁴ The exhibition is managed by the students themselves, who organize, physically move, curate and mount the exhibition and then present their works in public forums at each venue. This process trains students in the technical skills of moving and mounting an exhibition, but it also builds and extends that core process of exploration, self-knowledge and an increasingly strengthened capacity to understand and speak for one's own creative process, to address one's own interests, experiences and questions. A catalogue is produced that documents these processes and serves to communicate to a wider public. Furthermore, some students have used the exhibition opening events as an opportunity to actively interview members of the public about their thoughts on the exhibition, and on contemporary art in general, furthering their critical understanding of the relationship of creative practice to the social context. They further extend friendships and institutional linkages, contributing to supportive regional networks.

Alternative Forms of Agency

How might these processes, and the forms of agency that they embody, be understood in relation to development's frameworks? Professionalism,

confidence, networking and technical skills are certainly enhanced through these processes, all of which may contribute to employability and to the consolidation of a professionalized cultural sector in the region. Indeed, Patricia Belli, founder of La ESPORA, hopes that students' experiences with the organization will give them the capacity to 'creat[e] work for [themselves as artists] entirely through [their] ingenuity and [their] creativity' (interview, Managua, June 2008). However, much of the action that takes place through these processes does not easily contribute to categories such as employment, social inclusion or export-oriented development. Furthermore, it is the specificities of context that lend particular power to some of these forms of agency—a factor usually missing from higher-level framing of the values of creative practice to development.

The agency of a critically engaged, plural visual arts practice that stems from individual experience responds (an agency of *resistance*) to a number of contextual factors while it also constructs (an agency of *projects*) a critical platform for artistic production and debate about cultural self-representation in Central America. Processes of critical, collective reflection and exchange resist the pressures towards self-censorship faced by young artists in the region (from the global art establishment to produce images that embody stereotypes of violence, revolution or poverty and from the development community to produce work that addresses the 'issues' of 'underdevelopment' and by the market for politically complacent, decorative work). At the same time, they promote a genuine intellectual and visual exploration that moves between scales, from the intimately personal to the regional and the global. The outcomes of this wide-ranging, dialogic, investigative process cannot be predicted or predetermined, as donors might desire: their value lies precisely in their exploratory nature.

Agency also lies in the multi-scalar engagements that these processes generate. Development tends to frame artists' agency primarily in relation to local 'issues,' thus reinforcing the social distance between 'developing' and 'developed,' restricting artists from engaging in 'the global and the complex' (García Canclini 1998, p. 374) and from dealing with universal subjects such as loss, alienation or belonging. Aesthetic considerations are also often reduced, in instrumentalized development frameworks, to social productivity—becoming largely invisible as carriers of content and as a mediating field. This has the effect of flattening the subjectivity of artists,

reducing their creative practices to functional tools, reducing criticality (evident also in the debate about form and aesthetic values) and constructs a social distance between artists of the South, who are expected to be politically (and/or socially) productive, and artists from the North, who maintain a monopoly on aesthetic sensibilities. As Patricia Belli has pointed out: '[t]he stereotype is on us: leave aesthetics to the *superficial* artists of the first world and let artists of the third world think and act on their political issues' (Belli 2007). La ESPORA's practices, in contrast, engage in the exploration and construction of place in a progressive (not ghettoised) sense, which is both outward-looking and inward-looking, local/global and complex (Massey 1991), and not restricted to place as defined by poverty and problems.

Multi-scalar action does not disperse agency or remove it from the local context—on the contrary, it serves a centring function whereby the artists' own criteria for practice are debated, tested and refined in relation to local, regional and global lenses, and in light of the globalized context for art-making (see Mosquera 2010 on the politics of art and globalization with particular reference to Latin America). Skills and knowledge are also developed at La ESPORA that support Central American artists to present and curate their own work to international audiences, wresting curatorial control from the metropolis and providing a platform to speak back to it and to take charge of processes of cultural self-representation. ¹⁵

There is a sense that these agentic practices contribute to the imaginative construction of place, in more hopeful and emancipatory terms than those offered by the statistical frameworks and rationalist interventions of development. Central America is described by a number of cultural commentators as being in a process of cultural reconstruction and regeneration in this post-civil war period of relative peace (Cazali 2000, p. 330; Oyamburu 2000, p. 7; Pérez-Ratton 2000, p. 75; Rodríguez 2002). The practices of La ESPORA contribute to this regenerative trajectory through strategies of exploration, investigation, reflection and exchange. Their practices both resist the negative and homogenising framing of the region as characterized by underdevelopment, lack and deficiency, and at the same time play with and construct alternative, diversified conceptions of place and identity. In this sense, they respond to Achille Mbembe's claims that the function of art in the development context ¹⁶ is both to 'free us from the

shackles of development both as an ideology and as a practice’ and to ‘pave the way for a qualitative practice of the imagination’ (2009).

In all of these examples, the making and showing of art works is operating (in Gell’s terms) to mediate social agency in a range of sites and at a range of scales. In relation to development in particular, agency is linked to art’s liminal relationship to development’s signifying frameworks and to the uncertainty of arts ‘outcomes.’ The imaginative construction of place and identity must be open-ended and able to move ‘beyond geographic certainty’ (Pérez-Ratton 2011, p. 29) in order to be emancipatory. If the value of artistic practices is only tied to the local and to the issues of underdevelopment, then the capacity for transformation beyond those confines is denied. Here, the mainstream development community’s logic appears circular: artists must prove their underdevelopment in order to secure funds, yet funds are given in the hope of a transformation beyond underdevelopment.

Yet La ESPORA’s practices escape this framing, refusing to conform to such expectations, and in doing so, they reveal the limitations of the development imaginary. The pedagogical practices organized by La ESPORA actively mediate a more plural and emancipatory framing of place and subjectivity. The organization constantly shuttles between the local and the regional and global; between social, aesthetic, intellectual and political strategies; between making a living, making place and make believe; between the intimate experience of being and the concrete act of creating and placing work in public sites at multiple scales. Nicaragua is ranked 129th on the Human Development Index and is *also* a great place to make art. La ESPORA teaches children from disadvantaged families in Managua *and* shows work in New York, ¹⁷ and applies the same critical approach to both. Questions of underdevelopment are both negotiated on a daily basis *and* regarded as largely irrelevant to artistic processes. In its embrace of such ambiguity, and in its expansive and critically reflective forms of investigation and exploration (that include aesthetic concerns), La ESPORA —through its artistic practices—generates a space for emergence and becoming, one that necessarily extends well beyond the frame of development.

Notes

- 1 La ESPORA is an acronym for 'La Escuela Superior de Arte' (The Higher School of Art) and it translates as 'spore.' I acknowledge the problematic nature of the term 'contemporary art' and use it in this chapter to refer to an increasing diversity of artistic languages coupled with a self-conscious and self-reflexive attitude that emerged post-World War II in the visual arts.
- 2 Such as TEORÉTica in Costa Rica, La Curandería in Guatemala and Malagana in Nicaragua.
- 3 National art schools are criticized for the complacency of the art produced, their entrenchment of hierarchical relations between teachers and students and a lack of critical engagement with the act of art-making (see Cazali 2000; Stupples 2011). The pedagogical approach is primarily technical rather than critical, and artwork produced in the schools tends to conform to the demands of the market. Similarly, national cultural institutes are frequently critiqued for their conservatism (Pérez-Ratton 2002; Samos 2002).
- 4 Artists from the region who examine themes of violence, poverty, natural disasters or revolution tend to gain greater international recognition (see Stupples 2015).
- 5 The introduction to this volume has discussed the ways in which 'the arts' are typically supported within broader 'culture funds' and the implications of this.
- 6 McCarthy et al. 2004 review the possibilities and limitations of measuring art's instrumental effects in a range of contexts.
- 7 Post-development and post-colonial scholars have, over the last twenty years, highlighted the discursive violence inherent in the development imaginary. See Escobar 1995; McEwan 2009; Ziai 2007 for examples.
- 8 This perspective arrived somewhat late to development theory. Post-colonial and Latin American cultural theory had long emphasized the two-way nature of agency in any cross-cultural exchange, disrupting stereotypes of domination and submission. The term anthropophagy (coined by Brazilian Oswald de Andrade in 1928) is a metaphor to describe an aggressive swallowing of the dominant culture 'to one's own benefit' (Mosquera 2010, p. 13), and transculturation (described by Cuban Fernando Ortiz in 1948) points out the 'bilateral exchange implicit in any acculturation' (Mosquera 2010, p. 14).
- 9 See McGregor 2009 for an overview of post-development's contributions to development theory.
- 10 TACon stands for Talleres de Arte Contemporáneo (Workshops of Contemporary Art).
- 11 RAPACES stands for Residencia Artística Para Artistas Centroamericanos Emergentes (Artists' Residency for Emerging Central American Artists).
- 12 EX-IT stands for Exposición Itinerante Centroamericana (Itinerant Central American exhibition).
- 13 EspIRA is a non-profit artists' association which stands for 'Espacio para la Investigación y Reflexión Artística' (Space for Artistic Research and Reflection). It was founded in 2003 and brought together a sizable group of Nicaraguan, Central American and international artists to support the establishment of the independent art school La ESPORA in 2006.
- 14 These exhibitions no longer take place due to a lack of funding.
- 15 The late Virginia Pérez-Ratton was particularly active in this regard, curating Central American art for a number of notable biennales, including Sao Paulo and Venice. La ESPORA's Darwin Andino also organized the first regional discussion of curating as a practice in Central America, in 2009, and in 2010 represented La ESPORA at the Pontevedra International Biennale in Spain.

16 Mbembe is referring specifically to the purpose of art in Africa but, based on his broader discussion of the dehumanizing aspects of development within which this quote is set, I have extended his meaning to the international development context.

17 In 2013, at the annual Pinta NY exhibition of modern and contemporary Latin American art.

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6

System Error

Art as a Space to Produce What We Would Never Have Thought We Needed

Iolanda Pensa

Introduction

We would never have thought that what we needed was a radio station.

(Head of the development organization of Bessengué, 2003)

In 2003, the artist Goddy Leye promoted *Bessengué City*, a public art event organized in a neighborhood of Douala, the economic capital of Cameroon. The project, supported by the international funds of RAIN-Rijksakademie International Network, involved four artists in producing site-specific artworks in Bessengué, a neighborhood that UN Habitat terms a slum. Within this project, the sound artist James Beckett created a one-kilometer-range radio station, easily authorized to broadcast in Cameroon, since it was an artwork. The inhabitants of Bessengué—an informal settlement, constantly threatened with forced eviction, without streets, electricity, sanitation, access to clean water or waste management, positioned in a hazardous location regularly impacted by floods during the rainy season and dangerously connected to a major road—were the first neighborhood of Douala to have their own radio station. A group of young people and the community started volunteering to produce radio programs, and the simple

technical equipment was located in a shelter created by the artist Jesus Palomino. One year later, after the end of the Bessengué City public art event and during the summer holidays, the radio station was still broadcasting. Ten years later, after a series of art-based workshops and projects (Les Ateliers Urbains de Bessengué, ¹ Bessengué City, ² Bourne Fountain, ³ La Passerelle ⁴ and the SUD Salon Urbain de Douala ⁵), Bessengué has a development committee, streets, electricity and fountains with access to clean water. The place where many public art interventions have been implemented is now a shared space, a place people care for, where people meet and children play. It is not an anonymous slum; it is now the neighborhood of Bessengué.

What is all this? Art or development? A community radio or an artwork? This chapter argues that the most relevant contemporary art projects which actually produce development and social change are ‘system errors.’ When it is hard to say what is what, and when something is one thing but also ‘something else,’ it is probably here that we can find the most fruitful relationship between art and development. The relationship is not a direct one of cause and effect. Art triggers the exceptional and makes people say, ‘*ça reveille.*’ It wakes us up.

To contextualize this argument, this chapter highlights features of the system that frames the production of art, in particular in the so-called ‘developing’ countries: dynamics of inclusion and exclusion, the binary logic of national vs. international, local vs. global, authentic vs. Westernized, the determinant operating structure of the project and the role of stakeholders. Understanding the system which frames art and development shows that art which produces development is indeed an error of the system, something the system is not necessarily designed for. This chapter draws on the findings of the research project ‘Mobile A2K: Culture and Safety in Africa. Documenting and assessing the impact of cultural events and public art on urban safety (2011–2014).’

The System

Art historians struggle to speak about the artistic production of the world. Despite attempts to bring out new concepts and approaches (Zijlmans and

Van Damme 2008) and reorganize knowledge in new ways (Deepwell 1997; Fisher 1994; Oguibe and Enwezor 1999; Summers 2003), a heavy Western historical legacy continues to entrap our ability to represent, recognize and organize the complexity of the exceptions that fill and feed art history.

Trapped in a Line: Dynamics of Inclusion and Exclusion

The art history told by Ernst Gombrich (1950) is the bestseller with which and against which we must negotiate (Elkins 2002): the approach of Gombrich represents the symbol of our still-common practice of constructing history and knowledge around a line, where what comes next is the development of what was there before. The problem is that linear art history implies homogeneity of context, which is not a feature of our world. How do we deal with this? Despite attempts at rewriting history or dropping the idea of linear progressive history, the art history we know is still a tangle of wires.

The way artistic production is studied in Africa and linked to Africa within art history is a good example. So-called ‘traditional’ African art is documented in the history of African art, in studies related to anthropology, visual anthropology, twentieth-century art (Flam 2003), national art histories and contemporary African art. The same content is separately framed by different disciplines and lives parallel lives. In the case of so-called ‘traditional’ African art, even its name is changed: artifact, craft, primitive art, popular art, airport art, art.

The Binary Logic: National vs. International, Local vs. Global, Authentic vs. Westernized

Art history is highly national: each country builds its own history and teaches it at school. The construction of a national art history requires a process of national art exegesis and a strategy of dissemination. James Elkins (2007) notes that throughout Africa, only 79 art schools can be listed, and there is no tradition of non-Western art history (distinct from

criticism). Indeed, until independence, national art histories in Africa were histories of the colonizing countries (Said 1979). Only later did the new national process of rewriting art histories start (Harney 2004). National art exegesis and its dissemination represent a strategy to which we are simply accustomed.

Thanks particularly to post-colonial studies, the fact that art history and national art history stretch beyond borders has been acknowledged more widely. This new awareness has produced another direction for research (Harris 2011) and a schizophrenic result: on the one hand, scholars take the production of the world much more into consideration, and on the other hand, the world is accused of losing its authenticity and being ‘Westernized.’ [6](#)

This new attempt at exploring the world more broadly and bridging geographies, histories and contexts exists in tension with our current taxonomic systems: productions are still, largely considered to be either national or international, and what is international tends to be considered either ‘Westernized’ or peripheral (Bydler 2004).

Analyzing artistic production in Africa (artworks, biennials, public art, art residencies, independent spaces and artists’ initiatives) helps us to question such binaries, and to realize that national and international, local and global, authentic and Westernized, project and work of art, art and development are not antithetical concepts, although they are so often presented as such. To clarify, it is important to debunk the assumption that the art system is simply made up of artists, curators, critics, dealers, museums, galleries and art collectors.

Project vs. Artwork: The Project System With Objectives, Activities and Expected Results

Contemporary artistic production is part of a system that determines its own characteristics and values. The system we are accustomed to is made up of artists, curators, critics, dealers, museums, galleries and art collectors. Yet, such a portrayal actually represents an incredibly small number of places, works and experts that are, together, commonly perceived as the center of art. The immense rest—because it does not fit—is considered periphery.

There are various degrees of periphery depending on the extent to which a certain place echoes the so-called center of art. When the periphery just does not work that way and lacks most of the components of the recognized system, it is believed that there is essentially no contemporary art in those places. However, as Maharaj (2002, p. 72) argues, there exists an immense multiplicity of production sites in Africa, Asia and elsewhere:

Developments in China, South Africa, India, Nigeria—sites of emergency and emergence—suggest several incipient practices, models and experiments, some hardly recognizable as art in terms of the gallery-museum system. But if they do not look like art, they count as art—spasmic, interdisciplinary probes, transitive, haphazard cognitive investigations; dissipating interactions, imaginary archiving; epidemiological statistics, questionnaires and proceedings; ructions and commotions that are not pre-scripted.

His description reflects an operating system of art that has grown exponentially since the Second World War—the project system. The initial model of the World Bank—disseminated through the key roles played by the Rockefeller Foundation, the Ford Foundation and the European Commission—has spread around the world through foundations and non-profit organizations and governments that have embarked on a strategy of funding based on objectives, activities and expected results which respond to needs. ⁷ The system based on projects has spread so widely and with such impact that even productions that do not receive financial support are talking about themselves defining objectives, activities and expected results (Pensa 2013). Regardless of funding, the transformation of artworks into projects has determined the discourse, the wording and the way artists, curators and institutions work. Institutions have had to adapt to the new system (a theater, for example, which does not receive state funding, has to produce projects: it has to develop outreach activities, educational programs, training and multidisciplinary international partnerships and so on. Artists also have started responding to new clients, interested in urban and economic development, social change, community building, integration, outreach and so on). This does not imply that the arts are no longer a space of experimentation, research and freedom, but it implies that the client is not only the collector (or the person looking for a painting for his/her living room) or the museum.

This project system is mostly present in the so-called ‘developing’ countries, where development contributions paid by international

organizations are an institutionalized component of the local economy which also supports, directly or indirectly, the arts. This presence has influenced the format of cultural productions and their operating systems (i.e., biennials, public art, art residencies, independent spaces and artists' initiatives) and it has enriched the international dimension of national art by reinforcing the links between countries, continents and areas of the world. [8](#)

Evaluating Development: Talking About Development and Social Change vs. Producing Development and Social Change

When it comes to art and social change, the first question to answer is, who asked that art should produce development outcomes? The contention that art produces development and social change is variously connected to the social role of art, to the requirements of potential grant-makers, to the specific national context that encourages artists to intervene and to the international context which expects artists to represent the geography of the world and their otherness. Talking about art and social change and doing it are, however, quite different things. In none of the cases mentioned earlier has art really been asked to 'produce' social outcomes.

The social role is framed by the intentionality of artists and groups and the theoretical stance presented in their statements and manifestos. To meet the demands of grant-makers, producing a project and then sending a report that states that the project has been carried out as planned will do. To claim 'engagement,' institutions, artists themselves, curators and critics just have to tell the story and emphasize the commitment of artists and works. So everything can be done simply by talking about development and social change, but not necessarily by producing it.

The project structure employed by grant-makers is self-referential and trapped into the logic of 'responding to a need.' What art *can* do is something really experimental and unexpected, but the way in which projects are structured and then evaluated makes it difficult to devise satisfactory indicators in this field (an issue addressed by other chapters in this book). An innovative method that the NGO Arts Collaboratory is trialing is to evaluate whether and how far an existing situation has changed

before and after the intervention of a project rather than assess the project itself. This evaluation system may reveal the unforeseen and changes and reactions triggered by the project, but from the donors' point of view, it is far more difficult. It requires a mid-term evaluation and transforms the project into a component of a process without a direct correlation between investment and outcome. Grant-makers prefer to focus on specific, measurable results: the number of people involved, training and professionalization, infrastructure built and economic productivity. The uniqueness of a work of art can be considered neither in the project nor in its assessment. In all other cases, specifically related to the world of art, the fact that an artwork produces development and social change is not a criterion of artistic quality.⁹ The intentionality of artists and groups and the story of the work are useful elements in order to understand, analyze and contextualize cultural production, but art can be valuable even if it does not produce development and social change.

The ability of art to produce development and social change may be relevant for the development community, but what art are we talking about?

Evaluating Art: Art vs. Development

The easiest way to assess art is within its system. So, how can artistic quality be assessed in the 'system' of development?

In disciplines other than art history, the problem of selecting artworks and analyzing their quality is that very different productions all end up simply being labeled 'art' (theater as therapy, popular art, workshops, painting, sculptures, public art, performances, school projects and projects promoted by local art centers and so on). It is possible to narrow the field through specific selections (carried out by cultural institutions, donors, exhibitions), entrusting to others the task of qualitative analysis of the works, but this approach is not common. More usually, a selection is carried out directly, not according to the artistic quality of the work, but according to its ability to 'produce' development.

Within this selection, the dichotomy between the national and international level plays an important role. Authenticity hunting starts there. The nationality of the artists, the place where they live, their education or

self-education, the materials and languages used in their works become particularly important as selection criteria, because they are easier to justify than subjective criteria such as artistic quality (which would require a legitimacy within another type of system).

Art Produced in the So-Called ‘Developing’ Countries

The system which frames art is a tangle of wires, in which disciplines and a series of national and international art histories perpetuate the practice of constructing knowledge around a line, where what comes next is the development of what was there before. It is a system which looks for homogeneity, it includes and excludes, and it defines centers according to what it knows, and it condemns to the periphery whatever it does not know.

Art produced in the so-called developing countries suffers a series of systemic problems. It is not much known outside its country, and its country does not necessarily invest in producing a process of national art exegesis and a strategy of dissemination. It is often supported directly or indirectly by international organizations, and its most used operating system is the project (something different from the system made up of artists, curators, critics, dealers, museums, galleries and art collectors), a situation which provides national art with a highly international dimension. When the art produced in the so-called developing countries is observed as part of the phenomenon called the ‘internationalization of art,’ there are three possibilities: it is considered nonexistent, it is selected according to its capacity to provide the viewer with a convincing idea of the nation or continent that it should represent or it is blamed for losing its authenticity and becoming ‘Westernized.’ Differently from cultural production elsewhere, art in these countries is often expected to be socially engaged or to produce development, despite its capacity of producing development being tangential to determining its artistic quality, and its artistic quality is difficult to evaluate outside the art system.

The System Error

Art which produces development is a ‘system error.’ It is a system error because it has artistic value and it actually produces development: two things which together do not fit into the current system.

‘Mobile A2K: Culture and Safety in Africa’: Research to Document and Assess the Impact of Cultural Events and Public Art on Urban Safety

Bridging art and development has been at the center of ‘Mobile A2K: Culture and Safety in Africa. Documenting and assessing the impact of cultural events and public art on urban safety,’ [10](#) an interdisciplinary research investigation developed between 2011 and 2014 by an international team of scholars in the fields of art, design, architecture, communication, anthropology and sociology and representatives of cultural institutions. The research focused on cultural events and public art produced between 1991 and 2013 in Douala in Cameroon, Luanda in Angola and Johannesburg in South Africa. The aim of the research was to document and assess the impact of cultural events and public art on urban safety. The research was implemented using literature reviews, field research, qualitative interviews, panoramic reports, case studies, visual representations and a comparative analysis. In relation to art and development, the research did two specific things: it applied by default on its content the open license ‘Creative Commons attribution share alike,’ and it observed the impact of art on urban safety.

Creative Commons attribution share alike is a license which allows anyone to share, copy and redistribute content in any medium or format and to adapt, remix, transform and build upon it for any purpose, even commercially. This license has two restrictions: the work needs to be attributed, and those who use it need to adopt the same license. Research produces background knowledge: literature reviews, interviews and documentation. This background knowledge is not the ‘core business’ of research, it is preparatory work necessary to build a theory or to provide evidence. In this regard, hard sciences and social sciences are very different: while hard sciences are aware of the value of their database for further research, social sciences rarely provide open access to background

knowledge (such as interviews and notes). Furthermore, in the field of arts, very few journals are open access and, in particular in contemporary art, most of the studies are published in copyrighted books rather than journals. Adopting open licenses is a start at unraveling the skein of art history. In a system which continues to trap knowledge around disciplinary and linear histories, facilitating reuse and remix is the first easy step in constructing communicating vessels. Furthermore, Creative Commons attribution share alike is the license of Wikipedia, the encyclopedia with over 500 million readers and the mainstream online reference. With its unlimited potential for articles and links, Wikipedia is a revolutionary tool to document the artistic production of the world. The sum of articles can allow our current knowledge constructed around disciplinary and linear histories to cross over and to relate to practices and institutions, with the effects of acknowledging the art produced in the so-called ‘developing’ countries and of providing multiple entry points to contemporary mainstream information. To sabotage the system that currently frames art is a necessity if we want to link art and development in a way that just does not construct a new disciplinary and linear history, and new exclusions.

Mobile A2K sought to study the unexpected fallout of cultural events and public art in the three contexts of Douala, Luanda and Johannesburg. The concept of safety—defined as livability, civil cohabitation and social cohesion—is deeply related to achieving a significant improvement in the lives of at least 100 million slum dwellers (Millennium Development Goal 7d), but it is not a direct objective, neither of the institutions and artists promoting cultural events and public art in the cities at the center of our research, nor of the public administrations, donors and grant-makers supporting them. Evaluating art by looking at a potential unexpected fallout allowed the research to avoid getting trapped in the expectations of stakeholders and internal evaluation criteria. The selection of the artworks at the center of the research was based on the art curatorial intent of the promoters; we didn’t explore artworks produced independently by artists or artworks produced without art curatorial intent.

The research started with the following questions:

- (1) How do cultural events and public art affect urban safety in African cities?

(2) Can we assess these changes as positive according to a group of factors?

The hypothesis was that art is a space for experimentation and research, not directly connected to urban safety, but capable of triggering unforeseen ways of producing higher livability, civil cohabitation and social cohesion.

What emerged from the point of view of art and development is that the ability of art to trigger unforeseen ways of producing higher livability, civil cohabitation and social cohesion is directly connected to its capacity of generating a system error. This error occurs in two different ways: inside the production process and inside the work itself.

Charisma Generates System Errors

The future spatial practitioner may, as suggested by Miessen and Baser (2006, p. 25) ‘be understood as an outsider who, instead of trying to set up or sustain common denominators of consensus, enters existing situations or projects by deliberately instigating conflicts between often-delineated fields of knowledge.’ As ‘an enabler, a facilitator of interaction that stimulates alternative debates and speculations’ (2006, p. 25), the personal charisma of this figure can generate a system error. When a community works with an artist or a curator, there is an opportunity to meet outsiders, [11](#) to discuss topics outside everyday life and to observe problems and opportunities from a new point of view. The uniqueness of the experience—enhanced by the charisma of the artist or curator who activates it—has the effect of sabotaging habits. Within a community, there may be representatives for negotiating with the government and with the institutions for development and cooperation, but when a work of art is produced, it can be difficult to determine who the contact person is and the debate tends to expand. When there is no ‘representative,’ the process of art production produces a new reference group. This phenomenon is particularly significant when the work is carried out in an informal neighborhood that is threatened by forced eviction. The process of creation and production and the need to negotiate the land and the maintenance of the work of art all become an opportunity for the community to aggregate around something new. The ability of the

process to produce a transformation inside the community is strongly determined by the awareness of the value of the novelty: if the process is to have an effect, the community must feel like a protagonist, the center of something exceptional. The awareness of this exceptionality emerges in several ways: through comparison with other people (the feeling of being involved in something that others do not have), through the presence of people outside the community (the feeling that one's territory is somehow 'attractive') and through the personal charisma of the curator and of the artist (who may have the ability to activate a community and communicate the value of what they are doing).

Personal charisma can also influence people's lives and decisions. The way an artist or a curator lives and works can inspire people to take new opportunities into account. This may be observed in the personal experience of some of the people involved in the production of the works and the creation of new initiatives arising from their experience.



Figure 61 Hervé Langebeur, *Les écrits de New Bell*, Douala, 2010, Wikimedia Commons.

The Artwork as a System Error

A work of art itself may be a system error, but to be perceived as such, the work must be visible. Artworks produce different reactions depending on the perspective they are viewed from. When the work is completely immersed in a place, it may not be visible; people notice new infrastructure or a better atmosphere, but they do not necessarily notice the work, its content and message. At the same time, placed in a square or in a roundabout, a monument or a very large work of art tends to be perceived by the local public as a public statement. The emphasis is placed on the client, the observation of the work focuses on the dynamics of power and its message tends to be read as political and ideological. In both cases, the artwork is rarely capable of creating a relationship with its observer, unless the observer is there especially to look at the work (as in the case of external visitors and tourists). To see the work, a certain distance is needed.

The perception of the system error is evident in the words of those who have looked at the work and commented on it. In the words of the observer, the work is both itself and something else, it is a bridge and the beginning of a journey.

Let me tell you about the power of art. For a person to think of building a bed in a park, in public view, I call it the power of art. Whenever we see a bed we think of the bedroom. But in a park... it is so unique. This is a blanket. The person who was doing it was so gifted. Thumbs up to the person who did this.

(Philemon Diale, City Power worker coincidentally at the Troyeville Bed, July 2013. Interview collected by Caroline Wanjiku Kihato)

Troyeville Bedtime Stories is a white sculpture located in a park of Troyeville realized by Johannes Dreyer with the shape of a bed. The work is maintained by the artist and the community, and it has not been ruined despite the park not being surrounded by a fence and having no security guards opening and closing the gates, like in other parks of Johannesburg.

Caroline Wanjiku Kihato refers to the capacity of the artwork to transgress borders. The subject of the work is at once intimate and public, domestic and social. As Caroline Wanjiku Kihato describes it, the installation peels off the layers of society—it blows up the boundaries between public and private spaces at once exposing the intimacy of romance and domestic violence, the mundane and aspirational, the alien and

familiar, reality and fantasy. The Troyeville bed is a transgressor, pushing the boundaries of official versus unofficially sanctioned art and crossing the line of what is visible and invisible in public space.

Le Jardin Sonore by Lucas Grandin is a garden built as a small building of three floors in height, where the plants placed in different levels are irrigated by a system that collects rainwater in a cistern and distributes it drop by drop into tins producing musical harmony. The building is artwork, infrastructure and botanical garden, and the third floor is a viewpoint over the river Wouri. The peculiarity of the structure located close to the homes of Bonamouti is that despite its functionality, it is an anomaly compared to other structures normally built within neighborhoods (wells, fountains, sewers, paved streets, bridges) and a garden in the city of Douala, where there are no parks or public gardens. Around it, a friendly place has been created where children play and people meet.



[Source: Photo by Sandrine Dole, 2010, work by David Courtes, Douala'art, Wikimedia Commons.](#)

The Need for the Exceptional

Art which produces development and social change is a system error. It is a system error because it succeeds in injecting new discussions and speculations into existing situations, it humanizes and it leads people to carry out unexpected actions. It is a system error because art is not requested to *produce* development and social change, and what produces it is not necessarily evaluated as *art*. So, once we have both—art and development—we are facing something exceptional.

The exceptional is the most annoying and relevant aspect of art in relationship to development. Art can be reproduced (Benjamin 1968), but it is not scalable. In the production of public art, we can highlight protagonists and aspects of the process and we can anticipate some of the reactions according to the location and the land negotiations involved, but we cannot define *a priori* which artwork will produce development and social change. It is indeed the capacity of being a space for experimentation and research which brings art to trigger the exceptional. When looking at ‘impact,’ it is never a direct cause-effect relationship. We can collect evidence that the production of an artwork has boosted the development of a site or neighborhood (new traders, higher value of land, maintenance, new initiatives, other people in the area imitating the artwork design and colors, presence of visitors, less criminality), but we cannot directly connect the artwork to the effect, because to do so it we would have to consider everything except ‘art.’

Considering art and development as a system error creates a space to acknowledge experimentation and research, beyond the assessment criterion for those who finance it and beyond the dichotomy of national and international, local and global, authentic and Westernized, project and work of art, art and development.

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Notes

- 1 Les Ateliers Urbains de Bessengué was a workshop with international artists organized by doual'art in 2001 in Bessengué. The artists involved worked in the neighborhood of Bessengué, producing paintings, sculptures, murals and performances. doual'art is a not-for-profit cultural organization and art center, founded in 1991 in Douala, Cameroon, and focused on contemporary art and urban transformation. *Doual'art*. Online: www.doualart.org (accessed 3 December 2015).
- 2 Bessengué City was an art project curated by Goddy Leye in 2001 in Bessengué. The project involved the artists James Beckett, Goddy Leye, Hartanto, Jesus Palomino and the local community in producing artworks. The radio station was the artwork produced by the sound artist James Beckett. Bessengué City was organized with the support of the program R.A.I.N. Rain Artists' Initiative Network and it led to the establishment of the art organization artBakery, based in Bonendale, just on the outskirts of Douala.
- 3 Bourne Fountain is a small building with a shop and fountain designed by the architect and designer Danièle Diwouta Kotto in 2003 and produced by doual'art. The design of the construction took as a model the shelter created by Jesus Palomino in the project Bessengué City.
- 4 La Passerelle is a bridge and artwork by Alioum Moussa, produced by doual'art in 2005 in Douala, Bessengué. The jury who selected the work included members of the community of Bessengué.
- 5 The SUD Salon Urbain de Douala is a triennial festival of public art organized in Douala since 2007 and promoted by doual'art.
- 6 Other expressions are used, such as global art or internationalization of the arts.
- 7 Related references can be found in the history of institutions, in reports and internal documents and in the wide literature associated with project management.
- 8 Among the international relationships supported by grant-makers are South-South relationships, networks, festivals, partnerships and exchanges. Please refer, in the context of Africa, for example, to the programs of Pro Helvetia, the French Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Goethe Institute, the European Commission, Arts Collaboratory, the Prince Claus Fund, Triangle Arts Trust, the Ford Foundation, Africalia, Young Arab Theatre Fund.
- 9 An interesting counterexample here is that of curators Clémentine Deliss and Okwui Enwezor, who have highlighted and framed two groups of artists (Laboratoire Agit-Art and Huit Facettes Interaction) in ways that emphasize the performative aspect of their practice. In both cases, their work is associated with development and social change. See *Seven Stories about Modern Art in*

- Africa*, (dir.) Clémentine Deliss, Flammarion, Paris and New York, 1995, and *Documenta 1 Platform 5: Exhibition*, (dir.) Okwui Enwezor, Hatje Cantz Publishers, Ostfildern-Ruit, 2002.
- 10 See *Mobile A2K Culture and Safety in Africa*. Online: www.mobileA2K.org (accessed 4 December 2015).
- 11 An outsider can be a person who comes from outside the community, a foreigner or even a member of their community perceived in a new way because of the situation.

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7

Imagining Development Through Dance in Fiji

Megan Allardice

This is what Fiji needs, another option, because everyone seems to think that doctor, lawyer, politician is where you go... but there's other stuff and there's other things that are better for our own development as a country.

(Patricia, personal communication, Suva, 2011)

The Arts in Development Thinking

In 2011, I entered a research process with the belief that culture is constituent of and inherent to development, a view supported by writers such as Arjun Appadurai (2004), David Simon (2006) and Amartya K. Sen (1999), and that much of the significance of the arts is lost if their potential for creating lives of value (Sen 1999) either is not understood or is de-prioritized. This position was based on my own experience in the arts, in particular working with and observing contemporary dancers in Zimbabwe and Uganda between 2000 and 2009. This research journey, however, centered on fieldwork that I undertook in Suva, Fiji. The research findings both confirmed my conviction that culture is inherent to development and led me to acknowledge and re-evaluate the counter view. This view, held, for example, by Radcliffe and Laurie (2006) and evident in the UNESCO discourse around creative industries and cultural economy, is that culture

also has an instrumental, and particularly an economic, role and is, in that sense, a resource for development.

Development studies itself encompasses a range of views of what 'development' is and approaches to achieving it. My own position is aligned to the 'cultural turn' in development, a movement that reflects a post-modern shift in emphasis from the hegemonic grand narratives of modernist development towards micro approaches and the recognition of diversity (Nederveen Pieterse 2010, p. 64). In this view, development is thought to draw upon tradition as well as contemporary experience, valorizing the complex and individualized 'maps of meaning' (Nederveen Pieterse 2010, p. 64) of all actors. The value of the arts is also located within aspirations for choice and freedom (Kabeer 1999; Sen 1999), particularly in terms of Sen's notion of lives that people have reason to value. Furthermore, my research looks to the cluster of approaches known as 'alternative development' for modes of 'doing' development that are driven by concerns for participation and voice, and therefore responsive to diverse human desires and priorities.

Although the cultural turn is generally concerned with culture in the broad sense, I also found it a relevant position from which to examine the narrower field of 'the arts,' an element of cultural practice that includes dance and other performance genres, visual and audiovisual arts and literature. This range of activities and outputs is embedded in culture but distinguished by the intention of the creator, their particular point of view and their attitude in relation to culture and the surrounding society (Pérez González 2008, p. 11). Sandra Weber comments that art 'makes us look' (2008, p. 44). It does so because artists reflect upon issues (which are always 'social' in some sense) and, through their work, crystalize and heighten or highlight these in 'instances of concentrated communication [that are] incisive and engaging' (Stupples 2010, e-interview).

A concern with the highly subjective area of the arts within an alternative development approach inevitably suggested a qualitative research methodology. Qualitative enquiry implies acceptance of both 'multiple forms and conceptions of knowledge' (Sabatini 2009, p. 116) and 'multiple forms of evidence' (Eisner 1997, p. 39). Thus, it answers the demands of alternative development approaches for recognition of place specific knowledge as well as multiple ways of knowing. In this chapter, I discuss my use of two specific methods within a broader qualitative methodological

assemblage (Law 2004). One method—semi-structured participant interviews—is widely used across the social sciences and the humanities and I limit my discussion to the findings from this method. The other—a creative dance workshop—is an example of an arts-based method. As I have found no evidence of arts-based methods being used previously in development studies research, I discuss the method itself in some detail before turning to the findings from the workshop.

Negotiating Cultural Identity in Fiji

Culture and the negotiation of cultural identity have been central to Fiji's colonial and post-colonial history (Gaines 2011, pp. 169–70) and have a continuing impact upon current attempts to build a multicultural identity (Ratunabuabua interview, Suva, 3 August 2011; Nilan 2006, p. 2). The inhabitants of Fiji had long had contact with other Pacific peoples (Anderson 2003, p. 36; Hau'ofa 1993, pp. 6–9), but the arrival of Europeans in the mid-nineteenth century was their first contact with others who were racially distinct, with a different value system and a different god. Although the initial European settlers arrogated (the best and most profitable) one-fifth of the country, they were deprived of local labor through a policy of 'communalism' for the ethnic Fijian population, administered through a system of indirect rule (Lal 2002, p. 153). The solution proposed to the labor issue was the importation of indentured laborers from India. This began in 1878 and 60,000 Indians had been brought into the country by 1916, when the practice was stopped (Anderson 2003, p. 36). Many of the laborers stayed on, moving into urban areas as small business owners and civil servants or leasing land for farming from ethnic Fijian owners.

While Brij Lal (2002, p. 157) claims that ethnic Fijians are very secure (constitutionally and legally) ¹ in their ownership of land and this contributes to a 'vibrant cultural identity,' Vilisoni Hereniko (2003, p. 78) perceives present-day ethnic Fijian fears of losing their land, and therefore their cultural identity. These feelings of insecurity have been mobilized in the staging of military and civilian coups. A perceived lack of protection of ethnic Fijian interests led to the overthrow of Prime Minister Timoci Bavadra, who was seen as a puppet for Indian interests (Hereniko 2003, p.

80) in 1987, and Indo-Fijian Prime Minister Mahendra Chaudhry in May 2000 (O'Sullivan 2011, p. 96). Both Rabuka, who led the coups in May and September 1987, and George Speight, the civilian leader of the 2000 coup, claimed to be the 'voice of the people.' However, the coup of December 2006 had a more intra-ethnic dimension, as Prime Minister Laisenia Qarase was accused of promoting an indigenous elite while ignoring the needs of ordinary Fijians (O'Sullivan 2011, p. 95).

The Arts as Research Method and Content

The main research participants were members of VOU dance company.²

Founded in 2007, VOU describes itself as 'a contemporary Pacific dance company, to investigate our Pacific Island identities within today's high-tech globalized society through movement' (VOU dance company n.d.). The company comprises Director Sachiko Miller, a full-time musician and seven dancers coming from traditional/cultural dance and contemporary dance backgrounds. This is a multicultural group that actively demonstrates young people from different cultural backgrounds working together and sometimes dealing directly with issues of cultural identity. Furthermore, the company members seek to promote dance and music as career options that will enable a new generation to move beyond the ethnically differentiated occupational choices that have been made in Fiji over many generations (Nilan 2006). As such, they are strongly engaged with their national context, and it is within the history of ethnic and cultural divisions, as well as current efforts to overcome these through policy initiatives to establish a multicultural national identity (Nilan 2006, p. 2; Ratunabuabua interview, Suva, 3 August 2011), that VOU dance company consciously locates its work.

In order to explore the contribution of the arts to development, I first asked how development was conceptualized by this group of urban, semi-professional dancers in Fiji. I sought to establish a participant-generated definition of development through the use of an arts-based method. Patricia Leavy (2009, p. 2) describes arts-based research methodologies as 'the merging of cross-disciplinary social science research with the creative arts.' By using arts practice as a direct means of enquiry and source of data,

specific arts-based methods seek out, enable or amplify a range of voices (Finley 2008, p. 74). Such methods are appropriate to enquiry into the arts themselves because the arts attempt to understand and express the subjective and contextual ‘qualities’ of human experience, and these cannot be understood meaningfully in quantitative terms (Knowles and Cole 2008, p. 67). I chose to explore the potential of an arts-based approach through the use of contemporary dance, which Donald Blumenfeld-Jones (2008, p. 183) describes as useful in social science research because it is not ‘circumscribed by a specific vocabulary,’ ³ but selects consciously from the limitless range of movement and other elements available to express meanings (Opacic, Stevens and Tillmann 2009, p. 1570).

The arts-based research method that I used was a creative dance workshop, a setting which was familiar to all the company members. The workshop comprised a ‘dance exploration’ to examine the participants’ conceptualization of ‘development.’ The vocabulary available to them through their experience as semi-professional dancers includes contemporary dance, Pacific and Fijian traditional dance movement, the Indian ‘Bollywood’ style and other styles in which they have received occasional training, such as Japanese *butoh*. ⁴ Drawing on this vocabulary, they were enabled, through the participatory dance exercise and follow-up discussion, to voice their own perceptions of development, particularly as it applies to Fiji, thereby adding to broader understandings of this concept.

Categorizations of Fiji’s level of development by international development agencies were shared with the participants. The World Bank lists Fiji as a ‘lower middle income, developing country,’ placing it 86th on the Human Development Index, the highest position in the ‘medium’ range (World Bank, 2011), while the United Nations Development Programme, in 2010, rated Fiji as having a ‘medium’ level of human development (United Nations Development Programme, 2010). In light of these descriptions, the company members were asked to explore the following through dance:

- (1) Their response to the descriptions of Fiji presented
- (2) Their understanding of ‘development’ as a process
- (3) Their vision for Fiji.

I asked the participants to:

- (1) Write down up to five ideas or responses to the discussion topics
- (2) Create a movement or short movement sequence to represent each of the ideas
- (3) Create a movement sequence combining all of their movements or shorter sequences.

Each of the participants performed what they had created to the others. After each participant had presented their individual ideas through movement, the other participants attempted to interpret the movement in an informal guessing game. Participants suggested a meaning and the person who had created the movement affirmed, negated (in very few cases) or added to the suggestion that had been made. The person presenting then performed their full sequence.

The exercise was concluded with a focus group discussion in which the participants reflected upon the content of their expressions in dance and their experience of the process. Other development issues that had not come up in the dance exploration were also raised and discussed in this session.

A Participatory Understanding of Development

I synthesized the responses of the participants into a definition of development that I believe represents the perspectives of this group of dancers. The contributions of the participants generated a complex and multi-faceted definition, although it is possible to identify common elements. 'Development' was defined as:

- (1) Engagement with the present and future, informed by the past
- (2) Unity and cooperation across racial and other barriers for peace
- (3) Self-sufficiency, including a return to the land and traditional lifestyles
- (4) Social and economic stability and inclusion as bases for growth
- (5) Freedom of thought and expression, and medium of expression
- (6) Integrity and transparency
- (7) Freedom from oppression and militarism
- (8) Active participation and engagement.

A few examples demonstrate the way in which short dance sequences were interpreted and contributed to this collective definition of development. Firstly, Joseph (the company's musician) presented a vision for Fiji that suggested 'engagement with the present and future, informed by the past.' Using props—two traditional Fijian musical instruments, a drum and a guitar—he moved between them to illustrate his relationship to modernity (represented by the guitar) and tradition (represented by the other instruments). Although his body expressed a need to reach the guitar, he was constantly drawn back by the other instruments. When he managed to engage with the guitar in its own space, he was unable to play it properly but, when he gathered the other instruments around him, he smiled and played a melodious tune.

The component of 'self-sufficiency, including a return to the land and traditional lifestyles' came from sequences by Eddie and Robert, both of whom used stylized but easily recognizable movements based on activities such as planting, cultivating, harvesting and using the produce. Thus, they reflected the movement vocabulary of the traditional Fijian *meke*.⁵ Likewise, Mereia showed that that Fijians were not experiencing 'active participation and engagement' but simply went with the flow through a sequence incorporating the gentle horizontal arm movements commonly found in Pacific women's dance, referencing the movement of the ocean. Eddie expressed 'social and economic stability and inclusion as bases for growth' in the Japanese *butoh* style, using small particular movements of the hands within an overall movement of the whole body from a low and grounded position (deep *plié*) to upright and fully extended.

Some of the dancers examined metaphors and current jargon. Sachiko, for example, conveyed the literal and metaphoric meanings of 'shooting oneself in the foot' as a way of demanding 'freedom from oppression and militarism.' Her dance sequence included movement backwards through space, aiming and firing movements as a reference to broader militarism, military rule and frequent coups, as well as exaggerated miming of someone actually shooting herself in the foot, accompanied by falls, rolls and vocalized swearing.

John looked at the possibility of Fijians exploring 'freedom of thought and expression, and medium of expression' to find creative solutions to the country's challenges. He explored the visual image inherent in the concept of 'thinking outside the box' by creating a two-dimensional box shape using

arm movements, then using his whole body to expand beyond this shape in every direction.

In the short focus group session that followed the creative dance exercise, one further issue that had scarcely come up in the interpretation and discussion of the dance sequences was raised, namely, economic development. It should be noted that I was the one who pointed out that economic issues had not emerged in the dance sequences. When prompted in this way, the participants suggested that Fiji needs foreign investment but is not currently favored by investors because of the unstable political situation. One participant also stated that Fiji is ‘not producing anything that anyone wants’ (Field Notes, 6 August 2011, p. 41).

The varied emphases of the dancers’ definition of development support understandings of society consistent with the cultural turn in development, as diverse in terms of values and desires (Nederveen Pieterse 2007, pp. 98–9; Simon 2006, p. 10). Although the components of the definition are not directly contradictory, they tend to go in different directions. For example, ‘a return to the land and traditional lifestyles’ implies a more static notion of the value of tradition than an ‘engagement with the present and future’ that is simply ‘informed by the past.’ Meanwhile ‘freedom of thought and expression’ and ‘active participation and engagement’ suggest development that does not necessarily have any reference to tradition or the past. Thus, the VOY definition of development spans the range of views within the culture and development discourse, from a bounded concept of culture (Nederveen Pieterse 2010, p. 65) to an understanding of culture as individualized (and free) expression.

Individualism is often viewed as a Western concept or ‘obsession,’ but Joost Smiers (2003, pp. 3–4) suggests that the right to individual expression may be tempered by a sense of social responsibility. Therefore, it is significant that a number of aspects of the participant-generated definition indicate actions and that the members of VOY dance company were at least as concerned with participation and engagement, as with the claim to freedom of expression. They demonstrate a form of citizenship that is expressed through direct engagement with society through their art work. This is in line with Jesús Martín Barbero’s (2006, p. 31) notion of ‘cultural citizenship,’ defined as exercising agency through cultural or artistic practice, implying reflection upon and critique of society. Even more evident among the members of VOY is citizenship asserted through a range

of ancillary activities that they are engaged in as a consequence of being artists and members of the company. These include teaching and creating opportunities for young people and providing role models through their public persona (see, e.g., *MaiLife* January 2011).

The Use of an Arts-Based Method

It is in the findings produced by the arts-based method I used that both the potential and the limitations of this method become evident. In line with the practical application of alternative development, the workshop was participatory and sought to bring out the views and voices of the participants. Specific to arts-based research is Weber's (2008, p. 45) assertion that it 'works well because we do not have our guard up.' This was reflected in the comments by workshop participants, that using contemporary dance as a method enabled and gave them the freedom them to explore (political) issues that are generally taboo and are seldom discussed in Fiji (Field Notes, 6 August 2011, p. 41). Specifically, this method created space for an emphasis, in the participants' definition of development, on political and social change at a structural level, as well as enhanced opportunities for citizens to contribute to such changes.

What did not come up in the dance-based data was the importance of economic development. In synthesizing the workshop outputs, I drew the sole mention of this (in the component 'social and economic stability and inclusion as bases for growth') from the focus group session following the participants' dance presentations, rather than from the presentations themselves. However, economic considerations came up frequently in the interviews I conducted with VOU company members, and it was clear from my observation that economic concerns (among other objectives) drive the operations of the company. Director Sachiko Millar told me VOU is a 'commercial group' and the company emphasizes both provision of an income for its members and creation of economic opportunities in the arts for others, particularly young people (Sachiko interview 2 August 2011; Joseph interview 1 August 2011). Their vision appears to encompass economic development, according to a fairly conventional, growth-based model that is outwardly oriented, enabling global or at least regional

integration. For example, Patricia spoke during the focus group session of the need for foreign investment, while Sachiko, in an interview, referred to the export of VOUE dance company's 'product.'

The Inherent and Instrumental Roles of the Arts in Fiji's Development

To a great extent, the partial mismatch between what the participants said about development and what they danced about development took me back to the model I had begun to formulate from the beginning of the research process. This is shown in [Figure 7.1](#). The model delineates the two different ways in which the arts contribute to development—a range of inherent roles on the left and two major instrumental roles on the right. Importantly, it also draws on McCarthy et al (2004) to establish the relationship between the two, namely, that it is the inherent values of the arts that create an expectation of benefit, and this renders the arts effective in their economic and message-bearing roles. ⁶

The data from the dance workshop led to a definition of development consistent with the values shown as inherent in the model. The dancers, in the interviews I held with them, also stressed some of these inherent characteristics of the arts, but, in the interview setting, they were equally concerned with the contribution of the arts to economic development (an instrumental contribution). Drawing together both sources of data, I found evidence of a range of inherent contributions of the arts to development. These are bracketed by Sen's (1999) concepts of 'freedom' and 'lives that people have reason to value' (enriching lives). Sen's contention that freedom constitutes development necessitates a repositioning of economic growth as an important but not necessary contributor to development. If economic growth does not add to the freedom and range of choices of citizens (or indeed circumscribes such freedoms), it cannot be considered as development. For individuals, this means the freedom to live lives 'they have reason to value' (Sen 1999, p. 285), that is, to make choices and exercise agency towards achieving their self-determined aspirations (Ortner 2006, pp. 151–52).

Appadurai (2004, p. 59) locates the capacity for aspiration within culture. Thus, culture is the basis of a concept of freedom, and there are also many instances in which freedom or choice, exercised as agency, take on cultural or artistic forms (see, e.g., Arias 2006, p. 167; Barbero 2006, p. 31; Sommer 2006, p. 2). Some examples of this are discussed in relation to the work of VOU dance company below.

The arts enable the expression of freedom, both in terms of the freedom to participate in artistic life and in the content of the work produced. Some specific expressions of freedom are: resistance, again through both the product of artistic endeavor and the act of participation; seeking inclusion,

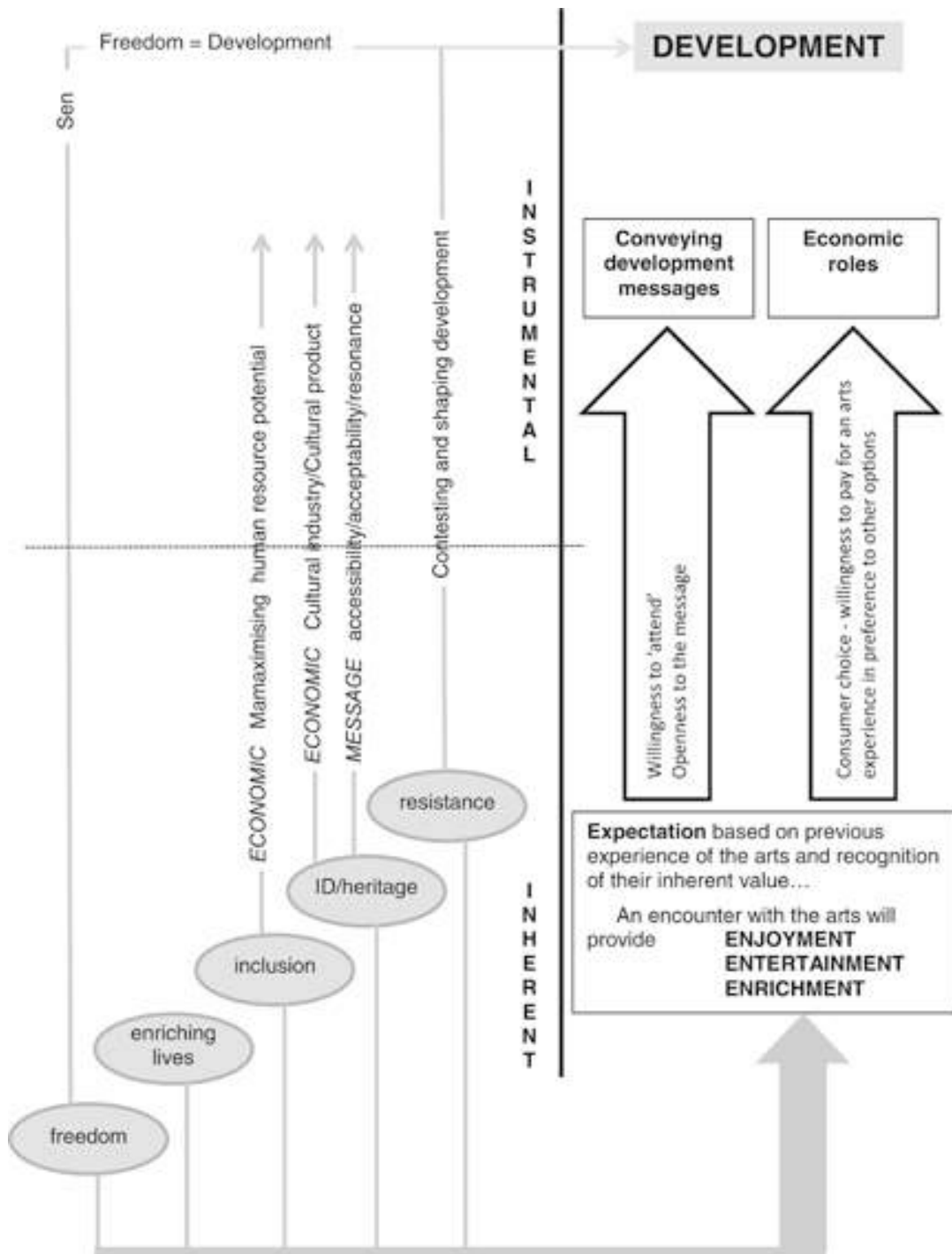


Figure 7.1 Impact and instrumental roles of the arts in development (2004) and Sen (1999).

with multiculturalism being of particular importance in Fiji; and the establishment, exploration and assertion of identity, as this is grounded in cultural heritage and contemporary experience. Overall, these inherent roles of the arts contribute, in the broader context of culture, to giving meaning

and value to the lives people live. Among the members of VOU dance company, the contributions related to identity and heritage were considered the most important, while notions of freedom or choice were both explicit and implicit in their responses. It is these two inherent values that I focus on here, and later compare to the respondents' perceptions of the economic value of the arts.

Every company member, including one of Fijian Indian descent, saw the assertion and/or preservation of Fijian, and sometimes Pacific, identity as the pre-eminent inherent contribution of the arts. All of the dancers stressed the importance of preserving (ethnic Fijian) traditional culture, particularly the *meke* dance form. Asked about the contribution that VOU dance company makes, John Peckham, one of the dancers, replied:

Showing them that Fijian culture is still alive because, in Fiji right now, we have forgotten about the culture... where we come from and everything that has happened in the past... and the dance that we used to do in the past... to bring it back to life.

(Interview, Suva, 27 July 2011)

The company has taken very seriously the learning of a *meke*, a dance performed by a group of people engaged in a social activity, such as fishing or going to war. Dancer Eddie Soro told me that the original function of a *meke* was internal, to give the participants in the shared activity psychological strength, and the *meke* are specific to the village they come from. In July 2009, the members of VOU traveled to Silana village on Ovalau Island, about 65 kilometers (by road and ferry) from Suva and stayed in the village for four days. During this time, they underwent a ceremony of three to four hours in which a spirit medium (the traditional custodian of the *meke*) conferred upon them the right to use the *meke* danced in the village, which demonstrates fishing activity. Eddie stated that the custodian was happy to teach them the dance, as the middle-aged people of the village had nearly all migrated to Suva and there was a fear that the *meke* would be lost. This has occurred in the context of very rapid urbanization, which has seen the population of Suva and the adjoining Nausori Corridor growing from 20,000 to 300,000 in a period of ten years (Huffer interview, Suva, 22 July 2011). A major forthcoming project of VOU is to record on digital video the *meke* from all the villages in Viti Levu and Vanua Levu, the two main islands of Fiji.

The other inherent value of the arts that came out of the interview data related to freedom. The participants recognized the value of both freedom of expression and the freedom to choose. I discuss the latter here using Naila Kabeer's (1999) term 'choice,' as this was the term generally used by the company members, but I assume this to represent the same aspiration as 'freedom' which Sen (1999, p. 5) posits as constituent of development. Choice and freedom are linked closely to the concept of agency. Thus, in the exercise of agency—making day-to-day and longer-term decisions about what the company does—the members of the company make choices on their own behalf and act upon them (Kabeer 1999, p. 438). Furthermore, in opening up dance as an opportunity for the company's own students and other young people, they create situations of enhanced choice for others. The vision of Fiji's Ministry of Education, National Heritage, Culture and Arts is '[a] national identity that celebrates and promotes Fiji's cultural diversity and unique traditional culture in all its forms' (Ministry of Education, Heritage and Arts. Fiji Government., n.d.). Art (as defined above) represents a means of engaging with and expressing culture. Despite the ministry's focus on economic development and the mandate of its agency, the Fiji Arts Council, to build a 'professional arts sector,' art remains an extracurricular activity that is not taught as a core subject in primary school. Therefore, VOU dance company's efforts to promote art as a career challenge the prevailing assumptions and practice (Ratunabuabua interview, Suva, 3 August 2011; Veikoso interview, Suva, 5 August 2011; Teaiwa, e-interview, 2 April 2014).

Reflecting on this, Patricia says:

I mean, they may not even choose the option but to just have it makes so much difference because they can know that they've made the choice themselves, the choice hasn't been made for them.

(Interview, Suva, 27 July 2011)

Agency is exercised by the members of VOU in the context of the cultural sector of Fiji. In this national context, characterized by 'suspended democracy' (Ratuva 2011, p. 106) and what some have viewed as military oppression, it is useful to consider Néstor García Canclini's caution against 'over-estimating the impact of the dominant on popular consciousness' (1992, in Nederveen Pieterse 2010, p. 70). I found in informal conversations that many Fijians view the current government quite

positively, particularly in respect of its efforts to combat corruption (e.g., M. Yee 30 July 2011; R. Stewart-Withers 13 October 2011). In addition, I did not encounter public shows of military power, such as military vehicles on the roads or personnel on the streets. Thus, many Fijians seem able not to allow military dominance to rule their consciousness. Indeed, dancers and other artists are part of a shift in the Pacific from a 'culture of survival to a culture of freedom' (Hereniko 2006, p. 32). ⁷ That is, the freedom of the mind and imagination to conceive, beyond the current moment and circumstances, of futures in which culture is not a place of retreat or regression, but the basis of assertion in Fiji's engagement across the Pacific and globally. In the exercise of 'cultural agency' (Arias 2006, p. 251), the members of VOU create cultural spaces and negotiate choices. These may not constitute a direct challenge to 'the dominant,' but they do ensure the sustained existence of cultural opportunity and artistic expression in a time of relative crisis which will form the basis of a vibrant civil and cultural space as and when the political circumstances change.

The economic contribution of the arts was the major instrumental role ascribed by the participants. As arts practitioners, the members of VOU dance company perceive economic opportunities both for themselves and for others, and regard opening up and raising awareness of these opportunities as a process of development. The contribution of the arts to economic development can be considered in terms of both employment creation and their economic output from cultural products. These two potentials are often combined in cases where individuals are employed in the sector and produce arts or cultural products. The company does not generally seek funding for its work, but attempts to support itself through the VOU Music and Dance School and through paid performances within the tourism sector and at diplomatic and private events. This has an impact on the type of work it does, ruling out large-scale productions, such as those undertaken (with funding support) by, for example, the Oceania Dance Theatre at the University of the South Pacific, and necessitating made-to-order commercial material. In the time that I was with the company, the female dancers spent two rehearsal sessions working on dance pieces to the theme songs of James Bond films, to be performed at a James Bond-themed evening event for a commercial client. While the company may not be enamored of such work, they recognize its financial contributions to their sustainability.

If, as Ashutosh Varshney suggests (2002 in Nederveen Pieterse 2007, p. 32), cultural identity is an outcome of ongoing processes of negotiation, then the arts as a means of expression represent one way of negotiating or one way of expressing agency. For the members of VOU dance company as well as for other artists in Fiji, there are two significant areas in which this negotiation takes place. Firstly, in their own lives and in the context of the company, the dancers of VOU make strategic choices about how they engage with tradition and what they draw from it. Eddie explains how this plays out in the work of the company:

VOU means ‘new’—yeah—so we’re trying to bring in something new... some new kind of style of dance but we also want to maintain that... identity, that culture of who we are. We are Fijians and also there’s a big number of Hindu Fijians so... our dance is a mixture of Indian, Fijian and the modern type of hip-hop and contemporary style of dance. So, we’re trying to maintain who we are but also bring in who we are now.

(Interview, 28 July 2011)

Thus, much of VOU’s repertoire could be described as ‘fusion,’ placing it within global trends in contemporary dance, for example, among companies in Uganda and Zimbabwe (Tangled Tribe 2004, p. 3) and dancers descended from other cultures working in the west (e.g., Norridge 2010, pp. 416–19 on the work of Akram Khan). Katerina Teaiwa (2007b) comments that, in the Pacific context, where cultural exchange is ‘layers deep,’ processes of fusion are internalized and contribute more to the formation of individual and group identities than do the nationalist prescriptions of states that are, in any case, perceived as weak and unstable. The resulting mode of expression, known as ‘hybridity,’ is represented by a dance piece by VOU dance company blending Bollywood (Indian) and contemporary styles (Sharleen, interview 27 July 2011) as well as an exercise I set for the company in which they created a modern *meke*, using traditional movement and music to comment on contemporary urban situations. VOU’s work, including involvement in music and design (see *MaiLife* January 2011), seemed to me to stretch from an inevitable expression of identities that are already ‘fused’ (Teaiwa 2007b, pp. 197–200) to more (self) conscious and deliberate efforts to achieve cultural relevance.

Secondly, the members of the company have to resolve issues of authenticity and commoditization that arise both from the type of cultural fusion that Eddie describes above and from their clear recognition of the

economic or commercial value that their work holds alongside its cultural identity value. Rotuman academic Vilisoni Hereniko notes that one response to the issue of how to make money is to sell one's culture.⁸ This is particularly relevant to Fiji, where tourism contributed 33.4 percent of the GDP in 2012.⁹ The risk lies in cheapening or degrading the culture when the same form is used but the meaning differs widely between local daily or ceremonial acts and commercialized performances of the same acts. Hereniko further suggests that a pragmatic response is to 'reconcile the soul with the wallet' and to attempt to achieve 'autonomy' rather than authenticity.¹⁰ While culture may be commercialized, cultural values may also inform or drive the process of commercialization (Teaiwa 2007a, p. 148). Control of the negotiation of this process rests with those for whom the culture is a root source and they determine the need that they wish culture to fulfil.

In making this determination, the company members are cultural agents, engaging with, evaluating and making choices about their diverse cultural backgrounds and which aspects of these cultures resonate for them in contemporary Fiji. They exercise freedom within the prevailing social and economic conditions, and it is in the process of negotiating these conditions that they give value to their own lives. Sachiko Miller states, 'I think it's made my life. This is my life. It gives my life purpose and meaning' (Suva, 2 August 2011).

Furthermore, they seek to create the conditions for others to live lives they have reason to value as well. For example, dancer Tevita Soro says:

The classes... teaching music to young ones... and dance. I guess before in schools, kids will be growing up thinking OK, yes just follow in the footsteps of everyone else. With VOU, now we've been doing the classes, we can show them that anything's possible. You can learn music, you can learn dance. It can be a career for them.

(Suva, 27 July 2011)

Conclusion

Both of the research methods discussed yielded evidence that the dancers perceive the arts as making an inherent contribution to development. They highlighted in particular the importance of the arts and their own work in

dance for the preservation of traditional culture as well as the creation of new hybrid identities. The dance workshop that I conducted with the company members took this further by opening a safe space in which they were able to examine and question the constraints they face and demand political freedoms. The respondents were more circumspect around political issues in an interview situation, but, in the interviews, they articulated the economic (instrumental) contribution of the arts to development much more strongly. Enabling them to do so also gave me a broader understanding of the potential contribution of the arts to development. The evidence certainly supported my belief that the arts and culture are inherent to development. However, I was also brought to a greater appreciation of the instrumental, and particularly economic, role of the arts, recognizing that it is the inherent values of the arts and culture—their capacity to enrich and give value to the lives people lead by providing choices and affirming identity—that underlie and make possible their economic contribution.

Notes

- 1 Security is granted, for example, through the Native Land Ordinance of 1880, which secured ethnic Fijian ownership of the remaining land, preventing further European acquisition and denying franchise to Indian settlers (Davie 2007, p. 261), and the establishment of the Native Land Trust Board (Lal 2002, p. 157).
- 2 VOU dance company. Online: www.voufiji.com/ (accessed 3 June 2011).
- 3 See also Jane Plastow (2009) on her work with women in Ethiopia.
- 4 *Butoh* is a form of dance theatre originating in Japan in the 1960s. As a purely physical dance form, it is characterized by distortion of the body to avoid classically beautiful forms and extremely slow, deliberate movement.
- 5 *Meke* is the term for a particular form of traditional Fijian music and dance specific to particular villages, and *meke* is used for celebrating community activities and stories. There are distinct female and male dances, accompanied by percussion and clapping.
- 6 Message-based use of the arts in development is an area of concern because of the danger of messages being driven or determined by donors. This is not discussed in this chapter because development donor funding for the arts is very limited in Fiji and VOU dance company is not often involved in message-driven work.
- 7 Citing Jackson, 2004.
- 8 This comment was made in a presentation to visiting American Field Service Scholars at the University of the South Pacific (USP) on 19 July 2011. Vilisoni Hereniko was Director of the

Oceania Centre for Arts, Culture and Pacific Studies (OCACPS) of the USP, Suva, at the time I undertook my fieldwork.

9 Calculated from data available from the Reserve Bank of Fiji (2013) and the World Bank (2014).

10 This comment was made in a presentation to visiting American Field Service Scholars at the USP on 19 July 2011.

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8

Anatomy of a Durational Project

Lanchonete.org, 2013–2017

Todd Lanier Lester

The term ‘expulsions’ is used by Saskia Sassen (2014) to radicalize our understanding of the ‘rising inequality, poverty, imprisonment, foreclosed homes and other injustices’ associated with increasing disparities. Expulsions take on ‘specific forms in each location of the world, and they have specific contents in diverse domains: economy, society, politics,’ which means they tend to be studied in their specificity, but Sassen warns that this obstructs them being seen as ‘the surface manifestations of deeper trends that today cut across the familiar divisions’ (2014). Such displacements, she argues, ‘share a simple, common element: There are people being (usually permanently) cast out of what had been their lives’ (2014).

For those of us who think about cities and watch for new urban phenomena, the relationship between the economic strength of a city and its ability to conjure mechanisms that dispossess and hide the dispossession of demographics within its overall makeup is not esoteric. Lanchonete.org, the focus of this chapter, uses art—and even the rhetoric of art—in a site-specific art project operating across the Center of São Paulo (Brazil) to encourage people-centric public policymaking processes that include those groups whose realities fall outside of the dominant culture.¹

Lanchonete.org can best be described as a progressive urban platform: a durational and iterative process involving activities that engage people, and therefore having a high degree of unpredictability. The platform is focused on a geographic area that is undergoing fast-paced change (given its

convenience and proximity to all major public transport options and important administrative facilities), characterized by aggressive gentrification maneuvers (henceforth referred to as *capital encroachment* to differentiate them from less aggressive forms of gentrification where policies serve as checks and balances). Also present in the Center of São Paulo, however, are countervailing forces that challenge this status quo of big business leading urban change. These forces include artists, cultural centers, anti-forced-eviction activists, cultural producers, community organizers, occupation dwellers and other citizen groups for whom Lanchonete.org offers both a sounding board and an opportunity to be heard.

Major cities of the world are increasingly characterized by contested (not just limited) space for a variety of reasons that include rural to urban migration, immigration and forced mobility. In this context, institutions, groups and individuals with the greatest social, political and financial power get priority access to ‘prime’ real estate and frequently disregard existing residents’ needs and desires as well as their vulnerability to spikes in the cost of living. Lanchonete.org acts as a reference to this global phenomenon, and it simultaneously proposes solutions. This platform amplifies good ideas already present in the Center of São Paulo, as well as those shared in dialogue with visiting artists and thinkers.

Looking Back

In 2005, I left the international humanitarian field after seven years of working around the world in areas of extreme poverty and conflict. I was disillusioned with a system I observed to hold national interests over systemic improvements. During that same period, I witnessed independent artists, unaffiliated to the big NGOs, doing the most courageous work in the same places yet not receiving acknowledgement, support and the resources needed to avert danger when needed.

In 2005, for example, while in Sudan working for the International Rescue Committee, I met Gadalla Gubara, the father of Sudanese cinema (then in his 90s), and his daughter Sara, also a filmmaker. They invited me to visit their studio, where I learned that the government had issued a decree of eminent domain ² to take the land where Gad’s film studio stood in 1998. According to Sara, the day of the decree was the day that Gadalla went blind. The

military used his studio as a dormitory, while his equipment and film reels were haphazardly stacked in corners, stored improperly and some destroyed. I came to know the Gubaras just after they regained the studio through a protracted legal battle, yet the land on which it was situated was still held by the city. It is widely believed that the city's demand of the land and its facilities was an attempt to silence the Gubara family, who was making a range of independent films challenging conditions in Khartoum (such as regular power outages) and the Sudanese state more broadly. Eminent domain—a tactic used all over the world to close spaces of free expression and censor alternative viewpoints expressed through art—was similarly used against a local painter and installation artist, Afifi, whose calligraphy shop was closed by the police after he installed an art piece that decried the poor conditions faced by local artists on a nearby overpass in Khartoum.

My reaction to these incidents and the broader phenomenon was to launch freeDimensional, an organization that provides safe haven to artists and activists in danger through a global network of participating artist residencies (see Joag and Lester, this volume). The freeDimensional approach started a movement within the artist residency sector, asking brick-and-mortar art spaces with hosting ability (apartments, spare rooms, staff capacity) to consider using those vacancies for hosting artists in danger. While Lanchonete.org is rather different than freeDimensional, it is another example of how the artist residency template can be stretched to fit the needs of a specific community.

Over a series of short visits to São Paulo (Brazil) beginning in 2005, I observed that the *lanchonete* (lunch counter) is a place where people from different economic strata share middle ground—if only to take a *cafézinho* and *pão de queijo* standing at the same counter—in an otherwise class-stratified city. Lanchonete.org celebrates the ubiquitous presence and porous, open-front and corner pass-through design of these lunch counters. The project covers the neighborhoods that make up the city center and the issues implicit therein (the state of housing, food and water sovereignty, transportation, political agency and access to municipal resources and to those available through corporate affiliations). Lanchonete.org is a complex and multi-faceted project, and while it is conceived as a platform (and an amplification device for diverse and marginalized voices), in what follows, I describe the two key cogs that generate its momentum: a cultural program (including artists' residencies) and a cooperative business (in the form of a restaurant).

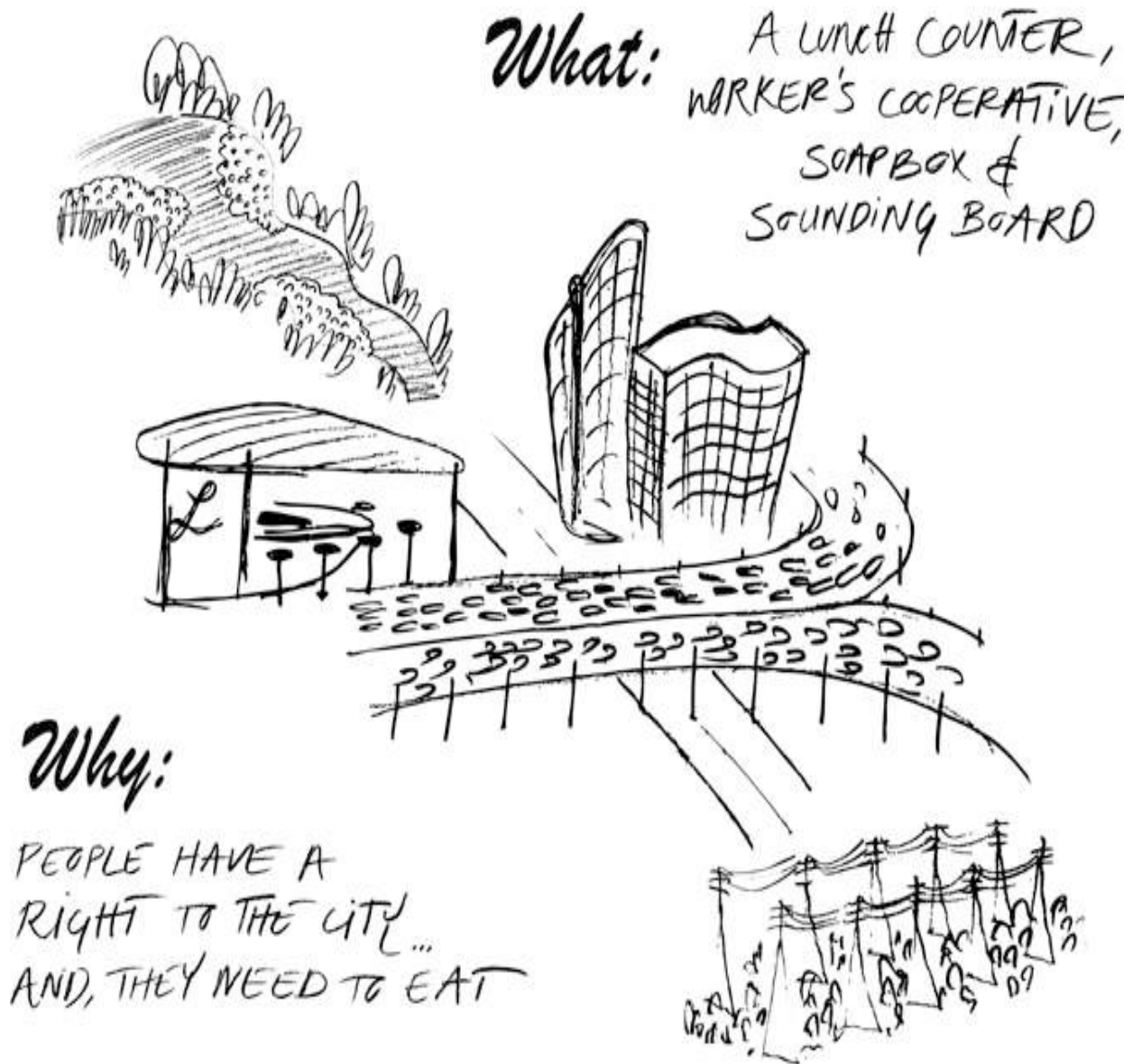
A range of contemporary events and phenomena currently shape the space of urban artistic engagement. The pan-western housing crisis of the last decade is still playing out, and it is joined by other events, such as the conservative turn of some governments (e.g., the Dutch), which simultaneously affect global funding for the arts. The response to recent natural disasters (such as Hurricane Sandy in the U.S.) has evoked a new urban vernacular of ‘resilience’ through which the increasingly instrumentalized culture monies (not unrelated in this sense to development funding) are tasked to solve urban problems in pronounced, utilitarian ways. Raquel Rolnik, UN Special Rapporteur on Adequate Housing and professor in the Faculty of Architecture and Urbanism at the University of São Paulo told me that one new development she sees is the role of cultural agents active in urban social movements. Projects are required to ‘quicken their pace’ to receive the capital support of funding bodies, a quickening that may effectively strip away—or pare down—the possibilities for genuine engagement. Nevertheless, this characteristic of the dominant market ideology frequently plays out in the political economy of philanthropy and donor setups, which are common interfaces to both the arts and development. By planning to shapeshift after five years, Lanchonete.org attempts to subvert the aforementioned bind on time in relation to observable impact.

What?

Lanchonete.org is an arts-based approach—imbued with a community organizing ethos and experience—that supports and amplifies citizens working for a just city. Lanchonete.org believes that the characteristics of a just city are attainable, yet enjoying the *right to the city* (Merrifield 2011) is not a static thing and may never be fully arrived at without incremental and new, outside-the-box approaches. Although Lanchonete.org is focused on the Center of São Paulo, in its specificity, it demonstrates a methodology for other cities and other contexts. It attempts to pilot an atypical organizational form, a cluster of associated people and organizations working together—members that don’t all have the same objectives and vocational backgrounds but share some basic values about, and aspirations for, the city.

Lanchonete.org is both restaurant and a cultural program, a business and an association. It is made up of people, just like the city itself.

Why?



Source: Lanchonete.org design by Adham Bakry

In the microcosm of daily life in the center of São Paulo, there is no one central issue that invites innovation, but rather, the cumulative causality of capital encroachment under the guise of gentrification as *fait accompli*, and

the set of conditions brought about by population growth and social service needs outpacing urban planning capacity. Lanchonete.org aspires to be a prism through which understanding and dialogue on issues, conditions, successes and failures that reflect daily life in the Center of São Paulo can gain momentum and flourish. Moreover, it aspires to be the engine for a citizen-authored feedback loop with the prospect of informing urban policy in the face of a beleaguered public discourse on diminishing public space. It seems that the usage of space in São Paulo is often a negotiation between people and business, with the municipal government often playing catch-up. A specific instance that demonstrates this showdown between people and capital, with the judiciary coming down on the side of business, is the injunction against engineer and community activist Ricardo Fraga Oliveira (founder of the Movement for the Other Side of the Wall) and his campaign at a construction site that required him to delete all references to the real estate development company from his Facebook page ('Court Approves Ban on Development Protestor', 2013).³

When?

Launched formally in 2013, Lanchonete.org will run for five years, from 2013 through 2017. Initial steps have included setting up administrative operations for the business, which will become a community-held asset by the end of the project, conducting research (via appreciative inquiry, public narrative framework and other approaches useful for understanding and building on local consensus), broad awareness raising and building a resource base both locally and internationally. The cultural program that includes residencies for visiting artists started in early 2014. Another central component, a membership body or association, *Associação Espaço Cultural Lanchonete*, has been founded to ensure that the restaurant and its cultural programming continue to reflect community desires and the diverse and evolving realities of people living in the center of São Paulo. The official 'art project' ends in 2018 in order that the cooperative project of this association may flourish, benefiting from art world resources, but unencumbered with limitations that can arise from a monodisciplinary, categorical or wholly grant-funded approach.

Where?

As São Paulo becomes more and more congested, the center, which was formerly perceived as a dangerous and blighted area (by some), has become coveted real estate for its convenience and accessibility to public and private goods. Along with this shift in perception, those desirous of relocating to the center for its convenience are encouraged to see occupiers and low-rent payers as freeloaders, even if they have settled areas and renovated buildings that were formerly thought to be unlivable. ⁴ It appears inevitable that real estate developers who bought buildings during the ‘danger’ period because they were devalued—and the capitalist system they represent—will push out the diverse range of mixed income constituencies that make up the center, for which the well-organized Occupations are bellwethers of change. ⁵

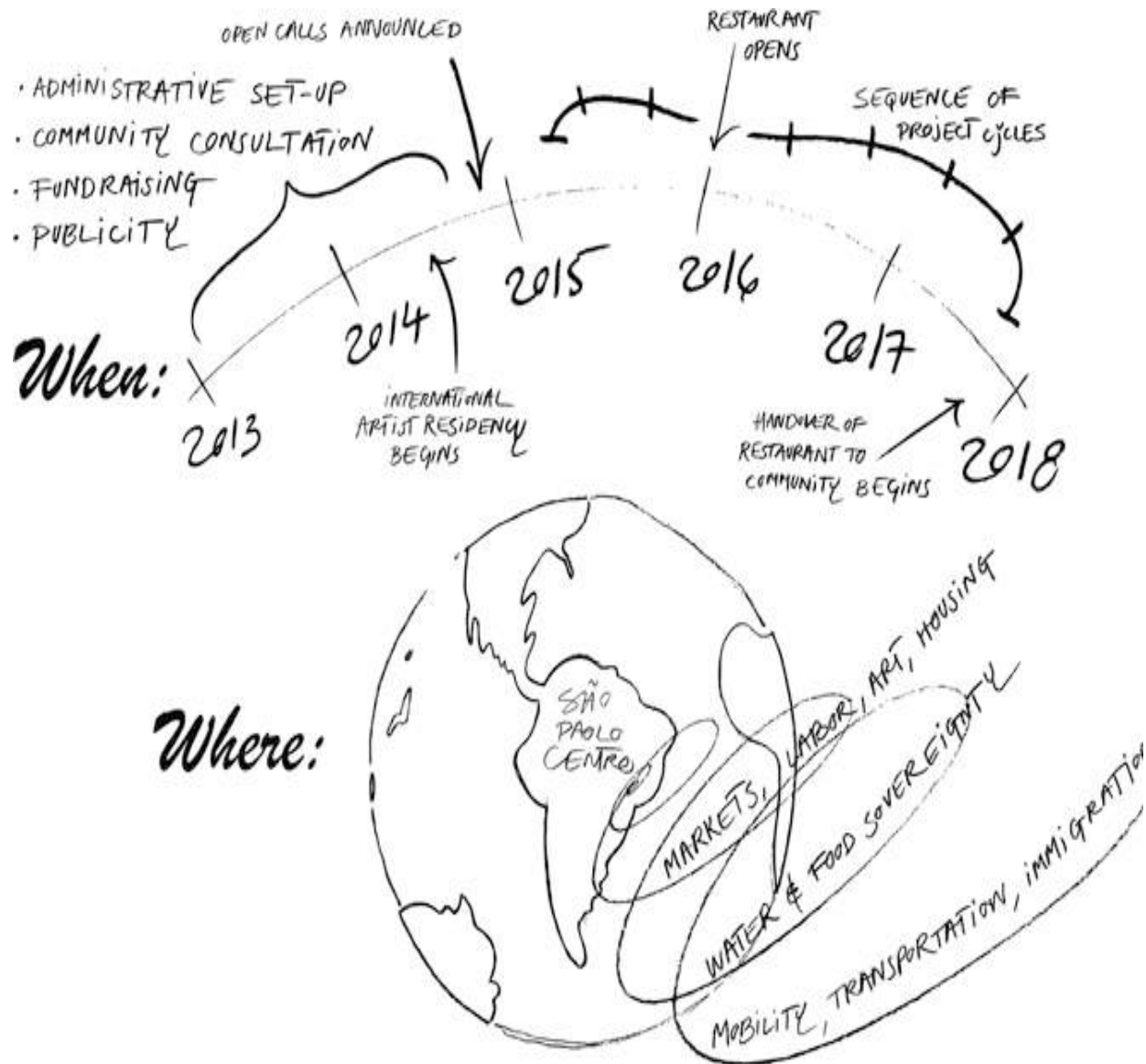


Figure 8.1 Lanchonete.org: when and where? Bakry.

How?

Lanchonete.org is interested in food as an aspect of culture and concerned with the broader, related issues of food justice and food sovereignty in complex urban environments. While producing food making as performance and setting up operations for a popular restaurant places a particular focus on gastronomy, nutrition and hospitality, these topics serve as an entry point for understanding and discussing the cumulative causality of class and labor on

urban, daily life in the surging city. This means that the food (of it) is both actual and somewhat of a trope. While we enjoy food and understand its relation to rights, labor and daily life, we are careful in how we deploy and encourage its discourse. 'Food-speak' is easily subsumed or coopted by the narrative of our 'hungry' market, and 'foodie' culture is deployed as an aspect of gentrification that also prices people out of their own neighborhoods. Furthermore, at the macro-level, global agri-business can be argued to be part of neo-colonial strategies that challenge food security and food sovereignty. Therefore, we are cautious about how we 'make our food' and careful that the process of identifying a location for the restaurant does not mimic the speculative market.

This is achieved by keeping the implementation process inviting and porous in order to accommodate new and changing issues as they emerge. By operating at a slow pace that maintains values of transparency and inclusiveness, Lanchonete.org seeks to amplify the different ways people claim their *right to the city*. The following can be categories as objectives, but we see them more as a code of ethics:

- (1) Enact food justice, equitable food systems and employment standards in a brick-and-mortar space (the restaurant) undergirded by a management and membership structure that reflects the same ethos and aspires for longevity in the community
- (2) Build durable relationships and partnerships to ensure that community desires, decisions, histories and consensuses are understood, as well as to access expert knowledge requisite for an emerging business in the hospitality sector ⁶
- (3) Amplify citizen voices and actions by forging new coalitions with guest artists and local artists, citizens and organizational partners, thereby enhancing solidarity on issues key to quality of life for all.

Who?

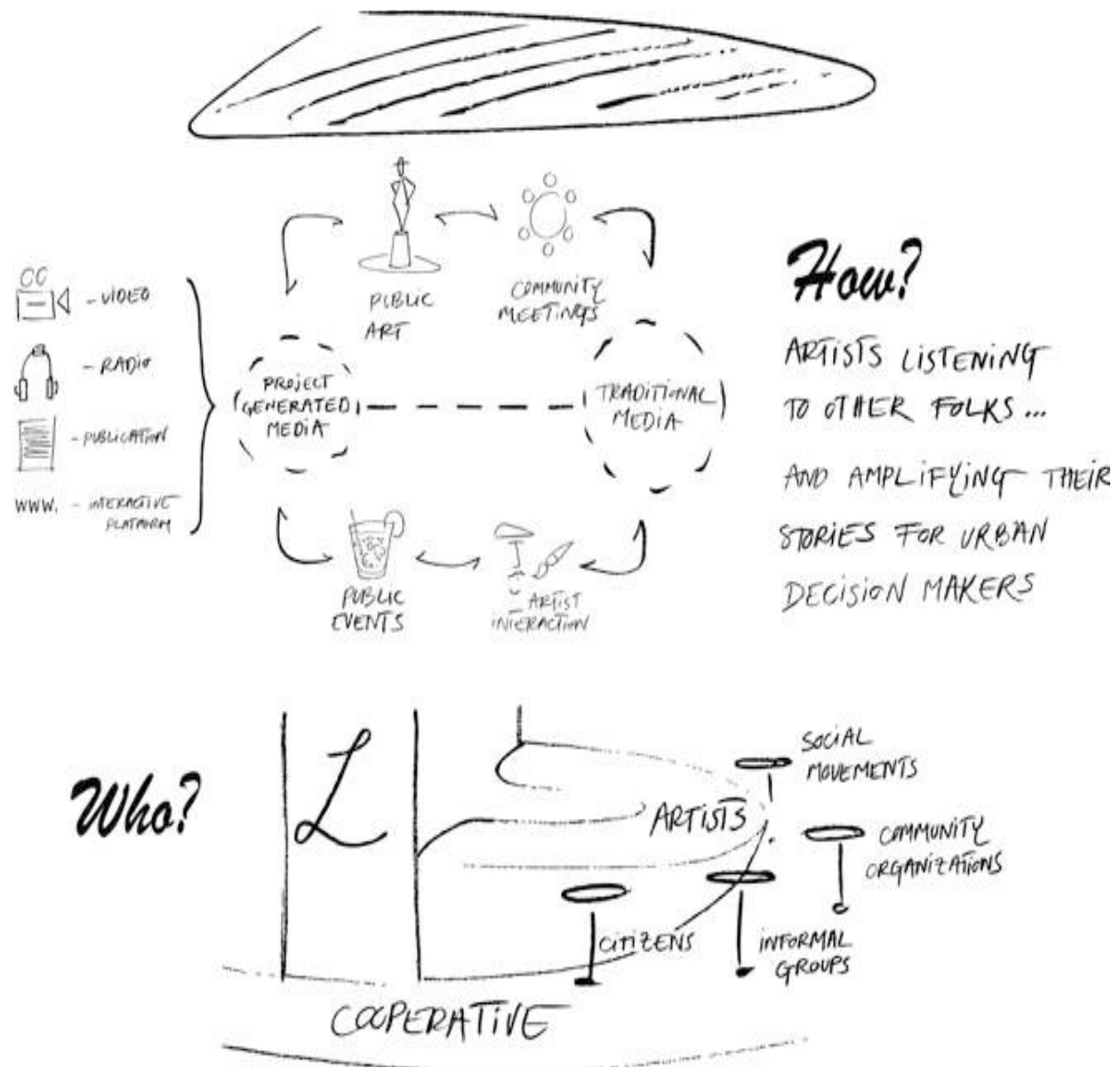


Figure 8.3 Lanchonete.org design by Adham Bakry.

Lanchonete.org works in consensus with individual citizens as well as community-based organizations and informal groups. The project was launched after extensive consultation with citizens and citizen groups (artists, food workers, occupiers, activists, gardeners and community organizers among them), guest artists, social movements, policymakers, local businesses, community-based organizations and educational partners in São Paulo. It also invites a group of international artists to reside in the Center of São Paulo and thus develop a relationship with its citizens (local artists among them), institutions, issues and patterns. The international artists

work in a cohort with local artists during each project cycle and are thus never on their own to interpret, decipher and ‘know’ the city. The artists constitute a bridge to a broader community dialogue, serving as catalysts that both ‘surface’ new information and insights and contribute to the project’s iterative design simultaneously.

Visiting Artists’ Program

The artist residencies are not studio residencies. Partner spaces (brick-and-mortar art spaces in the Center of São Paulo, [7](#) housing occupations, educational and cultural institutions) can be engaged to hold meetings and produce work throughout the residency period, and even exhibit that work in a weekend festival and exhibition that marks the end of each residency. However, the project seeks artists who are most interested and comfortable with the city as their studio and stage, and local counterparts as their guides to daily life in the center of São Paulo.

Each visiting artist (international or from another Brazilian state) stays approximately three months and joins a cohort with other participants. The first month is spent getting to know the Center of São Paulo, its citizens, institutions, issues and patterns, and meetings are facilitated between the residency artists and local artists, activists and organizers, social, urban-issue and arts organizations. The four guest artists are lodged in and around the center in a way that creates meaningful cultural exchange, such as with partner organization Occupation São João.

The artist residency is a vocationally specific concept of the art world and an accepted format for cultural exchange. Here, we use the acceptability of the format to streamline our fundraising endeavors, while simultaneously experimenting with how activists, researchers, architects and other thinkers who might not identify first and foremost as an ‘artist’ can benefit from the same qualities of mobility and exchange implicit to the format. Jakub Szczęsny, for example, is a Polish architect who was our first resident in March 2014 and lived at the Occupation São João.

Business as a Trojan Horse

While the most visible, tangible form of the project is the restaurant, the *Associação Espaço Cultural Lanchonete* is the backbone of the initiative. The association is the legal mechanism by which resources are attracted and held to implement the project, the primary mechanism by which community members (artists and non-artists, organizational leaders, youth and residents of the center) join and participate in the project and ultimately the mechanism by which the infrastructure and other capital assets are transferred to community members at the end of the five-year art project. The business is run as a worker's cooperative, and here the project is informed by inputs from outside the art world, such as the Rochdale Principles, a set of ideals for the operation of cooperatives, and the burgeoning global B-Corp (Benefits Corporation) movement, which is known as *Empresa B* in Brazil. The principle asset of the association is the restaurant. Although the restaurant will be accessible to the general public for regular meals during breakfast and lunch hours, at night the food service will be organized, themed and directed cooperatively by community members who have joined the association and the participating artists. These may range from special events to weekly community dinners.

Partners

Lanchonete.org works in partnership with food, youth and social service organizations, including Cities Without Hunger (Cidade sem Fome), GastroMotiva and the Centro Cultural São João of Occupation São João. Cities Without Hunger is a world-renowned urban gardening initiative operating in the eastern part of São Paulo, where unemployment is at the highest level. Teaching households how to grow produce in urban conditions provides both a healthy diet and income-generating opportunities. Cumulatively, the gardens under Cities Without Hunger management produce at a surplus; therefore, it is possible for a restaurant to buy directly from producers.

GastroMotiva trains at-risk urban youth to cook and become chefs in professional kitchens. It shares a very similar ethos with Cities Without Hunger, to first improve food preparation and dietary habits at the household level that, in turn, leads to employment opportunities and holistic betterment in families, communities, neighborhoods, businesses and the city. We

purchase our produce from Cities Without Hunger and hire our restaurant staff from the ranks of GastroMotiva trainees. Furthermore, the founders of both organizations are part of an advisory council for Lanchonete.org. Both organizations have expressed an interest in having a central location, or food lab, in the center for a variety of practical reasons; therefore, it has made sense to enter discussions with them early on regarding future usage and management of the restaurant facility. While these two organizations primarily serve constituents in the periphery of São Paulo, our partnership with the Occupation São João, a member of the housing movement, Frente de Luta por Moradia (FLM) is more focused on the center of the city, where there is a higher density of both population and the built environment.

In the phenomenon of forced eviction that affects millions of people at lower levels of economic agency, occupations are at the forefront because their legitimacy can be dashed with the claim of illegality. This *de jure* interpretation of the law does not account for the *de facto* reality (and complexity) of daily life in fast-evolving cities such as São Paulo. While land speculation both benefited from and fueled a ‘danger’ narrative in the center, occupiers have renovated whole buildings to livable states whereby they could more easily get to their jobs and enjoy convenience in this sprawling city. Simply put, they used things that were not being used. Through the normalizing effect of daily use, occupiers (and the larger socio-economic demographic that they represent) helped the inner city of São Paulo to be perceived as livable again, even if they are the first to be priced out and even if their methods are no more or less legal than those of the speculators able to pad the pockets of politicians for favorable prices on city-owned buildings and favorable zoning decisions (the same system deploys police forces willing to remove ‘occupiers’ from their homes in the middle of the night as one tactic when that property is ready to be ‘turned’ into something more luxurious). Working with the occupation movement has been useful in understanding issues at play in the Center of São Paulo from a group of people affected acutely and immediately by capital encroachment.

While Occupation São João is a single site and constituent member within the constellation of São Paulo-wide housing movements, of which the FLM is only one, it is a dynamic example for the following reasons: it is women-led, of small size (170 people, 60 families), is relatively homogeneous (most come from the same part of the periphery) and, perhaps most importantly, strategically innovative. Knowing that they are unlikely to ever be seen as legal tenants, they have found ways to ‘inch’ forward in claiming their right

to be there by leading the process of landmarking their building, the historic Columbus Hotel. Additionally, the Occupation has created the Centro Cultural São João, a unique art space that is open to the broader community providing space for language lessons; LGBT, immigrant and other group meetings; church services; sport and Capoeira instruction, among others.

The Prospect of an Alternative Policy Process

A city has many different stories, yet sometimes decision-makers need help hearing them all. The old lunch counters in the center of São Paulo and across the vast city typically have open fronts rather than doors, making them porous and easy to enter or pass through. These ubiquitous pedestrian meeting and service ‘points’ and their longstanding, popular tradition present an alternative to the homogenizing effect of capital encroachment on public space. Lanchonete.org is an art project that eventually takes on a physical form—in the shape of a popular restaurant—as a symbolic reference to the possibility of diverse groups and classes co-existing in the urban space. In this context, there are some big questions that the unfolding project asks of itself and that ricochet among its participants and peers:

- (1) Can diverse neighborhoods persist and survive in close proximity to the epicenters of capital?
- (2) Is it possible for the resources marshaled by a durational, site-specific art project to stay in that community after the ‘art project’ has ended?

Presently, the art world is enduring what I see as a market-driven fascination with social art. What this seems to mean on the ground is that community processes that are led by artists or are regarded *as* art are expected to reveal themselves faster than the life cycle of a community organizing endeavor. Therefore, to be both requires a steadiness that rebuffs capitalist tendencies, which are common in the art world, and not uncommon to other project-based sectors, such as international development.

The durational project is broken into three-month cycles that include a range of activities surrounding the visit of guest artists and their collaboration with local counterparts. At the end of the first three months, there are collaborative workshops designed by community members with

guest and local artists in easily accessible venues throughout the center, such as (but not limited to) the restaurant itself. Open to the public, the workshops constitute a mode and sequence of engagement that leads up to a final series of events, like a weekend festival of dialogue, art exhibition of local and international artists and related programming that will continue for the following month, often overlapping the first month of the next project cycle. To date, we have experimented with the workshop form, and themes have included urban mobility, access to water and urban waterways, home and forced eviction, youth and cultural movement, food systems and food justice, and education, as well as urban planning and citizen engagement broadly. Local curators and writers are engaged to document new insights and information from the overall process including these events, which are widely publicized, free and open to the public.

Documentation of the process, topics and results are archived on an eponymous website and, additionally, shared via a range of accessible formats (publications, media stories, audiovisual outputs, policy papers etc.) at the end of each project cycle. This constitutes a process whereby citizens and local partners ‘see’ their ideas and input interpreted by the participating artists and strategically relayed to the broader public and decision-makers through dynamically produced events as well as formal and informal media channels.

Conclusion

The success of Lanchonete.org will be measured by how effectively connections are supported (in the restaurant and on the project) across socio-economic class levels and areas of interest. It is hoped that people who do not benefit from the art world will derive value and meaning from the project in practical and even immediate ways that respond to their own needs and desires. Occupation São João, for example, has already told us that collaboration with international artists and cultural producers lends credibility to their approach, and the use of cultural strategy can potentially ‘build a bridge’ between people who come to the center to occupy abandoned buildings, seeking a better and more convenient way of life, and those now who ‘come down from Paulista’ and may have negative

impressions of occupiers, ethnic enclaves, informal groups and low-rent payers propagated by mainstream media.

It is hard to argue with urban plans that promise convenience, improved standards of living and beautification of the built environment (both public and private); however, these aspirations are often future-oriented and do not assure that the incremental changes necessary to achieve them will be easy on the population currently living in areas under heavy speculation. Without fail, when government, politicians and urban planners start to consider such projects, commercial interests are drawn like moths to flame, interests that do not normally take humanistic approaches to redevelopment without a system of checks and balances, including specific policies and the accessibility of the policymaking apparatus in situ.

The approach of Lanchonete.org is to make a durable platform that is artist-led, people-centered, inclusive and horizontal. This platform is being made for and with a specific community and relies on a variety of ingredients from the fields of journalism, community organizing, urban planning, architecture, design, politics, gastronomy, the policy sciences, the humanities and art in all its forms. A recent focus, for example, on the impending water crisis in São Paulo included an art gallery show (Kunsthalle São Paulo 2015), an opinion piece in a major news outlet (Hydrotropism: Lessons from Ficus Elastica 2015) and public meetings between artists and a range of other professionals.

There are many examples that share a similar DNA to this approach, such as arte/cidade, an occasional project by local São Paulo philosopher, Nelson Brissac Peixoto; the newer El Departamento de Comida in Puerto Rico; and a range of historic media and cultural initiatives known to have disrupted the status quo of dominant culture in other locations, such as the Fogo Process and participatory video more broadly.⁸ We believe that this approach works on a variety of levels (individual, institutional, artistic and so on), and that ultimately, coffee and food that is good and cheap, as well as a feedback loop that adequately represents and amplifies the daily lives and concerns of people living in the center, are both achievable.

Notes

- 1 Associação Espaço Cultural Lanchonete is a non-profit entity in Brazil. It has a president and three counselors, all of whom are Brazilian citizens living and working in the cultural sector. [Lanchonete.org](http://lanchonete.org) was originally conceived by Todd Lanier Lester, who works with a dynamic team of cultural producers—Joel Borges, Isabel Gandia, Lorena Vicini and Raphael Daibert—and the broader associations, who have added their ideas and modifications along the way.
- 2 Variouslly called compulsory purchase or acquisition, resumption or expropriation in other parts of the world to indicate the right of the state to take private property for public use.
- 3 See: http://www.article19.org/resources.php/resource/3756/en/brazil:-court-approves-ban-on-development-protestor?utm_source=ARTICLE+19+Mailing+List&utm_campaign=315cc6fa38-Free+Expression+23+May&utm_medium=email&utm_term=0_c3bf82663f-315cc6fa38-209348197%20%28accessed%2015%20September%202015%29.
- 4 I use the term ‘renovated’ here in juxtaposition to the more frequent notion of beautification as ‘projects... undertaken by city councils to refurbish their downtown areas, in order to boost tourism or other commerce.’ *Wikipedia*, s.v. Beautification. Online: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Beautification (accessed 15 September 2015).
- 5 [Lanchonete.org](http://lanchonete.org) works closely with Occupation São o Joao and the FLM, which is the movement of São o Paulo’s occupations.
- 6 Cities Without Hunger and GastroMotiva met through the [Lanchonete.org](http://lanchonete.org) project, thus confirming that one role of the project can be to make essential introductions. We feel this is an important role because often when people and organizations are claiming their rights to the city in limited-resource settings, there is an automatic default to working in isolation. We seek to build new alliances through this project.
- 7 Such as those organized through Circuito Centro. Online: www.circuitocentro.org (accessed 15 September 2015).
- 8 arte/cidade. Online: www4.pucsp.br/artecidade/ (accessed 15 September 2015). Challenge for Change The Fogo Process. National Film Board of Canada. Online: coolstudios.com/576/pdf/Challenge%20for%20Change%20-%20The%20Fogo%20Process.pdf (accessed 15 September 2015). El Departamento de la Comida. Online: eldepartamentodelacomida.com (accessed 15 September 2015).

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Part Three

The Practical Dynamics of Art and Development

9

Using Art to Fight HIV/AIDS in Uganda

Lilian M. Nabulime and Cheryl McEwan

Introduction

Since the 1990s, Uganda has made dramatic improvements in reducing HIV/AIDS prevalence rates and has been at the forefront in the global fight for disease prevention, awareness and advocacy. However, ignorance and stigma attached to the disease has not been entirely eradicated and, as in many countries in East Africa where prevalence rates had also either declined or remained stable in recent years, the number of HIV/AIDS infections is again rising. Although the picture is complicated by regional, gender and age group differences, the UNDP states: ‘Infections are now on the rise in Uganda, with an estimated 130,000 new infections annually. This is close to the total number of infected people at the height of the epidemic in 1994’ (2013). This is partly because of growing complacency concerning the disease, especially among young people (Kidimu 2009), but is also a possible consequence of the influence of external donors (especially the U.S.) in shifting government policy towards abstinence. According to the most recent UNAIDS survey, prevalence rates among Ugandans between the ages of 15 and 49 now stand at 7.3 percent and are even higher in women, at 8.3 percent, up from 6.4 percent in 2004–2005 (UNAIDS 2011). As in most sub-Saharan countries, Ugandan women are particularly vulnerable, with consistently higher prevalence rates being reported;

women in urban areas have higher prevalence than those in rural areas (11% versus 8%) (UNAIDS 2008, 2011). Patriarchal cultural and social relations mean that women lack the capacity to negotiate safer sex. Associated stigma means that they often delay seeking diagnosis and treatment, which renders the disease more difficult to treat. Women are put at greater risk by cultural practices, including female circumcision, polygamy and ritual sex (Sengendo and Sekatawa 1999), as well as by sexual abuse. Poverty and lack of education mean that for many women, sexual relationships are a means of achieving economic security, either through selling sex for money or goods and services, or forming long-term relationships with men (Nabulime and McEwan 2011).

Attempts to deal with HIV/AIDS in Uganda are complicated by the fact that there are over fifty different ethnic groups, many of whom possess their own language and cultural practices. In addition, nearly half of all women are illiterate, with a significant gender gap in literacy levels (UNDP 2009). Thus, despite relatively high levels of HIV/AIDS knowledge, risk perception and risk avoidance options, economic, social and cultural factors mean that women remain most vulnerable to the epidemic.¹ In countries like Uganda, where there have been substantial public education programs, awareness of the disease and how it is spread is not always the major problem. This is especially the case in urban areas, although lack of awareness does persist in poorer, rural areas, where literacy rates are low. Of critical importance are the taboos surrounding discussion of sex and sexuality and the related inability of women to exercise control of their sexuality within patriarchal societies (Ankrah et al. 1994). Lack of knowledge and skills, cultural norms and taboos are regularly reported as barriers to open dialogue, making it difficult for women and men, and parents and young people, to discuss sex, HIV/AIDS and prevention (Bastien, Kajula and Muhwezi 2011). In this context, it is important to find innovative ways of combating stigma and preventing disease transmission. Improving economic conditions in sub-Saharan Africa is clearly of importance in reducing HIV/AIDS infections. However, enabling dialogue between women and men about the taboo subjects of sex and sexual disease is, we argue, equally significant in reducing infection rates. The utility of art in facilitating this dialogue is the central concern of this chapter.

In this chapter, we report on an ongoing project that seeks to use art as a means to stimulate discussion about HIV/AIDS between women and men in

Uganda. It emerges from collaboration between an artist and a social scientist to rethink art—specifically sculpture—as not only an object of attention, but as an instrument of education, dialogue and social and cultural change. While NGO practitioners have long made use of props in HIV/AIDS prevention (e.g., wooden phalluses to demonstrate proper use of condoms), we illustrate how art can go beyond education in breaking down taboos and facilitating dialogue between women and men about HIV/AIDS. We illustrate how the sensory properties of sculpture enable it to move beyond the visual into the social in ways that make it a valuable tool in the fight against HIV/AIDS, specifically through its abilities to bring women and men together in dialogue. We make a case for the utility of art forms in generating dialogue, especially in contexts where literacy rates are low or in communities where modes of communication and information sharing are predominantly orate.

Art and HIV/AIDS Prevention: Experiments in Sculpture as Social Practice

It has long been acknowledged that HIV/AIDS usually affects those who are hardest to reach through conventional print and broadcast media channels: impoverished, uneducated and rural people (UNESCO 2001). For this reason, indigenous and predominantly visual and/or oral forms of communication (e.g., dance, drama, drums and storytellers, flipchart illustrations and posters) are considered most appropriate for disseminating information (Mushengyezi 2003). These methods have been widely and successfully used by NGOs in Uganda (Barz 2001), not least because they require cheap and readily available equipment. Despite this, art has been less commonly used to raise awareness about HIV/AIDS in Uganda, and in Africa generally, than it has been elsewhere (Wells, Sienaert and Connolly 2002). With the exception of the work of Francis Ssekyanzi, who was commissioned by the government to sculpt a relief panel in Kampala to raise awareness of HIV/AIDS in 2002, sculpture has not been considered an effective tool through which to engage with Ugandan communities about the disease. This is primarily because sculpture uses forms (e.g., woodcarving) and idioms (e.g., realism) that are unfamiliar to many

Ugandans, and sculptures are often heavy, expensive to produce and not easily reproduced or transported.

The research informing this chapter seeks to use sculpture in new ways, specifically as a form of social practice to generate social change. The idea that art has potential to transform society is not new, but is under-explored in the context of development. The idea of social sculpture, which foregrounds the social, cultural and political function and potential of art, derives in part from the work in the 1960s of German sculptor and performance artist Joseph Beuys (Morgan 2003; Rosenthal 2005). Beuys stressed the critical role of the artist in developing an expanded notion of art through interdisciplinary working that facilitates dialogue and creative agency in transforming people's lives. In bringing this notion of social sculpture to bear on HIV/AIDS prevention, we draw inspiration from Beuysian interdisciplinary collaborations by new genre public artists and academics (e.g., Cook et al. 2000; *Social Sculpture Research Unit* 2012), which promote the idea that the spaces of art should provide for the development and dissemination of ideas, a democratic arena, an active place for spectacle, celebration, dialogue, engagement and the transformation of public attitudes (Corrin and Gonzalez-Torres 2002). In particular, we are inspired by the idea of involving the public in art to facilitate social change.

In this research, we aimed to take art into communities, drawing in viewers as participants in the creation of meaning and interpretation of the sculptures, allowing them to participate in the development of the sculptures by commenting at various stages on their effectiveness as tools of communication, encouraging them to handle the sculptures and even take them home. The research also draws on traditions of Ugandan performance and musical art that entertain while simultaneously informing participants/observers about significant social issues. This socially oriented practice seeks to use sculptural forms either created from or inspired by domestic objects. The aim is to use art to break down taboos preventing women and men discussing HIV/AIDS, to produce sculptural forms inspired by and attuned to the specificities of Ugandan cultures and to explore their uses in creating dialogue, new methods of engagement and modes of intervention in the context of HIV/AIDS awareness and prevention.

The need to make the sculptures socially oriented and to closely involve target groups in partnership became apparent in the early stage of the research. This was critical in creating a sense of ownership, encouraging openness in discussion of HIV/AIDS and counteracting the deleterious effect of taboos in discussing sex. Pilot studies sought feedback on the effectiveness of various kinds of art forms (including masks and sculptures made of soap and referencing everyday objects) from potential target groups and those working with them. The latter included a Ugandan-run charity in London (Innovative Vision Organisation (IVO)), which, until its recent closure, supported women living with HIV/AIDS, thirteen HIV/AIDS organizations in Kampala and focus group discussions in rural Uganda. Responses provided key issues to reflect upon while developing the sculptures. Suggestions from IVO included: 'More effective HIV/AIDS prevention should start at home. Use forms associated with or adaptable to daily use or domestic rituals'; 'Use symbols that provide a constant reminder of HIV/AIDS'; 'Use measures that are persuasive, entertaining and educative based on experiences of women infected by HIV/AIDS.' Discussants felt that using art would be particularly effective: 'African culture believes in seeing and touching, therefore effective art says more than words'; 'Through images messages can be interpreted. A visual image sticks in the memory... It engages the attention more immediately than literature. Illiterate people too can observe and understand.' Similar points emerged from women's groups in Uganda, for example: '[art] can convey messages that are balanced, creative and entertaining. When I see I understand; when I hear I forget.'

Feedback confirmed that symbolism and metaphor are more appropriate than literal, descriptive or documentary imagery (Nabulime and McEwan 2011). For example, an installation entitled 'Vulnerability' ([Figure 9.1](#)) using sculptures representing baskets demonstrated that most women participants understood what was being communicated through the daily practice of straining flour. The installation comprises twenty bowls composed of basketry made of scrim, pigment, nails, latex, foil and food wrapping. Open vessels are used to refer to female physiology, with open-weave hessian scrim representing the porosity of the human body. Four of the baskets use diverse materials to communicate different meanings: one is painted red with nails protruding from the inside, communicating danger and pain; another is lined with latex to illustrate how hessian bowls can be

rendered impermeable, a metaphor for condom use; other bowls are covered in tin foil and food wrapping material, referring to the unreliability of improvised alternatives. Some bowls are upside down, suggesting abstinence. 'Vulnerability,' and similar sculptures, such as a meter-high wooden sculpture entitled 'Mortar and Pestle,' facilitated discussions about HIV transmission, bodily fluids, sexual anatomy, condom use and safe-sex practices that are otherwise difficult to discuss. Through the use of these sculptures, women visualized the virus in more tangible ways, and the discussions provided valuable insights into their knowledge of HIV transmission. In turn, this offered scope for practical interventions, specifically around the need for women to be able to negotiate safer sex.



[Source 21](#) [Dr. Mulla Nabity](#)

Prevention Through Dialogue: Using Soap Sculptures

Although a number of sculptures based on household objects were used successfully in the pilot research, as large artworks, they are costly and time

consuming to produce and are difficult to transport because of their size and weight. Instead, transparent soap was chosen as the material for community workshop sculptures in the main body of the research. The pilot research confirmed that soap is recognizable because of its universal everyday use; it is easy to transport and is relatively cheap. Associated with personal care, it also stimulated discussion about personal care related to HIV/AIDS, including accessing treatment, prevention and voluntary HIV/AIDS testing. Simple casting techniques were used to produce multiple objects from raw transparent soap using vinyl plastic molds. Reflecting on taboos concerning sex, abstract male and female genital forms were made and cast in soap. Embedded objects ([Figure 9.2](#)) convey messages that are familiar across Uganda. Cowrie shells symbolize femininity, currency and traditional healing. Beans communicate ideas about germination, life and fertility; rotten beans suggest the sequential stages of infection, multiplication of the virus, infertility and death; black beans illustrate the infection in its advanced stages. On a visual level, beans represent different symptoms of HIV/AIDS: rashes, sores, blood and blood clots. Lychee skin and seeds symbolize the multiplication of the virus, infection and rashes. Nails illustrate the worst stages of the disease: injury, infection, danger and full-blown AIDS; they also act as metaphors for the painful effects of HIV/AIDS, both physiologically and in terms of the psychological effects of stigmatization and shame. The smallness of each piece invites and facilitates closer inspection by the viewer.



[Figure 9.2](#) 'Male' and 'female' soaps with embedded objects.

The soap sculptures were used in a series of workshops to attempt to generate discussion about HIV/AIDS prevention. Their effectiveness was assessed through participant observation and interviews with the participants after each workshop. Initially, the focus groups were single sex to test effectiveness of generating dialogue amongst women and men respectively, and to gauge the different ways in which women and men responded. Later groups were mixed sex to test the effectiveness of generating discussion between women and men. The first workshop, in the Buganda region, involved 89 women who were interviewed individually, or in pairs and groups. Women from fourteen ethnic groups were involved, with Ganda most dominant (54%). The majority of participants were aged 15–25—the group most affected by HIV/AIDS (UNAIDS 2011). Participants were mainly single women, including widows and mothers, approximately half of whom were unemployed, with a small minority who were well educated and employed. The majority was either illiterate or had low levels of literacy. Those who were employed tended to earn an income insufficient to support their families. The second workshop, also in Buganda, involved 58 men drawn from 11 ethnic groups, but again with Ganda representing the majority (56%). Most were aged 26–36, the majority of whom were single, employed men and educated to at least secondary level. Reflecting the fact that men tend to have higher rates of literacy than women in Uganda, less than half of participants were illiterate or had low literacy levels. The third workshop was conducted around a public showing of the soap sculptures at Katikamu Catholic Parish in Kasana, in rural the Luwero District of Central Uganda. This facilitated a focus group discussion and informal interviews with 23 women and 12 men who were mainly poor and illiterate. Further workshops at public showings included: annual National AIDS Conferences in Kampala; Mutungo, a fishing village in Wakiso District, in 2010; Kampala Contemporary Art Festival in October 2012. These public workshops facilitated further feedback on the effectiveness of the soap sculptures in HIV/AIDS prevention via comments books from delegates and participants, some of whom are involved in policy-making, research and practice in HIV/AIDS. They also generated follow-up interviews with men and women, many of whom are poorly educated or illiterate.

The workshops revealed high levels of understanding and interpretation of the meanings of the soap sculptures, without the requirement for

mediation by the artist/facilitator (Nabulime and McEwan 2011). Nearly all participants recognized the imagery of the soap sculptures, the associations between body parts, sex and infection, and the bodily effects of the disease. Only one woman misinterpreted the symbolism of soap as ‘a detergent to cleanse the sores of patients,’ inferring incorrectly that the effects of the disease might simply be washed away. This required mediation by the artist/facilitator, but encouraged discussion among the women about more accurate symbolic associations. Participants in each workshop connected the fragile appearance of translucent soap, and its inevitable erosion through use, with the vulnerability of the human body. As one participant put it, ‘the use of soap may represent the frailty of life.’ Transparency was a key theme identified, with the sculptures linked to the notion of openness while living with HIV/AIDS. Of significance was the success of the workshops in initiating discussion about the disease in a public forum, specifically about sex and body parts. This proved to be the case in both single-sex workshops and in those where both men and women were present.

Findings From the Women-Only Workshop

Some participants in the women-only workshop expressed initial embarrassment at the realization that the soap sculptures are abstract depictions of genitalia, but this often turned quickly to amusement and eagerness to hold the sculptures. This enabled further discussion among the women about the need to protect against infection and, in turn, the need for transparency and openness by those who are infected in order to prevent further infection and the need to challenge the stigma associated with the disease. In explaining how the sculptures helped dialogue, one woman responded: ‘It’s all about removing shyness out of our lives, be open to talk about AIDS’ (interview with participant, Buganda, 10 October 2010). Transparency and openness were seen by the women as important in ensuring that those infected are able to receive treatment and to take measures to prevent the further spread of infection. The women also understood and interpreted the symbolism and messages of the embedded objects, which provoked discussions about effects of HIV/AIDS and the sharing of intimate personal experiences and knowledge of the disease. In

turn, this enabled the women to openly discuss the risks of unprotected sexual contact and the need to avoid sexually transmitted diseases. The soap sculptures enabled a discussion about HIV/AIDS infection and sex while simultaneously conveying a sense of the reality of suffering experienced by those living with the disease. The symbolic representation of the reality that HIV/AIDS often kills those infected was clearly understood. This also enabled women to discuss in a public forum their own experiences of the disease, either personally or its effects on family members and other people they know.

The majority of women responded at the conclusion of the workshop that the soap sculptures had helped them to discuss HIV/AIDS, sex and sexuality, HIV/AIDS testing and other prevention measures and the importance of openness about the disease. Some also pointed out that Uganda's ABC (Abstain, Be Faithful, Use a Condom) message—a multi-sector approach with high-level political support—had not helped them. Some explained that they had practiced fidelity and were faithful to their husbands, but nevertheless became infected after unprotected sex with husbands who had neither remained faithful nor were willing to use condoms. The inability to discuss sex and condom use with their husbands was highlighted as a major problem, which the ABC message does not tackle. Some women felt that the lack of sex education at home or school, ignorance and poverty push women into undesirable relationships and prostitution, and discussed these as additional reasons for high prevalence rates among women. The consensus was that the soap sculptures are useful in initiating discussions between women and men about HIV/AIDS and disease prevention.

Findings From the Men-Only Workshop

The workshop exclusively with men suggested that, on the whole, they were less embarrassed initially by the soap sculptures and more inclined to see them as fun and informative. As with many of the women participants in the first workshop, they recognized and understood images of transparency and the link between openness about the disease and saving lives. They also interpreted, without the need for mediation by the

artist/facilitator, the embedded objects in the soap sculptures as depicting suffering, the pain and hardships associated with infection and stigma. Awareness of the disease was already high among both literate and illiterate men, and lack of knowledge was not an issue. A claim by one participant that: ‘The shells show a woman’s private parts as the trouble maker’ required mediation, but this opened up conversation with other participants about the causes of the spread of the disease and the need for men to take responsibility. Participants discussed a number of issues not mentioned by the women, such as sexuality, eroticism, lubrication and fertility. While sexuality is not normally discussed openly, the sculptures encouraged men to discuss cultural factors that could lead them to become involved in multiple relationships. Discussions also emerged around the expectation that people with HIV/AIDS should abstain from sex, which some considered unacceptable. However, this led in turn to a discussion about awareness of safe-sex precautions. The consensus amongst the male participants was that the soap sculptures are helpful in stimulating discussion about the importance of openness, transparency and combating stigma in relation to HIV/AIDS prevention.

Feedback From Public Showings and Workshops

The first public soap sculpture exhibition at Katikamu Catholic Parish Church was important in testing the efficacy of the sculptures in a rural area amongst a mainly poor and illiterate populace and the possibilities of using these to generate dialogue between women and men. The launch was accompanied by a focus group discussion (in Luganda) with 35 men and women and was video recorded for analysis. An introduction by the artist/facilitator included a brief background to the research, describing the soap sculptures in general and in relation to the problems women, in particular, face as they cope with the HIV/AIDS epidemic, the contribution of Ugandan women living with HIV/AIDS to fight the disease and the artist/facilitator’s personal experience of caring for people infected by HIV/AIDS. Significantly, this meeting included women and men together, which would normally be considered inappropriate for the discussion of intimate issues. Thus, initial discussion focused on the use of soap as a

means of encouraging all participants to engage in dialogue about HIV/AIDS. Although intended as an indirect, and thus non-threatening, entry into the issues, participants were quite sophisticated in their interpretations. For example, one woman suggested, 'Soap is used daily in our homesteads for cleaning. I think soap was used to portray how HIV/AIDS is now also part of our lives. Just as we cannot avoid using soap, similarly we should not ignore the presence of HIV/AIDS in our lives.' One of the men observed, 'Like soap, our bodies can easily get infected and destroyed.' When the participants were introduced to and encouraged to interact with the soap sculptures, they expressed initial surprise, curiosity and then an eagerness to touch them. On realizing that they represented sexual organs, albeit in abstract form, some of the participants expressed some amusement, but also shyness and embarrassment. When asked about this, one of the women explained, 'With respect to the Ganda culture, adults would shy away from the discussion, since the sculptural forms represent the male and female genitals, which would cause embarrassment to the adults and the children.' However, with some encouragement from the artist/facilitator, this prompted a discussion among the participants about cultural norms surrounding discussion of intimate issues and led onto a conversation about the failure to talk openly about HIV/AIDS in the home. Some participants suggested that a lack of transparency has led to whole families being wiped out by the disease. Once the issue of embarrassment and the problems of non-communication had been aired, the participants were more comfortable in discussing openly the deeper symbolism of the soap sculptures in relation to the spread of the disease, its impacts on the body, the need for care, responsibility and openness and implications for sexual behavior. Some even related their discussion to personal experience of the disease. The consensus among participants was that the soap sculptures are valuable in enabling them to talk about topics that they would have previously found difficult in a mixed-gender group. They also recognized the value of being able to talk publicly about HIV/AIDS and its prevention. As one participant explained: 'I hope this can be taken to rural areas where people shy away from the reality of sex and disease' (9 November 2010).

Feedback from public exhibitions was overwhelmingly positive. One woman delegate at the National HIV/AIDS conference commented that the sculptures were unique because they 'revealed sexual organs, which are

rarely [depicted] in the African context.’ Follow-up interviews revealed that participants were impressed with the novelty and possibilities of the project, particularly in terms of education and facilitating discussion of prevention between women and men. The message of transparency was highlighted as being particularly important, as was the targeting of women’s lack of self-determination in sexual relations made possible through this approach. Feedback also suggested that policy-makers and practitioners were keen to see the project expanded and developed as part of a ‘sustainable solution to HIV.’

Summary of Workshop Findings

As we have argued elsewhere (Nabulime and McEwan 2011), soap sculptures resonate with men and women from different educational backgrounds, including both literate and illiterate people. They attract interest because they are unusual and novel. Initial responses are sometimes humorous or embarrassed, or both, but as the participants explain, humour helps break through initial shyness, and both men and women subsequently engage with the soap sculptures on a serious and reflective level. The sculptures are successful in stimulating discussion and reminding people of their own experiences of HIV/AIDS, which they then feel more comfortable articulating in public. They also enable respondents to share their reactions and opinions, often with great enthusiasm and passion. Of particular importance are the ways in which the sculptures succeed in creating dialogue between men and women about sex and HIV/AIDS that they traditionally find extremely problematic, if not impossible, in both public and private spaces. Despite being potentially controversial, very few participants object to the representation of genitalia, nor are they hesitant in giving their views. The scale of the tragedy of HIV/AIDS in Uganda perhaps means that there is widespread understanding of the urgency of opening up discussion of issues around the disease and sexuality in general, and acceptance of the usefulness of using sculptural forms that depict human genitalia to generate this discussion.

The research project was successful in using soap sculptures to stimulate discussion between women and men, inspired particularly by a desire to

explore the use of art in HIV/AIDS prevention. Sculptures are metaphorical, not literal, and are thus appropriate to the Ugandan context, where 'polite or softer ways of talking about issues regarding taboos is manageable' (Wells, Sienaert and Connolly 2002, p. 5). In contrast to literal props, such as wooden phalluses, they move beyond simply assuming that participants do not already have awareness of disease transmission, or wanting to educate them, to encouraging dialogue about HIV/AIDS and its prevention. There are a number of lessons that can be learned from the success of the workshops. We have argued elsewhere (Nabulime and McEwan 2011) that with support and investment, the soap sculpture project could be rolled out on a larger scale along the lines of an arts- or craft-based community development project, which has been successful in HIV/AIDS projects in other parts of sub-Saharan Africa (see, e.g., Marschall 2004; Martin 2003). The primary aim would be to assist in changing men's attitudes and promoting dialogue between women and men, but with potential to generate an income for women living with HIV/AIDS. In promoting dialogue and openness, a longer-term aspiration would be to help women acquire greater confidence in negotiating for safer sex, while recognizing that this also requires wider structural change beyond the scope of this project.

Conclusions

Using art in raising awareness and preventing the spread of HIV/AIDS presents particular challenges in sub-Saharan Africa. As Kate Wells, Edgard Sienaert and Joan Connolly (2002, p. 73) argue, 'Artistic and public expressions of love and physical intimacy are rare in Africa, and images of human sexuality are rarer still.' However, the soap sculpture project is effective as social sculpture because it combines art with craft-based methods using familiar, everyday objects and simultaneously builds upon the traditions of Ugandan performance and musical art, which entertain, involve and inform participants and spectators about significant social issues (Nzewi 2006). This is a more socially oriented practice that seeks to replace the traditional focus on sculpture as an object with works created from or inspired by domestic objects. It also seeks to involve people in

different ways, including allowing them to participate in the development of the artworks, and to handle and interpret them.

Participants in this study found it easy to relate to the transparent soap sculptures because soap is an item they use daily and the embedded objects reflect the material cultures of their everyday lives. Transparent soap sculptures demonstrate the effectiveness of metaphor and household objects in addressing and communicating the frightening and often taboo subject of HIV/AIDS. By encouraging openness and dialogue between women and men, they can educate, entertain and initiate discussion about the dangers of the disease, which may lead to behavioral change, while also reducing stigma-tization and discrimination of those living with HIV/AIDS. Soap sculptures depicting female and male genitalia stimulated discussion between women and men about sexuality and sexual practices in contexts where this is usually forbidden. This chapter has demonstrated how sculpture can be a powerful visual and participatory strategy for developing HIV/AIDS prevention and provoking discussion of intimate sexual matters. With the involvement of a skilled facilitator, the soap sculptures can focus attention, present information and generate/stimulate discussions in innovative ways by providing information, motivation, empowerment and self-expression. They can communicate messages, encourage reflection, educate, create awareness of modes of prevention, summarize information, entertain and eventually lead to change of attitudes.

Poverty and patriarchal social and cultural relations are clearly of great significance in constraining women's ability to control their sexuality, and thus in HIV/AIDS prevention. Unless men's attitudes towards women change and women's livelihoods are improved, awareness campaigns alone will do little to check the spread of HIV/AIDS. Although encouraging dialogue between women and men through the methods we have highlighted in this chapter does not address the structural problems of women's lives, or necessarily always help women negotiate for safer sex, it is a starting point in encouraging more openness about HIV/AIDS and its prevention. The use of soap sculptures in workshops represents a new method of engagement and mode of intervention in the context of HIV/AIDS awareness and prevention. It is inspired by ideas of social sculpture attuned to the cultural and social specificities of Uganda and responsive to the challenges presented by low literacy levels, orate cultures and patriarchal societies. It illustrates the potential of art in challenging

taboos and encouraging dialogue about sex and sexual relations between women and men, which is essential in the fight against HIV/AIDS.

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Note

- 1 A Practical Manual Guide by Lilian Nabulime (2014) entitled 'Bypassing Literacy using Sculptural Forms as a Communication Tool in the Fight against HIV/AIDS' is available from the College of Engineering, Design, Art and Technology, Makerere University.

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10

The Creative Interweaving of Multiple Threads

A Pragmatic Approach to Supporting the Arts in the Context of International Aid and Volunteering

Vanessa Eden

Introduction

For two years, I worked as a volunteer in the Fijian arts sector, where I witnessed the multiple roles that the cultural sector can play in economic and social development—touching many different parts of society and resulting in positive outcomes. I saw the income of some artists increase and many positive interactions between different local communities brought about through artistic practice. This chapter demonstrates, pragmatically, how capacity building in the arts can contribute to development through diverse, interconnected paths.

My practical experience validates existing theoretical research which argues that the arts can support economic development, peace building, strengthen local communities, contribute to sustainable development and maintain traditional knowledge (Arts Council England 2014; IFACCA 2013; Meeker 2004; Teaiwa 2007; UNESCO 2013). The 2013 UN *Creative*

Economy Report (UNESCO/UNDP 2013) argues that culture (and creative cultural expression) can be an important driver of development, and UNESCO has called for the inclusion of culture in sustainable development policies (UNESCO 2013; UNESCO/UNDP 2013). This argument builds on that of Jon Hawkes (2001), who advocated for culture to be regarded as the fourth pillar of sustainability alongside economic, social and environmental pillars. If culture were mainstreamed within sustainability policies and social planning, many positive economic and social outcomes might result.

However, what is missing from the literature on art and international development are first-hand accounts of the interface between arts organizations, development agencies and volunteering organizations. Mistakes and misunderstandings can sometimes be made in the program planning, delivery and evaluation of an international aid assignment (Betteridge 2013). Therefore, reflexive first-hand accounts by practitioners can help to inform development policy and practice.

The islands of the Pacific region are diverse, but there is also a sense of connection and shared culture. This is evident in a strong focus on people and relationships, on sharing networks and ‘on working together for the betterment of all’ (Huffer 2006, p. 44). Regional cultural identity is considered important for Pacific development, not least because it demonstrates to the rest of the world that there is a ‘Pacific Way’ of doing things (Huffer 2006; Firth 2006). It helps to maintain Pacific protocols and reinforces the idea of working collaboratively and maintaining Pacific values and concepts (Huffer 2006).

In this chapter, I explore how such a focus on relationships and networks contributed to positive outcomes for both individual artists and communities associated with the National Heritage Arts Exhibition and Competition.

The Arts Sector, International Aid and the Fiji Islands

In the Pacific, the arts are embraced as a ‘living’ entity and traditions and customs have a strong presence (Huffer 2006; UNESCO 2013, p. 4). Furthermore, the connection between arts and development has been argued to be of particular relevance for the potential of the cultural industries to

contribute to poverty alleviation (Radbourn 2003; Teaiwa 2007). David Throsby (2010, p. 28) explains that ‘the arts sector [is] an essential source of the creativity that drives the cultural industries and that can animate innovation and development in other parts of the economy.’ Sector representatives in Fiji that I spoke to agreed that supporting the arts, particularly through the kinds of networking, workshops and exhibitions that enable artists to learn from one another’s experiences and that are detailed later in this chapter ‘assists with national pride and [supports] peaceful co-existence and understanding.’ ¹ Such strategies, in turn, generate (sometimes indirectly) positive economic and social impacts that weave through different parts of society.

One ‘thread’ that donors can support is investing in locally based arts organizations through assigning volunteers with industry experience to work with them (DFAT 2014). Volunteers should have appropriate and relevant skills to share with local employees enabling capacity building in the sector (UNESCO/UNDP 2013). Capacity building, in turn, contributes to the consolidation and growth of the cultural sector. Volunteers should also be good active listeners, be flexible and reflexive and, vitally, culturally sensitive. Australian Volunteers International (AVI) in Fiji, through whom I was recruited, has started supporting the arts and cultural sector partly because its small size makes it easier to have an impact, duplication is less likely and connecting different organizations is possible. ²

The ownership of a project by local stakeholders is, of course, vital to its success, and priorities must be locally driven to be relevant and sustainable (ActionAid 2008; UNESCO/UNDP 2013). In my case, the host organization emphasized the need to develop stronger administration, planning and marketing skills, to which I was able to contribute.

Supporting Cultural Tourism and Arts Administration: Interconnections and Relationships

Income from tourism is a very important part of Fiji’s economy. In 2012, 660,590 visitors arrived in Fiji and spent FJD \$1,300 million (Fiji Bureau of Statistics 2014). The majority of visitors came from Australia (51%) and New Zealand (16%), but a reasonable number came from further afield

including North America, other Pacific Islands, Continental Europe, China and the United Kingdom (Fiji Bureau of Statistics 2014). When tourists visit Fiji, it is an opportunity to learn about the Fijian arts sector and Fijian culture.

From November 2008 to November 2010, I worked as a volunteer for AVI in the role of Cultural Tourism Developer and Arts Administrator at the Fiji Arts Council in Suva. The aim of my assignment was to support and strengthen aspects of the Fijian arts sector through the transfer of skills, through administration and networking, as well as supporting cultural tourism and local stakeholder capacity building. I organized arts festivals, exhibitions and workshops across a range of different genres, including performance arts, visual arts, fashion, poetry and handcrafts. These events were seen as a valuable conduit between the arts sector and the tourism sector.³ They provided an opportunity for visitors to see the diverse cultural and creative products made by Fijians and to learn the cultural story behind many of the products.

This section focuses on a project I carried out with the heritage and handcraft artists sector that demonstrates the way in which cultural sector capacity building can contribute to diverse positive outcomes. In Fiji, the heritage and handcraft sector encompasses mat weaving and handbag and fan weaving, pottery and ceramics, wood carving, masi (or tapa) making, textiles, wall hangings and jewellery. The exhibitions I organized helped to raise the quality of the products at the same time as creating an economic market outlet. Simultaneously, the exhibitions established an artist-to-artist mentoring environment and helped to preserve cultural knowledge.

Understanding connections in a multidimensional approach is important for development agencies that often seek multiple objectives in their arts projects but are not always clear about how to achieve them in practice (Stupples 2014). It also supports arguments for the cross-sectoral benefits of arts development noted in the academic literature (such as IFACCA 2013; Teaiwa 2007; UNESCO/UNDP 2013). Furthermore, the interweaving of these distinct threads reflects the value of supporting relationships in the arts sector.

Arts Exhibitions, Competitions, Festivals and Markets

An important element of my work was promoting economic development in the arts sector. It was apparent that as well as artists needing access to domestic and international markets, my work would also involve raising the quality of some products (whilst striving to maintain the integrity of the product) to ensure their international marketability. Having adequate access to domestic and international markets is a common challenge for artists in the Pacific Islands. ⁴ UNESCO has highlighted the importance of trade fairs for artists (UNESCO/UNDP 2013) and the importance of arts festivals for regional economies—they can act as the ‘glue’ which binds diverse industries together (UNESCO/UNDP 2013).

Apart from supporting economic development, the competitions, exhibitions and festivals that I helped to organize also promoted relationship building and enabled artists to learn from each other. Supporting the production of traditional cultural products and the skills needed to make these products, also helped to support the maintenance of diverse aspects of Fijian culture and cultural knowledge.

One such event was the annual National Heritage Arts Exhibition and Competition (hereafter NHAEC). This competition included a range of categories, some of which valued traditional skills (in, for example, mat weaving and wood carving), and others which valued design and innovation (for example, contemporary, woven handbag designs). Artists would come from throughout the Fijian Islands to participate in this exhibition and competition.

These events were particularly valued because of the opportunities they generated for networking and the exchange of ideas. ⁵ Feedback from Fijian colleagues ⁶ highlighted the importance of exhibitions in connecting artists from across the country, encouraging the cross-fertilization of ideas and experiences (an idea supported by Teaiwa 2007). At the NHAEC, for example, two weavers from two different regions met one another. The more experienced weaver offered to visit the other weaver’s region and carry out a weaving workshop, which she did, transferring many of her skills to the local women. At the following year’s competition, the women who had been taught entered some of the weaving competitions and won, beating the woman who had taught them. The teacher was happy and the new weavers were also happy as they had learned new skills and new ways of approaching their weaving.

Competitions like the NHAEC, helped to raise the quality of some products. This encouraged more international buyers (such as Trade Aid in New Zealand) to submit orders to the artists. Furthermore, winners of these national competitions were put forward to participate in international arts festivals, like the Melanesian Arts Festival. International arts festivals are recognized as another potential economic market and can give international customers direct access to the art and the artists, thus also raising awareness of Fiji's arts and culture (UNESCO/UNDP 2013).

Donor Funding: Understanding the Need for a Fuller Resource Package

In addition to the development of the artists' skills and the strengthening of domestic and international markets, I worked to strengthen the administrative skills of personnel within, and connected with, the host organization. This resulted in the setting up of a local artists' group which was run by the local artisans and was responsible for organizing the exhibitions and the coordination of some aspects of international trade.

Unfortunately, the possibility of further funding opportunities to support this organization was lost, partly due to a lack of financial and personnel resources. This appears to be a common problem for small organizations that may not have the right contacts (and the necessary time) to apply for funds from international donor organizations (Bludau 2010). Further funding to help with infrastructure, travel, workshops and project development would have consolidated the project's success and would constitute a more complete resource package, in addition to funding volunteers.

We made an unsuccessful application, for example, to a potential donor to set up a building with running water and electricity, where artists could come and practice. This central resource would have helped the artists to network, to share their skills and learn from one another, and it would have provided space to exhibit and sell their products. It would also have provided an opportunity for visitors to learn about the Fijian culture as well as the arts sector. The recent *Creative Economy Report*, however, does recommend that initiatives like this should be supported, perhaps

suggesting a growing recognition of the value of supporting infrastructure development in the sector as well as investing in skills, training and education (UNESCO/UNDP 2013, p. 112).

Conclusion

My grounded experience in the interweaving of multidimensional threads, both within the cultural sector and beyond it, demonstrate the potential contributions of the arts to development outlined by researchers (IFACCA 2013; Meeker 2004; Teaiwa 2007; UNESCO 2013; UNESCO/UNDP 2013). For those artists who participated in the exhibitions, competitions and festivals, these elements included the preservation of traditional knowledge; the learning of new skills; mentoring between artists; the development of new, contemporary designs; the exchange of ideas; and access to new domestic and international markets—all key elements in keeping arts and culture alive and vibrant in Fiji.

To support such benefits, donors should invest in a complete resource package over a reasonable time period in a way that is meaningfully integrated with an endogenous arts strategy (Stupples 2011). This means that as well as funding an appropriate, culturally sensitive volunteer in a host organization, donors need to commit to infrastructure funding and events funding. These elements would help to ensure that the host organization itself is strengthened, that it maintains ownership of its projects and that it becomes economically sustainable. Development organizations should also seek dialogue with experts in the field of arts and culture. Katerina Teaiwa (2007) suggests that communication between policy makers, donors, anthropologists, arts administrators and cultural practitioners is key to ensuring that the creative and cultural sectors are supported appropriately.

There are many elements to supporting an arts program, and it is the balanced interweaving of these different threads that contribute to a successful project. These threads can, in turn, have multidimensional impacts that reach diverse sections of society. Ultimately, the results of a successful project might, in some small part, contribute to ensuring the flourishing of arts and culture throughout the Pacific Islands which in turn

can contribute towards socially and economically sustainable Pacific Island societies for future generations.

Notes

- 1 Fiji Department of Culture and Heritage representative, personal communication, 2013.
- 2 AVI in-country representative in Fiji, personal communication, 2013.
- 3 Fiji Department of Culture and Heritage, personal communication, 2013.
- 4 Meaghan Beth Bludau (2010) noted that this was also the case in Central America.
- 5 The value of similar processes is evident at the far larger Festival of Pacific Arts, which takes place every four years and which many Pacific artists attend. One of the key aspects of the Festival of Pacific Arts is that it enables artist networking and serves to reinforce Pacific identity by enabling the exchange of 'views, skills and knowledge' (UNESCO/UNDP 2013, p. 26).
- 6 Fiji Department of Culture and Heritage representative, personal communication, 2013.

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11

Morris & Co. as a Strategy for Contemporary South African Craft Enterprises

Ingrid Stevens and Allan Munro

Introduction

Since 1994, there has been a great deal of interest in crafts in South Africa. The South African government, for example, has identified crafts as a potential area of economic growth with strategic contributions to nation-building, and it has provided funds for an array of crafts-based initiatives. Programs and funds have also been offered by local government, tertiary institutions, non-governmental organizations, businesses and individuals to support the development of craft enterprises. These activities are intended to create jobs and alleviate poverty, as South Africa has high unemployment ¹ and huge income disparities (van den Berg 2004, p. 22). Crafts are also seen as a way of encouraging the growth of foreign and local tourism and, more subtly, as a way of encouraging nation-building through the development of vernacular styles, thus ‘constructing’ a national heritage (see Bowe 1993). However, evidence suggests that many craft projects fail. In this chapter, we posit a strategy, based on an analysis of the Victorian craft-based enterprise Morris & Co., that could circumvent such failures.

The definition of ‘craft’ is a contested one vis-à-vis the term ‘art.’ ² Peter Dormer (1994, p. 7), defines craft as those objects ‘whose content is

substantially dependent on practical skill, and whose intention is discovered through the process of making the object.’ Richard Wollheim (1980, p. 38) states that craft involves a means and an end; the end defines the craft through the particular object and the means speaks to processes employed to reach that end. Craft, therefore, uses a plan, executes the plan (following a predetermined process) in a particular material, and produces a particular object. Through combining process and material, one can thus speak of a ‘ceramist,’ a ‘weaver,’ a ‘woodcarver’ and so on. An ‘enterprise’ is a project or business venture and, more aptly, ‘an undertaking, a bold or difficult one showing courage or imaginativeness’ (Sykes 1976, p. 345). This study employs the term specifically to refer to the potential of an enterprise producing crafts to create jobs and alleviate poverty. It focuses on craft-based enterprises, drawing on the historical craft enterprise Morris & Co. and selected contemporary South African craft enterprises.

Successful craft initiatives do exist in South Africa. As criteria for assessing the ‘success’ of an enterprise, we included longevity, sustainable earnings, products perceived as being of high quality, innovation, national/international recognition and the creation and sustaining of satisfying jobs. However, not all projects and interventions are successful. Examples exist which make clear that (donor) funding and enthusiasm are seldom enough to create a sustainable craft enterprise where none exists or to adapt an existing craft to changing circumstances such as new market demands or the loss of traditional materials or skills. The lack of a theoretical model that specifically explains the approaches, structures and procedures of a successful craft enterprise compounds the problem.

Post-apartheid South Africa has attempted to instigate a craft revival (see Coetsee 2002; Sellschop, Goldblatt and Hemp 2002), yet many craft projects have failed. Seeking strategies that might prevent such failures, we turned to Victorian Britain in the nineteenth century, where a similar craft revival occurred, which grew into the Arts and Crafts Movement. Britain at that time was an economically powerful industrial country, yet also had serious poverty and high unemployment (Hobsbawm 1975). Thus, the Victorian era saw the interface between high industrialization and high unemployment, resulting in the development of craft-based ‘cottage industries.’ This situation is comparable to the mixed economy in present-day South Africa, with one segment of the population prosperous, ‘privileged’ and mostly white, and the other poor, ‘under-privileged’ and

overwhelmingly black. Thus, while we do not suggest that Victorian Britain is like post-apartheid South Africa, there are nonetheless certain similar conditions and demographic parallels: similar population numbers; high unemployment; economic shifts, such as a burgeoning middle class on the back of potential exploitation, leading to a degree of instability; high urbanization and growing levels of poverty, with an attendant breakdown of traditional lifestyles and craft practices. So our research question was: could one develop a way of anticipating what needs to be in place for a craft enterprise to be effective in South Africa by using an historical model based in Victorian Britain?

Morris & Co. as a Strategy

The firm Morris, Marshall, Faulkner & Co. was founded in London in 1861, ³ when William Morris and friends set up ‘a sort of shop where they would jointly produce and sell painted furniture’ (MacCarthy 1994, p. 166). Within a month, they had stock to display and their first sales, of table glass (Lindsay 1975, p. 123). Thus, the company was started on an organized basis around a group of friends. Morris and his group saw themselves as makers and crafters, or at least supervisors of the crafting process, as well as designers. Their aim with the company was not merely to earn money, but to reform art and thereby to ‘reform a philistine age’ (Thompson 1976, p. 94). An important aspect of this approach was the aim of integrating art, society and labor in response to changes associated with the industrial revolution. This resonates with the South African government’s aim of enhancing employment, social cohesion and the development of national heritage.

Morris was a highly charismatic and important figure and took on the major share of the work: he was the manager, designed many of the products, made working drawings, liaised with clients, sought commissions and publicized the firm (Marsh 1986, p. 58). The partners soon set up offices, a showroom and workshops, and began to make stained glass, decorated tiles, embroidered designs on silk and wall hangings. They made the products themselves, co-opted family and friends to execute designs,

hired assistants and laborers as necessary, commissioned outside firms to execute their designs or hired expert designers, craftspeople and managers.

From the early 1860s, the company, largely because of Morris's energy and interest in learning new crafts and developing new designs, expanded its design and production into repeating patterns for wallpapers and textiles. These early designs, based on flowers and fruit, reflecting Morris's childhood interest in the English countryside, gave the company its visual and stylistic identity (MacCarthy 1994, p. 182). The company's (vernacular) products became fashionable with both the well-off middle and upper classes and 'set the pace among wealthy circles where any claim was made to cultivation' (Thompson 1976, p. 97). Thus, it was Morris's aesthetic sensibilities/designs that not only supplied, but simultaneously formed, the tastes of the upper and middle classes.

The company's reputation and financial stability were fully established by 1875 (MacCarthy 1994, p. 210). Consequently, in 1875, the company became Morris & Co., and Morris became sole owner (Kelvin 1984, pp. 234–37; MacCarthy 1994, p. 347; Mackail 1922, pp. 305–08). He had, from 1870 to 1875, changed the company from a small, specialized concern known mainly to artists and architects into a diversified and potentially lucrative enterprise well known to the general public and was now in a position to fully control it. The second half of the 1870s are seen as Morris's most creative years, characterized by continuing experiments with new crafts. Rather than commerce or money, Morris was excited by learning these crafts and by craft production. By the time of his death, Morris & Co. was a successful company with over a hundred employees, its own shop and showrooms, earning high profits from the design and production of textiles, wallpapers, stained glass, carpets, tapestries, embroideries, hand-printed books and more.

The first factor that accounts for this success is, by our analysis, design. The designs for Morris & Co.'s products were always innovative and bold, produced by designated designers. In other words, they did not come about in the production processes and were not copied from existing traditions, but were done expressly and deliberately *before* production of goods began. The planning stage included research into history and best practice, experiments with materials and techniques, the exploration of ideas and the development of final designs on paper. This planning was central to the enterprise.

The chief designer was Morris himself, with some designs undertaken by partners and later by managers. Each design was the work of one designer, who thus had artistic control and could ensure its quality and integrity. Nature dominated Morris's approach to pattern design and the decorative arts throughout his career. This provided a core vernacular for design that gives unity and cohesion to his entire oeuvre.

Designers, therefore, had clear visual aims and a rich source of inspiration for designs. These sources were researched, imaginatively manipulated, gave unity and cohesion to the variety of designs put into production by the enterprise and provided inspiration for renewal and innovation in design. This established a coherent, shared style that might be termed a 'house style' evidenced from the earliest products of Morris & Co. This ran through the various different products and ranges, with different designers and artists.

Furthermore, Morris was able to achieve a high quality in the execution of the company's designs by knowledge about, and concern for, skilled and appropriate craftsmanship, the best quality use of appropriate materials, the mastery of difficult, time-consuming techniques and control over the quality of the manufacturing processes. These aspects of the production process gave the products of Morris & Co. a distinct advantage in the Victorian marketplace, producing craft products considered to be of the best of their type ever produced.

The final products were varied in type, pattern and color; new products and designs were added constantly. Products included unique, one-off products as well as batch productions of popular products, prices ranged widely and the design and manufacturing processes allowed for constant innovation within a recognizable style.

The crafts produced by Morris & Co. were very successful because (1) they were original, although derived from older traditions; (2) they were different from the established tastes of the day, yet established a regional and vernacular (English) style; (3) they showed a deep understanding of essential aesthetic elements, such as the combination of simple, functional forms with rich surface decoration; and (4) they successfully combined functionality with decorativeness and innovation.

The company was initially founded on Morris' personal inherited wealth, which equates to start-up capital, but this dwindled, necessitating sound business principles, on which the success of Morris & Co. rests, as much as

on design. Morris created a company that traded for eighty years, independent of further outside investment (Harvey and Press 1991, p. 4). Although the company started somewhat informally (the partners had little business experience), it soon established formal and sound business structures and financial systems, it was professionally managed and attention was paid to all financial systems such as costs, prices, profit margins, accounts, estimates.

Furthermore, Morris was involved in the publicity and marketing of the firm's products. There were various means to publicize the company's products, including: a showroom, prestigious exhibitions, publicity material, personal contacts and visits by the public to the workshops; critically targeting niche markets and selected clients; personal contacts and attention to clients; advertising; diversified products to satisfy diverse markets; expanding shops and showrooms to other cities (then internationally); and using agents for exporting of products. The success of the marketing was linked to the quality and range of products.

By catering to different markets, the prices of Morris & Co.'s products could vary from reasonable to very high, depending upon range and exclusivity. Prices were kept low by various means without compromising quality: sub-contractors were used when they could produce goods for Morris & Co. more cheaply than the company itself could and thus labor costs were optimally curtailed. In spite of competition from other businesses (and imitations of its products), Morris & Co. remained profitable during Morris's lifetime because of its superior products, competitive prices and competent marketing and publicity.

Finally, it is vital to consider the role of labor in the success of any enterprise. Morris & Co. had a flexible approach to labor and used labor systems ranging from full-time employees to part-time piece workers, from highly skilled experts to assistants and apprentices, as well as outside contractors. However, all were subject to rigorous supervision within a sound organizational structure. In spite of Morris's socialist, humanitarian and democratic ideals, Morris & Co.'s organization was a charismatic one and all labor roles were centered around, and dependent on, his vision, his abilities and authority. One of his vital roles was that of inspiring and training his workers. Morris ran his own training, both of apprentices and of others involved in the company. He was an excellent teacher who closely

supervised his workers. He believed that anyone could be taught craft skills as evidenced by his taking on apprentices without selection.

Although salaries, wages and piece-work rates were above average for their time and place, labor systems were flexible so that, simultaneously, labor costs were kept as low as possible in order to keep prices of goods competitive. ⁴ Other conditions of labor at Morris & Co. were generally favorable and working conditions pleasant. Morris's employees had a number of advantages in terms of wages, training, working environment, a good relationship with owner and managers, opportunities for advancement and generally skilled and interesting work. Morris & Co. had no labor strife and a low labor turnover.

Morris & Co. succeeded largely because the charismatic Morris managed to integrate his approach to design, production, business and labor. He was a designer-craftsman who was also a businessman and employer who could, because of the structure of Morris & Co., keep all these under his control.

South African Craft Enterprises

In this section, we discuss two South African craft-based enterprises, comparing their practices with the kinds of strategies we have identified as influencing the success of Morris & Co. ⁵

Ardmore Ceramic Art is an enterprise producing decorative ceramics in the KwaZulu-Natal Midlands (Scott 1998). It has been in existence for 28 years, since 1985. Fée Halsted-Berning, qualified in fine arts, started the enterprise after she married and went to live on her husband's farm, where Ardmore is still situated. A second studio with a museum has since been opened at Lavendula Farm, near Caversham.

Because Halsted-Berning had to earn money, she began working with Bonnie Ntshalintshali, the daughter of a farm worker, producing ceramics. Together, they integrated two existing aspects of South African ceramics, namely traditional indigenous clay pottery and modelling with 'Western' ceramics (Halstead-Berning 2007). Although Halsted-Berning had training in hand-made ceramics, neither woman was trained to throw on the potter's wheel, so they approached ceramics more creatively than would many potters, using clay as an expressive medium. Ntshalintshali proved to be

exceptionally talented and, under Halsted-Berning's training, she became a creative and well-known artist. The two women formed a strong, fruitful partnership.

Because the work was noticed by buyers and the art world almost immediately and sold well, more local people joined the studio, making work that initially resembled Ntshalintshali's. Both Halsted-Berning and Ntshalintshali participated in prestigious exhibitions and Ardmore began to exhibit as a studio. Individual artists joined Ardmore and made their own, individual work, and the studio also produced certain studio lines in larger batch productions to cover costs.

Ardmore has since become famous both nationally and internationally, achieving the highest prices ever paid for South African ceramics.⁶ The work is exceptionally creative and of impeccable quality. Ardmore now employs one hundred people working from two studios. Halsted-Berning, based at the Caversham studio, visits the Winterton studio once a week to give instructions and guidance about aesthetics and design.

In general, while there is an Ardmore style, based on simple vessel shapes elaborated with complex modeled additions and highly detailed, brightly painted decorative surfaces (see [Figures 11.1](#) and [11.2](#)), there is a degree of individuality in the work of different artists. The studio produces what may be seen as three 'ranges.' The first is the 'house' line, which is sold through upmarket shops and is generally more expensive than other South African ceramics. These cups, bowls, platters, eggcups and candlesticks have simple modeling, and are painted in elaborate, exuberant patterns. The 'art' pieces made by the best Ardmore artists are kept for exhibitions and are extremely expensive. One type consists of larger vessels with extravagant modeled additions and very elaborate painting. The third range, of which fewer are made, is the purely sculptural 'tableaux' depicting narrative groups of figures. In a Western context, prices for art have always been higher than for craft. Ceramic work, both as craft and because they are breakable, has traditionally been relatively cheap. However, from early in its history, Halsted-Berning priced and promoted Ardmore products as art rather than craft (Halstead-Berning 2007).

Production at Ardmore is goal-directed and there is some planning, visual research and discussion, but the objects evolve in the making through the skilled, innovative contributions of those involved. However, Halsted-Berning provides core creative inputs to the designs. An Ardmore ceramic

piece is usually made by three people: a potter who throws the basic shapes, a sculptor-modeler who models the clay additions and a painter who adds the decoration. All are very skilled and are observed to work in a practiced, relaxed and free manner (see Endnote 5). All sign the work on its base. Halsted-Berning looks at the works in progress constantly and seems to



[Figure 11.1](#) Sable salt and pepper set, Ardmore, 2013, underglazed and glazed ceramics, size 80 cm x 100 cm, Ardmore, with permission



[Figure 1A.2](#) Sable, with permission, 2013, underglazed and glazed ceramics, size unknown.

know each piece intimately. She comments on, criticizes and cajoles the artists, thus providing ongoing quality control. The work made under her direct supervision tends to be more daring and better than that made independently, so the artists at Lavendula Farm tend to earn more.

The style of Ardmore is unlike anything else made locally or internationally and can be seen as part of the formation of a new, invented, South African vernacular. Halsted-Berning's aim is to enable people to be artists and encourage their creativity (Halstead-Berning 2007). This she seems well able to achieve, as evidenced by the exceptional quality of the work and the individual approaches detectable within a unified Ardmore style. Her artists are rewarded financially and valued for their creativity—the artists are paid at the end of each month for the work they have produced, and they can earn more for producing more or for making exceptional pieces. They earn more than most, if not all, workers in other South African craft enterprises.

Originally, day-to-day management systems at Ardmore were simple or non-existent—Halsted-Berning had little business training. However, with growth, the enterprise has developed formalized systems, for example keeping records, bookkeeping and paying taxes. Halsted-Berning has employed a full-time business manager, marketer and secretary-bookkeeper. However, she retains a powerful central management position herself, controlling much of the design, training, production, promotion and marketing of Ardmore's products.

The working environment at the Ardmore studios is attractive. Both are newly built or renovated and have copious working space and display areas for the sale of work. The artists enjoy many other benefits. After the death of Ntshalintshali in 1999, and because of the illness and death of many of Ardmore's artists from HIV/AIDS particularly, Halsted-Berning instituted an insurance and health system (Halstead-Berning 2007). The artists were educated about HIV/AIDS (previously taboo subjects) and the Ardmore Excellence Fund was established, with American donor funding.⁷ Now, 6 percent of all Ardmore's sales are transferred to this fund and used for death benefits, to provide health services such as anti-retroviral medications if they are not provided by the state, contributions towards pension schemes, bursaries for the artists' children, loans for housing and the development of the Bonnie Ntshalintshali Museum.⁸

Ardmore is one of South Africa's most successful craft enterprises, judged by its longevity, the number of artists employed, their exceptional earnings for the sector and the renown of its products, which is reflected in their very high selling prices.

Kaross is an embroidery business that has been in existence for almost 30 years on a farm in Limpopo Province. Kaross is in a rural area near the town of Letsitele in the Guyani District, surrounded by small, scattered rural villages. Irma van Rooyen (a fine arts graduate and practicing artist) moved to the farm in 1985 with her husband, a citrus farmer. Women from surrounding rural villages were unemployed—poverty was rife—and also largely unskilled. Critically, there is no indigenous tradition of embroidery in southern Africa (Nettleton 2000, p. 20). The Shangaan women from the area did, however, have some tradition of decorating their houses and clothes. They also made tray cloths and bed spreads embroidered with flowers in a European style (possibly adapted from Afrikaner traditions of embroidery). Rudimentary embroidery skills existed. In order to help the women earn something, Irma van Rooyen offered them cloth and thread, suggesting that they embroider pictures of their lives, which she would try to sell (van Rooyen 2007).

The women were initially not able to do this, as they lacked design and drawing skills, so she made drawings of their homes and villages, the surrounding bush and its animals, which they embroidered. Initially, her friends bought the work. As news of the project spread, more and more women joined. Kaross was established as a business by 1987. Solomon Muhati, a young local man who showed drawing and design skills, came forward and, with some design training from van Rooyen, started designing and drawing the designs onto cloths. Shops began to buy the embroideries—the enterprise grew (van Rooyen 2007). There are now over one thousand crafters, mainly Shangaan women, embroidering from their homes, and a small managerial staff, with three young local men doing all the drawing and design.

Kaross is a privately owned enterprise that sells to many shops as well as through Tiger's Eye, the largest southern African craft and curio retail chain. The enterprise recently opened its own shop, which sells only Kaross embroideries. This is run by van Rooyen's daughter who is also qualified in fine arts.

The initial Kaross designs originated from van Rooyen: she did the drawings, selected the backing cloth (usually black), chose the colors and type of thread and advised on stitches and color combinations. As she admits, the initial 'character' of Kaross was hers, combined with the (emerging) embroidering abilities of the women (van Rooyen 2007). Much

of her style still undoubtedly remains—the appearance of the smaller animal-and-background cloths has changed little through the existence of the enterprise. However, van Rooyen has for a number of years done no designing—the drawing of all designs is now done by three young local men. They all initially approached van Rooyen asking to design, showed talent and are now highly skilled, fluid and rapid in their designing and inventive in their ideas and interpretation of subject matter. Van Rooyen still discusses ideas and designs with the designers, suggesting new ideas when the drawings seem to become too repetitive, and so she has a strong advisory and ongoing teaching role.

The characteristic design of Kaross is a relatively simple one of an animal, bird or plant on a decorative, textured ground created by different stitches, surrounded by geometric borders. These ‘house’ cloths remain popular and have been made throughout the existence of the enterprise. Other ranges have gradually been introduced (see [Figures 11.3](#) and [11.4](#)). The latest ‘house’ designs are portraits, depicting specific people surrounded by symbols, objects or scenes relevant to them. Another new range is the limited production of large ‘white-on-white’ cloths, which are visually sophisticated, beautiful and quite distinctive—the light-colored backing cloth differentiates them from the work of most other South African embroidery projects. Kaross designs are thus varied in their subjects and forms and also in that they reflect the ideas of the three designers, yet are strongly identifiable as coming from Kaross, rather than being the work of individuals.



[Source: *Sell* Workshop, used with permission.](#) *Kaporn, 2007.* embroidered cloth, size unknown.

Designs are planned to a high degree in that each one—simple or complex—is drawn onto the cloth by the designers. Commissions are discussed and planned between them and van Rooyen. The embroiderers do not develop their own designs and are given cloths with designs drawn onto them in white pencil. These designs are in outline, fairly simplified, and do not indicate details of the patterns and textures which will fill them out. The better embroiderers are given larger, more complex cloths; the less skilled do the smaller, simpler ones. Along with a drawn cloth, each embroiderer is given a measured assortment of threads in a variety of colors chosen by the managers in the workshop in good color combinations. The women have seemingly few creative decisions to make. However, the placing of colors

on the design, the stitches used and textures that result are their decisions, thus interspersing the mechanical with the creative.



Figure 13.4 Storytelling cloth, Kaross, 2007, embroidered cloth, approx. 1000 × 1000 cm.
Source: [Isa Schop](#), used with permission.

According to van Rooyen, embroidery is not difficult to do, nor does it require complex technology, machinery or expensive materials. However, it is time consuming and labor intensive to produce, so it is suitable for job creation. When increased orders require increased production, van Rooyen does not push the women to increase productivity (problematic given the labor-intensive nature of the work), but takes on new workers. This has brought the number of craft workers to over a thousand, and the number is increasing.

Van Rooyen's main aim has been to create jobs and generate an income for very poor rural people. She expresses great satisfaction in having provided an income for so many people, as well as giving them creative opportunities and pride in their work. Observation of the surrounding villages suggests that she has indeed provided enough employment to make a significant difference to large numbers of families and has altered the socio-economic character of a number of nearby villages, which earn their major income from Kaross. Often a woman will bring her children and her

husband into the project as embroiderers, providing the family with a significant income.⁹ The embroiderers are paid per item when they bring in the embroidered cloths. Wages might be low by South African standards, but are high for a remote rural area. There are set rates for cloths of particular sizes, calculated by a formula worked out by van Rooyen according to the amount of yarn used and an estimate of the time taken. The bigger, more complex cloths are given only to the best embroiderers, who are paid at a higher rate (almost double the rate for the 'house' cloths). The workers' incomes are thus influenced by their skills and speed. The embroiderers who live nearby often choose to work at Kaross and many do so on the days they deliver the work, but most of them work from their own homes in nearby villages. This is advantageous, as it allows the embroiderers to run their homes, tend their families while they work and have no transport costs.

Van Rooyen has a central role as the business manager at Kaross, but the enterprise also employs a bookkeeper, three designers and van Rooyen's daughter. Finally, a number of seamstresses are employed full time to finish and sew the embroidered cloths into cushion covers, wall hangings etc. In total, approximately twenty people are employed full time and receive salaries. The designers, in addition, are paid bonuses for the more complex and larger cloths. Thus, pay and labor systems are flexible but systematized.

The growth of the business was organic and required no external funding or capital. As with the Ardmore example, van Rooyen had access to initial resources in the form of extant buildings, training and family income. Subsequent expansion led to the purchase of a second small farm and the conversion of its buildings into attractive, enormous workrooms, display areas, offices and a restaurant. The business subsequently expanded again, purchasing a house in Johannesburg as a showroom. In general, Kaross does little marketing and other enterprises have tended to do the marketing on the enterprise's behalf. Tiger's Eye, which buys the bulk of Kaross's production and then supplies its chain of tourist shops, has its own established marketing strategies, benefitting Kaross. Such a partnership is of great advantage to a craft enterprise.

Kaross's selling prices vary. The small 'house' lines are relatively inexpensive for such labor-intensive and time-consuming products. Van Rooyen is introducing even smaller products (napkins and small bags) that sell at even more reasonable prices to cater (partially) for the demand from

Tiger's Eye's expansion across South Africa. By contrast, the large interior wall hangings are extremely expensive.

New workers are not trained, but must demonstrate embroidery skills. They apply by bringing in a piece of embroidery that they have made independently, using off-cuts provided by Kaross. This is assessed: if they do their own drawings, avoid copying an existing Kaross design and produce stitching of the required quality, they are taken on. At present, Kaross is engaging approximately ten new embroiderers a week—a rapid expansion. This has resulted in the development of a burgeoning 'tradition' and culture of embroidery in the area. It is a common sight to see entire families sitting embroidering under trees in the nearby villages.

Once an embroiderer is part of the enterprise, each piece that he or she delivers is assessed and discussed with them, enhancing product quality. The environment of Kaross is an attractive one and very few people voluntarily leave the enterprise (perhaps, admittedly so, for lack of other opportunities).

Van Rooyen believes that the excellent quality and beauty of products is an essential ingredient for a successful craft enterprise (van Rooyen 2007). She is critical of money spent on starting craft enterprises which cannot succeed because they make poor, unsaleable products. By contrast, Kaross is a well-established, well-managed enterprise with inspired leadership and a long history, creating many employment opportunities and generating products of exceptional quality.

Conclusion

Clearly, there are many similarities between Morris & Co. and the two South African craft enterprises described here. From our comparative analysis, we have identified the following approaches as being common to all three, indicating a set of successful strategies for craft enterprise development:

Products and design

- (1) Good design
- (2) A variety of approaches, products and prices. Successful craft enterprises offer ranges of products at different prices: 'house' lines are simpler, smaller products, produced quickly, remaining popular with buyers and thus produced throughout the existence of the enterprise. Critically, however, the successful enterprise must produce more elaborate, larger exhibition pieces that require more time and skills to make.
- (3) Products are unique, innovative and recognizable as coming from one enterprise, with a coherent regional or heritage-based style across all products.
- (4) Products are marketable because of the above.
- (5) Recognizable sources of visual and cultural inspiration seem vital.
- (6) Appropriate materials and technologies need to be selected that speak to the locality, market and skills base.
- (7) Skilled production and skilled craftsmanship are essential.
- (8) Quality (quality control mechanisms) must be maintained.
- (9) The enterprise has the guidance, control and inspiration of a leader who benefits from art-design competence, who may be the owner, manager or head designer of the enterprise and who may work alone or be assisted by a team.

Business principles

- (1) The enterprise has an initial financial resource base, which is not essential thereafter.
- (2) The marketing and the publicizing of products are crucial from the inception of the enterprise (and are usually managed by one person). [10](#)
- (3) With enterprise growth, formal management systems must be established: systems of payment, financial control, ordering raw materials, controlling materials and wastage, paying taxes, packing, posting, transport; record keeping etc.

Labor practices

- (1) Sustainable craft enterprises require flexible employment systems. Generally, a few people are employed full-time as designers, managers, marketers and administrators, or in finishing off products. The majority are part-time workers who are paid for their piece work. This system, while cost effective and practical, is fairer if the enterprise can pay the workers on delivery rather than when those pieces sell.
- (2) Training is offered and often takes the form of learning-by-doing.
- (3) There is a low turnover of labor: employees have fair wages and good working environments, with a degree of job satisfaction.

Collectively, these strategies appear to offer a successful model for the development of a successful, sustainable craft-based enterprise that can be large in scale. Thus, we conclude that Morris & Co. can provide a powerful example for contemporary craft enterprises in South Africa.

Notes

- 1 The current unemployment rate is approximately 26%, and this is exacerbated by the statistic that in the age group 15–24, the rate is above 50% (South Africa Unemployment Rate).
- 2 For extensive debate around this, see Hallam and Ingold (2007) and Phillips and Steiner (1999).
- 3 The sources used include both primary sources, such as the minute books of Morris & Co., the products of the company and the letters and lectures of William Morris and secondary sources, namely the many biographies and commentaries on Morris written since his death.
- 4 This practice, which seems to suggest underpayment, and may seem to suggest exploitation, is in fact the product of a generally flexible labor market, coupled with job security, job satisfaction and good working conditions.
- 5 In each case, Stevens visited the enterprise, observing the workplace and interviewing the enterprise's leader, i.e., the owner or manager, as well as other craftspeople. In the case where there was more than one such site, she visited both and, in cases where the craftspeople worked from their homes, she visited a small number of them in their homes. She also visited the showrooms, selected retail outlets and galleries where the craft products were sold in order to view the finished products at their points of marketing. She investigated the Internet websites and other textual data. This was limited or non-existent, and what there was, was generally of a promotional and commercial nature. Thus there was little or no theoretical or scholarly data available (See Stevens 2007).
- 6 An example is R 120,000 (U.S. \$12,000 approximately) paid in 2007 for an elaborate modeled vase, while an eggcup might sell for R 1,300 (U.S. \$130). For examples of a variety of works, visit Charles Greig (2015).

- 7 This donor funding was earmarked not for production but specifically for the establishment of the excellence fund (Halstead-Berning 2007).
- 8 This museum is adjacent to the workshops at Caversham and was established in memory of Ntshalintshali. It houses a large collection of her works as well as works by other Ardmore artists.
- 9 The monthly earnings of the embroiderers, who are paid per completed piece, vary from about R 800 to R 1,500 (U.S. \$80 to U.S. \$150), or up to R 3,000 (U.S. \$300) for a family where more than one person embroiders (van Rooyen 2007). This can be compared to a minimum monthly wage of R 2,274 (U.S. \$227) for farm workers and R 1,491 (U.S. \$149) for domestic workers (Minimum Wages for Domestic Workers 2014), which is overwhelmingly the only other work that might be available in the location.
- 10 Although Kaross does little of its own marketing, its products are extensively marketed by Tiger's Eye.

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12

Collaborative South African Fieldwork Community Arts Development Program

Janine Lewis and Thabiso Qwabe

Advancement of proficiency in South African performing arts rests in the widespread dissemination of hybrid theater skills and education. For this purpose, the South African State Theatre joined forces with the Tshwane University of Technology (TUT) Drama Programme to establish the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme in 2007. This chapter serves to detail how the program has evolved over the years, affirming the development of new and intuitive ways of addressing the artistic training needs identified to empower communities whilst providing insight into an innovative and promising funding model.

Following South Africa's chequered political history through colonialism and apartheid ¹ and culminating in the onset of the democratic revolution of 1994, much of the available state-based arts funding has been rerouted to address broader development needs. Whilst this redress has been necessary, the implementation of the process could have been more effectively executed. From outside the country, the view of the democratization of the arts is seen as promising. Michael Kaiser (an international arts management expert with experience working in South Africa) has reflected on the changed focus in South Africa's arts funding since 1994, through which '[a] serious effort to redirect arts funding to indigenous groups was pursued.' 'Today,' he concludes 'South Africa can boast of a truly diverse range of

arts organizations producing everything from opera to African dance to a cappella choruses. Arts funding is not perfect—where is it perfect?—but it is growing and changing (Kaiser 2013). However, from within the South African arts sector, the view is not as glowing. Bunn (2009, p. 1) writes, ‘We are in a sorry state, it is clear, and, in close association with this crisis, the arts funding landscape is one of the sorriest of all.’ He goes on, ‘In the climate of reconstruction that followed [1994 democracy], some of the older stereotypes of art and direct action survived into the new arts funding models, while the visibility of artists as public intellectuals active in the making of culture and citizenship declined sharply’ (2009, p. 1).

With the building of a new democracy through neo-liberal economic development, the government’s limited reserves have been distributed to the various sectors under the discretion of need and importance, resulting in arts funding being severely curtailed and the allocation of funding regulated through the establishment of the National Arts Council created to redistribute these funds. The National Arts Council (NAC) of South Africa is a national agency mandated by the Department of Arts and Culture, established in April 1997 through an act of parliament (Act No. 56 of 1997), with the responsibility of developing South Africa’s creative industries by awarding grants to individuals and organizations in the arts. The vision of the NAC is to promote, through the arts, the free expression of South Africa’s cultures and to develop and promote excellence in the arts. The NAC operates by inviting applicants to submit their project proposals and applications for bursaries once per annum, and an independent panel of experts in each of the seven arts disciplines then adjudicates on each application and makes recommendations to council. However, as Bunn (2009, p. 10) suggests with regard to arts funding: ‘There must be a more aggressive engagement with other arms of government, most especially the Department of Arts and Culture, the National Lottery, the Provincial Arts Councils, and the Department of Education. The NAC simply has to have more money for disbursement. With the present level of funding, it may not be worth having the NAC as a disbursement agency at all, and it is certainly not worth having panels.’ An ever-dwindling funding base and increasing competition for scarce artistic resources continues to pose a serious challenge to the arts sector in South Africa.

As a result, artists are largely left to the mercy of the markets, yet the corporate and wealthy sectors of South African society view artists as mere

entertainment to liven up events or express national pride. Even in the case of the NAC, Meersman (2012) argues, ‘the market paradigm has “unintentionally” seen the vast majority of funds go directly or indirectly to centers and institutions that favor commercial work and spectacle.’ While this suggests that the arts have the potential to be commercially viable, artists themselves are still being marginalized in that they do not receive appropriate monetary compensation for their efforts. Even the commercial arts sector cannot compare with the huge endorsements given to the area of sports, the benefits of which do filter down to the sportspersons. Meersman (2012) is more explicit in his lament on the current state of affairs for South African artists in an opinion piece subtitled ‘Funding shortages, political meddling and a lack of interest and understanding from audiences and government have left SA artists out in the cold.’ He argues that ‘[t]he government and the private sector are big on lip service and acknowledging the artists’ importance in the abstract, but have to date overall dismally failed to respond to this constituency.’

Within this arena of contested funding is an increasing need for redress in terms of directing funding to sectors that were previously disadvantaged. This perspective was advanced in the National Arts Council Act of 1997, which included two key mandates: ‘to give the historically disadvantaged such additional help and resources as are required to give them greater access to the arts’ and ‘to address historical imbalances in the provision of infrastructure for the promotion of the arts’ (as described by Bunn 2009, p. 2). These directives are in line with Todaro and Smith’s (2012, p. 16) approach to development as a ‘multidimensional process involving major changes in social structures, popular attitudes, and national institutions, as well as the acceleration of economic growth, the reduction of inequality and the eradication of poverty.’ As an instrumentalization of the arts linked to a multidimensional understanding of development focused on core values of sustenance, self-esteem and freedom (Todaro and Smith 2012), this proposed reorganization and reorientation has merit. However, 20 years into South Africa’s young democracy and throttled by limited funding, the artists and performing arts companies creating work that is deemed worthy of state investment are still required to meet an almost debilitating set of hurdles—including proof of transformation, inclusion of people with disabilities, conducting workshops (especially in areas deemed previously disadvantaged) and, at times, complying with political agendas. State

funding is also sought from departments other than the National Arts Council, where the conditions include raising awareness of social issues or shifting focus to include knowledge transfer and upliftment. The Departments of Education and Health often successfully employ artists to drive their campaigns. However, as the focus is not on the practice of the arts, often the projects' successes are jeopardized by a lack of adequate skills and training, or are pure exploitation (of and by the 'artists' involved).

South African playwright and veteran arts activist, Mike van Graan further summarizes post-apartheid democratization specifically within the performing arts industry in South Africa:

The divisions within the arts community—principally, highly skilled and resourced Afrikaans practitioners and audiences on the one hand and “the rest” on the other—represents a failure of vision, imagination and strategic management as the “haves” in terms of skills, resources and expertise have got richer and the have-nots have generally been left to scrap over what public funding is made available; a huge opportunity to utilise the skills, expertise, resources across the country has been lost through political short sightedness and an absence of vision.

(Mike van Graan in Meersman 2012)

We argue that it is this broadening of arts education and exposure to high-quality theater through skills transfer that is the answer to the development of the performing arts in South Africa, to reduce the gap that van Graan identifies. This also responds to the question of development, as a multidimensional concept and not simply as synonymous with economic growth. Sen (1999) argues that all individuals are gifted with capabilities and realizing these capabilities will allow a person to escape from poverty and their state of ‘unfreedom.’ ²

In this chapter, we propose that the key for development in the South African arts rests in the widespread dissemination of hybrid performance skills and education. Most governmental schools do not offer arts as part of the curriculum, nor do they have effective extramural opportunities in many of the suburbs or townships throughout the country, resulting in many artistic skills and abilities not being identified or nurtured. Most communities, however, have managed to create their own community theater groups that meet together and create performances that speak to the social circumstances within their direct environments. These community groups (comprising young, jobless adults and youth from the area) are often spearheaded by entrepreneurial residents that see the opportunity to access

funding from the state or health and welfare centers to generate job creation. However, very few of these entrepreneur group leaders or performers have been exposed to the arts or performance training either at school or at tertiary level and are therefore relying purely on their limited knowledge of and exposure to the local media for inspiration. This results in the perpetuation of elementary faults and pitfalls in performance creation and production skills. Works generated by these groups engage with the specific stories from their communities and incorporate a variety of raw talents that display presence and magnetism in dancing, music and singing, yet the performances remain unsophisticated role-play demonstrations of culturally inherited skills (often including those not specific to their own region) along with didactic storytelling that displays little or no scripting finesse. In some of the provinces, cultural centers have been established to address such needs in arts development, and many of the regional theater complexes have been transformed into cultural hubs. These regional cultural centers should be nurtured and fed with competent, educated facilitators that can effectively assist in the development of new works and performance abilities in the arts. It is within such centers that real transformation in the performing arts in terms of representation and the creation of new works may be incubated. The opportunity to facilitate the micro-redistribution of the funding within these centers also needs to be adequately managed.

The South African State Theatre is one such organization that has had the insight to successfully secure funding from the state and the National Lottery in order to productively drive projects that strive to develop the arts community through skills dissemination and education, primarily in the Gauteng province. The South African State Theatre believes that training and education are key developmental aspects and integral to the proliferation of the arts.

If theatre is to succeed tomorrow; then we [the State Theatre] need to create ample opportunities for development of new artists, new audiences and for the creation of new theatre today. Our various programs are an endeavour towards ensuring that the arts take their rightful position in the whole context of cultural heritage development, moral re-generation and entertainment.

(SA State Theatre 2013)

In order to achieve these goals, the South African State Theatre established a Development Department in 2002 as a center of excellence for

developing artists and to support the presence and availability of sustainable, quality South African artistic products. To this end, in 2007 the South African State Theatre joined forces with the TUT Drama Programme to establish the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme. This program offers theater community groups development in dramatic arts education, as well as an opportunity to showcase their work in a professional theater environment.

This chapter details how the collaborative program has evolved over the years, affirming the development of new and intuitive ways of addressing the artistic training needs identified in the communities in and around the greater Tshwane Metropolitan area located in Gauteng, South Africa.

Scope

The aim of the State Theatre Development Department is to nurture up-and-coming young talent by creating ample opportunities for development of new artists, new audiences and for the creation of new theater today in order to ensure that South African theater is to succeed in the future. Currently, the Development Department has five programs, all dedicated to ensuring that theater has visibility and is available to all South Africans, and into which the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme fits. Through the experiential Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme, the State Theatre, in collaboration with TUT Drama, seek to develop quality artistic works and to bridge the gap between the developing and mainstream arts, business, academia and the community. A memorandum of understanding between the State Theatre and TUT Drama Programme was signed in 2008 and is binding for 10 years. Within this time, both parties are equally responsible for the progress and enrichment of the program to the mutual benefit of the students and targeted communities at large.

The program is characterized by a multidimensional approach to arts practice and community development objectives and a commitment to high quality theater for both artists and audiences. As the program has developed, the key stakeholders have consulted various forums in order to shape the goals and objectives for the project, and they continue to refine

these through adherence to publications such as the second revision of the 1996 Department of Arts and Culture White Paper on Arts, Culture and Heritage (2013), the 2010–2014 Medium Term Strategic Framework for Arts and Culture (DAC, (DAC, The Medium Term Strategic Framework for the Department of Arts and Culture 2009), and the adoption of the National Development Plan (NDP) with its vision for 2030 (2011). Although the NDP does not have a section dedicated to the arts, the program aligned its objectives to aspects relating to the areas of improving education, innovation and training as well as transforming society and uniting the country. The program now encompasses three core objectives: developing the arts, developing the artists and developing audiences, as elaborated in [Table 12.1](#).

In its first seven years, the fieldwork program has managed to annually incorporate an average of ≥ 150 community artists. The participants have an opportunity to showcase their projects generated from the fieldworker interventions to the general public at the State Theatre complex twice annually, and this forms part of the logistical infrastructure of the program.

[Table 12.1](#) The Objectives of the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme

The overall objective of the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme is to give community art groups enough information to entrench the South African theater tradition and create quality stage productions that will:

Develop the Arts

- Excite, delight and inspire audiences and the community at large;
- Challenge the performers to create premier dramatic work that interrogates, reflects, makes new discoveries and examines the current cultural paradigm in which South Africans live in order to entertain, excite, delight, appeal to the heart and the mind and reflect the country's multicultural narratives;

Develop the Artists

- Demonstrate vision, dynamism and artistic excellence in the promotion and development of the performing arts in South Africa;
- Ensure growth in the arts to the point where theater becomes second nature to children and adults and may compete with sport on a national level.
- Provide training, guidance and development of performers, writers, directors, producers, stage managers, technicians and entrepreneurs in the arts and entertainment industry;
- offer opportunities for the fieldworkers to attain experience in their fields of expertise.

Develop Audiences

- Educate the public about theater and theatrical work;
- Make theater accessible to disadvantaged communities;
- Appeal to a broader community and make all exposed to the arts proud to be a part of the development and transformation of a nation through mutual storytelling opportunities³
- both to have the opportunity to tell their story, and to have their stories heard.

Source: Compiled the by the authors, drawing on SA State Theatre 2013.

Selection Criteria

The State Theatre sends out an annual open call to all community theater groups to apply for participation in the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme. When accepted, the group will be included for a period of two consecutive years within the program, dependent on their

participation and development during this timeframe. At strategic points within the program, quality assessments are carried out to ensure these requirements are adequately met, as discussed below.

Selection criteria include the screening of completed application forms. Groups are required to work predominantly in drama (as opposed to purely dance, for example), have a minimum of ten members and should be from a historically disadvantaged area (township) ⁴ in the greater Tshwane Metropolitan area. The community groups include scholars, students and unemployed or employed youth/young adults. Depending on the development of the community infrastructure and financial circumstances of the group (for example, paying for rehearsal space) these groups rehearse in the specific community's school classrooms after a school day, community halls when space is available and permitted, under trees, or in the home or yards of a member of the group (most usually the leader) and, if the group is in close proximity, at the South African State Theatre. Successful community groups are invited to attend Phase One of the practical selection process: a closed showcase of their work (that precedes program involvement) from which fifteen groups are selected to participate in the second phase of selection. Phase Two involves demonstration of their abilities in a designated slot at the Mzansi Fela festival. From their participation at the festival, the successful groups selected for the program are announced.

Besides the participating community groups, fieldworkers and quality controllers are identified to work with the program. Once the community groups have been identified, a fieldworker is assigned to work with each group for the duration of the project. These fieldworkers are sourced from the alumni and B Tech degree (fourth year) students within the TUT Drama Programme. Each fieldworker is required to demonstrate good leadership and facilitation skills and should have specialized in at least directing or applied theater ⁵ during their studies. Each fieldworker is assigned only one group and is required to assist in the development of a production within the year, as well as to improve general performance skills, including acting, physical performance, voice and speech. The fieldworkers are employed by the State Theatre and are required to visit the community groups: twenty-four hours in a month for the first year of the project, and thirty-two hours a month for the groups participating in the second year of the project.

Progress reports are submitted by the fieldworkers to the development office at the State Theatre.

Quality controllers have been added to the program to ensure that the work done by the fieldworkers and community groups is of a high standard and to evaluate the groups as to their progress. The quality controllers work with the groups and assist the fieldworkers, and they also serve as adjudicators at the final showcase during the Mzansi Fela Festival (Mahlabe 2013). Quality controllers are sourced annually from representatives from within the performing arts industry and the staff of TUT Drama Programme.

Requirements

During the first year of participation within the program, a community group is required to select a published or reputable South African script [6](#) and produce this work for a public showcase. This includes understanding the premise of text analysis, technical preparation and scenography—design elements, rudiments of directing, character development and stage management.

The groups (or designated members) will also be required to attend workshops hosted by the State Theatre, which include theatrical production aspects such as scriptwriting, stage management and business management. A selection of these workshops is presented annually by professionals in their respective fields of specialization, with the past two years seeing a shift to focus more on arts administration and business management. Groups are also invited to professional productions at the State Theatre and often get to interact with professional directors and performers in informal discussions after these shows.

In the second year of participation, the community groups are required to devise a new work or adapt an established piece of world literature. In so doing, the group is required to exercise and apply what they have learnt in the first year towards creating their own work. This further allows the group to develop their own voice and to tell their own stories, providing a fresh platform for script development and storytelling. The groups are again included in workshops offered by the theater and included in the

professional theater forum. The participating community groups then have to present their work at two annual public showcases: the Youth Festival in June and the Mzansi Fela Festival in December.

Youth Festival

The Youth Festival coincides with National Youth Day's June celebrations and may include performances from any community. It is, however, not compulsory for the groups participating in the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme to perform, but they are evaluated at this time to assess their development. This preparation has been done only with the assistance from their designated fieldworkers and is subject to assessment by the quality controllers. As a platform to celebrate youth in theater arts in the country, the festival is not a competition and there are no prizes. Instead, areas of need and specific intervention are identified for each group. These areas of development are then focused on in rehearsals for the second half of the year and skills honed for the groups' final showcase in December at the Mzansi Fela Festival.



Source: ICJ Rehearsals in the community environment and at the State Theatre.

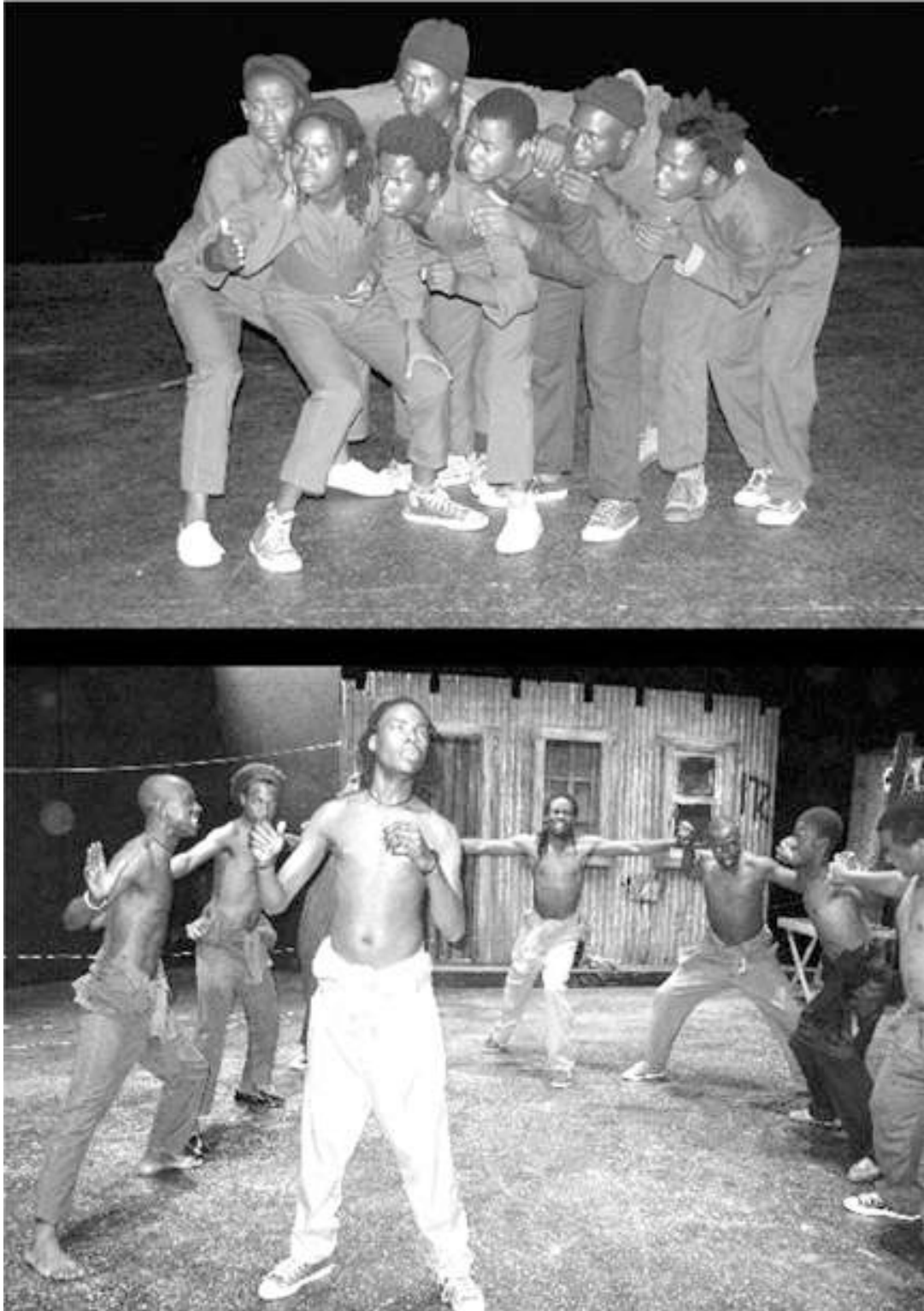
Mzansi Fela Festival

The Mzansi Fela Festival has become one of the most anticipated festivals of the year in the Tshwane Metropolitan area. Launched in 2007, the festival presents music, theater, dance, comedy and poetry from South African performers. Although this festival has grown to include mainstream theater performances as well as professional stand-up comedy, performance poetry, DJs, jazz and singers, it was initiated as an outlet for the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme. This is the platform where the community groups present the culmination of their work over the year and compete for accolades at the Development Awards Ceremony, and it serves to unearth the next generations of writers, directors and actors (see Figures 12.2, 12.3 and 12.4 for performances by community groups presented at the festival). The quality controllers act as adjudicators for the duration of this festival and deliberate on a range of awards that includes: Best Actor; Best Actress; Best Supporting Actor; Best Supporting Actress; Best Use of Costume; Best Use of Set, Props and Décor; Most Promising Play Script; Best Director; Best Overall Production. At this festival, the announcement is made regarding newcomers to the program in the form of successful community groups identified to start participating from the following year.

Over the years, a variety of invigorating ways have emerged to open the festival, including a march through the streets of the center of Pretoria with



Figure 12.3 Performance at the Mzansi Fela, State Theatre, 2009.



[Source: 123](#) Performance by Mzansi Fela, State Theatre, 2009.



Figure 12.4 Street performance at the Mzansi Fela, State Theatre, 2009.

community performers, professional street artists, TUT theater students and others. The opening is always created as an opportunity for participants and the general public alike to get involved and to generate excitement for the two-week program ahead. It is seen as an ideal occasion to introduce all involved to a variety of performance styles that people may otherwise not have been privy to. For example, in 2013, the festival was launched with a Jazz and African Music Night, the scale and professionalism of which had not been experienced by a vast sector of society, and to which they now were afforded free access. As a festival, the Mzansi Fela aspires to educate and entertain audiences in and around the Tshwane Metropolitan area. It strives to provide a performance platform for local artists from all walks of life and proudly promotes South African artworks while it creates a platform for the development of new theater work in South Africa and develops up-and-coming performers.

Impact

The TUT is a proud product of South Africa's first decade of democracy and is known for the quality of its teaching, research and community engagement.⁷

For the TUT Department of Drama and Film, this project has been valuable in cementing a solid collaboration with the State Theatre. Through involvement in this community engagement project, the drama program has also successfully met the intrinsic requirements of the university's mission to partner with communities in sustainable development, whilst offering career-focused and quality-driven learning opportunities for students. The academic environment at the university is increasingly focusing on applied research and community engagement activities in addition to career-orientated vocational training. Caring for the underprivileged, the upliftment of people and assisting those in need are key elements of the university's community engagement strategy.

This Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme may also be seen as contributing to the recruitment of quality candidates to further their studies at the TUT drama program and other programs within TUT Faculty of the Arts. In this manner, the Fieldwork Programme acts as a bridging incubator where fundamental skills of performance and the theater industry are instilled in community artists. These skills are nurtured through the two-year program, which allows for the artists (technician and/or actor alike) to hone their talents and make their entrance to the university more viable. The university does not offer automatic entrance for these prospective students: they are still required to undergo the prerequisite screenings and go through interviews and audition processes. The Department of Drama and Film has seen a marked increase in participants from this project who are seeking a qualification primarily within the drama program but also in the film program. Other departments within the Faculty of the Arts that have also benefitted from this community engagement program include the Departments of Entertainment Technology and Musical Theatre. There are various success stories of how community participants have gone on to acquire their degree and have made strides in the industry, noted below.

By functioning as fieldworkers in the development program, students (and recent alumni) apply their knowledge gleaned in the classroom and implement their career-driven practice through work-integrated learning. The State Theatre offers opportunities to identified groups and fieldworkers alike to stage a semi-professional show during or after the program, which

may include tours to other national theaters and/or to the annual National Arts Festival in Grahamstown, Eastern Cape. Many of the fieldworkers have been identified as admirable directors and facilitators through their involvement in this project and have gone on to be nurtured within the State Theatre as valuable administrative staff and as directors in their own right. Through the technical component of this project the State Theatre continues to train, ensure quality and elevate marginalized productions into the mainstream as well as facilitate their competitiveness and sustainability.

The Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme has successfully managed to stimulate audience development through an increase in community awareness of theater that is progressively growing year by year. The various communities come and support their designated group of artists that are participating in the project and, in so doing, get exposed to the workings of a professional theater and may also be introduced to modes of performance not previously witnessed. Therefore, the program has indirectly served to elevate the standard of performance from the discernable perspective of both the performer and the spectator, as well as expand the palette of productions and performances on offer to include a variety of multicultural offerings.

Success Stories

Since 2007, the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme has impacted over 100 community art groups. Moreover, the program has afforded seven community groups an opportunity to stage semi-professional shows at the Momentum Theatre ⁸ as well as various stages around the Gauteng communities. A further 39 community members have trained as stage managers, and all groups now have a more comprehensive understanding of business acumen, marketing, leadership and management skills. This training in business and marketing supports the entrepreneurial nature of the community groups that participate and has improved their project management and financial independence, offering more sustained income for all the group members. There has also been a shift from merely incorporating community groups to including school groups (primary and secondary) who offer theater as an extramural activity to the learners, which

contributes to the diversity of the project. At least 40 community group performers have gone on to study at the TUT drama department alone; ⁹ there are many still in the undergraduate course, with 10 having completed their fourth-year B Tech Drama degree.

Two students who were associated with the fieldwork program and who specialized in directing in their B Tech Drama degree, were taken into the State Theatre and further afforded the opportunity to direct professional productions at the theater complex as part of the 52 Seasons initiative. The 52 Seasons initiative is also funded by the theater in conjunction with the National Arts Council and serves to provide directors, writers, choreographers, actors, poets and musicians with week-long seasons to stage their productions at the Momentum Theatre at the State Theatre complex, at no cost. These productions, developed by the two young directors, Clive Mathibe and Princess Mhlongo, went on to enjoy successful runs at other national theaters including the Market Theatre in Johannesburg and at the National Arts Festival. Princess Mhlongo has since been awarded the Standard Bank Young Artist of the Year Award for Theatre in 2012 by the National Arts Festival and has also showcased various works on the international stages at the Salzburg Festival and the Edinburgh Fringe Festival.

Perhaps the most heartwarming accounts are of those participants that started as community artists, then became students and returned to the program as facilitators. One such story is of Kgaogelo Tshabalala, who started in the Fieldwork Programme for two years and went on to complete her four-year B Tech Drama degree. In her fourth year of study, Tshabalala returned to the program as a fieldworker, and the following year saw her directing more than one professional production in the State Theatre in shows that included other TUT alumni performers. This bodes well for Tshabalala's future and demonstrates an ingrained desire to give back to the community from whence she came.

Recent ex-students of the Fieldwork Community Programme who are currently undergraduate students within the TUT Drama Programme are also volunteering to return and help with the organization of the Mzansi Fela Festival in the capacity of stage managers, assistant directors and the like. The Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme continues to grow from strength to strength, adding such unexpected developments to a flourishing program.

Conclusion

Although South African arts funding is increasingly reduced in light of more pressing and urgent demands from a nation still steeped in crime and abject poverty and where education and health care should take priority for public funds, the existence of innovative collaborations such as this one between the South African State Theatre and Tshwane University of Technology Drama Programme are encouraging. As Kaiser (2013) has noted, arts funding is not perfect in South Africa, but it is changing. As a facet of this change, perhaps it is appropriate for funding to be channelled to institutions and established organizations that will endeavor to utilize it for valuable, sustainable and developmental projects, as opposed to funding independent artists who may still have a long way to go to prove their worth. In a country clouded by corruption and fraud in economically mismanaged projects, it is difficult to ensure that funding will be wisely spent. However, making the theater complexes that are already primed to service the communities the hub for appropriate distribution of such funds may be more viable, especially if those theaters partner with other reputable institutions and companies. Certainly, the example of the Fieldwork Community Arts Development Programme demonstrates that commitments can be made to communities, to high-quality arts and to the sustainable development of South African theater at large.

Notes

- 1 Apartheid, which means ‘the state of being apart,’ was a system of racial segregation in South Africa enforced through legislation by the ruling National Party government from 1948 to 1994, under which the rights of the majority black inhabitants were curtailed and Afrikaner minority rule was maintained. During this time, the government allocated ample funding towards regional arts councils that fostered young artists and established a thriving theater culture (albeit one-sided) through travelling performances and the upkeep of large theater complexes in the main city centers.
- 2 Sen (1999) argues that limiting factors like a lack of education, illiteracy, poor health and malnutrition contribute to a situation of ‘unfreedom.’
- 3 Oral tradition is inherent to Africa and includes the audience in the experience of the storytelling through participation. Stories are of the oral tradition and come alive through the telling,

especially in the telling where the expectation is that listeners will visualize themselves in the action.

- 4 'Historically disadvantaged area' is a generic term referring to the designated areas under the apartheid system that isolated non-white communities into living outside of the central business districts of towns and cities across the country. These designated areas are also known as 'townships' or 'locations.'
- 5 Applied theater springs from the desire to change or transform human behavior through the medium of theater. Applied theater utilizes the medium of theater to teach others, helps communities deal with issues and gives voice to the views of the silent and the marginalized. Applied theater is an umbrella term for all styles committed to utilizing theater for social change. The performances are usually played in spaces that are not usually defined as theater buildings, with participants who may or may not be skilled in theater arts and to audiences who have a vested interest in the issue taken up by the performance or are the members of the community addressed by the performance (Taylor 2003, pp. ii, 92). The term also includes other alternative theater practices variously labeled, such as: grassroots theater, theater for development, theater of the oppressed and theater in education.
- 6 Often, South African scripts have been developed through collaborative theater-making practices and although are readily available, have not been published in an official format. Relevant performance rights are secured for reproduction of all these works utilized within the Fieldwork Program.
- 7 Refer to the Tshwane University of Technology's website for a more comprehensive overview of the institution. Online: www.tut.ac.za (accessed 3 December 2015).
- 8 The Momentum Theatre is a small, black-box style theater within the South African State Theatre cluster that has a seating capacity of 120. Refer to the State Theatre's website for an overview of the complex. Online: www.statetheatre.co.za (accessed 3 December 2015).
- 9 Access into the TUT drama program is stringent and requires both academic prowess as well as practical demonstration in the form of an audition. There are over 300 applicants annually to the drama program, and only 45 are accepted on merit.

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Part Four

The Question of Evaluation

14

Evaluation Practices in Participatory Arts in International Development

Findings of a Systematic Literature Review

Kim Dunphy and Vicki-Ann Ware

Introduction

The task of international development is to improve human well-being, with priority placed on the reduction of poverty and suffering. Every day, 2.7 billion people earn less than \$2.50, 900 million people go to bed hungry and HIV/AIDS has tragic consequences for another 6,000 people (Clarke 2013, p. 219; Millennium Project n.d.). Participatory arts initiatives, including theater, dance, music, visual arts, creative writing and video making, are increasingly used to contribute to desired development outcomes, such as the Millennium Development Goals, which address hunger, universal education, gender equity, child health, maternal health, HIV/AIDS, environmental sustainability and global partnerships (see Harvey, Stuart and Swan 2000; Munier and Etherton 2006).

Arts initiatives addressing social change goals take place in a climate of growing accountability in international development (Kaufmann 2009; Vogel 2012). Funders encourage implementing organizations to seek the best outcomes relative to investment through initiatives delivering maximum benefits while causing least harm (Morra-Imas and Rist 2009; OECD 2010). Funded programs are increasingly expected to utilize

evidence-based approaches, make theories of change explicit and evaluate their work against clearly stated development objectives (Funnell and Rogers 2011). Monitoring and evaluation practices are increasingly employed so that impacts of development programs can be better understood and finite resources spent more wisely (DFTA 2014; OECD 2011).

A growing body of literature on arts-based initiatives documents their purported contribution to development outcomes. However, a scan of this research indicates that much of it seems not to include evaluation at all and, where evaluations are documented, they do not appear methodologically strong. As experienced practitioners of arts in development, we have been unaware of any substantial reviews of the evidence about our field. In the current climate of increased calls for development effectiveness, evidence-based practices and efficiency of expenditure of finite aid resources, a rigorous and reliable body of evidence is vital.

In response, this research contributes to understanding the potential of arts-based approaches to support international development. A systematic examination is offered of literature on the way artists, arts leaders and evaluators are substantiating claims about outcomes of arts-based programs in international development through their use of evaluation. The questions we address are: what evaluation practices are being undertaken in arts initiatives in the international development context? How rigorous is this work? What is missing?

An overview of the methods used to collect literature and the framework developed to analyse it are reported first, followed by findings about the evaluation practices of arts programs in development and two case studies of how evaluation has been applied. The validity of claims made by authors are discussed in light of these findings. Comparisons are made with evaluation practices in international development and the arts more broadly, and recommendations for future research are offered.

Literature Review: Evaluation in International Development and the Arts

Evaluation is a growing requirement of both international development and participatory arts practice, as agencies seek to better understand the effectiveness of their work and make better use of resources. The DAC Network on Development Evaluation defines evaluation as follows:

the systematic and objective assessment of an on-going or completed project, programme or policy, its design, implementation and results. The aim of evaluation is to determine the relevance and fulfillment of objectives, development efficiency, effectiveness, impact and sustainability.

(DAC 2008, p. 19)

A number of trends in international development attest to the growing emphasis on evaluation. The OECD laid out a range of principles for effective development in the Busan Partnership (OECD 2011). Donor countries have endorsed this agreement and established systems of regular program evaluations to measure effectiveness (for example, see DFAT 2014). This emphasis is also demonstrated in the activities of an active professional association such as IDEAS International (www.ideas-int.org), other international programs such as Initiatives for Impact Evaluation and the OECD's Quality Standards for Development Evaluation (OECD 2010). Evaluation (www.3ieimpact.org) is also increasingly becoming a standard requirement of aid funding. The USAID, for example, recommends that three per cent of program budgets are dedicated to evaluation (USAID 2011). Development agencies also increasingly demand evaluation skills. For example, the majority of employment positions and contracts for development work advertised in the ETAN bulletin (www.etan.org) in Timor-Leste between 2009 and 2014 request these skills.

An expanding body of literature also indicates the increasing sophistication of evaluation practice. Two significant themes in contemporary development evaluation are the focus on outcome rather than output and the importance of participation in the evaluation process (Morra-Imas and Rist 2009). Linda Morra-Imas and Ray Rist (2009) address the first in their comprehensive framework for results-based evaluation commissioned by the World Bank. In results-based approaches, evaluations do not simply measure what activity is undertaken, as is often the case in unsophisticated measurement frameworks, but the difference that is actually made by the activity. Nor do they support assumptions that change is beneficial. This framework recommends consideration of change across a

full spectrum: positive and negative, direct and indirect, intended or unintended (2009, p. 55).

The focus on participatory approaches in development over recent decades is reflected in new evaluation methodologies that accord value to participation of stakeholders (see for example, Lennie and Tacchi 2013). Most Significant Change (MSC) is one such methodology, conceived originally to evaluate multifaceted social projects in Bangladesh (Davies 1996) and now used extensively in different countries and contexts (Davies and Dart 2005). MSC provides a framework for systematic consideration of input from different stakeholders in any initiative, from program beneficiaries through to program managers and funders. It involves the collection of significant change stories from beneficiaries and the systematic selection of the most significant stories by stakeholders (Davies and Dart 2005). This method is seen to make a unique contribution to the understanding of real-world problems because it acknowledges different epistemologies alongside different values and worldviews.

Evaluation of participatory arts is also a burgeoning practice, but not yet as well developed. For example, there is no dedicated professional association or agreed professional standards, nor obvious movement towards these. No evidence of requirements for evaluation capacity was noted in arts vacancy advertisements on the Australian job website ArtsHub (www.artshub.com.au) over the same period of 2009 to 2014. This is despite evaluation taking place more frequently, across the spectrum from academic research to project-related assessments, driven by funder requirements for accountability and increasing interest by program hosts in effective practice.

An early article with international resonance was Matarasso's (1996) framework for evaluating arts programs, which proposed measures for the social impact of the arts, which had previously been considered unassessable. The most sophisticated new models for evaluating impact of arts participation consider not only outcomes but also processes by which outcomes are achieved. Boston Youth Arts, for example, developed a comprehensive model to measure the impact of arts participation on life success of young people. This model used a theory of change approach, i.e., a theory about how arts participation might elicit or stimulate change (Center for Theory of Change 2012). They posited and measured three levels of change that occur through arts participation: immediate

development of specific skills and competencies; intermediate outcomes including engagement, productivity and connection with others; and long-term outcomes of resiliency, self-efficacy, personal fulfilment and community engagement (Boston Youth Arts 2010).

Most Significant Change is also utilized in the evaluation of participatory arts programs (Johnson and Stanley 2007; Laidlaw Foundation 2010) to ensure the perspectives of different stakeholders are considered for any initiative. Margaret Kelaher et al. (2007) used MSC to evaluate arts companies with social change agendas in Victoria, Australia.

However, evaluation in both fields, international development and participatory arts, is neither ubiquitous nor uncontested. Much international development work occurs in the absence of well-developed evaluation practices, and the effectiveness of prevalent approaches is continually questioned. For example, a strong challenge to results-based management approaches arises from the focus on measuring outcomes, which is considered problematic in participatory development programs emphasizing process (Mango 2012). The concept of empowerment, which is central in development discourse, is considered particularly difficult to measure because of its intangible nature (Jupp, Ali and Barahona 2010).

In the arts, researchers' growing interest and the increasing requirements of funding bodies for project evaluation is not necessarily matched by enthusiasm from practitioners. The intuitive and emergent processes of art-making can be seen as antipathetic to analytical approaches required for evidence-based planning and evaluation (Conquergood 2002; Hill 2009). The paucity of relevant literature is both a symptom and an outcome of this, with practitioners not necessarily skilled or motivated to document their practice in these terms (Badham 2010; Cleveland 2005). This perpetuates the low use of professional literature in planning and reduces incremental progress that can be made by learning from others.

Training of practitioners that focuses on artform development and not the intentional thinking needed for attainment of specific goals is an additional challenge, and further difficulties are perceived in the lack of congruence between intuitive and practice-inspired approaches of art-making and the more reductionist approaches often applied in evaluation (Goldbard 2010; White 2006). Evaluation processes can be perceived by artists as unsatisfactory because they are being 'done to them' by evaluators who do not share or understand their values (Kelaher et al. 2007, p. 3).

Most significant of all are complexities around measuring value and the outcomes of arts engagement because of their perceived intangible nature. These difficulties are evidenced in persistent tensions about the intrinsic versus instrumental valuing of the arts (Carnwath and Brown 2014; Holden 2006; McCarthy et al. 2004; Throsby 2001).

Other barriers to the evaluation of arts programs include resource and skill limitations of arts organizations and the relative newness of many programs (Cleveland 2002, 2005; Sloman 2011). Consequently, evaluation is not often considered within arts project planning (Sloan 2008) and is generally unfunded and completed after the fact (Cleveland 2005; Mills and Brown 2003). This lack of focus on evaluation is evidenced in the program of *Performing The World*, an international conference on arts for social change held in New York. Of the hundreds of presentations made in 2012, only one discussed using formal evaluation approaches (Performing the World, 2012).

All these factors contribute to a lack of appropriate models for evaluating participatory arts initiatives that are satisfactory to stakeholders including practitioners, managers and funders. Consequently, the practice of arts as a social change mechanism involves sophisticated evaluation less often than might be desirable. Evidence about its potential contribution is consequently reduced, which can negatively impact allocation of resources, thereby reducing activity and the consequent potential for change.

Where the two professional fields come together, in arts applied in international development contexts, evidence suggests that evaluation is rarely strong. Michael Etherton and Tim Prenkti (2006, p. 144) comment that agencies supporting or practicing applied theater in international development in the UK largely do not undertake impact assessment, or if they do, only tangentially. A similar finding was made by the UK Department for International Development in their investigations of how major development agencies in the UK use arts initiatives in new approaches to development. Again, impact assessment was not undertaken regularly or systematically (Etherton and Prenkti 2006).

While differences exist between the disciplines of participatory arts and international development, there are also common concerns. These fields share the need for site- and community-specific evaluation approaches (Baker 2000; Cleveland 2005). Methodologies such as randomized controlled trials—highly valued in positivist research for their capacity to

indicate causation of change—can be difficult to implement in development and arts contexts.

In response to these issues, the following research study was undertaken to explore the range of methodologies used to evaluate arts in development and the degree to which claims about the impacts of arts in development are based on rigorous data collection and valid evidence.

Method

Search Criteria

Literature was searched for articles on arts initiatives undertaken in international development contexts, focusing on those that were (or discussed) evaluations of the initiatives. A wide range of humanities and social sciences databases were searched, including EbscoHost, PAIS International, APAIS, MLA International, JSTOR, ProQuest Dissertations and Theses, Bibliography of Asian Studies, SourceOECD, United Nations University Collection, Wiley online, World Bank eLibrary and Blackwell Synergy. Relevant journals were also hand-searched, including *Journal of Arts in Communities*, *International Journal of Community Music*, *Development in Practice*, *Development and Change* and *Development Communication*.

Reference snowballing techniques (Waddington et al. 2012) were also used, involving pursuit of references in identified papers. The amount of peer-reviewed literature in professional journals found was modest, so gray literature such as reports from development agencies and non-peer reviewed articles were also investigated. Google/Scholar was used to ensure a comprehensive search and key experts in the field also offered information on recent or ongoing studies.

The search primarily focused on studies sited in developing countries, identified as nations listed under ‘Medium human development’ and ‘Low human development’ in the *Inequality-adjusted Human Development Index* (UNDP 2014, pp. 168–71). However, due to the small numbers of studies identified, this analysis was supplemented with studies in lower socio-

economic communities in countries listed under ‘High human development,’ where similarities were perceived with international development issues.

Search terms included arts, culture, international development, music, dance, theater, drama, visual art and storytelling, trauma, peacebuilding, hygiene, advocacy, democracy, community building and the names of countries and regions. The timeframe covered the past twenty years (i.e., mid-1990s to the present day). Only material published in English was investigated. One article published by one of the current authors (Dunphy) was included, but it was analysed by the other member of the team to reduce the possibility of bias.

In total, 151 articles about arts initiatives in development contexts were located and examined, drawn from a potential pool of 546 articles that our search located, in turn drawn from a scan of 7,623 records.

Assessing the Quality of the Studies

The articles were analysed for types and the quality of the evaluation applied. Contemporary themes in development, discussed above, helped shape our framework of analysis. Articles were examined to determine the type of methodology used and why; whether they identified clear research questions and an evidence-based theory of change; focus on outcome rather than output; consideration of positive and negative, intended and unintended change; and participatory processes in evaluation. Dvora Yanow and Peregrine Schwartz-Shea’s (2006, p. 70) framework for assessing standards of qualitative research also assisted with determining methodological rigor. They recommend selection of the most *appropriate tool* to obtain data for the particular context selected from an established repertoire and then systematic analysis undertaken after ‘extended immersion in the data’ to allow ‘hypotheses or explanations to emerge’ (Yanow and Schwartz-Shea 2006, p. 71). Three further issues identified for investigation were issues of causality, timespan of evaluation and appropriateness of evaluators. The type of publication was noted as well, with the assumption that peer-reviewed publications had had some filter of

quality applied. The next section provides an overview of the studies and our findings.

Findings

Focus on Evaluation in Arts and International Development Literature

Our first finding was that, of this large sample of 151 studies, only 23 fitted our inclusion criteria that they either were, or included a focus on, evaluation. ¹ The majority of studies that did not include evaluation or any systematic approach to measurement of outcomes were program descriptions, often descriptive case studies (66 articles) or discussions of practice (17). A small number of articles (11) did include some critical reflection by artists or arts workers, but were not included in the evaluation sample if this was only a minor part of the article. Another subset of articles involved a research process other than evaluation (15), and a final group involved discussion of policy or practice issues (19).

Method/s of Evaluation Used

The 23 articles that included mention or application of evaluation were analysed in depth. Methodologies documented were both quantitative and qualitative. Two utilized quantitative approaches of randomized control trials only and three used mixed qualitative and quantitative methods, such as surveys and questionnaires. Sixteen articles applied qualitative-only approaches, with a combination of interviews and/or focus groups, along with participant observation by the evaluator as a frequently used strategy. Participatory Action Research (PAR) and Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA) were specific methodologies named in two studies, while Most Significant Change was applied in only one study. Two articles did not

discuss methodology at all, offering only unstructured practitioner reflection as findings.

Few qualitative studies offered a specific explanation for selection of their methodology, although 12 discussed use of methods that we judged as appropriate, in that they enabled collection of data that would answer the research questions or test their theory of change. The quantitative and mixed-method studies also appeared appropriate in their approaches, when that same criteria was applied.

Most studies were focused on assessment of outcomes, but the two offering practitioner reflections primarily examined program activities (outputs). The two articles discussing the use of PAR/PRA, despite identifying the importance of evaluation, did not clearly distinguish the research undertaken to facilitate development of a theater performance from an evaluation process to determine outcomes.

Collection and Analysis of Data

Many of the qualitative studies showed deficiencies in engagement with, and systematic analysis of, data. A further six studies were somewhat systematic in their analysis, but demonstrated a range of problems, such as insufficient data to substantiate claims despite evidence of engagement with it, or inadequate description of data in the article. Only four of the qualitative studies fully discussed the process of data analysis.

An overall lack of clear linkage between data collected and conclusions reached was evident. Only two-thirds of the studies offered a clear theory of change based on evidence, and several did not document specific research questions. Only two formally tested a hypothesis. Four qualitative studies made causal claims not supported by their data, with a further three suggesting some causality but acknowledging they could not fully support these claims. Of the quantitative and mixed-methods studies, only three of the five made claims about causality that were well supported by data.

Few articles discussed consideration of all possible outcomes, including negative and unexpected change, with more than half of the studies presuming change, and change in the direction *expected* and *positive*.

Timeframe of Evaluations

The timeframes of evaluations and examination of impacts were most often short term, with only one study utilizing a formal longitudinal element, with a six-month follow-up and comparison with a like project that had a twelve-month follow-up. However, several of the studies that incorporated sophisticated evaluator and practitioner analysis offered reflections on long-term engagements in communities even when formal longitudinal evaluation had not occurred. Most evaluators recommended longer-term processes or follow-up than they were able to implement themselves.

Two articles documented interesting efforts to understand longer-term impact of arts initiatives. Both these efforts were relatively informal and not part of a structured program design. Asif Munier and Michael Etherton (2006) discussed their return, at their own initiative, to sites where they had conducted arts initiatives five years earlier. They used informal interviews with former program participants to assess any lasting impacts of their work. Marcia Nogueira (2006) used interviews with local residents to consider outcomes of two programs she had undertaken in the same location almost a decade apart. By comparing outcomes of the first program with the second, noting changes that local residents attributed to the programs, she was able to draw conclusions about longitudinal change in the community.

Participation of stakeholders in evaluations seemed limited, with just six studies documenting participatory evaluation approaches. As mentioned previously, two of these conflated use of Participatory Action Research and Participatory Rural Appraisal in the development of the arts project with the evaluation process, leaving only four that really involved stakeholders in decision-making about evaluation processes.

One other problematic conflation was that of the roles of program developers, implementers and evaluators. The majority of articles involving qualitative methods were written by people who had all three of these roles in their projects simultaneously. While there were definite strengths in this fact, given these authors' detailed knowledge and engagement in the projects, the potential for biased or limited perspectives was very real.

The majority of the studies analyzed were published in peer-reviewed international journals, indicating that they had passed at least one recognized measure of quality.

Case Studies

In this section, two case studies are examined as a demonstration of the issues discussed above. Both articles were published in international peer-reviewed journals (*Evaluation and Programme Planning* and *Torture*).

Case Study One

An article by Bagamoyo College of Arts, Tanzania Theatre Centre, Mabala and Allen (2002) discusses the use of theater to increase condom usage in African villages to halt the spread of HIV/AIDS. It is offered here as an example of an evaluation with positive features, alongside areas needing significant development.

While theories of change were evident in the work discussed, they were not explicated specifically. The authors presumably anticipated that by watching their theater performance, communities' awareness of how HIV/AIDS is spread would be increased. This would lead to increased use of condoms, which in turn, would result in a reduction in the spread of AIDS. These theories would presumably have been based on the assumptions that: (1) the current problem with the spread of AIDS was lack of knowledge about how it was spread, including lack of awareness of condoms' efficacy in reducing AIDS infection, and lack of use of condoms; (2) theater was an effective means of sharing this information; (3) their particular program would be the type of theater that stimulated change effectively; and (4) increased awareness would lead to the behavior change of increased condom use.

However, none of these assumptions were explicated in the article, nor was any evidence provided to support them. The authors reported on perceived outcomes of their activity, purporting that 'condom demand has risen very strongly in all the districts' after their performance, with the following description of the theater activity offered as evidence:

The [young performers'] frank and open presentations broke the silence about sensitive subjects and created opportunities for change. For example, in Kisarawe, which is predominantly Muslim, the issue of condoms was very sensitive, but when the young

people shouted from the stage “We want condoms! Why do you want us to die?” the barriers to condom distribution were removed.

(Bagamoyo College of Arts et al. 2002, p. 337)

However, this research was not based upon clearly specified research questions, no tools to collect data were mentioned and there was no indication that conclusions were informed by valid data. No critical reflection was offered on how the performance may have been perceived by audiences and therefore impacted them. The major problem with this study was the artists-researchers’ assumption that, because they had undertaken the activity (i.e., young people presenting a theater work about condoms), that change would, and had, occurred.

One further consideration was that the authors and the project evaluators were also the theater performers who developed and implemented the program. As mentioned above, this offered the advantage that they were familiar with the work and the genre of art-making, with the disadvantage—evidenced in the article—that they may not have been dispassionate assessors of their project’s outcomes.

Case Study Two

Another study demonstrating aspects of robust methodology with some methodological shortcomings is Harris’s (2007) article about a project on trauma recovery and community re-building through dance/movement therapy.

Harris led a program with former boy combatants in post-conflict Sierra Leone to address guilt and shame about their war roles and the significant challenge of reintegration into home communities. He documented a clear theory of change for the program, positing that self-worth and the capacity for positive interaction could be restored in these young men through activities including improvised dance and dramatization of their time with the rebel army. The therapeutic activities were seen to allow youths to gradually dispel long-suppressed rage and reconnect more positively with others.

These hypotheses were strongly supported in the reported literature, with Harris drawing on theory about trauma recovery and reconciliation approaches, and providing detailed data from his observations of dance therapy sessions to support his argument. Methodology used included semi-structured interviews at pre-, mid- and post- program to determine participants' progress on predetermined therapeutic goals and participant observation by the researcher, including a ceremony in which the boys were welcomed back into their former home community.

The study also had several weaknesses. Full details of this methodology were not given, reducing the sense of rigor in a way that may not have been deserved. Secondly, like the previous example, the program developer, implementer, evaluator and author were the same person (Harris 2007). While David Alan Harris was mindful of this limitation, objectivity was significantly limited due to the absence of an outsider's perspective. The small sample size and lack of comparison with outcomes of other programs addressing similar issues also reduced the potential validation of the efficacy of this approach.

Having presented findings of our research and offered two detailed case examples of how evaluation tends to occur in arts and international development, we turn now to discussion of those findings and recommendations for future practice.

Discussion

Our findings confirm observations by Etherton and Prenkti (2006), that evaluation and impact assessment are not undertaken regularly by agencies supporting or practicing arts in development. Overall, approaches to evaluation of arts-based programs in international development are not methodologically strong. Although they mostly appear using some kind of formal methodology to gather evidence, this is most often not clearly explicated. Analysis of findings tends to be quite weak, leading to an overreach in conclusions drawn.

In comparing the articles examined in this study with practices of evaluation in international development and the arts more broadly, patterns can be observed. Two trends in development evaluation processes discussed earlier were the importance of participation from stakeholders in evaluation processes and consideration of all possible outcomes, including negative and unexpected change. In this literature review, limited evidence of the former was found, with only three studies discussing methods that involved stakeholder participation. Assessment of changes other than expected, including negative change, was not strongly evident in the literature, with the majority of the studies not reporting or apparently considering the possibility of change other than that expected.

We posit that there is no lack of projects with unexpected or negative outcomes, but they are not documented, either because of authors' and researchers' intransigent views of the positive contribution of their work, or the possibility that only initiatives with positive outcomes were reported in published studies. We noted a relationship between agencies' reluctance to share results publicly and outcomes of projects that were not entirely successful. For example, several unpublished reports in this category came to our attention during this research process, but we were not given permission to quote or include them in this review.

A very significant challenge, shared with other development initiatives, especially those led by NGOs, is the self-interest of those whose livelihoods depend on the activity. By engaging in an evaluation process, an organization opens the possibility of discovering negative or neutral outcomes, with perceived negative implications for funding (Baker 2000). Etherton and Prenklt discuss the dilemma for people who make their living working in arts and development who may be 'understandably loath to peer too hard at the goose which lays at least silver, if not golden, eggs' (2007, p. 144). However, this reluctance also limits learning and potential for whole-field improvement. A truly mature profession would welcome learning that comes through rigorous research and interrogation of unexpected (not necessarily negative) and undesired changes.

In addition to this reluctance for exposing imperfect practice, a number of other factors potentially contribute to the lack of quality research into impacts of participatory arts in development. Development practitioners who are skilled in monitoring and evaluation within their own professional sector can be challenged by the application of such skills to arts programs,

especially when they are unfamiliar with processes through which the arts work (Badham 2010). As mentioned previously, arts practitioners often lack skills in evaluation and may be antipathetic to those processes. Few professionals combine both skillsets. In the literature examined, there was evidence of people attempting to both lead and evaluate arts-based programs which, as discussed, offered both advantages and challenges.

These examples indicate some use of theory of change principles and evaluation strategies in the growing practice of participatory arts in development contexts around the world. However, significant room for improvement is evident, with evaluations infrequent, inconsistent and often methodologically weak.

Conclusion

This systematic literature review examined how evaluation is applied in arts programs in development. The findings confirm what we, as practitioners and researchers in the field of arts and development, had anticipated: that evaluation is not yet well-established practice in this area. Of 151 published articles examined, only 23 discussed or included evaluations. This finding indicates a critical problem for the field, with little more than 10 percent of published work offering any dispassionate assessment of outcomes.

Our analysis of these studies confirmed some clear trends. Methodological approaches were predominantly qualitative, with evaluation frameworks or tools including interviews, focus groups and participant observation. Few studies provided full explanations of their rationale for methods chosen. Evaluations were predominantly conducted in the short term, with no formal longitudinal studies applied to assess long-term change. While claims about outcomes were common, offering of theories or literature to inform the research was not consistent, and many studies did not use data appropriately to support claims made.

Given the growing requirements for evidence-based and outcome-focused work in development and other areas of professional practice, this situation is inadequate. For proponents of arts initiatives in international development to be better informed and justified in drawing on finite resources for their work, the evidence base needs improving.

For the evidence base to improve, evaluations need to be conducted more frequently and systematically. We recommend that these include application and documentation of: a specific research question; an evidence-based theory of change (i.e., how a program is understood to work); appropriate methods used to gather data to address research questions and a clear justification of this choice; critical reflection based upon deep immersion in the data to provide useful findings on the impact of the initiatives; and recommendations for future practice.

Note

1 These were: Abah, Okwori and Alubo 2009; Ahmed 2007; Arts Access Australia 2006; Bagamoyo College of Arts et al. 2002; Bergh 2010; Betiang 2010; Braden and Mayo 1999; Dalrymple 2006; Dunphy 2011; Fontes and Wilson-Grau 2008; Fontes, Wilson-Grau and Davies 2010; Harris 2007; Harvey, Stuart and Swan 2000; Impey 2002; Islam et al. 2001; Mavrocordatos 2004; Mize 2008; Munier and Etherton 2006; Mwansa and Bergman 2003; Nogueira 2006; Risi et al. 2004; Skinner et al. 1991; Swain 2009.

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15

The What and the How

Rethinking Evaluation Practice for the Arts and Development

Claudia Fontes

For some years now, I have been investing the knowledge I gain by being an artist in a field where, as far as I know, few artists—if any—have ventured: the monitoring and evaluation of the arts. Although I landed in this territory by chance, I have embraced it with enthusiasm from the very first moment, because it is an area that problematizes the very nature of the arts from an angle that most artists on a sane day prefer to avoid: the value of art-making (or, in artists’ jargon: ‘why, why, WHY am I doing this?’).

When art happens in the context of development, I believe ‘What is art?’ and ‘How do we value it?’ are two fundamental questions that need serious consideration. Policy makers designing development theories of change tend to muddle them up in a single question that has become the Holy Grail of development evaluators dealing with culture: ‘what is the social impact of the arts?’ This question not only skips defining what art is for whoever makes it, but it also hides two premises: (1) the arts have a social impact and (2) that this social impact can be captured and measured. Although I want to believe in both assumptions, the truth is that finding the right methodology for the emergence of evidence to give substance to them is still a pending task.

In this chapter, I will start by proposing to come back to the two original questions to contrast them with what international development donors have

been doing based on these assumptions. Then I will explain, from my own evaluation experience, how—by exploring alternative evaluative practices—we might find more relevant questions than the apparently unsolvable riddle trapped in ‘what is the social impact of the arts?’

The Problem with the What

Artists and therefore the production of contemporary art survive mainly in three economic circuits: art markets, and the charitable and public sectors. When the artists and their projects are based in countries of the so-called ‘South,’ the opportunities for funds narrow dramatically down to those offered by a fourth circuit: international development.

The processes of selection and validation of development donors are generally restricted to their development agendas, conditioning the production of art to the need to create awareness about whatever social issue is of concern at any given time in the regions where they work. This creates a specific global culture, which replicates itself almost identically in very different cultural backgrounds: the development culture. The specificity of this culture has very little to do with art. While the purpose of art is to deal with the uncertain and to explore novel ways of making sense of the world, questioning established paradigms by interrogating their meaning through self-expression, the selection criteria applied to the arts by the development donors are, in their majority, based on conservative approaches to risk, with a bias for predictable outcomes based on what is in my view, as an artist, short-sighted definitions of development. This lack of audacity is probably linked to the lack of involvement of artists and other local stakeholders in the decision-making processes run by donors, which generate, in turn, a lack of understanding of the specificity of their art practice in their context. Undoubtedly, the pressure that the international development community feels in a world dominated by a neo-liberal logic also contributes to this conservative approach. Surrounded by—though not yet surrendered to—political systems built around this logic, it is increasingly difficult for international development agencies—and the public sector in general all over the world—to justify the funding of art for its own sake in the current global recession, which demands austerity from

the 99 percent so that the 1 percent can accumulate more. In such a climate, proving that art is worth being funded because it has the potential to fix the consequences of the social failure instigated by neoliberalism itself, seems to be the only viable strategy to keep supporting it. However, as I will illustrate, this compliance with the pressure of the system does not come without consequences. As a result, obtaining material support for artists in these countries comes, most of the time, at a price: the instrumentalization of their art. While there are still a few development organizations that consider culture to be a basic need, ¹ in the international development circuit, art is generally funded because it is seen as a convenient tool to palliate and create awareness of social problems, and not because it is considered to be an essential activity that contributes per se to the integral development of human beings and consequently of the societies they form.

There has been an increasing interest amongst researchers and policy makers to gather evidence on how the arts are functional to addressing social issues, and much has been said about the arts' therapeutic powers and their beneficial impact on health, peace-making processes, social cohesion issues or the use of art as a tool for the dissemination of socio-prophylactic practices to mitigate the effects of AIDS, social inclusion, teenage pregnancy, violence against women... and the development list goes on. ² This research on the ameliorative effects of the arts has taken place both in the development context and the post-industrial Western context, and has influenced cultural policies in many Western countries, which in turn influence the decisions taken by decision-makers in international development agencies. Although there is nothing wrong with supporting the arts because of their potential contribution to social transformation, when this becomes the only, or hegemonic, reason for support, the result is a short-sighted use of art's potential and a very impoverished, mediocre art scene, which in turn weakens the 'beneficial' circle. Culture involves processes of giving meaning to our environment by contrasting our current perception with past experiences and comparing this knowledge with the experiences of others. Based on these meaningful experiences, we make decisions about how to behave towards others, towards the environment and, in general, towards what is to come. The arts, of all cultural practices, prepare us to deal with the uncertain, for instance, by developing the capacity of imagining ourselves in alternative scenarios and by developing empathy, the capacity of understanding other people's point of views and

perceptions. By predetermining what use the arts should have, some development donors obscure the channels for the production of meaning. Instrumentalizing the arts amounts to instrumentalizing the channels of perception and mechanisms of production of meaning of others, or to say it bluntly, to putting words in other people's mouths to make them describe how they should feel and how they should imagine their futures, in short, how they should make sense of the world.

I found a compelling example of the unforeseen consequences of the instrumentalization of the arts by the development sector when I was involved in an evaluation for Hivos's ³ culture program in Central America (Fontes and Wilson-Grau 2008). Back in the 1980s, Nicaragua was enjoying the emergence of a film industry led by INCINE (Instituto Nicaragüense de Cine), the Nicaraguan Film Institute created by the Sandinista government in 1979. When Nicaragua's political direction changed in the 1990s, the new government closed INCINE down. As a consequence, filmmakers became dependent almost exclusively on international development funds in order to carry on with their work. Since the international development funds had an agenda restricted to the production of documentaries (the contents of which had to adjust to the development agenda), Nicaraguans barely made any fictional films for almost twenty years. Because of the lack of an integral, coordinated and interactive vision in their cultural interventions, the international development community unintentionally contributed to the repression of self-expression in Nicaragua for almost twenty years, with the consequent loss of talent, creativity and knowledge across a whole generation. It took a donor with a bold policy on culture to start reverting this situation. As it happened, Hivos was one of the few international development donors who considered in its theory of change that the support of artistic expression for its own sake had a positive impact in the development of a society. Because of this belief, their culture program did not predefine results beyond the implementation of the activities proposed by their counterparts and the outputs generated by them. Their policy allowed intellectual space for the artists to own and define their own agendas, and the criteria of selection for partners was based on the contemporary relevance of their artistic practice.

The members of ANCI (Asociación Nicaragüense de Cinematografía), the contemporary Nicaraguan Film Association, ⁴ one of Hivos's counterparts in Central America in the early 2000s, explained to me that

thanks to the support they received from Hivos, Nicaraguans were finally able to produce short fictional films consistently for the first time since the closure of INCINE. This boost for the production of fictional work nurtured the film-making scene to the point that all short films produced in that period went on to win international awards. The buzz produced by the burgeoning film scene, and the skills and experience gained by a new generation in the realization of those films, even led to Nicaraguans producing their first feature film in twenty years. *La Yuma* (directed by Florence Jaugey and released in 2009) has already collected thirteen awards at international festivals. As a consequence of, amongst others, Hivos's healthy intervention, Nicaraguan cinema recovered its place in the global film scene, a new generation of actors, actresses, directors and technicians acquired skills to develop this scene in a more sustainable way beyond Hivos' support and the Nicaraguan public recovered a wealth of images to identify with and to help them open their own imagination on to the world.

This happy ending to the twenty years of funding restrictions suffered by Nicaraguan cinema is inspiring and makes us wonder why self-expression through the arts is not considered more generously in the development sector as a factor of social improvement and growth. Is it because art's impact is not being measured with the right tools? What are the systems of validation (are we doing the right thing?) and verification (are we doing it right?) that are failing to show us the full value of the arts in international development? How can they be improved?

The Problem with the How

When it comes to choosing systems of validation and verification to monitor the work they do, most of the institutions operating in the international development scene in the past twenty years have opted to work with variations of a tool called the Logical Framework Approach in order to plan, manage, monitor and evaluate their projects. The Logical Framework is based on a theoretical matrix designed ahead of the implementation of a project. This matrix highlights logical linkages between intended inputs, planned activities and expected results. Created to be used originally by the U.S. military as a planning approach for their

activities, it was then adapted for NASA, the U.S. space agency, then for USAID (the United States Agency for International Development), who finally adopted it in 1969 for application in development (Bakewell and Garbutt 2005).

The Logical Framework Approach tends to be applied indiscriminately across all programs in the development scene regardless of the nature of the work being measured: from agriculture to human rights, from micro-finance to culture. It relies heavily on the pre-formulation of indicators for the measuring of results mainly at the output level. The insistent use of the Logical Framework Approach trickles down from large, multilateral donors like the European Union, to donor agencies, to NGOs and, more to the point that concerns us, to cultural organizations mostly initiated and run by artists, who need to be 'converted' into the Logical Framework mindset if they want to get funds. While the Logical Framework Approach might work for those projects which can be easily measured quantitatively and by taking the outputs of the project as evidence of change (e.g., the number of water wells that have been cleared of dengue in a region might work as an indicator of good environmental management in a dengue program), it can bring more harm than good to artistic and cultural practices.

While monitoring and evaluating should be about collective learning for improvement and progress, when applied to cultural projects, the monitoring practices currently widespread in the international development scene perpetuate detrimental habits of compliance with the donors' agenda. Artists and organizers find themselves predefining indicators to please their donors, while intimately knowing that it is impossible to predict the impact their art projects can have on people. The evaluation of projects is undertaken for the project's final report next to the declaration of expenses as soon as a project finishes. A new project is then started and very rarely either the donor or their counterparts come back to ask those participating in the former project how it influenced their lives in the longer term. Executing one budget after another, counterparts become experts at ticking boxes on gender percentage and at calculating the number of youth in their audiences, but out of this process neither the donor nor the counterpart learns what it meant for those people to be exposed to their activities, what changed for them. This numbing way of monitoring the arts has another detrimental side effect: some people get really good at ticking boxes and designing indicators, they learn to respond satisfactorily to the requirements

of the donor and the time-pressured staff member at the donor's desk ends up assessing the quality of their projects by how clearly the application form has been filled in and how well it fits into the donor's own set of indicators.

Assessing the quality of the contents of a cultural project and its capacity to produce meaning in its own context is a very different task, and it usually exceeds the possibilities of gathering and analyzing information that donors gain by using the Logical Framework Approach. The whole situation finally gets justified with this politically correct question: 'Who am I,' says the donor, 'to judge artistic quality in anyone's art, let alone the artistic quality of an artwork that is meant for a cultural context so different to mine?' Although it is absolutely fair to pose such a question, the result of this situation is the emergence of a mediocre culture of development, in which those talented artists spearheading innovative and intellectually challenging projects who do not have the skills to 'sell' their projects following the logic of the donor do not get funds, while those who play safe with the contents of their project and are good at responding to the donor's methodological requirements are repeatedly funded. The donors' art managers and art officers, especially those who work closely with the artists they support, are aware of this and get frustrated by this vicious circle, but don't know how to escape it, since they are usually overworked by also trying to comply with the system they work within.

Xamul aay na, tey laajtewul a ko raw

'It is bad enough not to know, but it is even worse not to ask'. I came across this Wolof proverb while working in Senegal on an evaluation for the International Culture Programme of DOEN Foundation (called *How do you DOEN?*) back in 2010 (Fontes 2010). The saying exemplifies what I believe is the main problem with the monitoring and evaluation practices widespread in the development sector investing in culture: they fail to ask their supposed 'beneficiaries' what matters to them and why.

However, here I was working for DOEN, and the bottom line of my research was, as the Project Manager for the DOEN International Culture Programme Gertrude Flentge put it, 'We want to know what the people we

support need.’ The funds managed by DOEN come from the Dutch lottery buyer, rather than the taxpayer, and this gives them unusual freedom to define their own policy and their monitoring and evaluation practices. As an institution, DOEN enjoys the luxury of being as autonomous, flexible and creative as it gets. Sustainability is at the core of DOEN’s leading values and cuts across all work in the foundation. They choose to finance culture because they believe that culture provides a space for free expression, creative thinking and for connecting differences, and that this can in turn contribute to making social changes sustainable. I could not ask for a better institutional environment to test a different evaluative approach to look for evidence on the value of arts and culture in ‘developing’ contexts.

It seemed obvious that whatever methodology we used, it had to be as participatory as possible, engaging the whole range of stakeholders: the arts and culture managers and officers who make funding decisions on behalf of the donor, the artists and organizers working in the field who design local programs and apply for funds and the people making sense of those artistic and cultural productions (artists, spectators, readers, members of the press, academics, consumers of culture, decision-makers, neighbors and members of the public in general). Since we only engage in processes that are meaningful to us, the participation of those people needed to be as active as possible, engaging them at the core of the analysis of the evidence collected, questioning them about its meaning and significance and collectively reaching conclusions and recommendations for the primary stakeholders to get the chance to influence the donor’s policy.

We decided to use a methodology inspired by the Most Significant Change (MSC) technique, a monitoring approach based on storytelling designed by Rick Davies and Jess Dart (see Davies and Dart 2005). When using MSC, information is sorted and summarized by selecting and discussing the most significant changes. The technique does without the use of indicators, facilitates the emergence of significant knowledge and contextual information from the grassroots, and makes respondents focus on impact rather than on outputs. Since the technique embraces subjective evidence instead of struggling against it, it seemed to me that it could be a healthier departure point to unearth information about the impact produced by the arts, which can only emerge through the collection of multiple subjective voices.

The MSC technique starts by asking people two simple questions: ‘Can you tell me a story about the most significant change that you have experienced influenced by X?’ and ‘Why is it the most significant?’ As soon as you try to start answering these deceptively simple questions, the evaluative process kicks in: you are forced to start analyzing all the significant changes you have experienced in relation to the activity being evaluated and to select the one that you find most significant of all. In the process, you need to ask yourself why one change is more significant than another, and inadvertently, you start identifying the relationship between cause and effect amongst those changes: now you have built a narrative, a story, about what changed, in what order and which of all those changes is the most significant to you and why. ⁵

The second stage of this technique sees those first individual analyses told as stories informing a collective debate. A group of stakeholders gather to read and discuss the Most Significant Change stories, sort them out into domains of change (which can be predetermined or not) and then discuss what is the most significant change story under each domain. At a third stage of the technique, this group sends feedback to the storytellers.

While the Most Significant Change technique is generally used as an ongoing monitoring tool, for the evaluation of DOEN’s International Culture Programme, we used it as a one-off application, customizing it for the purpose of the research. We focused the research on four countries where DOEN has clusters of partners (Uganda, Kenya, Mali and Senegal) and invited some of the organizations already working with DOEN and some non-partner organizations to take part. The purpose was to gather information not only about what impact DOEN had contributed to in the past, but also about what other opportunities for supporting the arts they had failed to spot and how they could improve their support in the future. The emerging information would inform the policy of DOEN’s International Culture Programme.

After collecting about twenty to thirty Most Significant Change stories per country, we gathered a group of representatives of local culture organizations in each country, who analyzed the significance of the changes described in the stories, tagged them with key words and sorted these tags and the corresponding stories into domains of change or categories, for each of which they had to find a name. Although the meetings were held in English and French, participants were encouraged to use their mother

languages to find the most relevant names for the domains, and this generated intellectual space for extremely rich, locally rooted concepts to emerge. Then they selected the most significant change story under each domain, which further deepened the discussions in the group about what was the impact of their activities that mattered to them.

Once we had the domains of change defined from each country, we gathered the International Culture Programme staff in DOEN to go through a similar process. The difference for them was that they were required to adjust their analysis and the sorting of stories into the domains of change set by the local stakeholders in their discussions. This gave DOEN's staff a fabulous insight into the meaning that informs the decisions made by the organizations they support. The collective exercise also improved the mutual understanding and the sharing of knowledge among staff members.

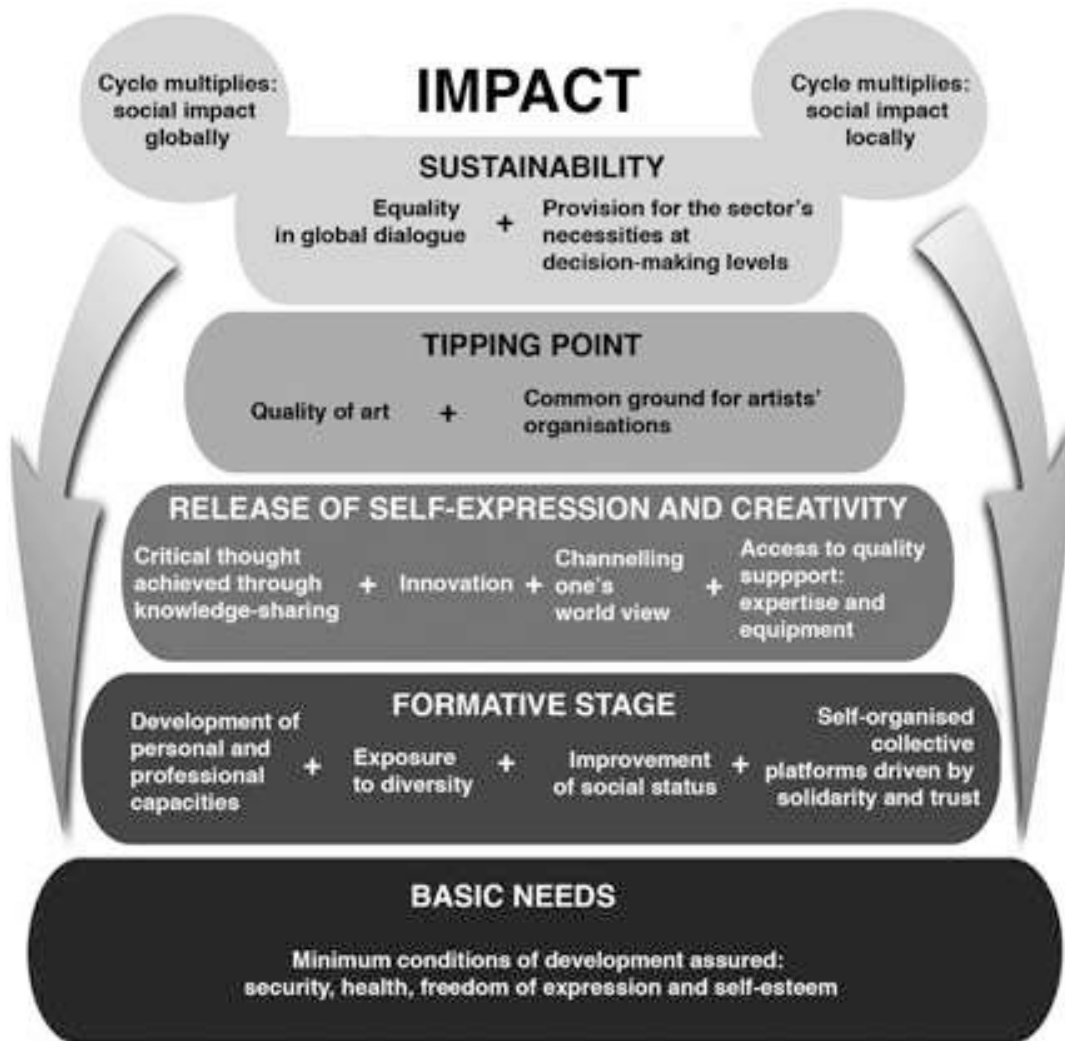
The results of the analysis made by both groups were discussed afterwards in each country with a wider group of stakeholders, which included the storytellers themselves. Feedback was shared, and there were also discussions about what desirable changes had not emerged in the sample of MSC stories. Finally, the local organizers discussed what instruments and strategies they had in place to generate these changes they had listed as significant and what obstacles they faced to do so.

By the end of this process, we had outlined a fairly comprehensive map of the aims and needs of the independent cultural sectors in each country from the point of view of local stakeholders. When we started this research, DOEN wanted to know how better to support the artists, cultural agents and their audiences living in the regions where they work. After we finished the process, not only DOEN but also their regional stakeholders had a much clearer idea of what they needed, why and how to achieve it. Most significantly, everyone felt they shared now a common purpose and that they could learn lessons from each other about how to achieve it.

The mapping of the chains of changes coming from the four countries was aggregated into a common meta-narrative, taking into account coincidences in the analysis made by all four groups. This meta-narrative works as a theory of change built from the various primary stakeholders' points of view. Rather than being a fixed 'theory' of change or a 'model' to be applied globally, this meta-narrative can be seen as a 'nomadic' approach to describing how culture can be developed and contribute to social development in various contexts. The cycle of cultural development

described in the diagram below can be taken as a basis to be contrasted against evidence gathered in future research projects in other parts of the world, each different cultural context enriching it and transforming it into a more nuanced and complex vision.

This diagram ([Figure 15.1](#)) describes a chain of changes that condition each other towards a hypothetical sustainable cultural sector system. ⁶ Critical elements in this chain of changes are the creation of collective platforms motivated by mutual cooperation, the sharing of knowledge and expertise in a non-hierarchical and critical fashion and the emphasis given to the quality of the art produced. While the two first elements could be more or less assessed by a donor following traditional monitoring methods, they would find it more difficult, if not impossible, to assess artistic quality in the same way. If we define ‘good quality’ in art as the depth of relevance of contents to the particular context the art addresses, it seems to be a priority when evaluating the impact of art programs to measure how meaningful those contents are to the people to which they are addressed.



[Source: IF](#) A sustained cycle for the development (2010, p.18). Reproduced with permission from IF.

To do this, sometimes donors appeal to the advice of local experts like art critics, curators or cultural researchers, but their view is, of course, limited to these experts' own particular understanding of the cultural scene. More often, donors abandon the quest completely and decide to focus just on assessing the organizational and managerial elements of projects, hoping that if local art institutions and organizations are well supported, the art being produced will consequently be of good quality. In the *How do you DOEN?* Evaluation, we created a third option: to look for meaning where it matters, that is, at the grassroots. As a consequence, the local stakeholders not only had a chance to define what quality is in their own art, but also the definition of culture itself was stretched and challenged by locally rooted

world-making strategies, which had so far been kept silent in the dialogue between local stakeholders and the international development scene.

The *Maaya* Lesson

Generally, the arts are valued in developmental policies either because of the economic opportunities that emerge around them—such as the number of jobs created, or the revenue obtained from entertainment and creative industries and from the production of commodities—or as a powerful, locally embedded channel of communication to convey urgent social messages using artists and artworks as vehicles. The *How do you DOEN?* evaluation escaped this reductionist framework and allowed the primary stakeholders to gain authorship of the process of analysis, at the same time that it activated dormant cultural models of interacting with nature and society extremely significant to their specific context. These helped not only to understand the impact of cultural activities, but also to better implement actions on the range of themes that DOEN was interested in supporting.

One of my own Most Significant Change stories emerging from the evaluation of DOEN's International Culture program comes from my experience in Mali. When the group of Malian organizers were sorting their Most Significant Change stories into domains of change, they were stuck by a particular set of stories. They eagerly agreed to group them under one single category, but could not agree on an overall term to name that category. These stories talked about an array of changes that appeared, from my Western perspective, to be dissimilar. They included: people taking care (both therapeutically and morally) of others, or being taken care of; changes in thinking regarding traditional ideas; openness to other cultural identities; affirmation of one's own identity; and changes in the social status of the users. To top it all off, one participant insisted on calling this category 'cultural diversity,' while another insisted the changes referred to 'marketing strategies.' The discussion was being facilitated in French and I sensed that language had become an obstacle. Being puzzled, I decided to give up the facilitation at that point and proposed that they switch the discussions into their common language. After half an hour of heated exchange of ideas in Bambara and much anxiety on my behalf, an epiphany

took place: ‘Of course,’ they said back to me in French, ‘these changes are changes in *maaya* !’

Writer Ismaïla Samba Traoré ⁷ explained that *maaya* is:

the individual adapting him/herself to the fundamental values of the society that enables him/her as an individual in the first place... *Maaya* ⁸ is the human aspect of things, the human dimension of behaviour, of identity, of culture... all that makes an individual have his/her two feet on Earth in a particular place with his/her mind placed on a specific set of memories and with the senses open to everything that surrounds him/her.

Society, art and ecology go hand in hand in the *maaya* understanding of the world. People’s social identity is rooted in landscape and develops through art. The transformation of any of these—society, environment or art—for better or for worse, affects the whole system. The place that the musical instrument *balafon* is given amongst the Senoufo people in the education of their children clearly illustrates this point:

The *balafon* in Africa, and especially amongst us [in Mali], was not only an instrument to play music, but it used to be an instrumental part of a child’s formative process. First, in order to learn how to play the *balafon*, you need to learn the big virtues of society. The *balafon* helps first of all to develop listening skills. There is a pattern to be learnt, you need to really observe, listen. In the Bambara context, listening is a great value, an initiation... Secondly, the teaching of *balafon* develops the child’s capacities of observation. Thirdly, the child also learns to recognise not only harmony but beauty. It is an education aimed at recognizing what is beautiful. But there is also a fourth element, which is ecology: children used to learn to build their own *balafon*, and the wood to make the *balafon* used to be very special, and you had to know the virtues of this wood, you had to learn to recognise what tree you could use, and at what point of the tree’s existence you could take the wood from the tree.

(Interview with Mamou Daffé, 2010) ⁹

Soon, this knowledge emerging from the evaluation translated into concrete actions and changes of behavior for those involved. The methodology we used allowed the local decision-makers participating in Mali to connect with the impact they were helping to generate in such a meaningful way that they became highly motivated and inspired to the point of federating themselves in a network inspired by the *maaya* spirit called KYA ¹⁰ to support the development of art and culture in Africa. KYA aims to create a favorable environment for the development of culture in Mali by rescuing the social dimension that *maaya* has in the collective memory and that is being lost by the influence of western individualism. Since its inception in

2009, KYA has been working on one of the initiatives which they had identified as being needed during the evaluation: the Maaya Fund, a fund to support artistic creation that aims to improve the working conditions for artists and cultural actors by providing credit and solidarity. ¹¹ When three-quarters of the country was occupied by rebels during the recent military upheaval in Mali and the arts were forbidden because of the state of emergency, the Maaya Fund proved to be an essential instrument for the support not only of culture, but of basic human values. The artists gathered in KYA managed to rescue colleagues under extreme conditions and were able to create a sense of solidarity and cooperation that helped to counteract the devastating effects of the political situation.

As for the DOEN Foundation, they came to understand, in depth, not only how they could better support artists in Mali, but also the maaya lesson inspired them to transfer this knowledge into their New Economy program. They chose one of the organizations participating in the International Culture Programme evaluation—the Festival sur le Niger—as a case study for a research project which dug further into how the organization’s entrepreneurial and cooperative culture driven by the maaya concept affected the social, economic and cultural development of the region. A book was published as a result of that research (Spaas 2012), and the whole experience had a strong influence on DOEN’s New Economy program’s policy and thinking. Looking into the future, now the DOEN International Culture Programme is considering the possibility of helping to develop the Maaya Fund further and even letting it take over a large part of the role the donor has at the moment in Mali.

Conclusion

Cultural critic Raymond Williams (1998, p. 48) identified three general categories for how culture is defined in Western societies: the ‘ideal,’ the ‘documentary’ and the ‘social.’ According to the ‘ideal’ view, culture is a path to human perfection. The analysis of this process would be the assessment of values which have a permanent reference to the universal human condition. The ‘documentary’ understanding of culture, instead, would refer to intellectual and imaginative work which records human

thought and experience. Criticism is the tool developed to analyze such records. Finally, the ‘social’ points at the behavioral aspect of culture, culture understood as a particular way of life, ‘which expresses certain meanings and values not only in art and learning but also in institutions and ordinary behaviour’ (Williams 1998, p. 48). To be able to analyze culture understood from this point of view, we need to understand the meanings and values implicit and explicit in such behavior.

The worldview implicit in *maaya* encompasses all three definitions of culture in a holistic way which is hardly considered by international development donors. The compartmentalized vision that the development sector generally has of the future and the role given in it to arts and culture has prevented them from developing a more meaningful and comprehensive projection not only of the future of the societies they want to support, but of their own. Art and culture have a transversal role to play in the making of strategies that could affect the behavior of citizens towards social and ecological issues. The evaluative adventure that DOEN Foundation was audacious enough to embark upon tells us that only when culture is seen as a transversal force that influences people’s behavior in everyday life, as a rhizomatic system that enables intelligence and knowledge to emerge from the bottom-up and influences all activities, is it likely to favor sustainable change in society.

The question ‘What is the social impact of the arts?’ seems to miss the mark after all. It would only be fair to complement it with another question, which implies the capacity of supporting good quality art: ‘What is the cultural impact of the society we are building?’ Or, to talk in Senoufo terms: ‘What will happen when there is no wood left to build the *balafon* ?’ And, ‘What will happen when there is no one with enough knowledge left to teach a child the *maaya* lesson?’

Notes

- 1 Some foundations with a more open approach towards supporting the arts include the Prince Claus Fund, Hivos, the DOEN Foundation, Mimeta, Africalia, the British Council, the Danish Centre for Culture and Development, the Lambent Foundation and the Goethe Institute.
- 2 Interesting analyses on the use of culture as an instrument for development can be found in (Mirza 2006; Warah 2008).

- 3 Hivos (Humanistisch Instituut voor Ontwikkelingssamenwerking or the Humanist Institute for Cooperation) is a Dutch international development organization. Hivos provides financial support to organizations in Africa, Latin America and Asia in the fields of culture, social change and green entrepreneurship.
- 4 See Fontes and Wilson-Grau 2008, Annex 8, p. 64.
- 5 You might like to test the MSC mechanism by self-evaluating your past week: ‘What was the most significant change that happened to you during the past week? Why was this change so significant to you?’ Even when experiencing the least eventful period of your life, you will be able to sort and single out what was the most significant change of all and why. It might happen that the most significant change was not very significant to you after all, or that the most significant change was negative, rather than positive. Or it might be that by coincidence last week you experienced such a significant change that it will impact the rest of your life. In any case, the focus on an extreme example from your own sample of changes in the past week becomes a rich source of information that points at both what is an unusual and what is an expected change in your life and why.
- 6 For a fuller description of this diagram, see Fontes 2010, [Chapter 9](#).
- 7 Ismaëla Samba Traoré, writer and editor, accompanied the debates held in Mali during the evaluation, providing cultural and historical context to what was being discussed.
- 8 *Maaya* literally means ‘being human’: *Maa* = human
- 9 Cultural entrepreneur Mamou Daffé has initiated CPEL Ségou (a program for the promotion of regional economy in Ségou) and the Festival sur le Niger—one of the biggest touristic and socio-cultural attractions in Mali. He is founding member and director of KYA, a network of cultural organizations formed as a result of the debates generated by the evaluation of DOEN’s International Culture Programme in Mali.
- 10 More information about KYA can be found on their website, *KYA Resea Culturel*, <http://www.reseaukya.org/>.
- 11 For more information about the Maaya Fund, see their website: Le Fonds Maaya (n.d.). *KYA Resea Culturel*.

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